the ruy lopez main line



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Glenn Flear

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by Glenn Flear

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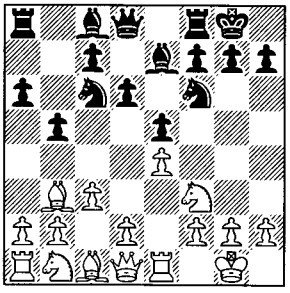
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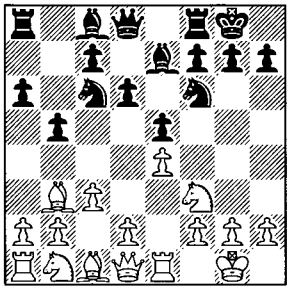
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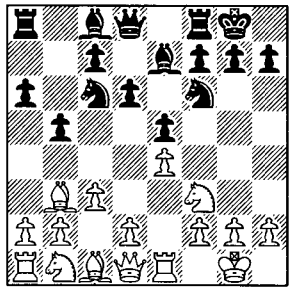
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INTRODUCTION



1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0

The Ruy Lopez (or Spanish) has featured regularly in the games of most leading players throughout the last century. A high proportion reaching the diagram position.

This is where I begin.

The Ruy Lopez Main Line is a coverage of the principal continuations that have the above *tabiya* in common. These resulting variations are the benchmark for all 1 e4 e5 openings and players. So the book is not called the Ruy Lopez 'Main Line' for nothing!

The first chess book I ever owned, Bobby Fischer's *60 Memorable Games*, featured introductions written by Larry Evans, and one of the Spanish games he entitled 'Meat and Potatoes'. It's standard fare and one of *the* fundamental openings.

The variations are named after leading classical players Chigorin, Keres, Smyslov and Karpov. There are games by Fischer, Spassky, Gligoric, Tal, Bronstein and others of their ilk. There is just so much history in the Spanish!

Most opening books however are read by players seeking modern and up-to-date interpretations, and so games by Kasparov, Anand, Shirov, Ivanchuk, Grischuk, Svidler and Leko also feature widely throughout these pages. I have game references up to November 2003, but at times I have chosen a rather older one, as it may illustrate an idea in a certain way.

So overall I have tried to strike a balance between the fashionable and the forgotten, with a slight but inevitable stress on the latest trends.

The book then is a selection of 77 complete games that illustrate how the state of theory is at present, but not forgetting the lessons that history has taught us.

In the diagram above, we can see that the kings are safely castled, the respective armies are still out of firing range and the centre has yet to reach a crisis. So rapid development is less important than an efficient deployment of one's forces. Therefore the main feature of all the variations is the emphasis on seeking *harmonious* development.

One aspect of these lines is that 10-15 book moves are played rapidly and only when the middlegame approaches do the players start to add their own individual touch. Another is that there are few exchanges early on, so games can be complex and multi-faceted and rarely fizzle out quickly.

The centre does sometimes become closed, when a period of manoeuvring is required, but

can also suddenly open up leading to sharp piece play.

The reason for the continued popularity is perhaps that there is plenty of scope for original thought but based on the knowledge that the opening is fundamentally sound.

White carefully prepares to take the initiative in the centre with d2-d4, and Black has various ways to react accordingly. The first eight chapters show the different methods that Black has at his disposal to meet White's main idea of playing first h2-h3 and only then d2-d4.

The last two chapters show White either playing d2-d4 immediately (Chapter 9), or delaying (or not even bothering) with d4 (Chapter 10).

I have not covered the Marshall Gambit (7...0-0 intending 8...d5, rather than 7...d6) and only limited myself to a brief look at how to handle Anti-Marshall Systems in Chapter 10. I make no excuse; these are covered in other works, and an author has to draw the line somewhere!

In the first nine chapters I have covered all the main variations, past and present, and have examined them with objectivity in mind. There is no intended bias to either colour.

In Chapter 10, I have limited myself to just picking out a selection of lines that show how players of the Black pieces can get a satisfactory or dynamic game.

Some variations (e.g. certain lines of the Chigorin) seem to involve long-term manoeuvring, where I have tried to give precedence to explaining the key manoeuvres and ideas as well as general pointers to why certain variations have superseded others. In others the tactical play requires precise analysis and naturally the character of my annotations is radically different.

The Ruy Lopez Main Line is an ideal opening to understand the importance of the centre, of qualitative development and flexibility towards a changing environment.

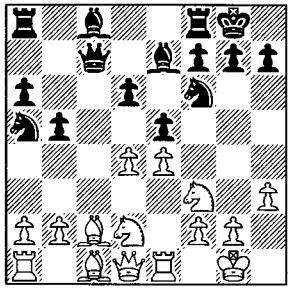
One needs to handle one's pieces as if conducting an orchestra, keeping in tune with the ebbs and flow of the music. If one piece is badly placed then the repercussions are felt by the whole ensemble.

The main point of all this is that the reader can develop these ideas in his own games.

So please turn the page and start to delve into the rich tapestry that is the Ruy Lopez Main line.

Glenn Flear,
Baillargues,
France
March 2004

CHAPTER ONE



Chigorin Defence with 12...cxd4 13 cxd4

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4

The position after 10...c5 has been known for many years as the Chigorin Defence.

One of the main themes of play in this line is whether Black's queen's knight can find a satisfactory role or just be locked out of play. Indeed Black has to decide how he would like to arrange his pieces in the case of d4-d5 by White.

By opening the c-file Black hopes for a more lively game than those similar lines in Chapters 2 and 3 where White plays d4-d5 and blocks the centre. Furthermore, with an open line on the c-file White rarely has the time to slowly organise a kingside assault. The early middlegame sees most of the action on the queenside or in the centre.

After the traditional 13...♘c6 (Games 4-5), Black puts pressure on d4 and White has to choose whether or not to keep the tension. The knight coming to c6 *after* the exchange of pawns allows this piece to come to b4 in the case of the White advance d4-d5. The space-gaining 14 d5 is however worthy of respect and has the advantage of avoiding any complications associated with ...d5.

The principal alternative 14 ♘b3, defending the d4-point, has been frequently played over the last 60 years and is still one of the critical lines.

Black's most active idea, playing for counterplay with ...d5, used to be associated with Panov's variation 13...♗b7 (Games 8-9). Nowadays 13...♖d8 (Games 1-3, or the earlier 12...♖d8 see Chapter 2) is often employed with the same pawn-break in mind. The aggressive 13...♖d8 is popular as the plan with ...d5 contains some sting as we can see in Game 2. The quieter 13...♗d7 (Games 6-7) combines sensible development with play on the c-file.

One of the reasons that Panov's 13...♗b7 is out of favour is that the bishop is better placed on d7 in the case of a closed centre. So 13...♖d8 and 13...♗d7 have the advantage of not sending the bishop the 'wrong' way.

Fashions come and go but 13...♖d8 is popular at present. It's perhaps Black's most dynamic choice here, but positional players may be attracted to the cautious manoeuvring typical of 13...♘c6 and 13...♗d7.

Game 1

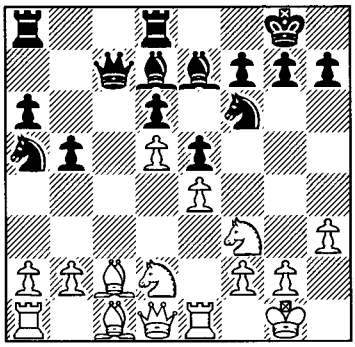
P.Svidler-R.Kasimdzhanov

Yerevan 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4

♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♖d8 14 ♘f1

Closing the centre at this point is commonplace but doesn't inconvenience the second player that much in the following variations: 14 d5 ♗d7



In this position White has two main tries:

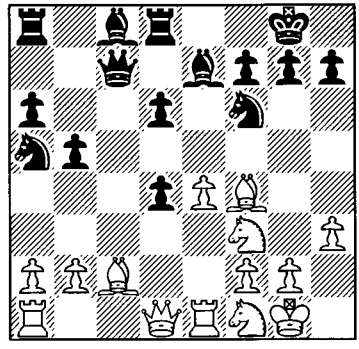
a) 15 ♘f1 ♖dc8 16 ♗d3 ♘b7 (or alternatively 16...♗d8 17 b3 ♘b7 18 ♗e3 b4 19 ♘3d2 ♗b5, J.Van Barle-H.Westerinen, London 1979) 17 ♘g3 (Not 17 g4?! ♘c5 18 ♗b1 h5! D.Campora-J.Estrada Nieto, Andorra 2001 when Black was doing well after 19 ♘3h2 hxg4 20 hxg4 ♘h7. Instead after 17 b4 a5 18 ♗d2 axb4 19 ♗xb4 ♘c5, A.Abreu-A.Hauchard, Havana 2001, a draw was agreed) 17...♘c5 18 ♗f1 (*ECO* prefers White because of the continuation 18 ♗b1 g6 19 ♗g5 ♕d8 20 ♕d2 ♗e8 21 ♗c2 a5 22 ♖ac1 b4 23 ♗e3 ♗b5 24 ♘h2 ♘a4 25 ♗d3 as in B.Perenyi-L.Lengyel, Hungarian Championship 1977 but in this Lukacs and Hazai suggest the time-saving 20...a5 and judge the position as equal) 18...♘a4 19 ♖e2 b4 20 ♗e3 ♕b7 21 ♖c1 ♗d8 22 ♖ec2 ♖xc2 23 ♖xc2 ♗b6 with a satisfactory game, D.Campora-J.Fernandez Garcia, Dos Hermanas 2000.

b) 15 ♗d3 ♘b7 16 ♘b3 (After 16 b4 the immediate 16...a5! is important as Black obtains access to the c5-square for his knight) 16...♖dc8 (16...a5 17 ♗e3 a4 18 ♖c1 ♕b8 is simpler) 17 ♕e2 a5!? 18 ♗e3 (White could consider the pawn grab 18 ♗xb5 when Black still has to prove that he has compensation after 18...♗xb5 19 ♕xb5 a4 20 ♘bd2 ♘c5 21 ♖e3) 18...♕b8 19 ♖ec1 a4 20 ♖xc8+ ♕xc8 21 ♖c1 ♕e8 22 ♘bd2 ♗d8 (Black switches his bishop to the queenside but is at present denied the standard b6-square) 23 ♘h2 h6 24 ♘hf1 ♗a5 25 ♘b1 ♗b4 26 ♘c3 ♖a5 27 ♗b6 with a draw as in G.Milos-V.Bologan, Buenos Aires 2000. Black cannot avoid the draw: 27...♖a6 28 ♗e3 ♖a5 29 ♗b6 etc. However if White plays for more with 29 a3 ♗c5 30 ♗d2 then Black has little to fear after 30...♗b6.

14...exd4

14...d5?! has been played a few times but is now considered dubious, e.g. 15 ♘xe5 dxe4 16 ♘g3 ♗d6 17 ♗f4 ♘c4 18 ♘xe4 ♗xe5 19 ♘xf6+ gxf6 20 ♕d3 with essentially a winning position for White, D.Barbelescu-M.Chiburdanidze, Polanica Zdroj 1984.

15 ♗f4



Continuing development whilst restraining the freeing advance ...d5. White hopes to recuperate the pawn at some point once he is good and ready. Instead 15 ♘xd4 is examined in Game 2.

15...♘c6

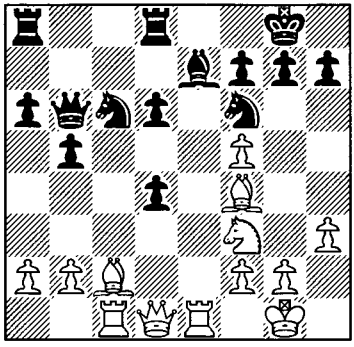
Following 15...♘c4 16 b3, Black could settle for 16...♘e5 17 ♘xd4 with a typical slight pull for White. However in O.Kor-

neev-J.Fernandez Garcia, Zaragoza 1996 Black tried unsuccessfully to mix it with 16...♘a3!? 17 ♗d3 ♕b6 18 ♘g3 b4 19 ♕d2 d5?! (perhaps his play can be justified with 19...♗e6 when play is far from clear) 20 ♖ac1! with advantage to White.

16 ♘g3 ♗e6 17 ♖c1 ♕b6 18 ♘f5

Similarly 18 ♕d2 ♖ac8 19 ♘f5 ♗xf5 20 exf5 of R.Antoniewski-J.Pinski, Poland 1988 should be met in the same vein with 20...d5(!). In B.Socko-P.Stempin, Suwalki 1999 White lost the thread with 18 ♗b1?! ♖ac8 19 ♘e2 d3! 20 ♕xd3 ♘e5 and was already on the defensive.

18...♗xf5 19 exf5



19...d5!

A clear improvement on 19...♖a7?! from A.Galkin-V.Bologan, Russian Team Championship 2001 which continued in White's favour with 20 ♗b1 ♖ad7 21 a3 h6 22 ♗g3 ♔f8 23 ♗a2 ♖e8 24 b4 with pressure. The text move is an attempt to be more active.

20 a3

After 20 ♗b1 ♖e8 White doesn't have anything better than 21 ♗c7 ♕xc7 22 ♘xd4 (Lukacs/Hazai) with equality.

20...♖ac8 21 ♗b1?!

Kasimdzhanov suggests 21 ♗d3!? ♗f8 22 g4 as a better try for complications.

21...♗f8 22 ♗a2 h6 23 ♕d3 ♘a5 24 ♘xd4

White regains his pawn but Black's pieces are all well placed and his structure is preferable in the long run, so he's a shade better.

24...♘c4 25 ♖c2 ♖e8 26 ♖6e8 ♖6e8 27 ♘f3 a5?!

This leads to a loosening of Black's grip.

Svidler was more worried about 27...♗c5! 28 ♗g3 (28 b4?! ♗f8 just leaves White with a weakness on a3) 28...♘e4 29 ♗h4 ♕d6 when Black can boast excellent centralisation.

28 a4! ♖e4 29 ♗c1 bxa4 30 ♗xc4 dxc4 31 ♖xc4 ♖xc4

Black can grab a pawn with 31...♕b5 32 ♖d4 ♕xf5 33 ♖d8 but the pin on the 8th is worth the half-pawn deficit.

32 ♕xc4 ♕b4 33 ♕c2 ♗c5 34 ♗d2 ♕b5 35 ♗e1 a3

Exchanging immediately leaves Black with a strong passed pawn but White seems to have enough resources. Possibly the alternative try 35...♗b4! 36 ♘d4 ♕d7 37 ♗c3 a3 gives better winning chances.

36 bxa3 ♗xa3 37 ♘d4 ♕e5 38 ♘f3 ♕a1?

Blundering the a-pawn and thus having to defend the ending a pawn down. Here 38...♕d5 is met by 39 ♕a4, but 38...♕b5! 39 ♘d4 ♕d5! (39...♕d7 is insufficient due to 40 ♘c6, as is 39...♕c5 40 ♕xc5 ♗xc5 41 ♘b3 ♗b4 42 ♗xb4 axb4 and now White's king gets there first: 43 ♔f1 ♔f8 44 ♔e2 ♔e7 45 ♔d3 with a probable draw) 40 ♕a4 ♗c5 retains some advantage.

39 ♕a4 ♕c1 40 ♕xa5 ♗c5 41 ♕a8+ ♔h7 42 ♕a4 ♕b1 43 ♕c4 ♕xf5 44 ♕xf7 ♕d3 45 ♕e6 ♕b1 46 g3 ♕d3 47 ♔g2 ♕e4 48 ♕xe4+ ♘xe4 49 ♘e5 ♗d4 50 ♘c4 ♔g6 51 f4 h5 52 ♔f3 ♘f6 53 ♗a5 ♔f5 54 ♗d8 ♔e6 55 ♘e3?!

Here 55 ♗xf6, playing with knight versus bishop on the same wing, would keep some winning chances alive.

55...♗xe3 56 ♔xe3

If 56 ♗xf6 then 56...♗xf4! 57 ♗xg7 ♗d6 is drawn.

56...♘d5+ 57 ♔d4 g6 58 ♔e4 ♘c3+ 59 ♔f3 ♘b5 ½-½

Game 2

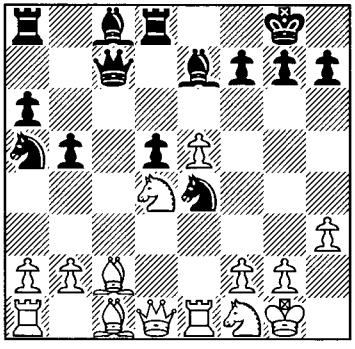
A.Grischuk-V.Bologan

Enghien-les-Bains 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♖d8 14 ♘f1 exd4 15 ♘xd4 d5!

The strongest at this point, whereas the inferior 15...♘c6 16 ♗e3 ♘xd4 17 ♗xd4 ♗e6 18 ♘e3 ♖ac8 19 f4 (G.Timoshenko-R.Kholmov, Voskresensk 1992) gives White a good version of a position analogous to play in Game 3.

16 e5 ♘e4



17 ♗f4

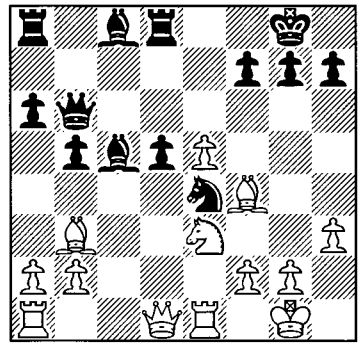
Supporting the e-pawn. Alternatives have been investigated but found wanting:

a) 17 f3?! ♗c5 18 fxe4 (if 18 ♗e3!?, as in M.Toux-M.Pytel, La Fère 2002, then 18...♘c4! would probably transpose to Hellers-Polgar) 18...dxe4 19 ♗e3 (19 ♖xe4?! ♘c6 20 ♗e3 ♘xd4 21 ♖h4 ♗f5 left Black on top in Gildardo Garcia-M.Wahls, Cuba 1996) 19...♘c4 20 ♗xe4 ♘xe3 21 ♘xe3 ♖xd4 22 ♕f3 ♖b8 and White was the one fighting for equality in F.Hellers-Zsu.Polgar, Adelaide 1988.

b) 17 ♘d2 ♗c5 18 ♘2f3 ♗b7 19 ♗f4 ♖ac8 20 ♖c1 ♕b6 and Black had powerful development in R.Kasimdzhanov-Peng Xiaomin, Genting Highlands 1998.

c) 17 ♘e3 (immediately) then following 17...♗c5 18 b3 (18 ♗f4 transposes to the main game) 18...♕xe5 19 ♗b2 ♗b7? (it could be that after 19...♕f4!, avoiding White's tactical idea, Black is just a pawn up) 20 ♘c6! turned out better for White in M.Brodsky-A.Aleksandrov, USSR Championship Moscow 1991 but hasn't been repeated since.

17...♗c5 18 ♘e3 ♕b6 19 ♘b3 ♘xb3 20 ♗xb3



Here 20 axb3?! seems wrong. The a-file doesn't help White so this is just weakening: 20...♗b7 21 ♗d3 ♗d4 22 ♕e2 f6 23 ♗xe4 dxe4 24 ♘g4 f5 25 ♘e3 ♕e6 and as both b3 and e5 are *en prise* White is clearly worse, A.Colovic-V.Dimitrov, Lazarevac 1999.

20...♗e6

After 20...♗b7, which seems to be a playable alternative, the continuation 21 ♕d3 ♗xe3 22 ♗xe3 d4 23 ♗f4 ♘c5 led to a black initiative in the game N.Motin-A.Gutow, Russia 2001. White should instead play 21 ♕g4 when Lukacs and Hazai suggest 21...♕e6! (as an improvement over Zaw Win Lay-T.Matsuo, Yangon Zonal 1998 which favoured White after 21...♗xe3 22 ♖xe3 d4 23 ♖f3 ♘c5 24 ♖g3) when Black seems to be OK.

21 ♕d3

The best option but Black is already better as we can see from the alternatives:

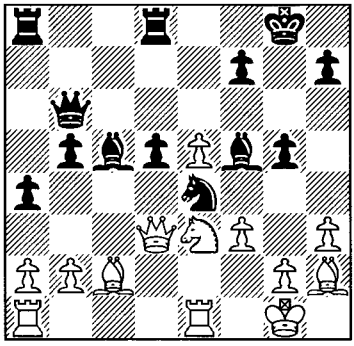
a) 21 ♗c2 ♘xf2 22 ♔xf2 d4 23 ♕f3 dxe3+ 24 ♗xe3 ♖ac8 with a clear advantage for Black, D.Saulin-M.Notkin, Moscow 1996.

b) 21 ♖e2 ♘xf2 (or more simply Wedberg's 21...d4 22 ♘g4 ♗f5 with a Black initiative) 22 ♔xf2 d4 23 ♘f1 d3+ 24 ♖e3 ♖ac8 and Black had excellent play in D.De Vreugt-F.Levin, Lvov 2001.

21...a5! 22 f3 a4 23 ♗c2 g5!

Aggressively played. White's pieces are coming under pressure on all fronts.

24 ♗h2 ♗f5



25 ♕e2?

The lesser evil is 25 fxe4, but Bologan offers the following continuation as proof that Black is still better: 25...♗xe4 26 ♕d2 ♗xc2 27 ♔h1 ♗e4 28 ♘g4 ♗e7 29 ♖f1 ♕g6 30 ♘f6+ ♔f8 31 ♖ac1 ♖a6.

25...d4?

Here Black misses 25...♗xe3 26 ♕xe3 d4 27 ♕d3 ♘g3 28 ♕d2 d3+ 29 ♕f2 ♕xf2+ 30 ♔xf2 d2! winning, as pointed out by Bologan.

26 ♗xe4?

White's turn to miss his chance: 26 fxe4! ♗g6 27 ♘d5! ♖xd5 (or here 27...d3+ 28 ♔h1 dxe2 29 ♘xb6 ♗xb6 30 ♖xe2 ♗d4 31 ♖b1) 28 ♗d3 with equal chances as analysed by Lukacs and Hazai.

26...dxe3 27 ♔h1

No better are 27 ♗xf5 ♖d2, or 27 ♗xa8 ♗d3.

27...♖d2 28 ♗xa8 ♖xe2 29 ♖xe2 ♗d3 30 ♖ee1 ♗b4 31 ♖ec1 e2 32 ♗g3 ♗d2 33 ♖g1 b4

White's rooks are totally dominated.

34 a3 b3 35 ♗e1

Giving the exchange in a desperate attempt to obtain a blockade.

35...♗e3 36 ♗c3 ♗xg1 37 ♖xg1 ♕f2 38 ♖e1 h5

Now however White is helpless whilst Black improves.

39 ♗d5 ♕c5 40 ♗b7 ♕b5 41 ♗a8 ♕c5 42 ♗b7 ♔h7 43 ♗a8 ♔g6 44 ♗b7 ♕b5 45 ♗a8 ♕c4 46 ♔h2 ♔h7 47 ♔h1 ♔g8 48 ♔h2 ♔f8 49 ♔h1 ♔e7 50 ♔h2 ♔e6 51 g3 ♕a6 0-1

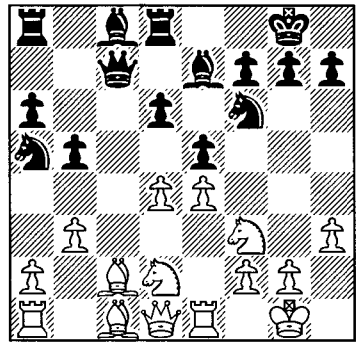
Something like 52 ♗e4 ♗xe4 53 fxe4 ♕d3 is too depressing to continue.

Game 3

A.Grischuk-R.Kasimdzhanov

Wijk aan Zee 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♖d8 14 b3



It's worth comparing play with Chapter 2, Game 14 where White plays b2-b3 in the analogous position where the c-pawns are still on the board.

14...♘c6

Note that 14...exd4 15 ♗b2 ♘c6 16 ♘xd4

transposes back to the game.

15 ♗b2 exd4

Otherwise 15...d5? is met by the unpleasant 16 ♖c1!, when 16...♕b6 17 exd5 ♘xd5 18 ♘xe5 is just good for White, J-R.Koch-Zsu.Polgar, Tunja 1989.

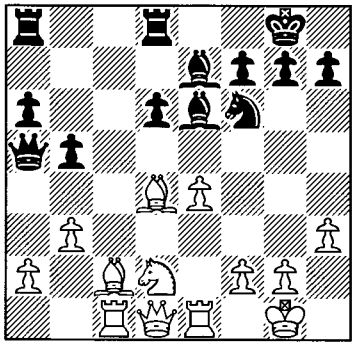
16 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 17 ♗xd4 ♗e6

Experience has shown that the bishop helps defend the king better on e6, so 17...♗b7 is inferior, e.g. 18 ♖c1 ♕a5 19 ♘f1! (Shirov doesn't bother with the niceties, he just goes straight for the throat! Even so, 19 ♗b1 ♖ac8 20 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 21 ♘f1 ♖e8 22 ♖e3 ♕d8 23 ♘g3 also gave White an edge in S.Dolmatov-Zsu.Polgar, New York 1989.) 19...♖ac8 20 ♘e3 g6 21 ♕f3 ♘d7 22 ♘g4 ♗g5 23 h4!! ♗xc1 24 ♖xc1 f5 25 ♘h6+ ♔f8 26 ♕f4 ♘e5 27 exf5 Splat! 1-0 A.Shirov-J.Fernandez Garcia, Ayamonte 2002.

18 ♖c1

The immediate 18 ♘f1 can be simply met by 18...d5(!).

18...♕a5



19 ♘f1

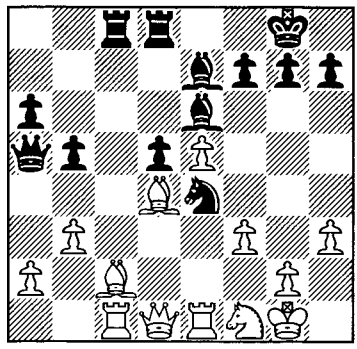
The modest 19 ♗b1 is well met by the liberating 19...d5!, when after 20 e5 ♘e4 21 ♘f1 ♖ac8 22 ♕d3, in K.Asrian-D.Pedzich, Ubeda 1999 Black could have tried 22...♗a3, as well as the game continuation of 22...g6 23 ♕e3 ♕a3, to achieve interesting and unclear play.

Black had good compensation after 21 ♘xe4?! (instead of 21 ♘f1) dxe4 22 ♖xe4 ♗a3 23 ♖c2 ♖d7 (23...♗f5!?) 24 ♖c6 g6 in Z.Almasi-Je.Piket, Monaco (rapid) 2002.

If 19 ♘f3, again the required move is 19...d5! e.g. 20 exd5 ♖xd5 21 ♖xe6!? fxe6 22 ♕e2 ♕a3 23 ♗b2 (if 23 ♕xe6+ ♔f8 24 ♖e1 ♕d6 Black defends and retains the exchange) 23...♕d6 24 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 25 ♗e4 ♖d8 26 ♗xd5 exd5 with equal chances as in A.Grischuk-S.Yuldashev, Yerevan 2001.

19...♘e8

Here again 19...d5!? comes into consideration. Then 20 e5 ♘e4 (Lukacs and Hazai suggest 20...♘d7 21 f4 g6 as worth investigating if the text proves to be inadequate) 21 f3 ♖ac8



a) 22 ♕d3 g6 (I tried 22...♗f5!? in S.Midoux-G.Flear, St.Affrique 2003: 23 ♕e3 [23 fxe4? dxe4 24 ♕e3 is bad in view of 24...♖xd4!] 23...♗g5 24 f4, when 24...♗h4! would have been fine for Black) 23 ♗b1 ♗b4 (I quite like 23...♗g5! when after 24 ♖cd1 [or 24 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 25 ♖e2 ♘c3] 24...♘c3 Black is doing well) 24 ♖ed1 ♘c3, and here White invoked favourable complications with 25 a3! ♗f5 26 axb4 ♗xd3 27 bxa5 ♘e2+ 28 ♔f2 ♖xc1 29 ♗xd3 ♖xd1 30 ♔xe2 and retained an advantage in C.Lutz-S.Yuldashev, Yerevan 2001.

b) Grischuk analyses 22 fxe4! dxe4 (following 22...♗a3 23 exd5 ♖xd5 24 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 25 ♖xc8 ♗xc8 26 ♕c2+ g6 27 ♗f2 Black has fair compensation for the pawn, but in *Informator 87* White is judged to be

slightly better, P.Svidler-A.Shabalov, Bermuda 2003) 23 ♖xe4 ♗a3 (after 23...♕xa2 24 ♘e3 ♗g5 then 25 ♔h2 intending ♖a1 is strong. There was a recent attempt to revive Black's fortunes with 23...♗g5, but after 24 ♘e3 ♕a3 25 ♕e1 ♕xa2 26 ♗b6 ♖e8 27 ♗b1 ♕xb3 28 ♖d1 ♖c6 29 ♖b4, R.Antoniewski-P.Stempin, Lubniewice 2003, White was better) 24 b4! as good for White, e.g. 24...♕xb4 (24...♕c7 25 ♘e3 ♗xc1 26 ♕xc1, or 24...♗xb4 25 ♗b3) 25 ♖b1 ♕e7 26 ♘e3 ♗c5 27 ♕d3.

All this suggests that the best chance to make 19...d5 work is to meet 20 e5 with 20...♘d7, as in the notes above.

What else can Black try?

After 19...♖ac8 20 ♘e3, Black has unsuccessfully tried 20...♖c7 21 b4 ♕xb4 22 ♗b6, E.Van Haaster-M.Solleveld, Nova College 2002 and 20...g6 21 ♘f5!, E.Dervishi-J.Estrada Nieto, St.Vincent 2002, but neither could be described as appealing! Skembris however recently tried 20...d5!?. A.Shomoev-S.Skembris, Cappelle-la-Grande 2003 then continued 21 ♗xf6 (stronger than 21 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 22 exd5 ♘xd5 23 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 24 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 25 ♖e5 ♖d8 26 ♕h5+ ♔g8 27 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 28 ♕xd5 ♕xa2, which is equal according to Skembris, e.g. 29 ♕a8+ ♗f8! 30 g3 ♕a3!; otherwise there is 21 e5?! ♘e4 after which Black isn't worse) 21...♗xf6 22 exd5 (22 ♘xd5 is best met by the immediate 22...♕xa2) 22...♗d7 (according to Skembris Black has enough compensation, but I have a feeling that White is still somewhat better) 23 ♗f5!? (critical is 23 ♕d3 g6 24 ♗b1) 23...♖xc1 24 ♕xc1 ♗xf5 25 ♘xf5 ♕xa2 with unclear play.

20 ♕d3

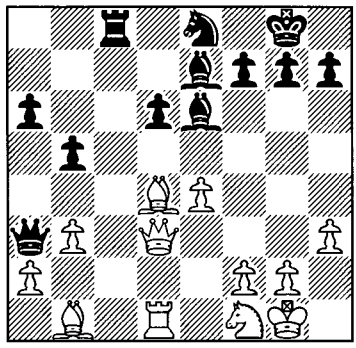
Now 20 ♘e3 can be met with 20...♗f6.

20...♖ac8 21 ♗b1

21 ♘e3 is more ambitious, but after 21...♗f6 22 e5 dxe5 23 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 Black's king is not really in danger nor are his pieces badly placed either.

21...♖xc1 22 ♖xc1 ♖c8 23 ♖d1 ♕a3

After 23...♗g5 the thrust 24 e5! is dangerous. Throughout this game it's noteworthy that Black resists the temptation to play ...g6 which blocks the b1-h7 diagonal at the cost of problems with the dark-squares



24 ♕d2

The dynamic potential of Black's game has gradually evaporated and now he's left with his backward d-pawn. White is clearly better as Grischuk now shows.

24...♗d8 25 ♘e3 ♕a5

Black may have intended 25...♗a5 26 ♕d3 ♖c1, but his queen is then trapped by 27 ♘c2.

26 ♕d3 b4?!

Creating a further weakness, but Black is short of ideas.

27 f4! ♔f8 28 f5 ♗d7 29 ♘c4 ♕b5 30 ♕g3 ♗f6

Following this move White should be able to win positionally; however after 30...♗c7 31 ♕h4 ♔g8 Black's ill-defended king becomes further exposed with 32 f6! etc.

31 ♗xf6 gxf6 32 ♔h1 ♕c5 33 ♕f4 ♗b5 34 ♘e3 ♕e5 35 ♕h6+ ♔g8 36 ♘d5 ♗c6 37 ♘b6 ♖d8 38 ♘c4?

A time trouble error. Instead 38 ♖f1! followed by ♖f4 would have been immediately decisive.

38...♕g3 39 ♕h5 d5!

Breaking out and giving hope.

40 ♗c2 ♕c3 41 ♕e2 ♔f8 42 ♖d3 ♕a1+ 43 ♗d1 ♗b5?

According to Grischuk, Black could have put up more resistance with 43...♕c1 44 ♕e1 ♕f4 45 ♕xb4+ ♔g7, but nevertheless White has an extra pawn and is well in control after 46 ♕e1.

44 ♕d2 d4 45 ♕xb4+ ♘d6 46 ♕c5 ♗xc4 47 bxc4 ♕xa2 48 ♕c7 ♔e8 49 ♖g3 1-0

Game 4

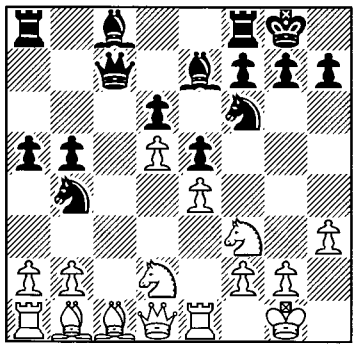
N.Short-P.Svidler

Dubai rapid 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♘c6 14 d5

Alternatives are dealt with in Game 5.

14...♘b4 15 ♗b1 a5



16 a3

Less worrying for Black is 16 ♘f1 as Black has a good game, e.g. 16...♗d7 (or here 16...♘a6!? 17 ♘3h2 ♘c5 18 ♘g3 [18 g4?! proved to be self-weakening in M.Adams-S.Agdestein, Hastings 1991/2 after 18...h6 19 ♘g3 ♘h7 20 ♘f3 ♘g5 etc.] 18...♖e8 19 ♕f3 a4 20 ♗d2 ♕b7 21 ♘f5 ♗xf5 22 ♕xf5 ♗d8, K.Le Quang-S.Conquest, Cappelle la Grande 1991) 17 ♗d2 (17 ♘3h2 ♖fc8 18 ♘e3 g6 19 ♗d2 ♘a6 20 ♕f3 ♕d8 21 b3 ♔g7 22 ♘hf1 h5, L.Stein-S.Reshevsky, Mar del Plata 1966) 17...♖fc8 18 ♘e3 (18 ♗xb4 axb4 19 ♗d3 ♗d8, D.Yanovsky-M.Botvinnik, Groningen 1946) 18...♘a6 19 ♘h2 ♘c5 20 ♕f3 ♕d8 21 h4 g6, M.Adams-V.Ivanchuk, Lucerne 1989.

The point of the text move is that because of the coming pin on the a-file, Black is denied the c5-square for his knight, unlike in these examples emanating from 16 ♘f1.

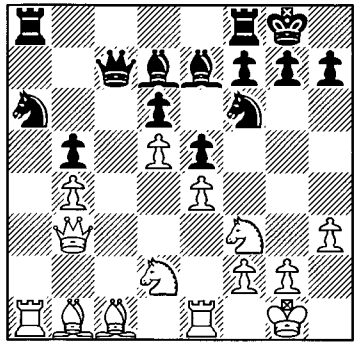
16...♘a6 17 b4 axb4

There's not much point in maintaining the tension, for instance 17...♗d7 18 bxa5 ♘c5 19 ♘b3 ♘xb3 20 ♕xb3 ♖xa5 21 ♗d2 ♖a4 22 ♗b4 with a pleasant edge, V.Kotronias-S.Skembris, Athens 1996. It's not necessary for White to capture on a5 e.g. 18 ♕b3 (rather than 18 bxa5) 18...♘h5 19 ♖a2 ♘f4 20 ♖c2 ♕d8 21 ♘f1 ♔h8 22 ♗xf4 exf4 23 ♖ce2 with an edge to White, M.Yudovich-G.Levenfish, USSR Championship 1939.

18 axb4 ♗d7

The risky pawn grab 18...♕c3 19 ♘b3 ♕xb4 20 ♗d3 ♘c7? loses to 21 ♖xa8 ♘xa8 22 ♕c2 ♕a4 23 ♗e3 ♕a6 24 ♖a1 ♕b7 25 ♖a7, T.Luther-A.Rossmanith, Bad Wiessee 1998. In this Karolyi suggests instead 20...♕c3 (rather than the lemon 20...♘c7) 21 ♗xb5 ♘c7 22 ♖xa8 ♘xa8 23 ♗d2 ♕c7 with only a small edge to White. He has the more active pieces and some space but queenside simplification limits the pressure.

19 ♕b3



19...♕b7

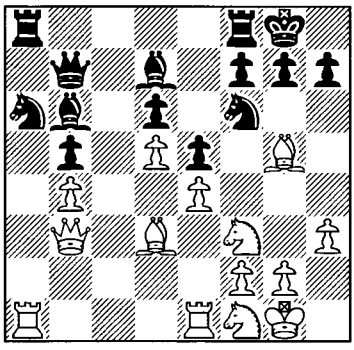
Black can again play with fire by risking

19...♘c5?! going for the win of the exchange, as in T.Luther-P.Lukacs, Budapest 1992. However following 20 bxc5 ♖xa1 21 c6 ♗c8 22 ♗a3 ♕a7 and now 23 ♖e3! (instead of Luther's inferior 23 ♗b4?!) 23...♗g4 (both 23...♘h5 24 ♕b2 and 23...b4 24 ♕xb4 ♗xh3 25 ♕b2 clearly favour White) 24 ♕b2 ♖xb1+ 25 ♕xb1 left Black with a very poor game in M.Chan-W.Kobese, Elista Olympiad 1998.

20 ♗d3 ♗d8

Karolyi gives the cautious alternative 20...♘c7 21 ♗b2 ♖xa1 22 ♖xa1 ♖a8 23 ♖a5 ♖xa5 24 bxa5 ♘a6 25 ♗a3 ♔f8 as satisfactory.

21 ♘f1 ♗b6 22 ♗g5



Black's next move leads to sharp complications but White is objectively better. So Black should have preferred 22...♔h8! 23 ♗xf6 (otherwise Black can come back unscathed to e8) 23...gxf6 24 ♘e3 (or 24 ♘h4 ♗d4 25 ♖ac1 ♖g8 26 ♗e2 ♖g7) 24...♖g8 25 ♔h2 ♘c7 and Black has active piece play in return for his damaged pawn structure.

22...♘h5? 23 ♗e7 ♖fe8 24 ♗xd6 ♗xh3 25 ♗xe5?

After 25 gxh3! Black shouldn't have enough for the piece in the complications following 25...♕d7 26 ♗c5, or 25...♘f4 26 ♗xe5.

25...♕d7 26 ♘1h2 ♗xg2 27 ♔xg2 ♖xe5 28 ♘xe5 ♘f4+ 29 ♔h1 ♕h3 30 ♖g1 ♗d4 31 ♗c2

Karolyi points out 31 ♖g3! ♕h5 32 ♖ag1 ♗xe5 33 ♖g5 ♕h3 34 ♖1g3 as winning.

31...♗xe5 32 ♕xh3 ♘xh3 33 ♘g4 ♗xa1 34 ♖xa1 ♘c7 35 ♖xa8+ ♘xa8 36 ♔g2

So after all that White has to make do with 'only' a positional advantage. Even so Black's defence isn't easy, especially in a rapid game.

36...♘f4+ 37 ♔f3 g5 38 d6 ♘b6 39 ♘f6+ ♔g7 40 e5 h6 41 ♗f5 ♔f8

Karolyi suggests 41...♘c4 42 ♘g4 ♔f8 as a better defence, but after the calm 43 ♔e4 h5 44 ♘f6 Black is still in trouble, e.g. 44...♘d2+ 45 ♔e3 ♘c4+ 46 ♔d4 g4 47 ♗d7 and Black's pawns are ready to drop.

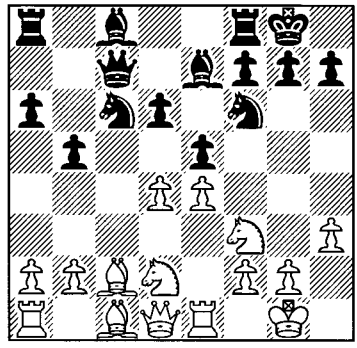
42 ♔e4 h5 43 ♘h7+ ♔e8 44 ♘xg5 ♘fd5 45 d7+ ♔e7 46 ♘xf7 1-0

Game 5

J.Rowson-M.Pein

British League, Birmingham 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♘c6



14 ♘b3

The slower 14 a3 allows 14...exd4 under satisfactory circumstances: 15 ♘b3 ♗b7 16 ♘bxd4 ♘xd4 17 ♘xd4 ♖fe8 18 ♗g5 h6 19 ♗f4 ♗f8 20 ♖c1 ♕b6 with approximate equality, J.Polgar-G.Kamsky, Dos Hermanas 1996.

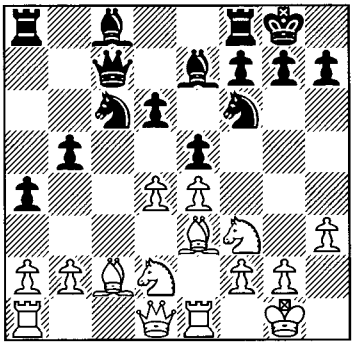
Instead 14...♗d7 can also be played, and is appropriate for those seeking a manoeuvring game: 15 ♘b3 a5 16 d5 ♘b8 17 ♗d2 a4 18 ♘c1 ♖c8 19 ♗c3 ♘a6, J.Timman-E.Torre, Tilburg 1982, or 15 b4 ♖fc8 16 ♗b3 a5 17 d5 ♘b8 18 ♗b2, J.Polgar-O.Kim, Yerevan Women's Olympiad 1996, and White has easier development but nothing concrete.

14...a5

The logical counter to the knight on b3. Keres experimented with two alternatives here, both shown to be inferior:

14...♗b7?! 15 d5 ♘a5 16 ♘xa5 ♕xa5 17 a4 ♖fc8 18 ♗d3 ♘d7 19 ♗g5, B.Larsen-P.Keres, Zurich 1959, and 14...♖d8?! 15 ♗d2 ♕b8 16 d5, V.Smyslov-P.Keres, USSR Match 1941.

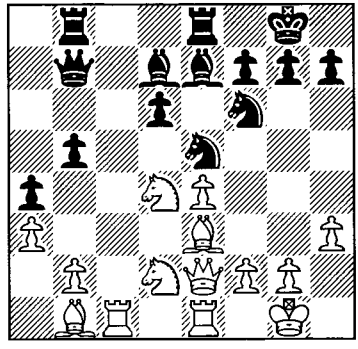
15 ♗e3 a4 16 ♘bd2



16...♗e6

Black has tried several other moves, the first of which is the most significant.

a) The sensible 16...♗d7 is also popular. In the following play the move order for both players is fairly flexible leading to numerous transpositional possibilities: 17 ♖c1 (17 a3 ♖ac8 18 ♗d3 ♘a5 19 ♕e2 ♕b8 20 ♖eb1 [White intends to open the flank with b2-b4 when he is good and ready, but Black has good harmony in his position] 20...♖fe8 21 d5 ♗d8 22 b4 axb3 23 ♘xb3 ♘c4 24 ♗g5 ♔h8 [a cool preparation to unpin] 25 ♕d1 ♘g8 26 ♗c1 and the knight on c4 is particularly noticeable but Black's pieces are in general ready to parry any White activity, O.Korneev-V.Tkachiev, Bastia 2003) 17...♕b7 (a recent high-level encounter varied with 17...♖ac8 18 ♘f1 ♕b7 19 ♘g3 ♖c7 20 ♗b1 ♖fc8 21 ♔h1 [avoiding any tricks involving ...♘xd4 followed by ...♘xf3+] 21...h6 22 ♕d2 ♗f8 23 a3 and offered a tense game in I.Smirin-I.Sokolov, Sarajevo 2002 where White retains a small pull) 18 ♕e2 (if instead 18 ♗b1, then 18...♖fc8 19 ♘f1 ♖c7 20 d5 ♘a5 21 b3 ♖xc1 22 ♗xc1 axb3 23 axb3 ♗d8, V.Anand-Je.Piket, Linares 1997, seems fine for Black) 18...♖fe8 19 ♗d3 (an interesting manoeuvre was employed in L.Dominguez-L.Bruzon, Havana 2003 after 19 a3 ♖ab8 20 ♗b1 ♗d8!? when White is restrained from ♗a2 because of the pressure on e4. The further continuation 21 dxe5 ♘xe5 22 ♘xe5 dxe5 23 ♗c5 ♖c8 24 ♗d3 didn't offer White anything, and at this point a draw was agreed) 19...♖ab8 (a reasonable attempt to improve was 19...exd4! 20 ♘xd4 ♘b4 21 ♗b1 a3! 22 b3 ♗d8 with a fine game for Black, L.Dominguez-L.Bruzon, Cuban Championship 2002) 20 a3 exd4 (the only other serious try is 20...♗d8 21 dxe5 ♘xe5! 22 ♘xe5 dxe5 when chances are equal, rather than 21...dxe5?! 22 ♖c5 ♗b6 23 ♖xb5 ♘d4 24 ♗xd4 exd4 25 ♖e5 as played in B.Ivanovic-M.Lazic, Yugoslav Championship 1993 where White had won a pawn, and after the further 25...♗e6 26 ♘g5 ♕c7 27 ♖xe6! fxe6 28 e5 h6 29 exf6 hxg5 30 ♘e4 he had a winning attack) 21 ♘xd4 ♘e5 22 ♗b1



22...♗d8 (Shirov recently introduced the line opening 22...b4 in A.Goloschapov-A.Shirov, Rethymnon 2003 which continued favourably for Black: 23 axb4?! ♕xb4 24 ♖c2 d5! 25 f4 ♘g6 26 e5 ♘xf4!; this looks like an area for future research) 23 ♘4f3! ♗a5 (23...♘g6!? is a suggestion of Wedberg's just keeping an eye on some central squares, or 23...♘xf3+ is also possible but after 24 ♕xf3 ♗a5 25 ♕g3 Wedberg prefers White slightly) 24 ♘xe5 dxe5 25 ♖ed1 ♗c6 26 b4! (M.Rytshagov-E.Gausel, Gothenburg 1998) where White retains a nagging edge due to a slightly superior pawn structure. In particular White may be able to use the c5-square.

b) Karolyi rejects the immediate 16...d5? because of 17 exd5 ♘xd5 18 ♖c1 with advantage to White. Black is just too loose in the centre and along the c-file.

c) 16...a3 17 bxa3 ♖xa3 18 ♕c1 ♕a5 19 ♗b3 ♗b7 20 ♕b2 exd4 21 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 22 ♗xd4 ♕a8 23 e5 favoured White in L.Aronin-G.Lisitsin, Leningrad 1947.

d) 16...♗a6?! (the bishop is ugly here) 17 ♖c1 ♕b7 of I.Boleslavsky-S.Reshevsky, Zurich Candidates Tournament 1953 can be met by Keres's idea 18 ♗b1 ♗d8 19 b4. Here Black cannot capture the b-pawn with his knight as it will be lost e.g. 19...♘xb4 20 d5 ♖c8 21 a3 and after 21...♘bxd5 22 exd5 ♖xc1 23 ♕xc1 ♘xd5 24 ♕c2 White has the attack as well as an extra piece. Neither is 19...exd4 20 ♘xd4 ♘xb4 21 a3 that inspiring, so Black should instead play 19...axb3! when after 20 ♘xb3 White has slightly the more comfortable game.

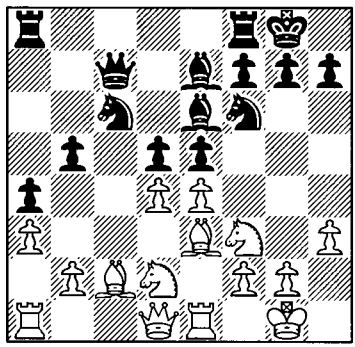
e) In P.Leko-M.Adams, Tilburg 1998 16...♘b4?! was played but as a result of the game continuation 17 ♗b1 ♗d7 18 a3 ♘c6 19 ♗d3 ♘a5 20 ♕e2 ♕b8 21 ♖ec1 ♖e8 22 ♖ab1 exd4 23 ♘xd4 b4 24 ♗b5! where White was better, it seems that 16...♘b4 is not Black's best.

All-in-all continuation 'a' is the most promising alternative.

17 a3

White can revert to 17 d5, although 17...♘b4 18 ♗b1 ♗d7 19 ♘f1 ♖fc8 20 ♕d2 ♘a6 21 ♘g3 a3 22 b3 ♗d8 23 ♗d3 ♕c3 was fine for Black in E.Geller-B.Ivkov, Havana 1965. White recently tried to spice things up with 18 dxe6!? (instead of 18 ♗b1) 18...♕xc2 19 exf7+ ♖xf7 20 ♘g5 ♕xd1 21 ♖exd1 ♖ff8 but this was only equal in V.Rajlich-P.Lukacs, Budapest 2002)

17...d5?!



A novelty of Tibor Karolyi who prepared Malcolm Pein for this game. Despite the critical nature of the move I was at first surprised that no one else has tried it.

However after taking a closer look I now suspect that it isn't quite sound, something that probably hasn't escaped Chigorin specialists and may well explain the world's lack of enthusiasm!

A couple of moves are standard:

a) 17...♘a5 18 ♗d3 (less precise is 18 ♖c1 e.g. 18...♕b8 19 ♗d3 b4 20 d5 ♗d7, S.Gligoric-P.Keres, Hastings 1964/5; and despite *ECO*'s enthusiasm for 18 ♘g5, after 18...♗c4 19 f4 ♘d7 20 ♘gf3 ♗f6 21 ♖c1 ♖fc8, W.Wittmann-C.Chellsdorp, Teesside 1974 Black had no particular problems) 18...♕b8 19 ♕e2 b4 20 axb4 ♕xb4 21 ♖eb1 (Black can't retain the tension) 21...exd4 22 ♗xd4 ♘b3 23 ♗c3 ♕b6 24 ♘xb3 ♗xb3 25 ♘d4 (Wang Pin-Wang Yuemin, China 1997) and White has the superior structure and obtains the bishop pair thus guaranteeing the

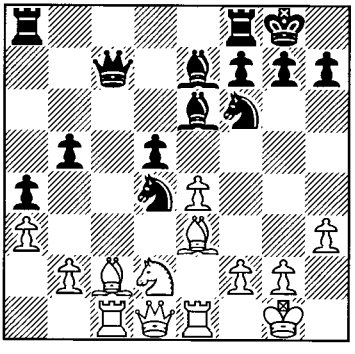
better chances.

b) The best hope for Black is probably 17...♖fc8 which has been played successfully on many occasions by Galdunts. Experience suggests that White can probably squeeze out a shade of an edge: 18 ♗d3 ♗d7 19 ♕e2 ♕b8 20 ♖eb1!? (here 20 ♖ec1 b4!? 21 ♘c4 exd4 22 ♘xd4 ♘e5, P.Herb-S.Galdunts, Bischwiller 1998, seems adequate for Black) 20...♘a5 21 d5 ♗d8 (or 21...♘c4 22 ♗g5 ♘a5 23 b4 axb3 24 ♘xb3 ♖c7 25 ♘xa5 ♖xa5 26 ♗d2 ♖a8 27 ♗b4 as in R.Kuczynski-S.Galdunts, Schoeneck 1996) 22 ♔h1 ♗b6 23 ♗g5 ♗d8 24 b4 axb3 25 ♘xb3 ♘c4 26 a4, Z.Lanka-J.Smejkal, Bundesliga 1996.

18 ♖c1

Not a bad continuation but there is a better one. After 18 exd5! ♘xd5 19 ♖c1! (instead after 19 dxe5 ♘xe5 20 ♘d4 ♗d7 21 ♖c1 ♕d6 22 ♕h5 ♘g6 23 ♘e4 ♕e5 Black wriggles out) if we compare with the note to Black's 16th move (where Black plays the immediate 16...d5) Black has the extra move ...♗e6 and White a2-a3. This may enable Black to be more competitive in the centre, but he still has problems in my opinion: 19...♕d6 20 dxe5 ♘xe5 21 ♗c5! ♘xf3+ 22 ♘xf3 or 19...♕b6 20 dxe5 ♘xe3 21 ♖xe3 and Black has no real compensation for the pawn, noting that 21...♗c5 is met by 22 ♗xh7+.

18...exd4 19 ♘xd4 ♘xd4



20 exd5

Otherwise 20 ♗xd4 ♕f4 21 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 22 exd5 ♗xd5 23 ♕h5 ♕h6 24 ♕xd5 ♖ad8 25 ♕xb5 ♖xd2 is just about okay for Black according to Karolyi.

20...♕b7

If 20...♕e5 21 dxe6 ♘xe6 22 ♖b1 ♖fc8 23 ♘f3 ♕h5, White retains an edge due to the bishop pair, but Karolyi feels that Black is fine due to the constant threat to exchange off all the queenside pawns.

21 dxe6 ♘xe6 22 ♗f5 ♖a6 23 ♕f3 ♕xf3 24 ♘xf3 ♘d5 25 ♗xe6!

If White tries to maintain the bishop pair with 25 ♗d2 then 25...♗f6 is sufficiently active for Black.

25...♖xe6 26 ♘d4 ♖e4 27 ♘xb5 ♖b8 28 ♘c3 ♘xc3 29 ♖xc3

Because of back rank problems Black cannot recuperate the pawn. Instead, however, he has active pieces pressing on White's majority.

29...f5 30 ♖c2 ♗f6 31 ♖ee2 ♔f7 32 ♔f1 ♖b3 33 ♗c1 ♔e6 34 ♖xe4+ fxe4 35 ♖c4 ♔d5 36 ♖xa4 ♗xb2 37 ♗xb2 ♖xb2 38 ♖a7 g5!

An excellent move covering the f4-square. Now the obvious capture on h7 leads nowhere, e.g. 39 ♖xh7 ♖b1+ 40 ♔e2 ♖b2+ 41 ♔e1 ♖b1+ 42 ♔d2 ♖b2+ 43 ♔c3 (if 43 ♔e3 then 43...♖b3+) 43...♖xf2 44 g4 ♖f3+ 45 ♔b4 e3 and Black achieves a comfortable draw.

39 ♔g1 h6 40 ♖a6 ♖b1+ 41 ♔h2 ♖f1 42 ♔g3 h5 43 ♖a5+ ♔d4 44 ♖f5

Winning a further pawn with 44 ♖xg5 leads to 44...h4+ 45 ♔xh4 ♖xf2 46 ♖g8 e3 and the advanced e-pawn saves the day for Black.

44...♔d3 45 ♖d5+ ♔e2 46 ♖d4 ♖xf2 47 ♖xe4+ ♔f1 48 ♖b4 ♖xg2+ 49 ♔f3 ♖f2+ 50 ♔g3 ♖g2+ 51 ♔f3 ♔g1 52 h4 g4+ 53 ♔f4 ♔h2 54 ♔g5 g3 55 ♔xh5 ♖c2 56 ♔g6 g2 57 ♖b1 ♖c6+ 58 ♔g7 ♖c5 59 ♔g6 ♖c6+ 60 ♔g7 ♖c7+ 61 ♔g6 ½-½

Game 6

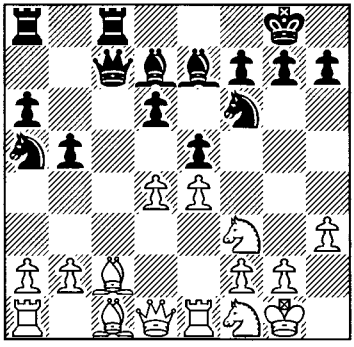
A.Grischuk-A.Zakharov

Ubeda 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 c3 d6 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♗d7

Freeing the c8-square for a rook in order to logically press on the c-file.

14 ♘f1 ♖fc8



The text move suggests that Black will concentrate his attention to the queenside. In Game 7 Black prefers the alternative idea of posting the queen's rook on this square.

15 ♘e3

Aiming for d5 or f5 but also covering the c4-square.

The rarer move 15 ♗d3 has historical significance: 15...♘c6 16 ♗e3 ♕b7 (Black could consider 16...exd4!? 17 ♘xd4 ♘e5 or 17...♘b4) 17 ♘g3 ♖c7 (more ambitious is 17...♗d8!? 18 a3 ♗b6 19 d5 ♘a5 20 ♗g5 ♘e8 21 b3 ♕a7, G.Timoshenko-S.Brenjo, Belgrade 1995) 18 ♖c1 ♖ac8 19 ♗b1 ♘e8 (another plan involves 19...♘xd4 20 ♘xd4 ♖xc1 21 ♗xc1 exd4 22 ♕xd4 ♗e6 23 b3 and now 23...d5!?) 20 ♕d2 g6 21 ♖ed1 f6?! 22 ♘e2 ♗f8 (G.Maroczy-R.Reti, New York 1924) and now 23 ♘e1 retains an edge according to Alekhine.

15...♘c6 16 ♗b3 a5

After 16...♘a5 White can keep a pull with 17 ♘d5 ♘xd5 18 ♗xd5 ♗c6 19 b3!, E.Anka-O.Eismont, Harkany 1993.

Instead 16...♕d8!? 17 a3 (17 dxe5 ♘xe5 18 ♘d4 is recommended by *ECO*) 17...♖ab8 18 d5 ♘a5 19 ♗c2 ♘c4 was prematurely agreed drawn in J.Van der Wiel-Je.Piket, Dutch Championship 1999. White retains his space edge but Black is solid and rated higher!

17 dxe5 ♘xe5

If 17...dxe5?! Black is pushed onto the back foot after 18 ♘d5 ♕d8 19 ♘g5 ♗e8 20 ♘xf6+ ♗xf6 21 ♕h5 ♗xg5 22 ♗xg5.

18 ♘d4

18 a3 is suggested by Dolmatov. That would allow White to keep the bishop on the a2-g8 diagonal without having to exchange a pair of knights.

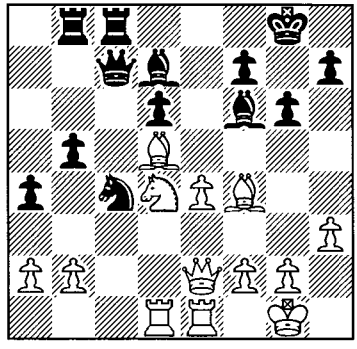
18...a4 19 ♘d5 ♘xd5 20 ♗xd5 ♖ab8 21 ♗f4 ♗f6 22 ♕h5

White's better pawn structure and active pieces yield attacking chances, but Black's defensive chances in such positions shouldn't be underestimated.

22...g6 23 ♕e2

If Black doesn't undertake anything active then Grischuk's intention was to follow-up with ♖ad1, ♔h1, ♖f1, ♗h2 and f4-f5.

23...♘c4 24 ♖ad1



24...♗e5

If 24...♕a7 then White can continue 25 ♘f3 ♘xb2 26 e5! when the complications

favour White, e.g. 26...♘xd1 27 exf6 ♕xf2+ 28 ♕xf2 ♘xf2 29 ♖e7! as pointed out by Grischuk.

25 ♗h6 ♕a7 26 ♘f3 ♗xb2 27 e5!

Cutting Black's dark-squared bishop off from his king.

27...♖e8

Black has several alternatives: 27...♗xe5? loses to 28 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 29 ♘xe5 and 27...♗c3?! leaves Black's king in trouble after 28 ♘g5! ♗xe1 29 ♗xf7+ ♔h8 30 ♕xe1. However 27...dxe5! is less clear as after 28 ♘g5 ♗e8 29 ♘e4 ♕e7 30 ♕f3 ♖b6 White has compensation for his pawns with ideas such as 31 h4 or 31 ♗g5 but Black is still in the game.

28 ♘g5 ♖xe5 29 ♗xf7+ ♔h8 30 ♕f3 ♖f5 31 ♕g3

For his pawn White has an impressive array of pieces in the vicinity of Black's king; however Dolmatov believe that Black can defend with 31...♘e5! 32 ♖e2 ♗d4. White can win back his pawn with the continuation 33 ♗e6 ♗xe6 34 ♘xe6 ♗c5 35 ♗g7+ ♔g8 36 ♗xe5 dxe5 37 ♖d5 with about equality, but I'm not sure that he can do any better.

31...♗c6 32 ♗xc4 bxc4 33 ♖xd6 ♖e8 34 ♖xe8+ ♗xe8 35 ♖e6 ♗b5 36 ♔h2 1-0

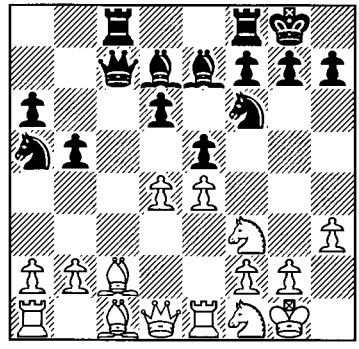
Black lost on time but after each of 36...♖xf2 37 ♕d6 ♕a8 38 ♘f3, 36...♗f6 37 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 38 ♕e5 and 36...♗g7 37 ♗xg7+ ♔xg7 38 ♕d6 ♔h6 39 ♖e7 ♕xf2 40 ♖xh7+ ♔xg5 41 h4+ ♕xh4+ 42 ♖xh4 ♔xh4 43 ♕d4+ ♔g5 44 ♔g3 White wins, as pointed out by Grischuk.

Game 7

V.Bologan-Peng Xiaomin

Shanghai 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♗d7 14 ♘f1 ♖ac8



Choosing the queen's rook. Its colleague will hope to find a role on the e-file or remain where it is to await events.

15 ♘e3

The advantage of 15 ♖e2 is that the c2-square is securely defended. The bishop may at some point be able to come to b3 and bear down on the a2-g8 diagonal, whereas from d3 this is less likely.

a) So after 15 ♖e2:

a1) The immediate 15...♘c6 eases White's task to develop smoothly: 16 ♗e3 (or 16 ♗g5 ♖fe8 17 ♖c1 ♕b7 18 d5 ♘b8 [clumsy but not serious] 19 b4 ♖c3 20 ♗d3 ♖ec8 21 ♖xc3 ♖xc3 22 ♕b1 ♗e8, L.Psakhis-D.Rogic, Ohrid 2001, and Black was able to reorganise) 16...exd4 17 ♘xd4 ♖fe8 18 ♘g3 g6 19 ♗b3!? (a negative consequence of 15...♘c6) 19...♘a5 20 ♗g5 ♘xb3 21 axb3 ♕b7 22 ♕d2, L.Bruzon-P.Acs, Cuba 2000, and despite the exchange of one of his bishops White retained some pressure.

a2) More precise seems to be 15...♖fe8 16 b3 ♘c6, played only now that White is committed to b2-b3. Then after 17 ♗b2 ♗f8 18 ♖c1 ♕b7 19 ♗b1, the best way forward is 19...exd4! (a shade too passive is 19...g6 20 dxe5 dxe5 21 ♘e3 ♗g7 22 ♖d2 ♗e6 23 ♘d5, M.Chandler-P.Thipsay, London 1989) 20 ♘xd4 ♘e5 21 ♖xc8 ♗xc8 22 ♘g3 ♘g6 23 ♖e1 d5!, which was equal in R.Farakhov-A.Obukhov, Orsk 2001

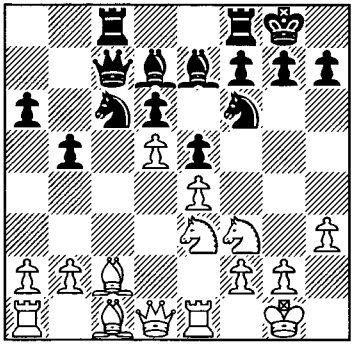
b) The other method for White, 15 ♗d3

♘c6 16 ♗e3, can be compared with Game 1, note to White's 15th, where White employs the same development against ...♖fc8. Then 16...exd4 17 ♘xd4 ♘e5 18 ♘g3 (18 ♖c1 ♕b7 19 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 [this could presumably transpose to Game 1, note to White's 15th] 20 ♗b1 ♘c4 21 ♗c1 b4! [a noteworthy idea] 22 ♘g3 g6 23 b3 ♘a3 24 ♗d3 ♘b5 equal, G.Sax-J.Estrada Nieto, Hungary 1999 and after 18 ♗b1 ♖fe8 19 ♘g3 g6 20 f4 ♘c4 21 ♗c1 ♘b6 the game D.Jakovenko-A.Obukhov, Russia 2001 remained tense) 18...♘xd3 (Obukhov now considers 18...g6 19 ♗h6 ♖fe8 20 ♖c1 ♕b7 21 ♗b1 d5! with equality as better) 19 ♕xd3 g6 20 ♗h6 ♖fe8 21 ♘gf5! with attacking chances, Ma.Tseitlin-A.Obukhov, St.Petersburg 1998.

15...♘c6

Possible is 15...♖fe8!? 16 b3 ♘c6 (16...exd4!? 17 ♘xd4 ♘c6 18 ♗b2 ♘xd4 19 ♕xd4 ♗e6 20 ♖ad1 was prematurely drawn in B.Kutuzovic-D.Rogic, Bosnjaci 2002 but opening the centre looks a plausible alternative) 17 ♗b2, and now H.Westerinen-G.Rajna, Roskilde 1978 continued 17...♗d8?! (Popovic points out 17...♗f8 with the intention of playing ...exd4. This is in fact analogous to play following 15 ♖e2 above, see note to White's 15th, except White has economised a tempo here having done without ♖e1-e2) 18 ♖c1 ♕a7 19 dxe5 dxe5 20 ♘d5 with a clear advantage for White.

16 d5



This is the main move here although White has experimented with various other ways to handle the central tension; perhaps of these 16 ♗b3 is the most dangerous alternative.

a) 16 dxe5 ♘xe5 17 ♘d4 ♖fe8 (N.De Firmian-Pr.Nikolic, Reykjavik 1986) and now 18 ♗d2 suggested by Nikolic is unclear. Instead White erred with 18 b3? allowing 18...♗xh3! as 19 gxh3 ♕c3, threatens the rook as well as ...♕xd4 followed by ...♘xf3+.

b) After the slow 16 a3?! Black should be tempted by 16...♘xd4! 17 ♘xd4 exd4 18 ♕xd4 d5! exploiting the loose nature of White's pieces.

b1) 19 b4 dxe4 20 ♗xe4 ♖fd8 and Black was already better in V.Gavrikov-V.Hort, Tunis Interzonal 1985.

b2) 19 e5 ♗c5 20 ♕f4 ♖fe8 21 ♘f5 ♘h5 22 ♕f3 ♗xf2+ 23 ♕xf2 ♕xc2, C.Hartman-LB.Hansen, Copenhagen 1996, also left White with problems.

b3) 19 exd5 ♗c5 20 ♕c3 ♗xe3 21 ♖xe3 ♕xc3 22 ♖xc3 ♖xc3 23 bxc3 ♘xd5 if anything favours Black. White's compromised structure is not fully balanced by the bishop pair, Z.Siklosi-D.Rogic, Austrian Team Championship 2000.

c) 16 ♗b1 ♘xd4 (after 16...♖fe8 17 d5 Black no longer wins a tempo against the white bishop and the knight must therefore go to a less active square) 17 ♘xd4 exd4 18 ♕xd4 ♗e6 19 ♕d1 ♘d7 20 ♗c2 ♗f6 and Black was sufficiently active in G.Sax-J.Hjartarsson, Thessaloniki Olympiad 1984.

d) The cheeky 16 ♗b3 can be met by 16...♘a5 17 ♗c2 ♘c6 repeating, but this won't suit everyone!

Black can instead play 16...exd4 17 ♘xd4 ♖fe8 to keep things going, but White will be pleased to have activated his bishop. In E.Bacrot-V.Korchnoi, Biel 2003, Black instead tried 16...♘xd4 17 ♘xd4 exd4 18 ♕xd4 ♕c5 19 ♕d3 ♖fe8 20 ♘f5 ♗xf5 21 exf5 d5 22 ♗e3 ♕b4 23 a3 ♕e4, but this gave White a small endgame advantage due

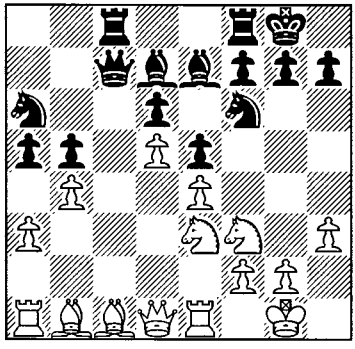
to his bishop pair.

If White, on the other hand, wants more than a repetition (apart from trying a 16th move alternative) then after 16 ♗b3 ♘a5 there are a couple of ideas:

d1) 17 ♗d5!? but this led only to equality in Pe.Popovic-A.Savanovic, Budva 2003 after 17...♘c4 18 ♗xc4 bxc4 19 ♕c2 exd4 20 ♘xd4 ♖fe8 21 ♘ef5 d5.

d2) 17 ♘d5 ♘xd5 18 ♗xd5 ♘c4 19 ♗xc4 (the unusual idea 19 ♗g5!? led after 19...♗xg5 20 ♘xg5 h6 21 ♘xf7 ♖xf7 22 ♖c1 ♕b8?! 23 b3 ♘b6 24 ♖xc8+ ♗xc8 25 ♗xf7+ ♔xf7 26 dxe5 to some advantage for White in J.Polgar-P.Acs, Essent 2002, but in this I suggest 22...♗c6! 23 b3 ♗xd5 24 exd5 ♕b6 with equality as a plausible improvement) 19...bxc4 20 ♗d2 exd4 21 ♘xd4 ♗f6 22 ♗c3 ♖fe8 23 ♕f3 ♕c5 24 ♖ad1 is a reasonable try, G.Sax-D.Rogic, Pula 2001.

16...♘b4 17 ♗b1 a5 18 a3 ♘a6 19 b4



White plays to restrict the black knight.

19...g6

Switching attention to the kingside.

a) Here 19...♖a8 intends to bring the other rook into play on the c-file and prepares to compete for the a-file after an eventual ...axb4. One could argue that Black thus changes his mind about which rook to put on c8! True, but the queenside structure has changed since Black's 14th. 20 ♗d2 ♖fc8 21 ♗d3 (21 bxa5?! frees the Black queenside and can be met by ...♘c5, ...♕b7 and ...♗d8 to win back the pawn) 21...axb4 (In both G.Kasparov-Je.Piket, Internet 2000, 21...♕b7 22 g4 g6 23 ♘f1 axb4 24 axb4 ♗d8 25 ♘g3 ♘c7, and I.Yagupov-A.Obukhov, Alushta 2002, 22 ♘c2 axb4 23 axb4 ♘e8 24 ♘h2 ♗d8 25 ♕f3 ♘ac7 26 ♘e3 ♖xa1 27 ♖xa1 ♖a8, White wasn't able to obtain much pressure) 22 axb4 ♕b7 23 ♘h2 ♘c7 24 ♘hf1?! (a slack move that hands the initiative to his opponent; instead better is 24 ♕e2 but 24...♖xa1 25 ♖xa1 ♖a8 is very solid for Black) 24...♖6a1! (deflecting the queen) 25 ♕6a1 ♘h5! 26 ♘c2 f5! with good play for Black, V.Anand-Je.Piket, Amsterdam 1993.

b) Clarifying the queenside with the immediate 19...axb4 has its supporters, but it does open the a-file for White's rook: 20 axb4 ♕b7 (20...♘6b4?? just loses a piece after 21 ♗d2 ♕c5 22 ♕b3) 21 ♗d2 ♗d8 (or 21...g6 22 ♗d3 ♘h5 23 ♗f1 ♘g7 24 ♕b3 ♘c7 25 ♘d1 f5 (a dynamic plan as White doesn't seem to be going very far) 26 ♗d3 f4, A.Brkic-D.Rogic, Bosnjaci 2003) 22 ♗d3 ♗b6 23 ♘h4 (or 23 ♕e2 ♘c7 24 ♘d1 ♖a8 25 ♘c3 with modest pressure for White, F.Hellers-J.Howell, Reykjavik 1990) 23...g6 24 ♕f3 ♗d8 25 g3 ♔h8 26 ♔h2 ♘g8 27 ♘hg2 ♘c7 28 g4, as in G.Sax-P.Cladouras, Bundesliga 1992, and Black's defence was solid after 28...♘e8 29 ♕e2 ♘g7.

20 ♗d2 ♘h5

Again Black can play 20...axb4 21 axb4 ♕b7. *ECO* quotes 22 ♗d3 ♘c7 23 ♘c2 ♘h5 24 ♗e3 ♖a8 25 ♕d2 ♖xa1 26 ♘xa1 f5 27 ♗h6 ♘g7 28 ♘b3 f4 29 ♘a5 ♕b6, M.Tal-J.Hjartarsson, Reykjavik 1986, when Tal suggests 30 ♘h2 intending ♗d3-e2-g4 with an edge. It's interesting to note however that Tal played this line with the black pieces (up to move 21 when his opponent varied) against Michael Adams two years later. An indication that the former world champion believed in Black's game.

21 ♗d3 ♕b7!?

The most aggressive continuation for Black would be 21...♘f4 22 ♗f1 f5, but after

the further moves 23 exf5 gxf5 24 ♖c1 ♕b7 25 ♖xc8 ♕xc8 26 bxa5 ♘c5 27 ♗b4 e4 28 ♘d4, as in P.Leko-P.Lukacs, Budapest 1993, White seemed to have the better of it.

22 ♘c2 ♗d8 23 ♗h6

23 bxa5 is possible but after 23...♘c5 24 ♗b4 ♘f4 25 ♗f1 f5 things start to get murky.

23...♘g7 24 ♕d2 axb4 25 axb4 ♗b6

Black reorganises his pieces first before hitting out with ...f5.

26 ♖ab1 ♘c7 27 ♘a1 f5 28 ♘b3 fxe4

If 28...♖f7 then 29 ♘a5 ♗xa5 30 bxa5 should favour White slightly.

29 ♗xe4 ♗f5 30 ♗xf5 ♖xf5

According to Bologan after 30...gxf5 31 ♖bd1 f4 32 ♘a5 ♗xa5 33 bxa5 b4 34 ♘g5 White is clearly better. Instead 31...♘ce8 32 ♘a5 ♗xa5 33 bxa5 b4 may be more solid but one still has to prefer White.

31 ♖bc1 ♖xf3!?

Trying to activate at the cost of the exchange. Again the looseness of Black's structure enables White to get the better chances after 31...♖e8 32 ♘a5 ♗xa5 33 bxa5 ♘xd5 34 a6 ♕a8 35 ♖cd1 e4 36 ♘d4 ♖fe5 37 ♕a2.

32 gxf3 ♘f5 33 ♖c6 ♘xh6 34 ♕xh6 ♘xd5 35 ♖xd6 ♘f4

Black has lively pieces for his sacrifice but after White's next move it doesn't look enough.

36 ♘d2 ♖f8 37 ♘e4

The imprecise 37 ♖xe5?! is met by 37...♕a7! with strong counterplay.

37...♗d8 38 ♖ed1 ♘e2+ 39 ♔g2 ♘d4

On 39...♘f4+ White simply plays 40 ♔h2 etc.

40 ♖1xd4!

The clearest way forward is to return the exchange; this eliminates Black's annoying knight and with it hopes of serious counterplay.

40...exd4 41 ♖xd4 ♕f7 42 ♖d3

White only has one (rather ugly) extra pawn but his king is significantly safer and this makes Black's defence very unpleasant.

42...♗e7 43 ♕d2 ♕f4 44 ♕c3 ♕f5 45 ♕d2 ♕f4 46 ♕d1 ♗f6

Certainly not 46...♗xb4?? 47 ♕b3+.

47 ♖d5 ♖b8 48 ♕d3 ♗e5 49 ♘g3 ♕f6 50 ♖xb5 ♗xg3 51 ♔xg3 ♖d8 52 ♕c4+ ♔h8 53 ♖d5 ♖f8 54 ♕e4 ♔g7 55 b5 1-0

Game 8

Y.Grünfeld-J.Pinter

Manila Olympiad 1992

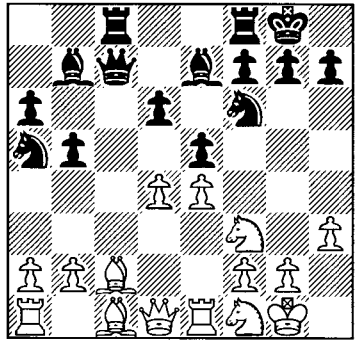
1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♗b7

This move, commonly known as Panov's variation, has fallen out of fashion.

14 ♘f1

Closing the centre with 14 d5 is examined in the next game. The text continues the standard knight manoeuvre.

14...♖ac8



White has three moves to parry Black's threat and against each of them he must be aware of the possibility of ...d5 blasting open the centre.

15 ♖e2

This slightly artificial-looking move is probably White's best here.

Both bishop moves have their negative side:

a) 15 ♗d3 d5 16 dxe5 (16 ♘xe5 is less effective here as 16...dxe4 is played with a gain of time and 16 exd5 e4 17 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 18 ♖xe4 ♗xd5 19 ♖e1 ♕b7 20 ♗f4 ♖fd8 21 ♘1d2 ♗b4 gave adequate counterplay for Black in B.Verlinsky-V.Panov, Moscow 1945) 16...♘xe4 17 ♘g3 f5 18 exf6 ♗xf6 19 ♘xe4 dxe4 20 ♗xe4. This is analogous to the variation in the note to White's 16th move starting with 16 dxe5, but here the rook is on e1 rather than e2. Now 20...♖fd8 21 ♕e2 ♖e8 is somewhat annoying for White and thus Black has sufficient play, for example 22 ♕d3 ♗xe4 23 ♖xe4 ♖ed8 24 ♕f1 ♕c2 in the game P.Ellrich-P.Ostermeyer, Helmbrechts 1963.

b) 15 ♗b1 exd4! (trying to take advantage of the bishop on b1 and rook on a1 which can be considered out of play with an open centre; however 15...d5?! is considered inferior in view of 16 exd5 exd4 17 ♗g5! when 17...h6 is met by 18 ♗xh6 gxh6 19 ♕d2 with a strong attack) 16 ♘xd4 ♖fe8 17 ♘g3 d5!? (the sharpest) 18 e5 (18 exd5 ♗b4 19 ♖f1 ♕e5 is fine for Black, M.Kozakov-A.Sulypa, Lvov 2000) 18...♗b4 19 ♗f5 ♖cd8! (with 19...♗xe1? Black gets into trouble after 20 exf6) 20 ♗g5 ♖xe5 21 ♖xe5 ♕xe5 22 ♘h5 ♘xh5 23 ♗xd8 ♘f4 and *ECO* considers that Black has enough compensation for the pawn.

15...d5!?

Instead 15...♘h5 can be met with 16 d5, whereupon play would be similar to the next game.

16 ♘xe5!

White's two alternative captures don't lead to any advantage.

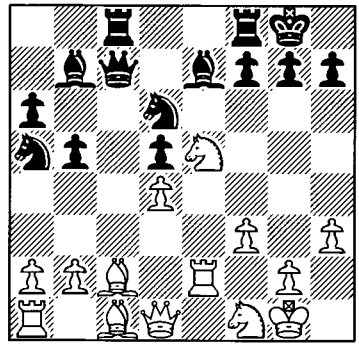
a) 16 dxe5 ♘xe4 17 ♘g3 ♖fd8! (better than 17...f5 18 exf6 ♗xf6 19 ♘xe4 dxe4 20 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 21 ♖xe4 which doesn't quite give enough play for the pawn, A.Gipslis-G.Borisenko, USSR 1960) 18 ♘f5 ♗c5 19 ♗e3 ♗xe3 20 ♘xe3 ♘c4, A.Tzoumbas-V.Kotronias, Peristeri 1994.

b) 16 exd5 exd4 17 ♘xd4 ♘xd5 18 ♗e4 ♖fd8 19 ♗f5 ♖a8, V.Hresc-Z.Siklosi, Austrian Team Championship 1999.

16...♘xe4

In later games Joszef Pinter has tried 16...dxe4 17 ♗g5 (similar is 17 ♘g3 ♖fd8 18 ♘f5 ♗d6 19 ♘xd6 ♕xd6 20 ♗e3, H.Stefansson-J.Pinter, Lyon 1994) 17...♖fd8 18 ♘g3 h6 19 ♗h4 ♘c6 20 ♘xc6 ♗xc6 21 ♘f5 ♕d7 22 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 23 ♕d2 (J.Murey-J.Pinter, French Team Championship 1994) and White retains a small pull.

17 f3 ♘d6



18 b3

White also obtained the smallest of edges in G.Milos-R.Monier, Argentina 1998 with 18 ♗f4 ♕d8 19 ♕d3 g6 20 ♖ae1 ♘f5 21 ♔h1 ♗d6 22 ♕d1 ♘g7 23 ♘e3.

18...♖fe8 19 ♗f4 ♕d8 20 ♕d2

Although White only has a small advantage, Black has the problem that it's much easier for White to improve and thus increase the pressure.

20...♗f8 21 ♖ae1 ♘c6

The knight seeks a superior emplacement to a5.

22 ♘e3 ♘e7 23 h4

White presses and Black is without counterplay; clearly White has won the opening phase.

23...♘g6 24 ♗g5 ♕c7

After 24...♗e7, Grünfeld gives 25 ♗xe7 ♖xe7 26 ♕d3 with a clear advantage, but this looks too optimistic, e.g. 26...♖ec7 intending

to come to c3. Instead, White should probably prefer 25 ♘3g4 ♗xg5 26 hxg5 ♘f8 27 g3 with attacking chances.

25 ♘d3

The c5-square is another problem for Black.

25...♗e7 26 ♗xe7 ♘xe7

Grünfeld thinks that Black should prefer 26...♖xe7, but even then after 27 h5 ♘f8 28 ♘c5 ♖ce8 29 h6 he has problems.

27 ♘c5 ♘g6 28 ♕d3 ♖e7 29 h5 ♘f8 30 ♘f5 ♘xf5 31 ♕xf5 ♖ce8 32 ♖xe7 ♖xe7 33 ♖xe7 ♕xe7 34 ♕e5

Simple exchanges expose the fact that Black has been playing most of the game with a bad light-squared bishop.

34...♕xe5 35 dxe5 ♗c8 36 ♔f2 d4

Otherwise White's king comes to this square. For instance after say 36...♘e6 37 ♘xe6 fxe6 38 ♔e3 h6 39 ♔d4 ♔f7 40 ♔c5 ♔e7 41 ♔c6 the win is only a matter of time.

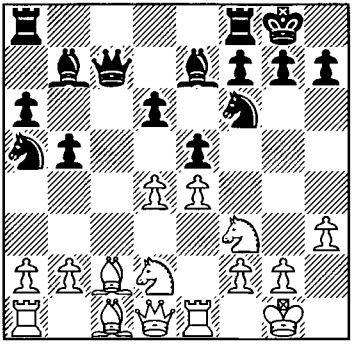
37 ♔e2 h6 38 ♗e4 a5 39 ♔d3 ♘e6 40 ♘xe6 ♗xe6 41 ♔xd4 a4 42 ♗c2 axb3 43 axb3 1-0

Game 9

A.Shirov-J.Timman

Belgrade 1995

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♗b7



14 d5

A logical move when the bishop is on b7 and the knight on a5, getting in each other's way.

14...♖ac8

The immediate 14...♗c8 is sometimes played, the idea being that the bishop heads for a better diagonal at the cost of a tempo or two:

a) 15 ♘f1 ♗d7 16 ♘g3 ♖fc8 17 ♗d3 ♕b7 18 ♕e2 ♗d8 (J.Donner-M.Euwe, Beverwijk 1952) illustrates a typical redeployment.

b) 15 ♗d3 ♗d7 16 ♖b1 ♖fc8 17 b3 g6 18 ♘f1 ♘b7 19 b4 a5 20 a3 left the knight on b7 badly-placed, Z.Hracek-J.Radulski, Budapest Zonal 2000

c) 15 b3 ♗d7 16 ♗b2 ♘h5?! (Matanovic instead suggests 16...♕a7 with ...♗d8-b6 in mind) 17 ♘f1 ♘f4 18 ♕d2 ♖fc8 19 ♘e3 ♕d8 20 ♔h2 ♗f8 21 ♘g1 ♘b7 22 g3 was much better for White, A.Kapengut-V.Dydyshko, USSR 1976.

15 ♗b1

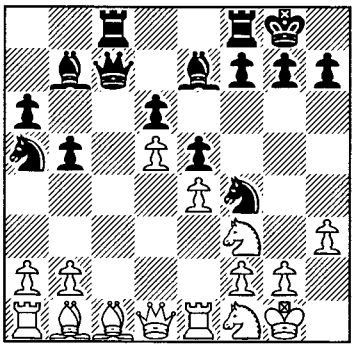
The other option is 15 ♗d3 ♘d7 (in a similar vein to the main game Black could try 15...♘h5!? 16 ♘f1 ♘f4 when after 17 ♗xf4 exf4 Black has a tempo less than in Shirov-Timman but this may not be significant: 18 ♕d2 ♗f6 19 ♖ac1 ♕b6 20 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 21 ♕xf4 ♗xb2 22 ♘g5 ♗f6 23 e5 ♗xg5 24 ♕xg5, P.Enders-R.Bernard, Rostock 1985, yields nothing for White after 24...♕d8!) 16 ♘f1 f5 (16...♘c5 17 ♘g3 ♘xd3 18 ♕xd3 ♕c2 19 ♕xc2 ♖xc2 20 ♘f5 ♖e8 21 b3 also turned out favourable for White in K.Aseev-Z.Sturua, Lvov 1985) 17 ♘g3 f4 18 ♘f5!? ♗d8 (18...♖xf5 is a shade too courageous: 19 exf5 ♘c5 20 b3 ♗f6 21 ♖b1 ♘xd3 22 ♕xd3 ♕c2 23 ♕xc2 ♖xc2 24 ♖b2 gave Black insufficient compensation in P.Leko-M.Gomez Estaban, Pamplona 1993/4) 19 b3 (19 ♗d2 ♘c4 20 ♖c1 g6 21 ♘h6+ ♔g7 22 b3 ♘c5 with interesting complications, Pe.Popovic-J.Tompa, Yugoslavia 1991) 19...g6 20 ♘h6+ ♔g7 21 ♘g4 h5 22 ♘gh2 as given by Leko is

clearly better for White as Black is still tangled up on the queenside.

15...♘h5 16 ♘f1

16 ♘xe5? can be strongly met by 16...♕xc1! 17 ♕xc1 ♖xc1 18 ♖xc1 dxe5.

16...♘f4



17 ♗xf4

At the time a new and double-edged move. White gives the bishop and hopes for easy development, but the dark-squares are weakened. The other principal line continues 17 ♔h2 ♕d7! 18 ♘e3 (White could also try 18 ♘g1 intending g2-g3) 18...♗d8 19 b3 g6 20 ♗a3 ♗a8, where Black has ideas of ...♘b7 followed by ...♗b6. Play is not clear especially as White's pieces don't seem that harmonious, I.Smirin-Vl.Litvinov, Minsk 1985.

Note however that 17 ♘e3? is bad because of 17...♕xc1, as in J.Grana-S.Fernandez, Spain 1999.

17...exf4 18 ♗d3 ♗f6 19 ♕e2

In his notes, Shirov shows a preference for 19 ♖b1, and if 19...♘c4 then 20 ♗xc4. This was tried out in Dm.Schneider-P.Mahesh Chandran, Nakhchivan 2003 when after 20...♕xc4 21 ♕d2 g5 22 ♘1h2 White went on to win the game, but things weren't at all clear.

19...♕c5

Wedberg suggests 19...♘c4!?. Now if 20 ♖ac1 ♕b6 21 b3 then 21...♘e5 is fine.

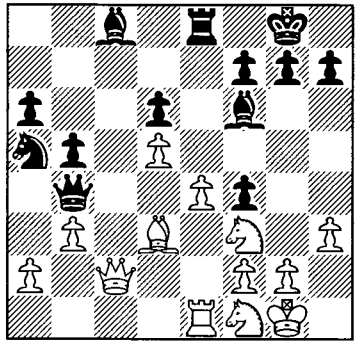
20 ♖ac1 ♕b4

20...♕xc1? is bad because of 21 ♖xc1 ♖xc1 22 ♕d2 with a nasty fork.

21 b3 ♖fe8

Black has enough activity on the dark-squares to compensate for his clumsy queenside pieces.

22 ♖xc8 ♗xc8!? 23 ♕c2!



23...♕c3?

Timman is made to regret not having tried 23...♘b7! 24 ♕c6 ♖d8 25 ♕xa6 ♘c5 26 ♕xb5 ♕c3 with adequate compensation e.g. 27 ♗e2 ♘xe4, 27 ♗b1 ♗xh3 or 27 ♗c4 ♗a6.

24 ♖c1 ♕xc2 25 ♖xc2

In the simplified position the problem of the knight on the edge becomes more significant.

25...b4 26 ♖c7 ♗b7 27 ♘1d2 ♔f8 28 ♔f1 ♖e7 29 ♖xe7 ♔xe7 30 ♔e2 ♗c3 31 ♘b1 ♗a1 32 ♘e1

Heading for the loose pawn on b4...

32...f5 33 ♘c2 fxe4 34 ♗xe4 ♗f6 35 ♘xb4

...and now the a6-pawn becomes a target.

35...h6 36 ♗d3 ♗d4 37 ♘c2 ♗a7 38 ♘c3 1-0

If now 38...♗c8, then 39 b4 ♘b7 40 ♗xa6 etc. Note how Black's queenside pieces were helpless even in an ending.

Summary

The fashionable move 13...♖d8 is a critical area particularly when the centre opens with ...d5. Further developments in the sharp tactical lines of Game 3 are to be expected over the coming years.

The slower manoeuvring of the traditional 13...♘c6 and the solid 13...♗d7 may better suit positional players but precise handling by White may yield a small pull into the middlegame.

Panov's variation 13...♗b7 is out of sorts as both 14 d5 (gumming up Black's queenside minor pieces) and 14 ♘f1 (not minding any opening of the centre) 14...♖ac8 15 ♖e2 d5 are generally accepted as favourable for White.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♖d8

13...♘c6

14 d5 – *Game 4*

14 ♘b3 – *Game 5*

14 a3 – *Game 5 notes*

13...♗b7 (Panov's Variation)

14 d5 *(D)* – *Game 9*

14 ♘f1 – *Game 8*

13...♗d7 14 ♘f1

14...♖fc8 *(D)* – *Game 6*

14...♖ac8 – *Game 7*

14 ♘f1

14 b3 – *Game 3*

14 d5 – *Game 1 notes*

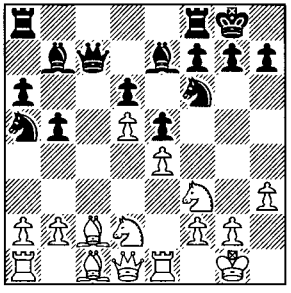
14...exd4

14...d5 – *Game 1 notes*

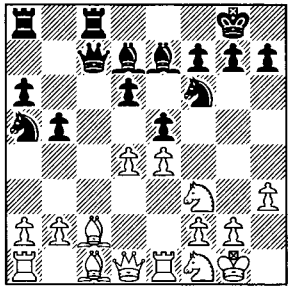
15 ♘xd4 – *Game 2*

15 ♗f4 – *Game 1*

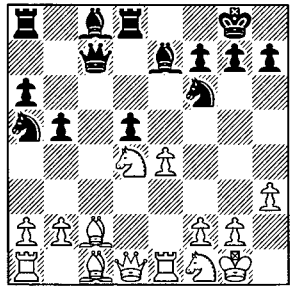
15...d5 *(D)*



14 d5

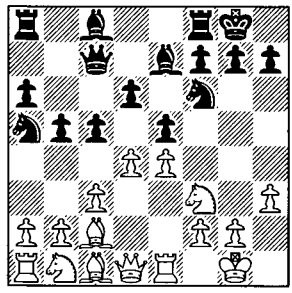


14...♖fc8



15...d5

CHAPTER TWO



Chigorin Defence: 12th Move Alternatives

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7

This is the starting point of what has been called the Classical Chigorin.

In Chapter One, White continued with 12 ♘bd2 and then Black with 12...cxd4. Here we look at various 12th move alternatives.

An important consideration in the Chigorin is the possibility of White playing d4-d5 at some point closing the centre. The immediate 12 d5 is featured in Game 10 whereas in Games 13 and 17 White also opts for d4-d5 but one move later. With the centre blocked for the moment, play switches to the wings and a period of heavy manoeuvring is in prospect. This popular method avoids tactical surprises, but with no action in the centre Black may well have sufficient time to reorganise his pieces for the defence. The most logical moment is in Game 17 where d4-d5 is played with a gain of time.

After the popular 12 ♘bd2 Black has several reasonable moves apart from 12...cxd4. In Game 12 Smyslov's 12...♗d7 continues natural development by linking rooks but puts no immediate pressure on the centre.

Another cautious plan involves 12...♖e8 with ...g6, and ...♗e7-f8-g6 to follow as in Game 11.

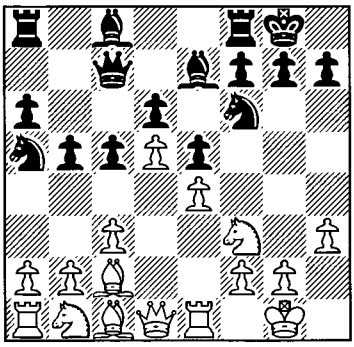
It's popular these days to bring the rook to d8, with plans of arranging a timely ...d5, either on move 12 (Games 13 and 14) or after the exchange of pawns on the c-file (see Games 1-3 in Chapter 1). Those who generally prefer having some open lines in a position may prefer 12...cxd4 13 cxd4 ♖d8 whereas those not unduly worried by the blocked centre will find the material in this chapter satisfactory. Transpositions between the two related systems are on the cards if Black soon plays ...cxd4 anyway.

The traditional 12...♘c6 invites White to release the tension in the centre. In reply the once popular 13 dxc5 is largely ignored at the highest level these days as it's considered to lack bite. I have included two model Fischer games to illustrate how play may develop, one win by him and one by his opponent! The natural 13 d5 hitting the knight is considered a better way of achieving an opening advantage as illustrated by Svidler's win over Piket in Game 17.

Game 10
N.Short-E.Bareev
Dortmund 1995

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4

♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 c3 d6 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 d5



Closing the centre at this point is not considered to be especially dangerous for Black. Black is able to place his bishop at will on d7 (its best square) and he can immediately redeploy his sidelined knight. If we compare an early d4-d5 from Chapter 3 (see Games 20-23) here White has clearly chosen a less critical moment.

12...♘c4

Black prepares to bring the knight back to the more-in-touch b6-square.

As a general rule, counterchances often involve an eventual ...f7-f5 and ...c5-c4. The former gaining space on the kingside, the latter on the other wing. These moves can be used to try and undermine the White centre. For instance, in certain cases the d5-pawn becomes dislocated from its colleagues as ...f7-f5 may remove the White e-pawn and ...c5-c4 denies support from the white c-pawn. The knight on b6 may help in this process with its influence on c4 and d5.

Black should remain flexible but at the same time be focused on his aims and ready to react on either wing. White's space advantage can turn into something more concrete if Black plays planlessly.

The alternatives suggest that the text is not the only path to a satisfactory game:

a) 12...c4!? 13 b4 (or 13 ♘bd2 ♘b7 14 ♘f1 ♘c5 [the knight is well-placed here] 15 g4 [avoiding any ideas of ...f5] 15...♖e8 16 ♘g3 ♔h8 17 ♔h2 a5 [expanding on the queenside to seek counterplay] 18 ♖g1 b4 19 ♗e3 ♗a6 20 ♘d2 ♖ab8 21 ♖b1 ♖b7 with an unclear position, A.Antunes-M.Sisniega, Novi Sad Olympiad 1990) 13...cxb3 (13...♘b7 leaves the knight badly placed) 14 axb3 (White obtains some pressure on the a-file) 14...♘e8 15 ♗d3 g6 16 ♗h6 ♘g7 17 ♖e2 f5 18 ♖ea2 fxe4 19 ♗xe4 ♘b7 20 b4 a5 and Black held firm, J.Becerro Rivera-A.Shabalov, Virginia Beach 2002.

b) 12...♘e8 13 b3 ♘b7 14 ♘bd2 g6 15 a4 ♖b8 16 axb5 axb5 17 ♘f1 ♘g7 18 ♗h6 (18 g4 is critical) 18...♘d8 19 b4 f6 20 ♖a3 ♘f7 (this knight's manoeuvre is typical of such positions) 21 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 22 ♘g3 ♗d8! 23 ♕e2 c4! and Black has the better prospects as his bishop is heading for b6 to dominate the a7-g1 diagonal, M.Sion Castro-A.Beliavsky, Leon 1994.

c) 12...♗d7 13 b3 ♘b7 14 c4 (in Z.Hracek-Pr.Nikolic, Selfoss 2002 Black's king's knight again headed for f7: 14 a4 ♖fb8 15 ♘a3 ♘e8 16 ♕e2 ♘d8 17 ♗d2 g6 18 ♘h2 f6 19 c4 bxa4 20 bxa4 ♘f7 21 ♘g4 ♗f8 and Black is ready for anything) 14...b4 15 ♘bd2 ♘e8 16 ♘f1 g6 17 ♗h6 ♘g7 18 g4 f6 19 ♘g3 and as everything has become rather blocked a draw was agreed in G.Kasparov-A.Matanovic, Banjaluka 1979.

13 a4

If 13 b3 ♘b6 14 ♗e3 ♘e8 15 ♘bd2, Black should get his kingside counterplay going e.g. 15...g6 16 ♗h6 ♘g7 17 ♘f1 f5 18 ♔h2 ♗f6 19 ♕e2 c4 offers Black adequate counterchances, I.Boleslavsky-A.Tarnowski, Krynica 1956.

13...♗d7

Otherwise 13...♘b6 is possible. White has tried the following:

a) 14 b3 (trying to transpose back to the main game could be met with...) 14...bxa4!? 15 bxa4 a5 16 ♘a3 ♗a6 17 ♗d3 c4, M.Sion Castro-J.Campos Moreno, Palma de Mallorca

1991, and Black follows up with ...♘d7-c5.

b) 14 a5 ♘c4 15 b4 cxb4 16 cxb4 ♗d7 should be OK for Black.

c) 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♖xa8 ♘xa8 16 ♘bd2 ♘b6 17 ♘f1 c4 18 ♘3h2 g6 19 g4 h5 (fighting for control of key squares) 20 ♘g3 h4 21 ♘e2 ♘h7 22 ♗h6 ♖e8 23 f4 g5 24 fxg5 (A.Kosteniuk-P.Acs, Wijk aan Zee 2003) was comfortable for Black who should now capture with the bishop and achieve a fine game.

14 b3 ♘b6

The significant alternative 14...♘a5 is also respectable: 15 axb5 (only equal was 15 b4 ♘c4 16 ♘bd2 cxb4 17 cxb4 ♖fc8, N.Ioseliani-Liu Shilan, Velden 1983) 15...axb5 16 ♘bd2 (or 16 ♗e3 ♘b7 17 ♘bd2 ♖a5 18 ♕b1 ♖fa8 19 ♕b2 ♘e8 20 ♗d3 g6 with equality, M.Kuijf-P.Van der Sterren, Budel Zonal 1987) 16...♘b7 17 ♗b2 ♖a5! (17...g6 18 c4 ♘h5 19 cxb5 ♗xb5 20 ♘c4 f6 21 ♕d2, G.Kasparov-G.Kuzmin, Tbilisi 1978, is an example from the world No.1's youth; here he can claim an edge) 18 ♘f1 ♖fa8 19 ♖xa5 ♕xa5 20 ♕d2 ♕b6 and Black has no problems on the queenside, D.Gross-A.Elmady, Egypt 2002.

15 a5

Gaining time and space but leaving the a-pawn potentially exposed.

15...♘c8 16 ♘bd2

Instructive was the continuation of G.Kasparov-V.Ivanchuk, Prague rapid 2003: 16 b4 c4 17 ♘bd2 g6 18 ♘f1 ♘h5! 19 ♗h6 ♖e8 20 ♕d2 ♗f8 21 ♘g3 ♘xg3 22 fxg3 ♘e7 23 ♖f1 f6 24 ♖f2 ♔h8 25 ♗e3 ♗g7 26 g4 ♖f8 and White was unable to make any headway.

16...g6 17 ♘f1 ♘e8 18 ♗h6

A typical move, but Bareev considers 18 g4 ♘g7 19 ♘g3 to be more precise.

18...♘g7 19 g4

At various stages White can consider b3-b4, consolidating the advanced a-pawn. He also has available an active plan based on ♘f3-h2, preparing a quick f2-f4, as Black is not yet well organised for an opening of the position.

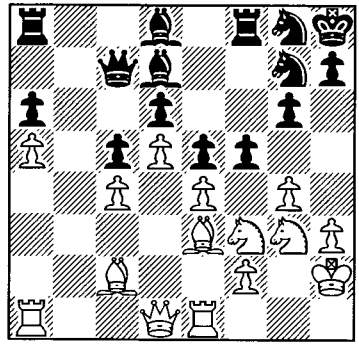
19...♗d8 20 ♘g3 ♘e7

Heading for g8.

21 c4?!

This turns out poorly as Black is able to obtain breathing space on the queenside. Wedberg prefers 21 b4 to defend the a-pawn. If instead 21 ♘d2 ♔h8 22 f4 then 22...♘g8! competes for the dark-squares.

21...♔h8 22 ♔h2 ♘g8 23 ♗e3 bxc4 24 bxc4 f5



An interesting moment. Black sharpens the struggle with ...f5 now that his king is snugly hidden away.

25 exf5 gxf5 26 gxf5 ♗xf5

With the benefit of hindsight Bareev now prefers 26...♘xf5! as 27 ♕d3 can be met by 27...♗c8! freeing the pin as h7 is now defended.

27 ♘d2!

Hoping to get a grip on the e4-square whereas after 27 ♘xf5 ♘xf5 Black's counterplay on the f-file gives him the initiative, i.e. 28 ♗xf5 ♖xf5 29 ♘d2 ♗g5 30 ♗xg5 ♖xg5 31 ♘e4 ♖f5 as pointed out by Bareev.

27...♗c8

Bareev criticises this plan (to grab the h-pawn) without offering an alternative, but retaining his best bishop isn't such a bad idea anyway.

28 ♖g1! ♕d7 29 ♖g2! ♘e7

Grabbing a hot pawn with 29...♕xh3+ is dangerous as after 30 ♔g1 ♘f6 31 ♖h2 ♕d7

32 ♘de4 Black will have problems to defend h7.

30 ♔g1 ♘ef5 31 ♘xf5 ♘xf5 32 ♕g4?

A poor move. Instead critical is 32 ♗xf5! ♕xf5 33 ♗h6 ♖g8 34 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 35 ♖a3 ♗h4! 36 ♕f1 ♕g6+ 37 ♕g2 ♗f5 38 ♖b3 when White obtains the b-file (and thus an edge) but nothing concrete.

32...♕f7 33 ♕e2 ♖b8

Black's pieces spring to life.

34 ♗e4 ♖b2 35 ♕d3 ♘xe3 36 ♕xe3

If 36 fxe3 then 36...♗xh3 37 ♖h2 ♕h5 38 ♕e2 ♕h4 leaves White with little hope.

36...♕f4 37 ♘f1 ♖f7 38 ♖a3 ♗h4 39 ♕xf4 exf4

The exchange of queens accentuates the problems in White's position.

40 ♘h2 ♖e7 41 f3

Alternatively 41 ♘f3 loses to 41...♖xe4 42 ♘xh4 ♖e1+ 43 ♔h2 ♖bb1 44 ♖g5 ♖h1+ 45 ♔g2 ♖hg1+ winning a rook.

41...♖g7! 0-1

Exchanging White's best defender leaves his king in a hopeless mess (42 ♖xg7 ♔xg7 as ...♗xh3 is coming) and no better is 42 ♘g4 ♖xg2+ 43 ♔xg2 h5.

Game 11

C.Lutz-J.Pinter

French Team Ch., Bischwiller 2003

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 h3 d6 9 c3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2

The aggressive 12 b4 has been rather forgotten, but contains some sting: 12...cxb4 13 cxb4 and now:

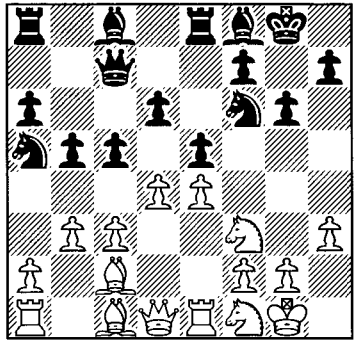
a) 13...♘c6 14 ♗b2!? (an interesting gambit whereas 14 a3 ♘xd4 15 ♘xd4 exd4 16 ♗b2 ♗e6 17 ♗xd4 ♘d7 18 ♘c3 ♗f6, I.Bondarevsky-S.Gligoric, Hastings 1961/2 was about equal) 14...♘xb4 15 ♗b3 ♘c6 16 ♘c3 ♗b7 17 ♖c1 ♕d8 18 ♘d5 ♘a5 (I suggest 18...♘xd4! 19 ♘xd4 ♘xd5 20 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 21 exd5 exd4 when White's compensation doesn't impress) 19 ♘xe7+ (19 dxe5 dxe5 20 ♗xe5, K.Klundt-C.Renner, Augsburg 1987, may offer White an edge) 19...♕xe7 is given as equal by *ECO*, but after the further moves 20 ♗a3 ♘xb3 21 axb3 ♘xe4 22 dxe5 ♖fd8 23 exd6 (E.Vasiukov-R.Kholmov, USSR Championship 1966) I prefer White.

b) 13...♘c4! (the safest way to equality) 14 ♘bd2 ♗b7 15 ♘xc4 bxc4 16 d5 a5 17 b5 a4 18 ♗xa4 ♕a5 19 ♗c2 ♕xb5 (M.Tal-R.Sanguinetti, Munich Olympiad 1958) and Black had successfully navigated the opening to equalise.

12...♖e8 13 ♘f1 g6

Less precise is 13...♗f8 in view of 14 ♗g5 (a nuisance of a move, but perhaps not the only way to obtain an edge) 14...♘d7 15 b3 ♘b6 16 ♖c1 (practical, just completing development and waiting to see Black's intentions; instead 16 ♗d2?! ♘c6 17 dxc5 dxc5 18 ♘e3 ♗e6 was more comfortable for Black in M.Matulovic-B.Ivkov, Belgrade 1964) 16...♗e6 (16...♘b7 is suggested as an improvement in *Informator 4*) 17 ♗d2 f6 18 c4 ♘b7 19 dxe5 dxe5 20 ♗d3 ♕d7 21 ♕e2, as in E.Geller-B.Ivkov, Budva 1967. Here *ECO* claims an edge for White who can quickly get a knight to d5 whereas Black cannot.

14 b3 ♗f8



15 ♘g3

After 15 ♗g5 ♗g7 16 ♕d2, V.Korchnoi-V.Smyslov, USSR Championship 1973, Black

decided to open the centre with 16...cxd4, but after 17 cxd4 exd4 18 ♘xd4 ♘c6 19 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 20 ♘g3 ♗b7 21 ♖ac1 ♖ac8 22 ♗b1 ♕b6 23 ♗e3! White retained an edge.

Delaying matters by one move with 16...♗b7 17 ♘g3 cxd4, also led after 18 cxd4 exd4 19 ♘xd4 ♘c6 20 ♘xc6 ♗xc6 21 ♖ad1 ♖e6 22 b4 to a slightly preferable game for White in E.Geller-B.Ivkov, Skopje 1969.

In L.Guliev-J.Pinter, Condom 2003 the players indulged in some heavy manoeuvring: 16...♘c6!? 17 ♖ac1 ♗b7 18 ♗b1 ♘a5 19 ♘g3 c4 20 b4 ♘c6 21 d5 ♘b8 22 ♘h4 and White retained a pull but Black was rock-solid.

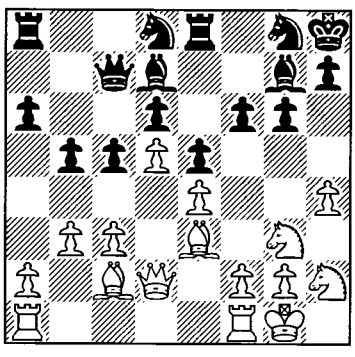
15...♗g7 16 d5 ♗d7 17 ♗g5 ♘b7

Pinter attempted to improve in a later game with 17...c4 in M.Kazhgaleyev-J.Pinter, French Team Championship Besançon 2003, but after the continuation 18 b4 ♘b7 19 a4 a5 20 axb5 ♗xb5 21 ♗a4 ♗xa4 22 ♕xa4 ♖ec8 23 ♘d2 ♘d7 24 ♗e3 h5 25 ♕b5 axb4 26 ♕xb4 he had difficulties.

18 ♕d2 ♔h8 19 ♘h2 ♘g8 20 ♖f1 f6

White is preparing to expand on the king-side, whereas Black pushes back the bishop and in the meantime generates the useful defensive square f7 for his queen's knight.

21 ♗e3 ♘d8 22 h4!



22...♘f7

Stopping White's h-pawn with 22...h5 is not without risk, White would prepare an eventual sacrifice to prise open Black's king.

23 h5 g5

Something of a concession. Instead exchanging dark-squared bishops with 23...♗h6!? comes into consideration. Eliminating one's bad bishop is a positive step, but leaving the dark-squares exposed to attack isn't, so 24 ♗xh6 ♘gxh6 25 f4 still yields a White initiative.

24 a4 bxa4?

This leads to a loss of grip on the light squares. I suggest instead 24...♖eb8, as then 25 b4 can be met with 25...cxb4 26 cxb4 ♖c8 when the queenside structure remains intact.

25 b4!

Leading to the exchange of light-squared bishops, a positional catastrophe for Black.

25...♗b5 26 ♗xa4 cxb4 27 cxb4 ♖eb8

Here 27...♗xf1 28 ♗xe8 ♖xe8 29 ♖xf1 is no improvement.

28 ♗xb5 ♖xb5 29 ♖fc1 ♕b7 30 ♖c4 ♖c8 31 ♖ac1 ♖xc4 32 ♖xc4 ♘fh6 33 ♕c3

White calmly takes possession of the c-file.

33...♕a8 34 ♖c8 ♕b7 35 ♖c7 ♕b8 36 ♖c8 ♕b7 37 ♖c7 ♕b8 38 ♗a7 ♕f8 39 ♖c8 ♕f7 40 ♖c7 ♕f8 41 ♘hf1 f5

The only hope. Otherwise ♘e3 followed by its implantation on f5 will be too strong.

42 exf5 ♘xf5 43 ♕c4 h6

After 43...♘fe7, White keeps the pressure on with 44 ♘e4! (not 44 ♘e3?! ♕d8 45 ♘gf5 ♗f6 which doesn't get far, especially as Black threatens ...♖xb4) 44...♘f6 45 ♘xd6 ♘fxd5 46 ♗c5! with a very strong attack, or in the case of 44...♘xd5, then 45 ♘xg5.

44 ♘e3 ♘xg3 45 fxg3 ♘e7 46 ♕g4 ♗f6?!

Cracking under the strain of such an onerous defensive task. Instead 46...♕f7 requires White to be precise. The most incisive is then 47 ♗c5! (47 ♕d7? can be countered by the cheeky 47...♖xb4!) 47...dxc5 48 d6 ♖xb4 49 ♖xe7 when the d-pawn should seal the day.

47 ♕e6 ♖xb4 48 ♘f5 1-0

Game 12
E.Ermenkov-I.Ibragimov
Dubai 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 ♗d7

Developing the last minor piece in this modest way was an idea developed by Smyslov and others half-a-century ago.

13 ♘f1

a) 13 b4!? is a rather direct way to seek space on the queenside. Then 13...cxb4 14 cxb4 ♘c6 (14...♘c4?! is considered more risky for Black e.g. 15 ♘xc4 bxc4 16 ♖e3 ♖fe8 17 ♗b2 ♗f8 18 ♖c1, V.Korchnoi-B.Ivkov, USSR-Yugoslavia 1958) 15 a3 ♖fc8 16 ♗b3 a5 17 d5 ♘d8 18 ♗b2 a4 19 ♖c1 ♕b7 20 ♗c2 ♘e8 21 ♘f1 g6 22 ♘g3 ♘g7 23 ♕e2 f6 24 ♗d3 ♘f7, and Black had no problems, L.Ljubojevic-R.Hernandez, Buenos Aires Olympiad 1978.

b) Closing the centre with 13 d5 when Black's pieces have room to manoeuvre shouldn't be too dangerous. Indeed this position sometimes occurs with White having an extra tempo, e.g. D.Jakovenko-Y.Balashov, Russian Championship Krasnodar 2002 went 12...♗e6!? (instead of 12...♗d7) positively provoking 13 d5 ♗d7, but then White's 14 b3 made sense, keeping an eye over events on the queenside.

Coming back to 12...♗d7 13 d5, legendary Ruy Lopez specialist Paul Keres had this position with both colours: 13...♘b7 14 ♘f1 c4 15 g4 h5 16 ♘3h2 hxg4 17 hxg4 ♕c8 (or even 17...♘h7!?) 18 ♘e3 g6 19 ♔g2 ♔g7 20 f3 ♖h8 (P.Keres-G.Friedemann, Tallinn 1935) and 13...c4 14 ♘f1 ♘b7 15 ♗e3 ♘c5 16 ♘3d2 g6 17 f4 exf4 18 ♗xf4 ♘h5 19 ♗h6 ♘g7 20 ♘e3 ♗f6 21 ♖f1 ♕d8 22 ♕f3 ♗g5 (V.Mikenas-P.Keres, Tallinn 1937) and in both cases Black can look forward to a satisfactory middlegame.

c) Over the years 13 dxe5 has been played on many occasions, but it seems to me that modern White players recognise that this simplified approach doesn't push Black as much as keeping the tension.

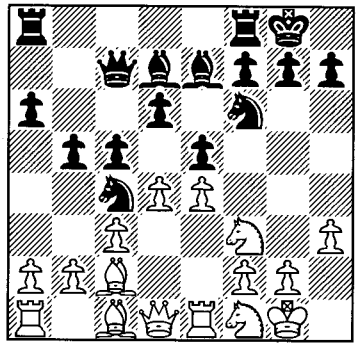
Here are some sample lines, which are by and large reasonable for Black. Note that, as a rule, Black should cover the target squares d5 and f5 whereas the manoeuvre ...c5-c4, followed by ...♘a5-b7-c5 should offer chances of counterplay: 13...dxe5

c1) 14 ♕e2 c4 15 ♘f1 ♖ad8 16 ♘e3 ♗e6 17 ♘f5 ♗xf5 18 exf5 ♖fe8, A.Onischuk-Je.Piket, Biel Blitz 1999.

c2) 14 ♘f1 ♘c4 15 b3 ♘b6 16 a4 c4! 17 a5 cxb3!, I.Boleslavsky-V.Smyslov, 1946.

c3) 14 ♘h2 ♖ad8 15 ♕f3 ♖fe8 16 ♘hf1 ♗e6 17 ♘e3 c4 (17...g6 is simpler) 18 ♘f5 ♗f8 (Ftacnik recommends 18...♘b7 19 ♘f1 ♘c5, bringing the queen's knight to bear down on d3) 19 ♘f1 ♘d7 20 ♘1e3 ♘c5 21 ♘d5 ♗xd5 22 exd5 ♕b7, E.Mortensen-PH.Nielsen, Danish Championship 1994.

13...♘c4



With the bishop on d7 there is a double reason for White to think about bringing his knight to e3: There is less pressure on the e4-pawn and Black is not covering the d5-square that well.

The reasoning behind 13...♘c4 is to firstly watch e3 and if the knight is booted back, then from b6 it helps to protect d5.

The non-committal move 13...♖fe8 has

been played occasionally:

a) 14 ♘e3 g6 15 ♗d2 ♗f8 16 ♖c1 ♘c6 17 d5 ♘e7 18 c4 gives White an edge due to a space advantage allied to well-organised pieces, F.Olafsson-B.Sliwa, Marianske Lazne 1961.

b) 14 d5 c4 15 g4 h5! (with the thematic kingside counter) 16 ♘3h2 hxg4 17 ♘xg4 ♗xg4 18 hxg4 ♘h7, J.Struk-I.Ibragimov, Fuerth 2001.

c) 14 b3 g6 (for 14...cxd4 15 cxd4 ♖ac8 see Chapter 1) 15 ♗g5 ♘h5 16 ♗xe7 ♖xe7 17 ♘e3 ♘f6 18 ♖c1 (or 18 ♕d2 ♖ae8 19 ♖ad1 ♘b7, M.Tal-W.Unzicker, Moscow 1982) 18...♘b7 19 b4 c4 20 a4, yields some pressure for White, L.Stein-A.Matanovic, Tel Aviv Olympiad 1964.

Finally, 13...cxd4 14 cxd4 followed by either rook to c8 is known from Chapter 1.

14 ♘g3

White has several alternatives of which the latter is perhaps best:

a) *ECO* considers 14 ♕e2 as favourable, but is rather optimistic about White's chances: 14...♖fe8 15 b3 ♘b6 16 dxe5 (I don't rate this idea unless White can organise ♘d5 early, which is not the case here) 16...dxe5 17 c4 ♘h5 18 ♗d2 ♖ab8 19 a4 bxa4 20 bxa4 ♗d6 21 a5 ♘c8 22 ♗a4 ♗xa4 23 ♖xa4 ♘a7 24 g3 ♘f6 25 ♖a2 ♘c6 and Black was slightly better in V.Topalov-A.Frolov, Biel Interzonal 1993.

b) After 14 a4, Keres suggests 14...cxd4 15 cxd4 ♖ac8 although in practice placing the other rook on c8 has been more popular.

c) 14 d5 is analogous to a number of other lines covered both here and in other games. Here is another example: 14...g6 (Hübner likes this plan, see another game between the same opponents in the note to Black's 14th) 15 ♗d3 ♘b6 16 ♗h6 ♖fb8 17 g4 c4 18 ♗c2 ♗f8 19 ♗g5 (the exchange of these bishops is generally fine for Black if White can't exploit the kingside dark squares) 19...♗g7 20 ♘g3 ♘a4 21 ♖b1 ♘c5, with an interesting game in prospect. White will hope to achieve something on the kingside whereas Black intends ...a5 and ...b4, S.Dolmatov-R.Hübner, Bundesliga 1992.

d) Exchanging a pair of knights with 14 ♘e3 eases Black's space problems, e.g. 14...♘xe3 15 ♗xe3 ♖fc8 (15...g6 intending ...♘h5 is recommended by Hübner) 16 ♖c1 ♗c6 17 ♘d2 cxd4! (17...♕b7 18 d5 ♗d7 19 c4 is less promising for Black) 18 cxd4 ♕b7 19 d5 ♗e8 20 ♕e2 ♗d8! (A.Karpov-T.Petrosian, Milan Match 1975) and with the bishop coming to b6 Black has equalised.

e) 14 b3! ♘b6 15 ♘e3 (looks critical) 15...c4 (Ibragimov, who is a leading expert in this line, avoided the standard ...c4 move in a recent encounter: 15...♖fe8 16 dxc5 dxc5 17 c4 ♗f8 18 ♗b2 g6 19 a4 bxa4 20 bxa4 a5 21 ♖b1 ♖a6 22 ♗c3 ♗h6 23 ♘d5 ♘fxd5 24 cxd5 f6, R.Paramos Dominguez-I.Ibragimov, Ubeda 2001 with reasonable chances for Black) and now there are two noteworthy moves:

e1) 16 bxc4 has been played many times: 16...♘xc4 17 ♘xc4 bxc4 18 ♗a3 (here 18 a4 ♖fe8 19 ♗e3 ♕a5 20 ♕d2 ♖ab8 of V.Korchnoi-T.Petrosian, Candidates Tournament 1962 was only equal) 18...♖fe8 (the threat was 19 ♘xe5) 19 ♕e2 (or 19 ♖b1 g6 20 ♘h2 ♗c6 with a satisfactory game for Black, M.Wahls-R.Hübner, Munich 1992) 19...♗f8 20 ♘d2 ♖ec8 (surely 20...exd4!? 21 cxd4 c3 22 ♘b3 a5 is more combative) 21 ♖eb1 ♕a5 22 ♗b4 ♕c7 23 dxe5 dxe5 24 ♗xf8 ♔xf8 25 ♖b4 kept the pressure on in J.Nunn-W.Unzicker, Bundesliga 1989, but Black played too passively.

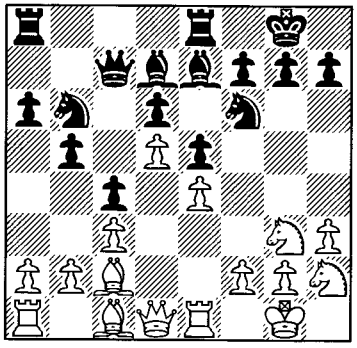
e2) 16 ♗a3!? ♖fe8 17 ♕d2 a5 (criticised by Ernst but 17...♖ac8 18 ♗b4 ♗f8 19 ♖ad1, B.Simonovic-S.Vukovic, Yugoslav Championship 1946, left White in control) 18 bxc4! (now Shirov is ready to simplify, as ...a5 has taken away the a5-square from Black's queen and weakened the b5-square) 18...♘xc4 19 ♘xc4 bxc4 20 d5 (Shirov later proposed 20 ♖ad1 as preferable) 20...♗f8 21 ♕e2 g6 22 ♘d2 ♖ec8 23 ♔h2 ♖ab8 24

♖ab1 ♖b5 25 ♖xb5 ♗xb5 26 ♖b1 with white pressure, A.Shirov-Je.Piket, Wijk aan Zee 1998.

14...♖fe8

Otherwise the alternative plan starting with 14...g6 led to a satisfactory game for Black in S.Dolmatov-R.Hübner, Manila Interzonal 1990: 15 d5 ♘e8 16 a4 ♘g7 17 b3 ♘a5 18 axb5 axb5 19 ♗h6 ♘b7 20 ♕d2 ♖fb8 21 b4 f6 22 ♘h2 ♘d8.

15 d5 ♘b6 16 ♘h2 c4



Gaining space on the queenside and access to the c5-square. However White has designs on the central d4-square, an influential square for a knight. Alternatively 16...b4 has been played but in the following example Black suffered for having ceded the c4-square to his opponent: 17 cxb4 cxb4 18 b3 ♕b7 19 ♗d2 ♘c8 20 ♗d3 ♗d8 21 ♕e2 a5 22 ♘hf1 ♘a7 23 ♘e3 ♘b5 24 ♘gf5 ♕b8 25 ♕f3 ♘d4 26 ♘xd4 exd4 27 ♘c4 ♗e7 28 ♗f4 ♖d8 29 e5, Y.Kruppa-A.Frolov, Podolsk 1989.

17 f4!

In general, the disadvantage of an early f2-f4 is the risk of losing control of the dark squares, but here Black's pieces are not well placed to compete actively in the centre.

17...exf4 18 ♗xf4 ♘a4 19 ♖b1 ♘c5 20 ♘f3 ♕b6 21 ♘d4 b4 22 ♔h2 a5

Although Black has made some progress, White's piece disposition is by far the most menacing.

23 ♕f3 b3 24 axb3 cxb3 25 ♗d3 a4

After 25...♘xd3 26 ♕xd3 Ermenkov intended ♘gf5 and ♕g3 with an attack.

26 ♘df5 ♗f8 27 ♗g5 ♗xf5 28 ♘xf5 ♘fd7 29 ♗f1 ♘e5 30 ♕g3 ♘cd7

Black organises his central defences, but White now presses on the light squares.

31 ♘d4!

Intending ♗b5 and so forcing a clumsy reply.

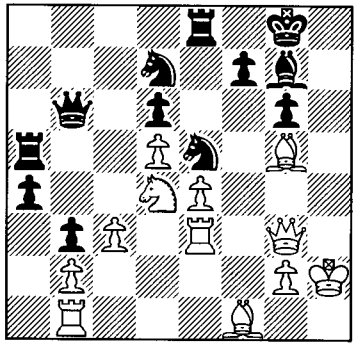
31...♖a5 32 h4

Anticipating ...g6.

32...g6?!

Ermenkov points out Black's best defence: 32...h5!, as 33 ♗e2 g6 34 ♗xh5? fails to 34...gxh5 35 ♗d8+ ♘g4+ with check!

33 h5 ♗g7 34 hxg6 hxg6 35 ♖e3



With two of Black's major pieces out of touch on the queenside White just probes away on the other wing. Ibragimov must have been alarmed by the prospect of facing ♕h4 and ♖h3 so he tries to fight back.

35...f6?!

A panicky move that weakens the e6-square. Black can instead delay this move, e.g. 35...♘c5 (intending ...a3 with counterplay) 36 ♗e2 (36 ♕h4?! is premature due to 36...f6!) 36...a3 37 bxa3 ♖xa3 38 ♕h4 f6! (38...♘ed7? is too slow after 39 ♖h3) 39 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 40 ♕xf6 ♕d8 with chances to hold the ending.

36 ♗f4 ♔f7 37 ♗e2!

This bishop is heading for g4 and then e6.

37...♖h8+ 38 ♔g1 ♗h6 39 ♗g4 ♗xf4 40 ♕xf4 ♘c5 41 ♖f1 ♕d8 42 ♗e6+ ♔e8 43 ♖h3!

43 ♕xf6? would be naive as after 43...♕xf6 44 ♖xf6 a3 Black's counterplay would be very dangerous on the queenside.

43...♖xh3 44 ♗xh3 ♕e7 45 ♕h4 a3 46 bxa3 ♖xa3 47 ♘b5!

In *Informator 78* Ermenkov gives 47 ♖xf6 ♘f7 48 ♗e6 as winning, but this seems too optimistic as after 48...♖a1+ 49 ♔h2 b2 50 ♘c6 b1Q 51 ♗xf7+ ♔d7 Black is ready to give perpetual.

47...♖a5 48 ♕h8+ ♔f7?

Here 48...♕f8! resists, e.g. 49 ♘xd6+ ♔e7 50 ♘c8+ ♔e8 with a repetition for White but can he play for more? Ermenkov intended 51 ♕h7 but was aware of the resource 51...♘xe4. However this isn't the end of the story as 52 d6! (but not 52 ♕c7? ♕c5+) 52...f5 (52...♘xd6? fails to 53 ♖xf6! ♕xf6 54 ♕g8+) 53 ♖d1 b2 54 ♕b7 still yields winning chances for White.

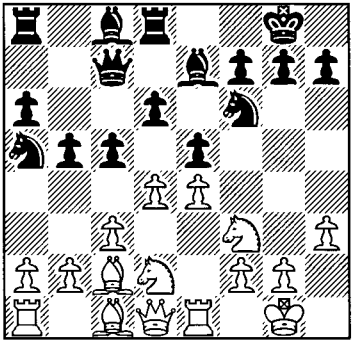
49 ♘d4 ♕e8 50 ♕h7+ 1-0

Game 13

P.Leko-R.Kasimdzhanov

Yerevan 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 ♖d8



This is similar, and can transpose, to the popular 12...cxd4 13 cxd4 ♖d8 of Chapter 1, Games 1-3. White now has a wide choice but must be aware that Black may at some point be ready for ...d5.

13 d5

Closing the centre is far from the only way to handle the position:

a) 13 dxe5?! is not really appropriate as this opens the d-file for Black's rook, e.g. 13...dxe5 14 ♕e2 ♗b7 15 ♘f1 c4 16 ♘g3 g6 17 ♗g5 ♗c6 (D.Isonzo-S.Skembris, Bratto 2002) and Black has good play with ...♘b7-c5 to follow.

b) 13 a4 ♗d7 (linking rooks) 14 ♘f1 cxd4 15 cxd4 ♘c6, eyeing the weakened b4 and giving Black an easy game in L.Dominguez-R.Kasimdzhanov, Yerevan 2001.

c) 13 ♘f1 cxd4 (13...d5?!, as played in the original game I.Boleslavsky-P.Keres, Zurich Candidates Tournament 1953, unfortunately fails to 14 dxe5! dxe4 15 ♘1d2! exf3 16 exf6 ♗xf6 17 ♕xf3 ♗e6 18 ♘e4 ♗e7 19 ♕h5 with a white initiative according to Vasiukov, although 19 ♘g5 looks even simpler to me) 14 cxd4 transposes to Chapter 1, see Games 1-2.

d) For 13 b3 see the next game.

13...c4 14 ♖e3

This defends the c3-pawn and thus prepares White for b2-b4.

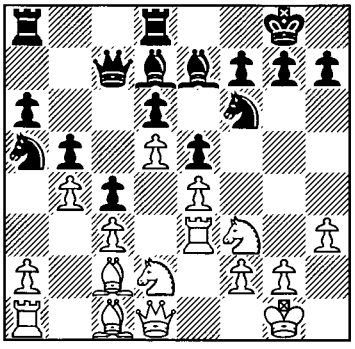
If instead 14 ♘f1 ♘b7 15 g4 (or 15 ♘g3 ♗d7 16 ♘h2 ♘c5 17 f4 a5 18 ♔h1 b4 19 ♘f3 g6 20 ♖f1 ♗b5 21 ♗e3 b3, P.Murdzia-Pi.Staniszewski, Polish Championship 2003 with excellent counterplay for Black), Black counters with 15...h5! 16 ♘3h2 (16 gxh5!? is the latest try as in D.Arutunian-V.Golod, Pardubice 2002 where after 16...♗xh3 17 ♘3h2 ♕c8 18 ♘e3 [Golod suggests the immediate 18 ♕f3 as a possible improvement for White] 18...♘c5 19 ♕f3 ♔h7 20 ♔h1 ♖h8 21 ♖g1 ♔g8 chances were balanced) 16...hxg4 17 ♘xg4!? (or here 17 hxg4 ♘h7 18 ♔g2 ♗g5 19 ♗xg5 ♘xg5 20 ♕d2 ♕e7 21 ♘g3 g6 22 ♖h1 ♔g7 with equality,

M.Rytshagov-M.Voiska, Cappelle-la-Grande 1993) 17...♗xg4 18 hxg4 ♘h7 19 ♖e3 ♗g5 20 ♖h3 ♗xc1 21 ♕xc1 ♕e7 22 ♘g3 ♕g5 again with equality, as in T.Bakre-E.Vladimirov, Calcutta 2001.

14...♗d7

The game P.Enders-A.Delchev, Budapest 1995 varied with 14...♘b7 15 b4 cxb3 (instead 15...♗d7 transposes back to the main game) 16 axb3 ♗d7 (Kasimdzhanov instead prefers 16...a5!?) 17 ♗a3 ♘c5 18 b4, but was somewhat preferable for White.

15 b4



15...♘b7

Lukacs and Hazai suggest 15...cxb3 followed by activating the king's bishop with 16 axb3 ♖dc8 17 ♗a3 ♗d8 18 ♖c1 ♕b8 19 ♗d3 ♗b6 with equality.

16 a4 a5!

Fighting for influence on the queenside.

17 axb5 ♗xb5

The attempted improvement 17...axb4 of T.Luther-C.Arduman, Istanbul 2003 was unsuccessful e.g. 18 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 19 cxb4 ♗xb5 20 ♘b1! ♗e8 21 ♖a3 and White was in control.

18 ♘b1 ♗e8 19 ♖e1 ♘d7 20 ♗e3 ♘b6 21 bxa5?

Better is 21 ♕e2! leaving the knight on b7 distinctly restricted. Then if 21...axb4 22 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 23 cxb4 f5, White can simply take a pawn with 24 ♗xb6 ♕xb6 25 ♕xc4. Instead Black should try 21...♖dc8! 22 ♖c1 f5! 23 ♘bd2 axb4 when matters are far from clear.

21...♘xa5 22 ♘a3 ♖db8 23 ♘d2 ♘b3!

Simplifying to equality.

24 ♘xb3 cxb3 25 ♗xb3 ♕xc3 26 ♗d2 ♕d4 27 ♖a2 ♘a4 28 ♘c2 ♕c5 29 ♕f3 ♕b5 30 ♘b4 ♘c5 31 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 32 ♗c2 h6 33 ♖b1 ♕c4 ½-½

Game 14

T.Luther-A.Graf

Ohrid 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 ♖d8 13 b3

Keeping Black's knight from the c4-square and retaining the tension, at least for one more move.

13...♗d7

Here 13...cxd4 14 cxd4 exd4 15 ♗b2 ♘c6 16 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 17 ♗xd4 transposes to Game 3 in Chapter 1.

14 d5

14 ♘f1 turns out to be very similar to 12...cxd4 lines that are covered in Chapter 1. The principal difference is that here White spends a couple of tempi manoeuvring with his knight and consequently Black has time to fully develop in peace: 14...cxd4 15 cxd4 ♖ac8 16 ♘e3 ♘c6 17 ♗b2 exd4 18 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 19 ♗xd4 ♗e6 20 ♕f3 (or 20 ♖c1 ♕b7 21 ♕f3 ♘d7 with either ...♗f6 or ...♘e5 in the air) 20...♘d7 21 ♖ad1 ♗f6 was about equal in O.Korneev-J.Baron Rodriguez, Cocello de Ortigueira 2002.

The text move closes the centre only now that the knight on a5 hasn't access to c4. Black therefore intends to reroute his sidelined steed via b7 and d8 (and ultimately f7) which, at some point, requires moving the rook which no longer has a role to play on d8, hence Black's next move.

14...♖dc8!?

There are a couple of alternatives worth

looking at:

a) 14...g6 15 ♘f1 c4 16 b4 ♘b7 17 ♗g5 (otherwise 17 ♗e3 a5 18 a3 ♖a6, O.Korneev-J.Estrada Nieto, Dos Hermanas 2002, is similar but 17 a4!? may be the most testing, see 14...c4 below) 17...a5 18 a3 ♖a6 19 ♘g3 ♖da8 20 ♖c1 axb4 21 axb4 ♕d8 22 ♗e3 ♘e8 23 ♗b1 ♘g7 with a comfortable game as in M.Brodsky-Je.Piket, Wijk aan Zee 1995.

b) 14...c4 15 b4 ♘b7 16 a4 a5 17 ♗a3 (with an edge according to Piket; this has since been tested in practice...) 17...axb4 18 ♗xb4 ♘c5 19 axb5 ♗xb5 20 ♗xc5 ♕xc5 21 ♗a4 ♘d7 22 ♗xb5 ♕xb5 23 ♖b1 ♕c5 24 ♖b4 (M.Adams-E.Torre, Bled Olympiad 2002) and one has the impression that Piket was right!

15 ♗b2?!

15 ♘f1 is preferred by Lukacs and Hazai, with the intention of retaining the bishop on the c1-h6 diagonal.

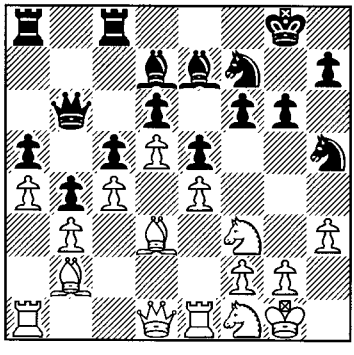
15...g6 16 ♗d3 ♘h5 17 ♗f1 ♘b7

After 17...♘f4, the temporary outpost cannot be maintained due to 18 ♔h2 followed by g3.

18 a3 ♘d8

From here the knight is aiming for the f7-square. It gets out of the way and becomes a useful defensive piece covering some important squares around its king.

19 c4 ♕b6 20 ♗c3 b4 21 ♗b2 f6 22 ♗d3 a5 23 a4 ♘f7 24 ♘f1



With the queenside seemingly blocked for the duration it makes sense to displace the Black king away from the future area of action.

24...♔f8!? 25 ♘g3 ♘f4

Instead 25...♘xg3 26 fxg3 would give White some potential play on the f-file.

26 ♘e2 ♘xd3 27 ♕xd3 ♔e8 28 ♘h2 ♔d8 29 f4 ♔c7 30 ♖f1 ♖g8 31 ♘g4 ♖af8 32 ♖f2 ♔b7

Chances are balanced. White has some space on the kingside, but Black's king is very well placed and his position remains rock-solid.

33 ♖af1 ♕d8 34 ♘g3 ♗xg4 35 hxg4 ♕d7 36 g5?!

Lukacs and Hazai consider this to be inferior to either 36 fxe5 ♘xe5 37 ♗xe5 fxe5, or 36 f5. I don't like the former but the latter just looks equal.

36...exf4 37 ♖xf4 ♘xg5 38 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 39 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 40 ♖xf6 ♕e7?!

Better is 40...♖e8! 41 ♕e3 ♖e5 with an edge to Black..

41 ♕f1 ♖g7 42 ♕f4 ♖f7

Instead 42...♘f7?! gives White a strong initiative with 43 ♖e6 ♕d8 44 e5! ♘xe5 45 ♘e4

43 e5!

A fine positional sacrifice sealing the e5-square and weakening the c5-pawn.

43...dxe5 44 ♖xf7 ♘xf7 45 ♕e3 ♔b6 46 ♘e4 ♘d8

White's next move is coming anyway.

47 d6 ♕a7 48 ♘xc5

Alternatively 48 ♕xc5+ ♔b7 49 ♕xa7+ ♔xa7 50 ♔f2 ♔b6 51 c5+ ♔c6 52 ♔e3 ♘e6 is also equal as neither side can make progress.

48...♔c6 49 ♕f3+ e4!

Of course not 49...♔xc5?? 50 ♕e3+, but 49...♔xd6? is also bad after 50 ♕f6+.

50 ♕xe4+ ♔xd6 51 ♕d4+ ♔e7 52 ♔h1

52 ♕g7+ gets nowhere after 52...♘f7.

52...♕c7 53 ♕e4+ ♔f7 54 ♕d5+ ♔g7

55 ♕d4+ ♔g8 56 ♕d5+ ♔g7 57 ♕d4+ ♔g8 58 ♕d5+ ½-½

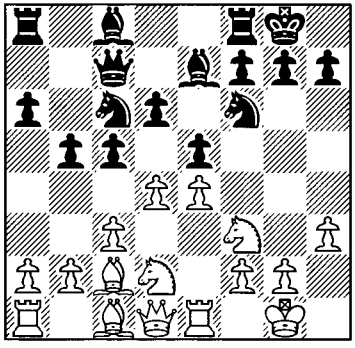
Game 15

R.Fischer-M.Filip

Curaçao Candidates 1962

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 ♘c6

The traditional approach putting pressure on the d4-square.



13 dxc5

With the d-pawn under pressure White usually resolves the tension now with 13 d5 or the text (named after Rauzer) move.

However some rarer alternatives are worth mentioning:

a) 13 a3 ♗d7 14 b4 cxd4 15 cxd4 ♖fc8 with a position typical of Chapter 1, e.g. 16 ♗b3 a5 17 ♗b2 axb4 18 axb4 ♖xa1 19 ♗xa1 exd4 20 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 21 ♗xd4 ♗e6 with near equality, E.Gufeld-A.Karpov, USSR 1971.

b) 13 ♘f1 cxd4 14 cxd4 takes us back to Chapter 1.

c) 13 ♘b3 ♗b7 (again Black can play 13...cxd4 with transposition to Chapter 1 or 13...a5!? 14 d5 ♘d8 [the knight is heading for c5] 15 ♘bd2 c4 16 ♘f1 ♘b7 17 g4 ♘c5 18 ♘g3 ♖e8 19 ♗e3 ♗f8 with a tense struggle, E.Alekseev-A.Lugovoi, St.Petersburg 2002) 14 d5 ♘b8 15 c4 ♘bd7 (better than 15...bxc4 16 ♘bd2) 16 ♗d2 b4 17 ♘c1 ♘e8 18 ♘d3 g6 19 ♗h6 ♘g7 20 g4 and a draw was agreed, D.Velimirovic-A.Karpov, Budapest 1973.

13...dxc5 14 ♘f1 ♗d6 15 ♘h4 ♘e7

Otherwise 15...g6 16 ♗h6 ♖d8 17 ♕f3 ♘e8 18 ♘e3 f6 19 ♘d5 ♕f7 is somewhat preferable for White, who simply took the bishop pair with 20 ♘b6, V.Smyslov-M.Botvinnik, Moscow Match 1957.

16 ♕f3 ♖d8

An attempt to vary from 16...♗e6 17 ♘g3 ♕c6 18 ♘hf5 ♘xf5 19 ♘xf5 ♗xf5 20 ♕xf5 when White had a persistent edge, M.Tal-M.Filip, Reykjavik 1957.

17 ♘e3 ♕b7 18 ♘g4 ♘xg4 19 hxg4

Being able to capture with the h-pawn reinforces White's nagging bind and he may even have ideas of using the h-file.

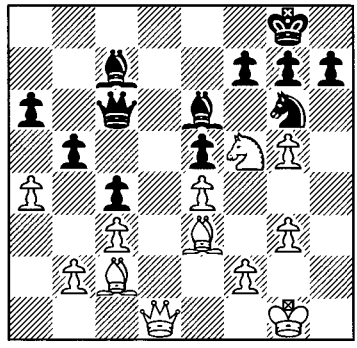
19...♘g6

If 19...♕d7!? then 20 g5! rather than 20 ♘f5 ♘xf5 21 exf5 ♗b7 looks the most troublesome for Black.

20 ♘f5 ♗e6 21 g5 ♗c7 22 ♗e3

White retains an edge due essentially to the relative activity of the knights.

22...c4 23 ♖ed1 ♖xd1+ 24 ♖xd1 ♖d8 25 g3 ♖xd1+ 26 ♕xd1 ♕c6 27 a4



27...♔f8?

A serious error. Better is 27...♕d7 when White would probably try and invade on the queenside with 28 ♕a1.

28 ♕a1?

Continuing with his plan but missing 28 ♕h5! (Bisguier) when 28...♔g8 loses to 29 ♕xg6! hxg6 30 ♘e7+.

28...♗c8 29 ♕a3+ ♔g8 30 axb5 axb5 31 ♕a7 ♗b7 32 ♔h2 ♕a6 33 ♕c5 ♕c6 34 ♕b4

The exchange of queens would ease Black's defensive task.

34...♗c8 35 ♗c5 ♗d8 36 ♗e3 ♗c7 37 ♔g1 ♗e6 38 ♕a3 ♗c8 39 ♔h2 ♗e6 40 ♕a1 ♗c8 41 ♕b1

As he's not getting anywhere Fischer decides to change tack.

41...♗e6 42 ♔g1 ♗c8 43 b3 ♗e6 44 bxc4 ♗xc4

Here 44...bxc4 also comes into consideration. In either case pressure on the queenside is light, but the cramping effect of the knight on f5 is a nuisance for Black.

45 ♗d3 ♗xd3 46 ♕xd3 ♔f8

If 46...♗a5 then 47 ♗d2 threatens ♕d6 to exchange into a winning ending.

47 ♕b1 ♕c4 48 ♕d1 ♕c6 49 ♕b3 ♔g8 50 ♕b4 ♕d7 51 ♔h2

This is nearly zugzwang, e.g. 51...♗d8 52 ♕d6; 51...♗b8 52 c4; and 51...♕c6 can be met by the flashy 52 ♕e7! ♗a5 53 f3.

51...♕e8 52 ♕c5 ♕d7 53 ♔g2 ♗b8 54 ♕b6 ♗c7 55 ♕c5 ♗b8 56 ♕b6 ♗c7 57 ♕b7 ♘f8 58 ♗b6! ♗xb6 59 ♕xb6

Black still can't shift the White knight as 59...g6 goes down to 60 ♘h6+ ♔h8 61 ♕f6 mate.

59...♘e6

So Black loses a pawn and the game.

60 ♕b8+ ♕d8 61 ♕xb5 ♘xg5 62 ♕xe5 ♘e6 63 ♘d4 ♘f8 64 c4 ♘g6 65 ♕d5 ♕c8 66 ♘f5 1-0

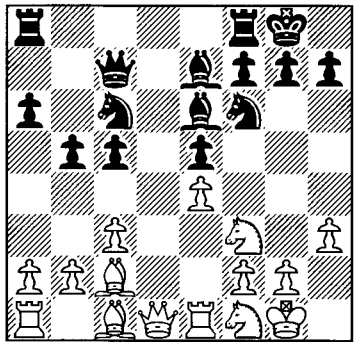
Game 16

R.Fischer-R.Kholmov

Havana 1965

A famous tournament where Fischer played by telex due to political problems between the US government and Cuba.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 c3 d6 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 ♘c6 13 dxc5 dxc5 14 ♘f1 ♗e6



This is nowadays considered to be Black's best way of handling Rauzer's 13 dxc5.

15 ♘e3 ♖ad8 16 ♕e2 c4

Best. The older 16...g6 doesn't fully equalise, e.g. 17 ♘g5 ♗c8 18 a4 ♕b7 19 axb5 axb5 20 h4 ♗d6 21 ♘d5 ♘h5 22 ♘f3 f6 23 ♗h6 ♖f7 24 ♖ed1, V.Smyslov-M.Botvinnik, World Championship, Moscow 1957.

17 ♘g5

After 17 ♘f5, Black does best to continue with 17...♖fe8! when he has no problems, for instance 18 ♗g5 ♘d7 19 ♗xe7 ♘xe7 20 ♘g5 ♘f8 21 ♖ad1 f6 22 ♘xe6 ♘xe6 23 ♕g4 ♘xf5 24 exf5 ♘c5, G.Andersson-LA.Schneider, Eksjo 1976, or 18 ♘3h4 ♔h8 19 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 20 ♕f3 ♘d7 21 ♘f5 ♕f8 22 ♗e3 ♘c5, L.Kavalek-A.Karpov, Caracas 1970.

17...h6!

An interesting positional decision. White is invited to take the bishop pair and double Black's pawns and yet this constitutes an effective defence, or rather preparation for a counterattack on the 'd' and f-files.

18 ♘xe6 fxe6 19 b4?

A poor move as soon becomes clear. White has other options:

a) 19 b3 ♗c5 and here:

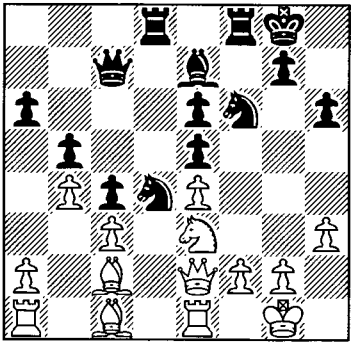
a1) 20 ♖f1 ♖c8 21 a4 ♕f7 22 axb5 axb5 23 bxc4 b4 with active piece play for the pawn, L.Kavalek-M.Cuellar, Sousse Interzonal 1967.

a2) 20 bxc4 b4 (obtaining dark-squared play in compensation for the pawn) 21 ♗b2 bxc3 22 ♗xc3 ♘d4 23 ♗xd4 exd4 24 ♘d1 d3!? 25 ♗xd3 ♕e5 26 ♘e3 ♘h5 27 ♘g4? (27 ♕c2 is unclear) 27...♖xf2! 28 ♘xe5 ♖f1+ and mates, T.Mull-B.Lengyel, Dortmund 1988.

a3) 20 ♖d1 ♘d4! 21 cxd4 exd4 with good compensation, A.Suetin-Nei, USSR 1966.

b) Suetin quotes the following curious reference; 19 a4 ♗c5 20 axb5 axb5 21 ♖f1 ♕b6 22 ♔h1 ♘e7 23 g3 with a complex game between the readers of *Zarya Vostok* and the readers of *Pravda Ukraina* 1969(!).

19...♘d4!



This is even stronger than in the note above as the b4-pawn is loose and there is no pressure on Black's c-pawn.

20 cxd4 exd4 21 a3 d3 22 ♗xd3 ♖xd3

Material equality is re-established and Black has the more active pieces as well as a protected passed pawn.

23 ♘g4 ♔h7 24 e5 ♘xg4 25 ♕e4+ g6 26 ♕xg4 ♖f5 27 ♕e4 ♕d7 28 ♗e3 ♕d5

Black's major pieces are dominant.

29 ♕xd5 ♖xd5 30 f4 g5!

This devalues White's majority.

31 g3 gxf4 32 gxf4 ♖f8 33 ♔g2 ♔g6!

The king heads for f5.

34 ♖g1 ♖d3 35 ♔f3+ ♔f5 36 ♖g7

Hoping to ease his pains through activating the rook to harass from behind.

36...♗d8 37 ♖b7 ♖g8 38 ♖b8

If 38 ♖f7+ then 38...♔g6 39 ♖b7 ♔h5, whereupon 40 a4 is met by 40...♗h4 etc.

38...♖g7 39 a4 h5

But not 39...♗h4?! which is met by 40 ♖f8+.

40 axb5 axb5

With Black threatening ...h4 and ...♖g3+ there is no hope left.

41 ♖xb5 ♗h4 42 ♔e2 ♖g2+ 43 ♔f1 ♖h2 44 ♔g1 ♖e2 45 ♗b6 c3 46 ♔f1 ♖h2 0-1

Game 17

P.Svidler-Je.Piket

Tilburg 1998

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 ♘c613 d5 ♘d8

After 13...♘a5 14 b3 (if 14 ♘f1 then 14...♘c4 etc. makes sense comparing with analogous variations in Chapters 2 and 3) 14...♗d7 (Black has two tempi less than the variation starting 12...♗d7 13 d5, and even with a closed centre this can be significant!) 15 ♘f1 ♘b7 (a position played by Hungarian GM Bela Lengyel on countless occasions) 16 ♘3h2 c4 17 b4 a5 18 ♘g3 g6 19 ♕f3 ♖a6 20 ♗g5 ♕d8 21 ♗h6 ♖e8 22 a3 with some pressure for White, P.Leko-B.Lengyel, Budapest 1993.

14 a4 ♕b7

Not ceding the a-file lightly and covering b5.

If instead 14...♖b8 15 axb5 axb5 16 b4, and then:

a) 16...♘b7?! (holding onto c5 but otherwise passive) 17 ♘f1 ♗d7 18 ♗e3 ♖a8 19 ♕d2 ♖fc8 20 ♗d3 g6 21 ♘g3 ♗f8 22 ♖a2

and White retained some pressure, A.Karpov-W.Unzicker, Nice Olympiad 1974.

b) The 'bad' knight on b7 really should be heading for f7. Even so in the game L.Dominguez-Rom.Hernandez, Santa Clara 2000 White obtained an attack after 16...c4 17 ♘f1 ♘e8 18 ♘g3 g6 19 ♘h2 ♘g7 20 ♖f1 f6 21 f4 ♘f7 22 f5 g5 23 h4.

c) 16...♘e8 17 ♘f1 g6 18 g4 f6 19 ♘g3 ♘f7 (Black digs in around his king so White switches to the a-file) 20 ♗e3 ♗d7 21 ♕e2 ♘g7 22 ♖a3 (H.Pinson-P.Palmo, corr 1980) and White retains a nagging initiative

d) 16...♘d7!? hasn't been tested at a high level. The c5-square is secure but Black is rather gummed up.

15 ♘f1

Here Svidler points out that the line 15 b4 c4 16 ♘f1 ♘e8 17 ♘3h2 allows play with 17...f5(!).

15...♘e8 16 ♘3h2 f6

Although there is nothing dramatically wrong with 16...f5, after 17 exf5 ♗xf5 18 ♗xf5 ♖xf5, White can try 19 b3 with an edge according to Svidler as the option of playing c3-c4 will enable White to consolidate his d-pawn.

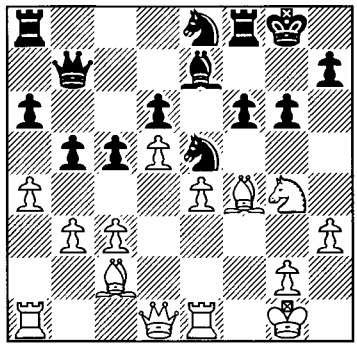
17 b3

Not altogether necessary but trying to keep his options open on this wing before pressing on the other. Alternatively 17 ♘g3 g6 18 f4 exf4 19 ♗xf4 ♘f7 20 ♘f3 ♗d7 yields a typical position. White has the more active game and retains a small edge but Black has managed to find good defensive squares for his knights, V.Jansa-Z.Nikolic, Vrnjacka Banja 1982.

17...♘f7 18 f4 exf4 19 ♗xf4 ♘e5 20 ♘e3 g6 21 ♘eg4 ♗xg4?!

Svidler criticises this move, but still prefers White after both 21...♘g7 22 ♘h6+ ♔h8 23 ♘f3, and 21...h5 (a bit loosening in the long term) 22 ♘xe5 fxe5 23 ♗e3. Perhaps 21...b4 is the most accurate.

22 ♘xg4



22...♘xg4?!

22...b4 is suggested by Svidler, forcing White to make a decision. If he blocks the wing, he may not be able to break through on the kingside. However if he opens lines with 23 cxb4 Black may obtain counterplay.

23 hxg4!

At first sight a surprising choice, but this enables White to use the h-file and the forward g-pawn helps cramp the black game.

23...♘c7 24 ♖f1 ♖f7 25 ♕f3 b4 26 ♗d2 a5 27 cxb4 cxb4 28 ♖ac1 ♖af8

Wedberg suggests 28...♘a6, intending to come to c5, but Svidler shows why this is in fact unsatisfactory: 29 ♗d3 ♘c5 30 ♖xc5! dxc5 31 e5 with serious problems for Black.

29 ♗d3 ♘a6 30 ♗xa6

Exchanging off the knight and thus leaving Black helpless on the c-file.

30...♕xa6 31 ♖c6 ♕a7+ 32 ♗e3 ♕d7 33 ♖fc1 ♖a8 34 ♖c7 ♕e8 35 ♗d4 ♗d8 36 ♖7c6 ♗e7 37 ♖c7 ♗d8 38 ♖7c6 ♗e7 39 ♖1c4 h6 40 ♖c7 ♗d8 41 ♖7c6 ♗e7 42 ♖c7 ♗d8 43 ♖xf7 ♕xf7 44 ♕f4 ♕d7

Neither 44...♕f8 (because of 45 ♖c6 ♗e7 46 ♖c7 ♕d8 47 ♖b7 ♕f8 48 ♗e3) nor 44...♕e7 (45 ♖c6 g5 46 ♕f5 ♔g7 47 e5!) defend for long either.

45 ♖c6 ♗e7 46 ♕xh6 ♕xg4 47 ♖c7 1-0

Amongst others, White plans 48 ♗xf6(!).

Summary

I consider the modern 12...♖d8 and the traditional 12...♘c6 to be the most trustworthy. Both of them provoke White to release the tension early when Black is able to react accordingly.

In each of these systems White's dxe5 shouldn't be too worrying. The problem with d4-d5 in general is that Black has less space and it's often just a shade easier for White to switch from one wing to another and back again.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2

12 d5 *(D)* – *Game 10*

12 b4 – *Game 11 notes*

12...♘c6

12...♖e8 – *Game 11*

12...♗d7 (Smyslov's System) – *Game 12*

12...♖d8

13 b3 *(D)* – *Game 14*

13 d5 – *Game 13*

Others – *Game 13 notes*

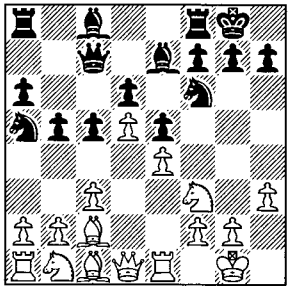
13 dxc5 (Rauzer)

13 d5 – *Game 17*

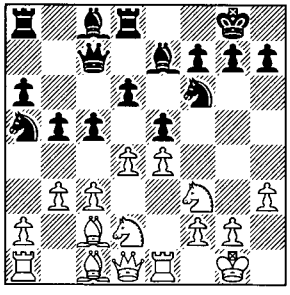
13 a3 – *Game 15 notes*

13...dxc5 14 ♘f1 ♗d6 – *Game 15*

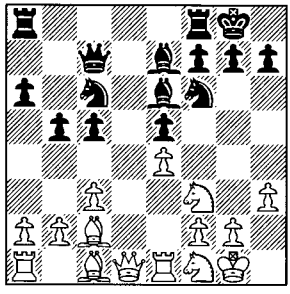
14...♗e6 *(D)* – *Game 16*



12 d5

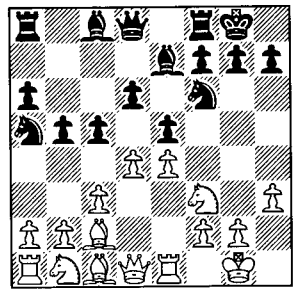


13 b3



14...♗e6

CHAPTER THREE



Black's 11th move Alternatives

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4

The traditional Chigorin inaugurated by 11...♕c7 is the best-known of Black's 11th move options. In this chapter we notice that alternatives lead to varied types of position and naturally the choice for players of the black pieces should be aimed at finding the variation that best suits one's individual style.

The second most common move (after 11...♕c7) is Keres's 11...♘d7 (Games 24-27) which keeps the tension allowing White a say in the future shape of the centre.

Hebden's provocative gambit variation (Game 19) leads to smooth development for Black at the cost of a pawn.

Liquidation by Black of two pairs of central pawns, as in Game 22, allows Black to have free piece play at the cost of a slightly inferior structure.

In total contrast, the utterly closed centre of Games 20, 21 and 23 leads to manoeuvring on both flanks before the two sides make further contact. White's space advantage makes it easier for him to prepare for line-opening, but Black is not without chances to obtain counterplay, as well illustrated in Game 21.

If White wishes to play d4-d5, the best moment is when it immediately gains time (by hitting Black's knight) or when Black's light-squared bishop is on b7 where it is less influential (with a blocked centre) than on d7.

The plan of opening the c-file for Black is normally associated with Chapter One, but in Game 18 Ponomariov tries it immediately before White's knight has committed itself to d2.

One of the most dynamic options is for Black to time the exchange of his e-pawn for White's c-pawn as in Game 25.

Game 18

A.Morozevich-R.Ponomariov

Moscow 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 cxd4!?

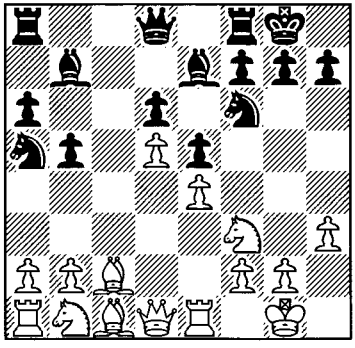
A surprising choice. Until recently this was considered premature as White has the option of using the c3-square to develop his knight. The modern interpretation is that this really isn't such a problem.

In Chapter 1 we examined Panov's Attack 11...♕c7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♗b7 which is more popular. There White has already 'committed' his knight to d2.

12 cxd4 ♗b7

A later game saw Morozevich (as Black!) adding his own interpretation to this line: 12...exd4!? 13 ♘xd4 ♖e8 (the d-pawn being isolated is a negative factor in the black camp in such positions, but he is generally able to keep the balance by creating sufficient play against the exposed e4-pawn) 14 ♗g5 h6 15 ♗h4 ♘d5! 16 ♗xe7 ♘xe7 17 ♘d2 (so the knight prefers d2 after all!) 17...♗b7 18 a4 ♕b6 19 ♘4b3 ♘ac6 20 axb5 axb5 21 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 22 ♘f1 ♘e5, when a draw was agreed in the game P.Leko-A.Morozevich, Wijk aan Zee 2002.

13 d5!



Closing the centre could well be White's best chance to obtain something out the opening. Instead 13 ♘bd2 exd4!? 14 ♘xd4 transposes to Game 22.

13...♖c8

Alternatives haven't been very successful:

a) 13...♘c4 14 a4 bxa4 15 ♗d3 ♘b6 16 ♘c3 ♘fd7 17 ♗e3 ♔h8 18 ♘xa4 ♘xa4 19 ♕xa4, M.Sion Castro-V.Smyslov, Oviedo 1992, where White has a promising queenside initiative.

b) 13...♗c8 and then

b1) 14 ♗d3 ♗d7 15 ♗e3 g6 16 b4 ♘b7 17 ♘c3 ♖c8 18 ♕d2 and White has harmonious pieces and the better options, P.Leko-LB.Hansen, Copenhagen 1995. Note in particular how the knight on b7 is likely to be a long-term headache for Black.

b2) 14 ♘c3 ♗d7 15 ♘e2 ♖c8 16 ♘g3 ♕c7 transposes to a position that could arise from Chapter 1. A typical continuation could then be 17 ♗d3 ♖fe8 18 ♖b1 ♗d8 19 b3 as in V.Ciocaltea-M.Johansson, Havana 1966. Black's pressure on the c-file is not really hampering White's organisation and White has the more promising piece disposition and thus can claim an edge.

14 b3

Instead 14 ♘bd2 ♕c7 should be compared to play from Chapter 1.

14...♕c7 15 ♗d3

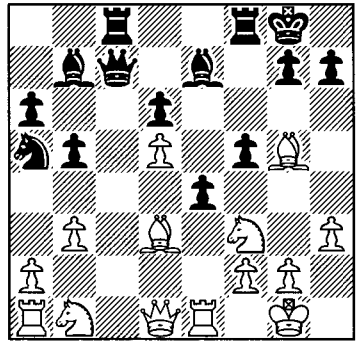
15 ♖e2?! allows the tactical shot 15...♘xe4!?, as immediately capturing on e4 loses back a bishop in return. This isn't the end of the matter however as after 16 b4! ♘f6 (if 16...♘c3?! 17 ♘xc3 ♕xc3 18 ♖b1 ♘c4, then 19 ♗f5 threatens 20 ♖c2 as well as 20 ♗xc8) 17 bxa5 ♗xd5, Black has a piece less but has adequate compensation (good active development, two central pawns and a third ready to drop) in Morozevich's opinion.

15...♘xe4

The best try here could be 15...♘d7, e.g. 16 g4 (possible is 16 ♗a3!? but not 16 ♘bd2?? in view of 16...♕c3) 16...♘c5 17 ♗c2 ♘d7 18 ♖e2 with a small edge for White.

Otherwise 15...♗xd5? is just bad: 16 exd5 e4, and now 17 ♗d2! put Black in trouble in A.Kapengut-A.Hennings, 1970.

16 ♗xe4 f5 17 ♗d3 e4 18 ♗g5



18...♗f6

Morozevich criticises this move but believes that White is clearly better anyway, e.g. 18...♖fe8 19 ♗xe7 ♖xe7 20 b4 ♘c4 21 ♗xc4 ♕xc4 22 a4, or 18...♗xg5 19 ♘xg5 exd3 20 ♘e6 ♕f7 21 ♕xd3! ♖fe8 22 ♘d2.

19 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 20 ♗e2 exf3 21 ♗xf3

White has emerged with much the better game despite his lack of development! Black's minor pieces are kept out of the game by White's pawns, and once White does get his knight and queen's rook into play then Black's lack of cohesion will begin to tell.

21...b4

Too passive is 21...♗a8 22 ♘d2 ♘b7 23 b4 ♖ff8 24 ♘b3, when White has everything under control.

22 ♘d2

Or even 22 a3, when the combative 22...♕c2 23 ♘d2 ♕xd1 24 ♖exd1 ♖c2 25 axb4 ♖xd2 is coolly met by 26 ♖xa5 winning a pawn.

22...♖ff8

Instead after 22...♕c5!?, then 23 ♖c1 ♕xc1 24 ♕xc1 ♖xc1 25 ♖xc1 ♖f7 26 a3 bxa3 27 b4 a2 28 bxa5 ♖c7 29 ♖a1 ♖c2 is less clear. White should prefer 23 ♕e2 keeping control.

23 a3!

Putting the poorly placed black knight in mortal danger.

23...♕b6 24 axb4 ♕xb4 25 ♖a4 ♕c3 26 ♖e3 ♕b2 27 ♘f1 ♖c5

Neither alternative is much of an improvement: 27...f4 28 ♖e1 ♕c3 29 ♘d2, with ♘e4 to follow, and 27...♖c1 28 ♕d3 f4 29 ♖e7 ♕f6 30 ♕e2 ♘xb3 31 ♖xb7 ♘c5 32 ♖bb4 ♘xa4 33 ♖xa4 etc.

28 ♕e1

An illustration of the dangers of neglecting the a5-knight in the Main line Lopez!

28...♖c1

28...♘xb3 still loses a piece to 29 ♖b4.

29 ♕xa5 ♕b1 30 ♗e2 f4 31 ♖f3 g5 32 ♗d3 ♕b2 33 ♖c4 1-0

Game 19

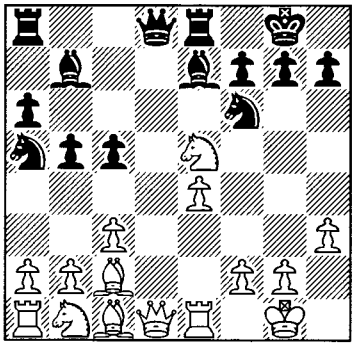
D.Gormally-M.Hebden

Hastings 2002/3

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 c3 d6 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♖e8!?

Because of his devotion to this speculative pawn sacrifice I have called this the Hebden Variation, after my fellow Leicester GM.

12 dxe5 dxe5 13 ♘xe5 ♗b7



Otherwise 13...♗d6 14 ♘xf7 ♔xf7 15 e5 ♕e7 16 ♗f4! ♗c7?! (16...♗b8! where it is defended by the rook, looks like a possible improvement) 17 ♖e3 ♕d7 18 e6+ ♖xe6 19 ♕xd7+ ♗xd7 20 ♗xc7, G.Sax-M.Hebden, London 1993, is only slightly better for White if followed up by 20...♖xe3 21 fxe3 ♘c4 22 ♗b3 ♗e6 23 ♗xc4 ♗xc4 24 ♘d2 ♘d5 25 ♗g3 ♘xe3 26 ♗f2.

14 ♕f3

NCO gives 14 ♘d2 ♗d6 15 ♘ef3 (Kotronias gained a plus with 15 ♘g4 ♘xe4 16 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 17 ♗g5 in V.Kotronias-M.Hebden, Hastings 2003/04) 15...♕c7 16 b3 ♖ad8 17 ♗b2 with an 'edge for White'. After 17...c4 18 ♕e2 ♗f4 19 ♖ad1, T.Ernst-M.Hebden, Malmo 1987/8, White is clearly better according to *ECO*. After the more recent try 18... ♗c5 19 ♖ac1 (if 19 b4?! then 19...♗xb4 20 cxb4 c3) 19...♘h5? 20 b4 ♘g3

21 ♕d1, J.Howell-M.Hebden, British Championship 1991, White wins further material. It's clear that 19...♗b6! (instead of 19...♘h5) is superior, with reasonable practical chances.

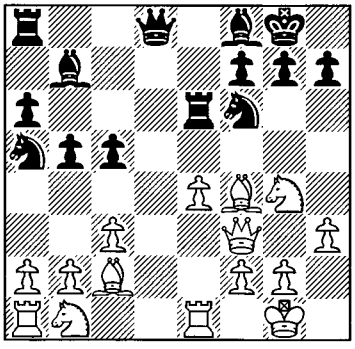
14...♗f8

This is preferred by Hebden over 14...♗d6 which didn't turn out well in the following encounter: 15 ♘g4 ♘xg4 16 ♕xg4 ♘c4 17 f4 ♗f8 18 e5 g6 19 ♕g3 ♗g7 20 b3 ♘b6 21 ♘d2 f6 22 ♘e4!, and White was well on top in I.Smirin-L.Gofshtein, Israel 1991.

15 ♗f4

Although Hebden assures me that his variation is sound there are some unanswered questions. Here for instance Paul Motwani suggests 15 ♘g4, when 15...♘xe4? fails to 16 ♖xe4 ♗xe4 17 ♗xe4 ♖xe4 18 ♕xe4 ♕d1+ 19 ♔h2 ♕xc1 20 ♕xa8 ♕xb2 21 ♘e5!. Because of this line he instead suggests 15...♘xg4 16 ♕xg4 ♖e6, but it doesn't feel like adequate compensation to me.

15...♖e6 16 ♘g4



16...♘xe4!

Now this works and represents a clear improvement over the previously known 16...♘c4. Then after 17 ♘xf6+ (Rowson recommends 17 b3, e.g. 17...♘xg4 18 ♕xg4 ♘e5 19 ♕g3) 17...♖xf6 (17...♕xf6 also led to problems after 18 ♘d2 ♘e5 19 ♕g3 ♕d8 20 ♖ad1 ♘g6 21 ♘c4!, in M.Chandler-M.Hebden, British Championship 2000 and 18...♘xb2 wouldn't help much according to Bogdan Lalic who gives 19 ♖ab1 g5 20 ♗g3 with advantage) 18 ♗g5 ♖xf3 19 ♗xd8 ♖xd8 20 gxf3 ♘xb2 21 a4 b4 22 ♖a2 ♘c4 23 ♖d1 ♖e8 24 cxb4 cxb4, N.Short-M.Hebden, Port Erin 1999, White should have continued with Short's 25 ♗b3! ♘e5 26 ♔g2, when Black would have insufficient compensation for the exchange.

17 ♗xe4

Here 17 ♖xe4 is also met by 17...f5.

17...f5 18 ♘d2

Trying for more than the stem game in which the point was shared after 18 ♕g3 ♖xe4 19 ♘h6+ (or 19 ♖xe4, but after 19...♕d1+ 20 ♔h2 fxe4 21 b3 c4 it looks like a draw) 19...♔h8 20 ♘f7+ ♔g8 21 ♘h6+ (21 ♘xd8? ♖xe1+ 22 ♔h2 ♖xd8 favours Black) 21...♔h8 22 ♘f7+ ♔g8 23 ♘h6+ and drawn, A.Naumann-M.Hebden, Paignton 2000.

18...fxe4 19 ♕g3

Or if 19 ♘xe4 then 19...♕e7.

19...♕e7 20 ♖e2 h5 21 ♘h6+ ♔h7 22 ♘f5 ♕f6 23 ♘e3

Black's wayward knight on a5 will need recycling and he has the slightly worse pawn structure. However he has a space advantage, so he shouldn't be worse.

23...♗c6 24 ♗g5 ♕g6 25 ♖ae1 ♘b7 26 ♗f4 ♕f7 27 ♘ef1 ♖ae8 28 ♕h4

With visions of ♘f1-g3 hitting e4 and h5.

28...♗e7! 29 ♗g5 ♗xg5 30 ♕xg5 ♖e5 31 ♕h4 g5!

Taking the initiative.

32 ♕g3 h4 33 ♕h2 ♖5e6 34 f3 exf3

Possible is 34...♘d6!?, but after mass simplification on e4 chances are equal.

35 ♘xf3 ½-½

A plausible continuation would be 35...♗xf3 36 ♖xe6 ♖xe6 37 ♖xe6 ♕xe6 38 ♕c7+ ♔g8 39 gxf3 ♕d5, and with both kings exposed a draw is very likely.

Game 20

V.Bologan-S.Sulskis

Obrid 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4

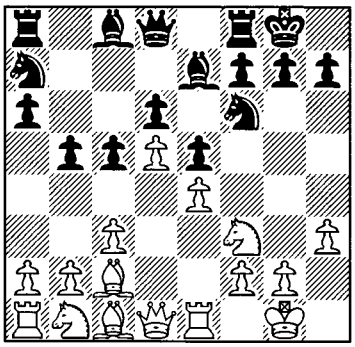
♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♘c6

Borisenko's Variation.

12 d5

A convenient moment to close the centre as White gains time. It seems less logical to play 12 ♘bd2, as after 12...cxd4 13 cxd4 exd4 14 ♘b3 ♘b4 15 ♗b1 d3, Black has sufficient play e.g. 16 ♘bd4 ♗b7 17 a3 ♘c2 18 ♘xc2 dxc2 19 ♗xc2 ♖e8 20 ♘d4 ♗f8 21 f3 g6 with equal chances, G.Sax-B.Abramovic, Skopje 1996.

12...♘a7



The knight can also return to a5 as in the next game, but from the odd-looking a7-square this piece can eventually go to b6 or e7 via c8.

13 ♘bd2

I quite like the idea of playing the immediate 13 a4, for instance:

a) 13...♘d7 14 ♗e3 ♕c7 15 ♘bd2 ♘b6?! 16 a5 (denying Black use of the b6-square) 16...♘d7 17 b4 ♖e8 18 ♘f1 ♗b7, as in J.Nunn-J.Van der Wiel, Amsterdam 1988. The best way to take advantage of White's significant space advantage would be 19 ♕d2 ♘c8 20 ♗d3, intending c3-c4. If Black were to close the queenside with ...c4 then White's pieces would be better placed to exploit the kingside without the risk of being distracted elsewhere.

b) 13...♘e8!? 14 a5 f5!? 15 exf5 ♗xf5 16 ♗xf5 ♖xf5, A.Vitolinsh-A.Kakagaldiev, USSR 1979. Suetin claims the position to be about equal but I still prefer White who has a bind on the e4-square. His space advantage means that Black's knight on a7 is short of ideas and will take a while to be redeployed to e7.

c) After 13...♗d7!? 14 ♘xe5 dxe5 15 d6 White obtains the bishop pair, A.Kuzmin-R.Ziatdinov, Tashkent 1987.

13...♗d7

Here 13...c4 14 ♘f1 a5?! (a rather optimistic plan) 15 ♘e3 ♕c7 16 ♕e2 ♘h5 17 a4 ♘f4 18 ♕f1 yields a clear advantage to White as Black's c4-pawn is undermined, M.Adams-H.Westerinen, London 1988.

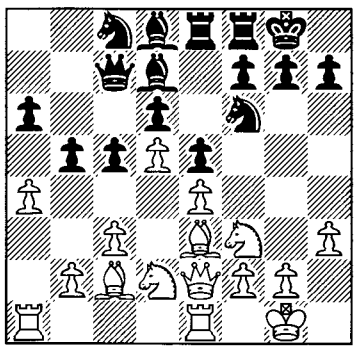
14 a4

In the following sequence Black is able to show the positive side to his set-up: 14 ♘f1 ♘c8 15 g4?! h5! (a fine counter hitting at White's kingside before he has time to control that front) 16 ♘3h2 hxg4 17 hxg4 ♘h7 18 ♘g3 ♗g5 19 ♔g2 ♘e7 20 ♖h1 ♘g6 (this knight now comes into its own eyeing f4 and h4) 21 ♘e2 ♕f6 with a model position for Black whose manoeuvres were most instructive, P.Korzubov-J.Klovans, Minsk 1983.

14...♕c7 15 ♘f1 ♖ae8 16 ♗e3 ♘c8 17 ♘1d2!

With Black having put his rooks on the kingside Bologan decides to switch back to the other wing!

17...♗d8 18 ♕e2



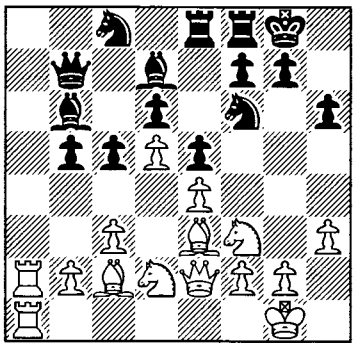
18...♕b7

In order not to play too passively, Black could consider 18...♘h5!? intending counterplay with ...g6 and ...f5.

19 ♖a2

Alternatively 19 axb5 axb5 20 b4 c4 21 ♖a2 can be met by 21...♘h5, as 22 ♘xe5 ♖xe5 23 f4 ♘xf4 24 ♗xf4 ♖ee8 intending ...f5 is fine for Black.

19...h6 20 ♖ea1 ♗b6 21 axb5 axb5



22 b3?!

The most precise is 22 ♖a6! ♘e7 23 ♗d3, as 23...♘exd5 24 exd5 e4 is unsatisfactory after 25 ♘xe4 ♘xe4 26 ♗xb5(!).

22...♘e7! 23 b4 c4?

A better defence is to open the c-file with 23...cxb4 24 cxb4 ♘g6, as after say 25 ♗xb6 ♕xb6 26 ♖a6 ♕c7 Black is the most likely to be able to use the open line.

24 ♗xb6 ♕xb6 25 ♖a6 ♕b8 26 ♕e3 ♘c8 27 ♘h4 ♖e7 28 ♘f1 ♘e8 29 ♘g3 ♘c7 30 ♖6a2 ♔h7 31 ♘gf5

With the queenside covered, Bologan switches back to the other front. He could also have played with the other knight, e.g. 31 ♘hf5 ♗xf5 32 ♘xf5 ♖d7 33 ♗d1, or 31...♖ee8 32 ♘xg7 ♔xg7 33 ♘h5+.

31...♖ee8 32 g4 g5 33 ♘g2 ♗xf5

Removing one attacking piece but the weakened kingside is still lacking defenders.

34 gxf5 ♕b6 35 ♕f3 ♘e7 36 f6 ♘g6 37 ♕f5 ♖d8

If 37...♖a8, then 38 ♖a5 keeps Black under pressure on both wings.

38 ♗d1! ♔h8 39 ♗h5 ♖g8 40 ♔f1 ♖df8 41 ♖a7 ♖d8 42 ♕g4 ♖df8 43 ♕d7

43 ♗xg6? is bad because of 43...fxg6 44 ♕d7 ♖xf6 threatening mate.

43...♘e8 44 ♖1a6

This does win but simpler is 44 ♖b7! ♘xf6 45 ♖xb6 ♘xd7 46 ♖xd6 ♖d8 47 ♖a7.

44...♕b8 45 ♖a8 ♘xf6 46 ♕f5 ♘xh5 47 ♖xb8 ♖xb8 48 ♖xd6 ♖a8 49 ♖d7 ♖g7 50 ♔g1 ♔g8 51 ♔h2 ♘hf4 52 ♘xf4 gxf4 53 ♖xf7 ♖xf7 54 ♕xg6+ ♖g7 55 ♕e6+ ♔h7 56 ♕f5+ ♔g8 57 ♕xe5 ♖f8 58 h4 f3 59 ♔h3 ♖ff7 60 d6 ♖g1 61 ♕d5 ♔f8 62 d7 1-0

Game 21

A.Galliamova-Xie Jun

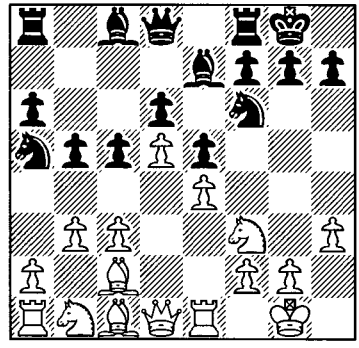
Kazan/Shenyang Match 1999

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♘c6 12 d5 ♘a5

On this square the knight keeps an eye on the queenside but is in danger of becoming sidelined.

13 ♘bd2

After 13 b3, we have the following:



Now Black has 13...♘e8!, (a manoeuvre typical of such blocked positions; Black intends ...g6, ...♘g7 and ...f5 to obtain counterplay) 14 a4 ♗d7 15 axb5 axb5, and now:

a) 16 ♗e3 g6 17 ♘bd2 ♘g7 18 b4 cxb4 19 cxb4 ♘c4! (placing the knight on the prospectless b7-square would be too passive) 20 ♘xc4 bxc4 21 ♕d2 f5, L.Psakhis-O.Romanishin, Moscow 1986.

b) K.Asrian-S.Sulskis, Ohrid 2001 instead continued 16 ♘bd2 g6 17 ♕e2 ♘g7 18 ♖a2 ♕b6 19 ♘f1 ♘b7 20 ♗d3 ♖xa2 21 ♕xa2 ♕a5 22 ♕b1 ♖a8 23 ♗b2 f6 (and the knight will head for f7) 24 ♘e3 ♘d8 25 ♕c2 ♕c7 26 ♕e2 ♖a2 27 ♗b1 and a draw was agreed. I prefer this to 13...g6 14 ♗h6 ♖e8 15 ♘bd2 ♗d7 16 a4 ♕c7 17 ♕e2 ♗f8 18 ♗e3 (it's not in White's interest to exchange the dark-squared bishops as he is not in a position to exploit any holes on Black's kingside) 18...♘h5 19 axb5 ♗xb5!? 20 ♗d3, M.Wahls-O.Romanishin, Taastrup 1992.

13...g6 14 b3 ♗d7 15 ♘f1 ♘h5 16 ♗e3

Alternatively 16 ♗h6 ♖e8 17 ♕d2 ♗f6 18 ♖ac1 ♗g7 19 ♗g5 f6?! (19...♗f6 is less committal) 20 ♗e3 f5 21 exf5 gxf5 22 ♕d1 ♘f6 23 ♗g5, with a type of King's Indian where there is a danger that the knight on a5 will be poorly placed, J.Timman-T.Wedberg, Swedish Team Championship 2003.

16...♗f6

Not rushing to expand with ...f5. Xie Jun first hopes to improve her bishop's diagonal and bolster her king.

17 ♔h2 ♘b7 18 g3 ♕c7 19 ♕d2 ♗g7 20 ♕e2

Waiting is a feature of such positions. Black again delays ...f5 as White is then ready to exploit the loosening of Black's kingside, e.g. 20...f5?! (premature) 21 exf5 ♗xf5 (21...gxf5 is answered by 22 ♘h4) 22 ♘g5 ♗d7? 23 ♘xh7! etc.

20...♕c8! 21 ♘g1 ♕e8

Just as in the King's Indian, the queen indirectly defends the knight on h5, so that ...f5 is now a positional threat.

22 ♗d2 f5 23 exf5

23 f3 would is less ambitious offering no hope of an advantage.

23...gxf5 24 ♘f3 c4!?

Stopping White supporting the d-pawn with c3-c4 and trying to open lines on the queenside when the knight could hop to c5 with lively play.

Also interesting is 24...e4!? 25 ♘h4 ♗f6 (25...b4 would also provoke White to sacrifice the exchange) 26 ♘g2 (compared to analogous positions in the King's Indian the knight on b7 is passively placed) 26...b4 (or perhaps 26...♕g6 27 ♖ad1 ♖ae8, with ...♘d8 to follow) 27 cxb4 ♗xa1 28 ♖xa1 with unclear play.

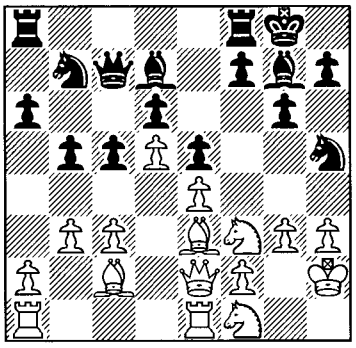
25 b4 a5 26 a3 ♘f6

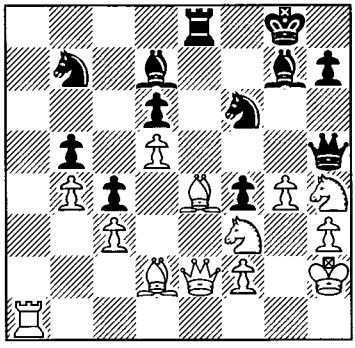
Hitting the weakened d5-pawn.

27 ♘e3 axb4 28 axb4 ♖xa1 29 ♖xa1 f4 30 ♘f5 ♕h5 31 ♘5h4 e4! 32 ♗xe4

32 ♘d4 allows 32...fxg3+ 33 fxg3 ♕xe2+ 34 ♘xe2 e3! when Black is clearly on top.

32...♖e8 33 g4





Up to here Black has played a logical game but now she cracks.

33...♕f7??

Why not 33...♗xg4! 34 hxg4 ♘xg4+ 35 ♔g1 ♘f6 winning back the piece with plenty of interest.

34 ♘g5 ♕e7 35 ♖a8!

35 ♖a7 is also good.

35...♗f8

If 35...♖xa8, then 36 ♗xh7+ ♔f8 37 ♘g6+.

36 ♖xe8 ♗xe8 37 ♘f5 ♕e5 38 ♕f3 ♘xe4 39 ♘xe4 ♔h8 40 ♘g5 1-0

Game 22

P.Svidler-L.B.Hansen

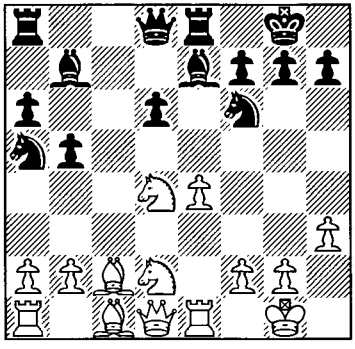
Esbjerg 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♗b7 12 ♘bd2

It's a question of taste, but White can play d5 closing the centre when the knight on a5 and bishop on b7 are not ideally placed (see the next game).

The text is for those who prefer a more open struggle.

12...cxd4 13 cxd4 exd4 14 ♘xd4 ♖e8



15 b3

A typical pawn structure has arisen. The opening of the centre gives Black pressure on the lines leading to the e4-pawn, but there is often a downside to giving up the e5-pawn. Here it's in the form of an isolated d-pawn and the decentralised knight on a5.

Nevertheless, experience suggests that careful defence should yield full equality:

a) 15 ♘f1 ♗f8 16 ♘g3 ♖c8 (or 16...g6 17 b3 ♘d7 [a similar plan to the game] 18 ♗b2 ♖c8 19 ♕d2 ♗g7 20 a4 b4 21 ♖ab1 ♕b6, B.Brinck-Clausen-LB.Hansen, Copenhagen 1994; in this earlier example Hansen achieved a comfortable game) 17 b3 d5 18 e5 ♘e4 19 ♗b2 (19 ♘xe4 dxe4 20 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 21 ♖xe4 ♘c6 22 ♗b2 ♖xe5 was dead equal in D.Agnos-V.Dydyshko, Pula 1997) 19...♖xe5 (Adams gives 19...♘xg3 20 fxg3 ♘c6 as unclear) 20 ♘df5 ♖e6 21 ♗xe4 dxe4 22 ♕g4 ♖g6 23 ♕f4 ♕g5 24 ♕xg5 ♖xg5 25 ♖ad1 ♖e8 26 ♘d6 ♖d8! (an improvement on 26...♗xd6 27 ♖xd6 ♖d5?! 28 ♖xd5 ♗xd5 29 ♘h5, with advantage to White, M.Adams-O.Romanishin, Groningen 1993) 27 ♘xb7 ♘xb7 28 ♖xd8 ♘xd8 29 ♖d1 ♘c6 30 ♘xe4 ♖g6 with equality, V.Kotronias-O.Romanishin, Tilburg 1994.

b) 15 b4!? ♘c6 16 ♘xc6 ♗xc6 17 ♗b2, and here Black has a couple of tries:

b1) 17...♘d7 (perhaps the safest way to a satisfactory game) 18 ♘b3 (or 18 ♗b3 ♗f6 19 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 20 ♖c1 ♖c8 21 ♕f3 ♗b7 22 ♖xc8 ♕xc8 23 ♕f4 ♕c7, J.Polgar-A.Grischuk, Linares 2001) 18...♗f6 19 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 20 ♘d4 ♘e5 21 ♘xc6 ♘xc6 22 ♕d2 ♖ac8 23 ♗b3 ♘d4, Pe.Popovic-O.Romanishin, Novy Smokovec 1992.

b2) 17...♗f8 18 ♕f3 ♖c8 19 ♗b3 ♕e7 20 ♖ad1 ♗b7 21 ♕f5 d5 22 e5 ♘d7 23 ♘e4, Xie Jun-M.Chiburdanidze, Manila Match 1991, and now according to Peters Black should continue with 23...♕e6! 24 ♕xe6 ♖xe6 25 a3 ♘b6.

15...g6

The most solid is perhaps 15...♗f8 16 ♗b2 g6 17 ♕f3 ♗g7, e.g. 18 ♖ad1 ♖c8 19 ♗b1 ♘c6 20 ♘f1 ♘e5 21 ♕e3 ♘ed7 22 ♕f4 d5 23 ♘g3 ♕c7 with full equality, J.Polgar-G.Milos, Buenos Aires 2000.

16 ♗b2 ♘d7

16...♗f8 transposes to the previous note.

17 ♘f1 ♗f6 18 ♘e3!?

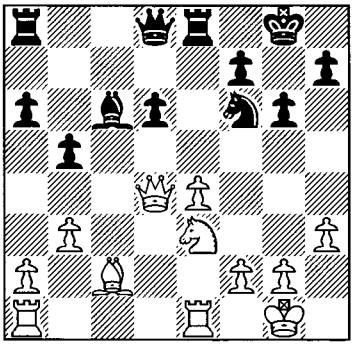
The more routine 18 ♘g3 would probably transpose to positions resulting from 15 ♘f1 above. Instead Svidler has visions of this knight having a more active role hopping to g4 or d5.

18...♘c6

Taking the opportunity to exchange off his problem knight.

If Black instead grabs the e-pawn with 18...♗xe4, then 19 ♘g4 ♗xc2 (19...d5 20 f3 doesn't help matters) 20 ♖xe8+ ♕xe8 21 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 22 ♘xc2 yields dangerous play on the dark-squares.

19 ♘xc6 ♗xc6 20 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 21 ♕d4



21...♖e6?

The rook is not happy here as it will provoke White into getting his light-squared bishop to the a2-g8 diagonal. But 21...♗xe4? is again unsatisfactory, e.g. 22 ♘g4 ♘xg4 23 ♗xe4 d5 24 ♕xd5 ♕xd5 25 ♗xd5 ♖xe1+ 26 ♖xe1 ♖d8 27 ♗b7 and Black loses a pawn.

Black should prefer 21...♕e7, with only a small edge to White according to Svidler.

22 f3 a5 23 b4 a4

For the moment the bishop is denied access, but Svidler doesn't give up that easily!

24 ♖ac1 ♕e8 25 ♖ed1 ♖d8 26 ♗b1 ♗a8 27 a3!

With ♗a2 now looming Black tries to make a counterattack in the centre.

27...d5 28 ♖c7!

28 ♗a2? is countered tactically with 28...♘xe4! 29 ♘g4 ♘g3 when White has some tempting checks but no win.

28...♖dd6 29 ♗a2 dxe4

A lesser evil was 29...♕d8, but White keeps a big advantage with 30 ♕c5 ♗c6 31 exd5 ♖xe3 32 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 33 ♕xe3.

30 ♕xd6 ♖xd6 31 ♖xd6 ♕e5 32 ♖d8+ ♔g7 33 ♖xf7+ ♔h6 34 ♖xf6! ♕a1+ 35 ♔h2 exf3 36 ♘g4+ ♔g5 37 ♗d5! fxg2

More robust is 37...h5, but Svidler intended 38 ♖xf3! (38 ♖g8 fxg2 39 ♖gxg6+ ♔h4 is less clear) 38...hxg4 39 ♖g3 ♗xd5 40 ♖xd5+ ♔f6 41 h4 and White mops up with ♖xb5 and or ♖g5.

38 ♗xg2 ♗xg2 39 ♔xg2 h5 40 ♖d5+ ♔h4 41 ♖f4 1-0

Game 23

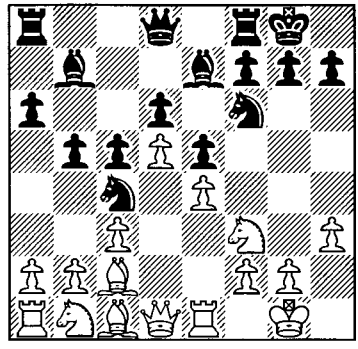
A.Shirov-A.Grischuk

New Delhi 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♗b7 12 d5

Black has extra time compared to other games with d4-d5, but this is not so important. Indeed Black often takes time to redeploy the bishop from b7 to the more influential d7 as is evident in the following lines.

12...♘c4



Black hastens to redeploy this knight to b6 before White plays b2-b3 when the queenside minor pieces would be stepping on each others toes.

For the record, the negative-looking 12...♗c8 transposes to Game 21.

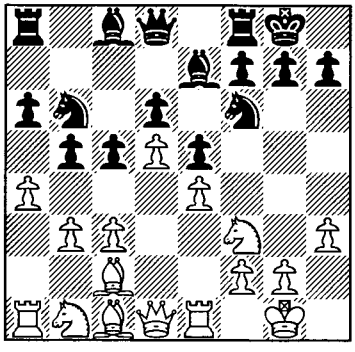
13 a4

The main alternative is 13 b3, with which there is much experience, e.g. 13...♘b6 14 a4 (following 14 ♘bd2 g6 15 ♘f1 ♘h5 16 ♗h6 ♖e8 17 ♕d2 ♗f6 18 ♘g3, Black can try 18...♘f4!?, an idea borrowed from the King's Indian. If White ever captures on f4 then the long diagonal opens up to become the domain of Black's dark-squared bishop. Even if this costs a pawn Black will obtain great dark-squared compensation: 19 ♖ac1 ♘d7 20 ♗b1 a5 21 a3 c4 22 bxc4 bxc4 23 ♗xf4 [finally taking the plunge!] 23...exf4 24 ♕xf4 ♘c5, with sufficient counterplay, A.Kunte-G.Milos, New Delhi 2000) and now there are three ideas:

a) 14...c4 is an active try but after 15 bxc4 ♘xc4 16 ♘a3 ♕c7 17 ♘xc4 ♕xc4 18 ♕d3, Black came under pressure in the endgame in A.Khalifman-A.Beliavsky, Reykjavik 1991.

b) also insufficient is 14...bxa4 15 bxa4 a5 16 ♘a3! (clearly heading for b5) 16...♗a6 17 ♗e3 ♘fd7 18 ♖b1 ♕c7 19 ♘d2 ♖fb8 20 ♘b5 with a comfortable edge for White, B.Gelfand-Pr.Nikolic, Sarajevo Match 1991.

c) 14...♗c8, when we have the following position:



This retrograde step is considered best as Black keeps options open concerning his queenside structure.

c1) 15 ♗e3 bxa4! 16 bxa4 ♘c4 17 ♗c1 ♘a5 (the knight vacates the open b-file and from here eyes b3 and c4) 18 ♘bd2 ♕c7 19 c4 ♖b8 20 ♖a2 g6 21 ♗b2 ♘h5 was fine for Black in V.Anand-O.Romanishin, New York Match 1994.

c2) 15 ♘a3 b4! (again Black reacts with a gain of time) 16 cxb4 cxb4 17 ♘b1 a5 18 ♗d3 h6 19 ♘bd2 ♘h7 20 ♘c4 ♘xc4 21 ♗xc4 ♘g5 22 ♗d3 ♗d7 23 ♗e3 (I.Yagupov-A.Bezgodov, Aars 1999) and now Fedorov suggests 23...♘xf3+ 24 ♕xf3 ♗g5 25 ♖ac1 ♕b8.

c3) 15 ♘bd2 g6 16 ♗d3 ♗d7 17 a5 ♘c8 18 ♘f1 ♘h5 19 ♗h6 ♖e8 20 ♕d2 ♗f6 21 b4 c4, with a typical position played several times by Romanishin, e.g. 22 ♗c2 ♘f4 23 ♖a3 g5, M.Wahls-O.Romanishin, Biel 1995, with chances for both sides.

13...♘b6 14 ♕e2!

The favoured move at present. Black is invited to make a decision concerning b5.

Romanishin has had this position on numerous occasions and faced a variety of moves.

a) Of these 14 a5 clearly gains space but doesn't seem to worry Black e.g. 14...♘bd7 15 b4 ♕c7 (or 15...♖c8 16 ♘bd2 g6 17 ♘f1 ♘h5 18 ♗h6 ♖e8 [Black is ready for anything with this set-up] 19 ♗d2 ♗f6 20 ♘e3 ♕e7 21 c4!?, E.Mortensen-L.B.Hansen, Copenhagen 1995) 16 ♘a3 ♘h5 17 ♗d2 ♘f4 18 ♖c1 c4 (J.Gdanski-O.Romanishin, Polanica Zdroj 1991) and Black eventually won on the kingside.

b) Kasparov avoided the defence chosen by Grischuk in this game by playing b2-b3 first and then ♕e2. He managed to gain some advantage as follows: 14 b3!? ♗c8 15 ♕e2 ♗d7 16 c4 b4 17 ♘bd2 g6 18 ♘f1 ♘h5 19 g4 ♘f4 20 ♗xf4 exf4 21 ♕d2 ♗f6 22 e5, G.Kasparov-A.Grischuk, Cannes rapid 2001.

14...♘xa4

A consequence of 14...♕d7 15 a5 is that Black is denied the preferred d7-square for his knight. Even so, the game A.Grischuk-A.Bezgodov, Russia 1999 was only equal after 15...♘c8 16 b4 c4 17 ♘bd2 g6 18 ♘f1 ♘h5 19 ♗h6 ♖e8 20 ♘g3 ♘xg3 21 fxg3 ♗f8. Faced with the same position as Black Grischuk prefers to release the tension on the queenside, the significance of which is open to speculation.

15 ♗xa4 bxa4 16 c4 ♘d7 17 ♖xa4 ♘b6 18 ♖a3 a5 19 ♘c3

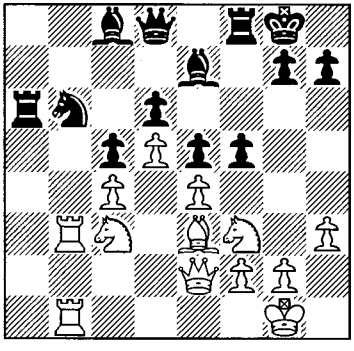
By transposition, the moves 19 ♘bd2 ♗c8 lead to the game I.Gazik-O.Romanishin, Stary Smokovec 1992 after which 20 ♘f1 a4 21 ♗d2 ♗d7 22 ♖c1 ♕c7 23 ♘g3 was slightly more promising for White.

19...a4 20 ♗e3 ♗c8 21 b3

A new move, but the plan is similar to that of V.Topalov-Je.Piket, Groningen Match 1997 which continued 21 ♘d2 ♗g5 22 ♖b1 ♗xe3 23 ♕xe3 ♗d7 24 b4 axb3 25 ♖axb3 with slight pressure for White.

Shirov aims for the same pawn structure (with consequent space advantage and more active pieces) but with extra chances due to the presence of dark-squared bishops.

21...axb3 22 ♖xb3 ♖a6 23 ♖eb1 f5?!



Trying for some action, but this proves to fail tactically. Instead 23...♘d7 is passive but solid.

24 ♗xc5!

A surprise. Shirov gives up a piece for two big central pawns and lively pieces.

24...dxc5 25 ♘xe5 ♘a4

Shirov considers White to be clearly better in the case of 25...♗b7 26 exf5, but after 26...♗d6 I can't see anything obvious for White. However with three pawns and well-placed pieces he clearly has full compensation for the piece.

26 ♘xa4 ♖xa4 27 ♘c6 ♕c7 28 e5 ♖a6 29 ♕f3

Shirov considers a better choice to be 29 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 30 e6 with an edge. It's only two pawns but it's clear that Black will be the one in danger with such an ineffective bishop.

29...f4!

Fighting for breathing space.

30 ♖e1 ♗f5 31 ♖b5 ♗c2!

Aimed against the intended ♕b3.

32 ♖b2 ♗g6 33 ♖d2 ♗e8 34 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 35 d6 ♕e6 36 ♕b7

Black appears to be on the ropes with ♕xa6 and d6-d7 both threatened. However Grischuk finds a remarkable resource.

36...♗c6! 37 ♕xa6 ♗xg2! 38 f3

38 ♔xg2 allows dangerous counterplay with 38...f3+ 39 ♔h2 ♕h6.

38...♗xf3 39 ♔h2 ♗g4!

Yet another amazing bishop move!

After 39...g5 40 ♖d3 g4 (following 40...♖a8?, White wins with 41 ♕xa8+! ♗xa8 42 d7, or if 40...♗a8, White consolidates starting with 41 ♕a2) 41 ♖xf3 gxf3 42 ♕b7 f2 43 ♕g2+ ♔h8 44 ♕xf2 f3, White is better but Black is still fighting.

40 ♕b7

Capturing the bishop leads to the following forcing line: 40 hxg4 ♕xg4 41 ♖f1 f3 42 ♕a2 ♕h4+ 43 ♔g1 ♕g3+ 44 ♖g2 ♕xg2+ 45 ♕xg2 fxg2 46 ♖xf8+ ♔xf8 47 e6 g5 48 ♔xg2 h5 which is only drawn!

40...♕h6 41 ♕d5+ ♖f7 42 ♔g1 ♕xh3 43 ♕g2 ♕h4 44 ♖f2 f3?

After all that fine work Black finally goes

astray. Here Shirov points out that 44...♗h3! 45 ♕a8+ ♖f8 46 ♕d5+ ♔h8 47 ♕f3 ♕g5+ 48 ♔h1 ♕h4 would hold.

45 e6!

This works as capturing the queen allows mate in two; Black's defence crumbles.

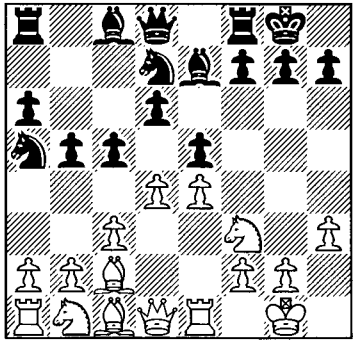
45...♖f8 46 e7 ♖e8 47 d7 ♗xd7 48 ♕xf3 ♕g5+ 49 ♔f1 1-0

Game 24

N.Short-A.Nenashev

Calcutta 1998

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♘d7



The Keres system, a speciality of A.Graf (formerly known as A.Nenashev).

12 dxe5

The most popular move 12 ♘bd2 is covered in Games 25-27. Other ideas are less critical:

a) 12 d5 ♘b6 13 b3 (13 g4?! h5! [a noteworthy counter] 14 ♘h2 hxg4 15 hxg4 ♗g5 16 ♘d2 g6 and Black had the better chances in R.Fischer-P.Keres, Curaçao Candidates Tournament 1962) 13...f5 14 exf5 ♗xf5 15 ♘a3 (K.Hulak-P.Ostojic, Yugoslav Championship 1978) and now Matanovic proposes 15...c4 as unclear.

The double-edged ...f5-break is justified by the weakness of White's advanced d-pawn.

b) 12 a4 ♗b7 is analogous to positions studied in Chapters 4 and 5 arising from 9...♗b7 and 9...♘d7.

c) 12 b3 exd4! (especially suitable now that the long diagonal has been weakened) 13 cxd4 ♘c6 14 ♘c3 (or 14 d5 ♘b4 15 ♘c3 ♗f6 16 ♗b2 ♘xc2 17 ♕xc2 ♘e5 with equality, L.Stein-M.Tal, USSR 1964) 14...♗f6 15 ♗e3 cxd4 16 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 17 ♗xd4 ♗b7 18 b4 ♖c8 19 ♘e2 ♖e8 20 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 21 ♘g3 d5 with comfortable equality, G.Milos-Da.Lima, Sao Paolo Zonal 2003.

d) 12 ♔h1!? (a surprising waiting move. If Black now releases the tension in the centre White's knight can come to the more active c3-square, so Black decides to develop something...) 12...♗b7 (otherwise 12...♖b8 13 d5 ♘c4 14 g4 ♖e8 15 ♖g1 [another way of justifying his twelfth!] 15...♘f8 16 b3 ♘b6 17 ♘bd2 ♘g6 18 ♘f1 ♘f4!, and Black was fine in B.Bratovic-R.Loncar, Pula 2003) 13 d5 (only now that the bishop is committed to b7) 13...f5 (trying to gain from the placing of the bishop on b7 by undermining d5) 14 exf5 ♘c4 (Kramnik hints at how he would have played against 14...♘f6, i.e. 15 ♘g5 ♗xd5 16 ♘d2 ♕d7 17 ♘de4 ♗xe4 18 ♘xe4 d5 19 ♘g5 ♘c6 20 ♘e6 with the initiative) 15 ♘bd2 (V.Kramnik-R.Ponomariov, Linares 2003) and now instead of capturing on d2 Black should have played 15...♘cb6! 16 ♘e4 ♗xd5 17 ♘eg5 (better than 17 ♘fg5?! ♖xf5 18 ♘xh7 g6 19 ♘g3 ♖xf2) 17...♘f6 with unclear play.

The game continuation 15...♘xd2?! 16 ♕xd2 ♘f6 17 ♘g5 ♗xd5 18 f4 favoured White.

e) 12 dxc5 comes to the same thing as the main game. This was recommended by Fischer and is still Nigel Short's preference, but Black doesn't seem to be unduly worried by this idea as we'll see below.

12...dxe5 13 ♘bd2 ♗b7!

This seems to be the generally accepted route to eventual equality. Of the three alternatives, the first two are now considered

inferior, the latter is new:

a) 13...f6 allows White to install a knight on f5 and create some pressure: 14 ♘h4 ♘b6 (or 14...♖f7 15 ♘f5 ♗f8 16 ♘f1 ♕c7 17 ♘1e3 ♘b6 18 ♘g4 ♗e6 19 ♕f3, J.Echavarria-O.Castro, Pensilvania 1998) 15 ♘f5 ♖f7 16 ♕g4 ♔h8 17 h4 ♕e8 18 h5 ♗e6 19 ♘f3 ♗f8 20 ♘3h4 with white pressure in J.Klovans-A.Nenashev, Minsk 1986.

b) 13...♕c7?! is known from a classic game: 14 ♘f1 ♘b6 15 ♘e3 ♖d8 16 ♕e2 ♗e6 17 ♘d5! ♘xd5 18 exd5 ♗xd5 19 ♘xe5 ♖a7 20 ♗f4 ♕b6 21 ♖ad1 and White's superior pieces create strong pressure, R.Fischer-P.Keres, Curaçao Candidates Tournament 1962.

c) Graf's latest try is 13...♖e8 14 ♘f1 ♘c4 15 ♘3h2 ♗g5 16 b3 ♗xc1 17 ♖xc1 ♘cb6 18 ♘g4 ♕g5 with an unclear game, A.Khalifman-A.Graf, Spain 2003.

14 ♕e2

After 14 ♘f1 ♘c4, Black will soon have to decide whether or not to touch his kingside pawns:

a) After 15 ♘g3 g6 16 b3 ♘d6 (M.Tal-O.Romanishin, Jurmala 1983) K.Pytel analyses 17 ♗h6 ♖e8 18 h4 f6 as being unclear.

b) An example of the problems that Black can face if he doesn't defend precisely: 15 ♘3h2 ♕c7 16 ♘g4 ♖fe8 17 ♕f3 ♗f8 18 ♘g3 ♘d6 19 ♗g5 ♖e6 20 ♖ad1 c4 21 ♘e3 ♘c5 22 ♘d5 ♗xd5 23 exd5 ♖ee8 24 ♘h5 e4 25 ♕g3 ♔h8 (and now a neat combination that won a pawn) 26 ♘f6! ♖e7 27 ♗f4 ♖d8 28 ♘xe4!, A.Shirov-M.Khazhgaleyev, Bastia 2002.

If Black doesn't want to play a defence based on ...g6 then he could do worse than follow the following example (after 15 ♘3h2): 15...♘f6 16 ♕e2 ♕c7 17 ♘g3 ♘d6 18 ♗g5 ♔h8 19 ♖ad1 ♖ad8 20 b3 ♘g8 21 ♗c1 c4 22 b4 a5 23 a3 axb4 24 axb4 ♘f6 with no particular problems for Black, S.Ganguly-P.Thipsay, Jodhpor 2003.

14...♖e8

The continuation 14...♕c7 15 ♘f1 ♘c4 16 b3 ♘d6 17 c4, N.Short-L.Portisch, Tilburg 1988 is given as an edge to White in some sources, but this is debateable as the game soon transposed to the diagram after Black's 20th move.

Al Modiahki-N.Davies, Port Erin 2003 saw 17...♖fe8 18 ♗b2 f6 19 ♘e3 ♘f8 20 ♘d5 ♕d8 21 cxb5 axb5, and just when it was getting interesting the players agreed a draw.

15 b3

A prophylactic move stopping the black knight using the c4-square.

The more compliant 15 ♘f1 is met with 15...♘c4:

a) 16 b3 ♘d6 17 c4 ♕b6 18 ♗d3 f5 19 ♘3d2 ♘f6 20 ♘g3 f4 21 ♘h5 b4 22 ♗b2 ♘f7, and Black went on to win in R.Ziatdinov-A.Nenashev, Tashkent 1989.

b) 16 ♖d1 ♕c7 17 b3 ♘d6 18 c4 ♘f8 19 ♗b2 ♗f6 20 ♘e3 ♘e6 21 ♘g4 ♘d4 22 ♘xd4 cxd4 23 cxb5 axb5 24 ♘xf6+ gxf6 25 ♗d3 ♔h8, was unclear in A.Shirov-M.Kazhgaleyev, Bastia 2002.

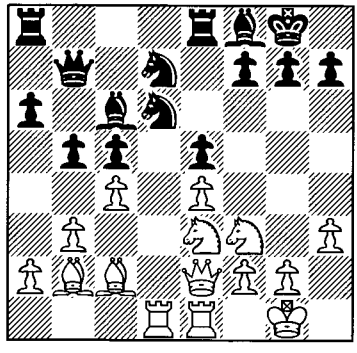
15...♗c6!

Black was recently successful with an alternative: 15...♗f8!? 16 ♖d1 ♕c8 17 ♘f1 c4 18 ♘e3 ♘f6 19 b4 ♘c6 20 ♘d5 ♘xd5 21 exd5 ♘d4!, with adequate counterplay, V.Kramnik-V.Ivanchuk, Monaco rapid 2003.

16 ♘f1 ♘b7!

So the knight heads for d6 anyway.

17 ♗b2 ♘d6 18 ♖ad1 ♗f8 19 ♘e3 ♕b8 20 c4 ♕b7



We have transposed to Short's earlier game against Portisch which continued 21 ♗a1 ♘xe4 22 ♘g4 ♘ef6 23 ♘fxe5 ♘xe5 (but not 23...♗xg2? due to 24 ♖xd7 ♘xd7 25 ♕d3 g6 26 ♕xd7 ♕xd7 27 ♘f6+ ♔g7 28 ♘fxd7 with a clear advantage) 24 ♗xe5 ♘xg4 25 ♕xg4, when Black should have played 25...♖e6! as later suggested by Portisch, rather than 25...g6? 26 h4! etc.

21 ♘d2 ♖ad8 22 f3 g6 23 ♗c3 b4 24 ♗b2 ♗g7 25 ♕f2 ♘f8 26 ♘d5

White is finally ready to occupy the d5-square, but to balance things up, Black has access to d4.

26...♘e6 27 ♘f1 ♘d4 28 ♘fe3 a5 29 ♗d3 ♖f8

According to Nenashev, 29...♖e6 30 ♕h4 ♖f8 (intending ...f5) is even better for Black.

30 ♕h4 f6 31 f4 exf4 32 ♕xf4 ♔h8 33 ♗xd4 cxd4 34 ♘c2 f5 35 e5 ♘b5! 36 cxb5

In Nenashev's opinion 36 ♘dxb4 ♘c3 37 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 is also equal.

36...♗xd5 37 ♖d2 ♖fe8 38 ♘xd4 ½-½

Game 25

V.Anand-R.Ponomariov

Mainz rapid 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♘d7 12 ♘bd2 exd4!

Black's most dynamic choice.

After 12...♗f6 13 ♘f1 exd4 14 cxd4 ♘c6, White has various tries but the latter is the biggest test:

a) 15 d5, here or over the next few moves, gives Black a pleasant choice as he then has a firm hold on the central dark-squares.

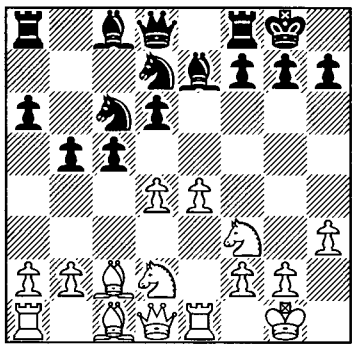
b) Keeping the tension with 15 ♗e3 ♗b7! leads to a tense game: 16 ♕d2 ♖c8 17 ♖ac1 ♖e8 18 ♘g3 g6 19 ♗b1 ♕e7, D.Agnos-S.Skembris, Karditsa 1996.

c) 15 ♗f4 cxd4 16 ♗xd6 ♖e8 17 ♘1h2 ♗e5 18 ♗xe5 ♘dxe5 19 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 20 ♘f3 ♘xf3+ 21 ♕xf3 ♗e6 22 ♖ed1 ♕b6 was about equal in L.Guidarelli-S.Skembris, Cap d'Agde 1998.

d) 15 e5! is critical: 15...dxe5 16 ♗e4 ♗b7 17 dxe5 ♘dxe5 18 ♘xe5 ♕xd1 19 ♖xd1 ♗xe5 20 ♖d7 ♖ab8 21 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 22 ♗xc6, V.Akopian-Y.Kosashvili, Santiago 1990 with an edge to White (2 pieces are a shade preferable here to rook and pawn) according to *ECO*.

The move 12...♗b7 results in a position that can occur from various move-orders, with the three Black themes being interchangeable, i.e. ...♗b7, ...♘d7 and ...♘a5, compare with Chapter 5 for 9...♗b7 and also with Chapter 6 for 9...♘d7. Z.Lanka-T.Steinermayr, Donau 1996 proved to be preferable for White after 12...♗b7 13 ♘f1 cxd4 14 cxd4 ♖c8 15 d5 ♘c4 16 b3 ♘cb6 17 ♘g3 g6 18 ♗d2 ♕c7 19 ♖c1.

13 cxd4 ♘c6



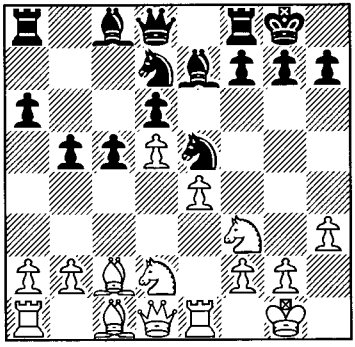
14 d5

I believe that White's best try for an edge could be 14 dxc5!, e.g. 14...dxc5 (otherwise 14...♘xc5 15 ♘f1 ♗e6 16 ♘e3 ♗f6 17 ♘d5 ♗xd5 18 exd5 ♘e5 19 ♘d4, should be preferable for White due to his impending control of the c6-square, O.Renet-M.Hebden, Clichy 2001) 15 e5 c4 16 b3 ♘c5 (after 16...c3 17 ♘e4 ♘dxe5 18 ♘xe5 ♕xd1 19 ♖xd1 ♘xe5 20 ♘xc3 ♗f6, H.Stefansson-A.Graf, Komatini 1993 White retained an edge with 21 ♗e4 ♖b8 22 ♘d5) 17 bxc4

♗e6 (best could be the 17...♘b4!? 18 ♗a3 ♘xc2 19 ♕xc2 b4 20 ♗b2 ♕d3 of RB.Ramesh-S.Yuldash, Udaipur 2000 which may give reasonable compensation) 18 cxb5 (or 18 ♗a3 bxc4 19 ♖e3 ♖b8 20 ♕e2, V.Kotronias-A.Graf, Karditsa 1996 and again White was for preference) 18...axb5 19 a3 b4 20 ♖e3 ♕d7 21 ♗b2, D.Ariel-A.Nenashev, New York 1998 with an edge to White.

The continuation 14 ♘f1 exd4! is covered in the notes to Game 27.

14...♘ce5



15 ♘xe5

A sharp struggle centred on the control of some key squares follows 15 ♘h2:

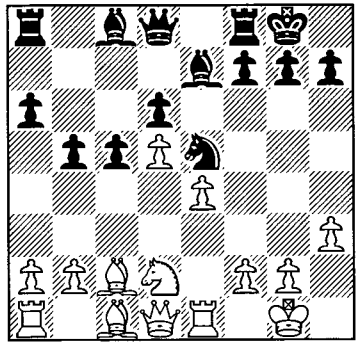
a) 15...g5!? (a risky idea to support the e5-knight that is borrowed from the Modern Benoni) 16 ♘df1 ♗f6 17 ♕h5 ♔h8 18 ♘g3 ♖g8 19 ♘g4 ♖g6 20 ♘e3 c4, and although White eventually won I feel that Black was doing OK at this stage, R.Ponomariov-A.Graf, Plovdiv 2003.

b) 15...♘g6 16 ♘df1 (16 g3!? is a new idea to prepare an early h-pawn advance: 16...♘f6 17 h4 ♘e5 18 ♘df1 h5 19 ♗f4 ♘fg4 20 ♗xe5 dxe5 21 ♕d2 c4, R.Ponomariov-M.Adams, Cap d'Agde rapid 2003 and Black had equalised) 16...♗g5 17 ♘e3 ♘de5 18 ♘f5 ♗xc1 19 ♕xc1 ♘e7 20 f4 ♘xf5 21 fxe5 ♘d4 22 exd6 ♕xd6 (a possible improvement is a line given by Lukacs & Hazai: 22...f6! 23 ♘f3 [the Hungarian analysts give this an '!' but I think it's dubious; I prefer 23 ♕d1 ♕xd6 24 ♘f3 with about equal chances) 23...♘xf3+ 24 gxf3 ♕xd6 25 f4 f5 and Black is getting on top) 23 e5 ♕b6 24 ♗e4, D.Agnos-S.Skembris, Greek Championship 1996, and now (rather than 24...f5?! 25 ♗f3 etc.) a possible improvement is 24...f6!? 25 exf6 ('?!' perhaps, as according to Lukacs & Hazai 25 ♕f4! retains the better of a complicated struggle) 25...♖xf6 26 ♕d2 ♗f5, given by Agnos as unclear.

Another idea is the immediate 15 a4, e.g. 15...b4!? 16 a5 ♖a7 17 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 18 f4 ♘g6 19 ♘c4 (so White has a great square for his knight, but things are still not clear...) 19...♗d7 20 ♗e3 ♗b5 21 ♗d3 ♗h4 22 ♖f1 ♖e8, with a double-edged struggle ahead, A.Timofeev-A.Graf, Dubai 2002.

15...♘xe5

If 15...dxe5, *ECO* recommends 16 b3 retaining a small pull, as in S.Zjukin-A.Morozevich, Eesti 1995. Instead 16 ♘f1 c4! 17 ♗e3 ♗b4 18 ♖e2 ♗b7 19 ♘g3 g6 20 a3 ♗c5 21 ♕d2 ♗xe3 22 ♖xe3 ♘c5, T.Luther-S.Skembris, Turin 1996 was about equal.



16 a4

The critical moment for this move.

Instead 16 f4 has been played a few times, but Black has been doing well. Play is double-edged after 16...♘g6 17 ♘f3 f5 (17...♗h4!? was introduced by Ponomariov this time playing as Black: 18 ♘xh4 ♕xh4 19 f5 ♘e5 20 ♖f1 ♗d7 21 ♗f4 ♕e7 22 ♕e1 f6,

B.Damljanovic-R.Ponomariov, Plovdiv 2003) and now:

a) 18 ♕e2 fxe4 19 ♗xe4 ♖a7 20 ♕c2 ♗h4 21 ♖e2 ♖af7!, T.Enders-A.Graf, German Championship 2000, Black temporarily sacrificing a pawn for the initiative.

b) 18 a4 b4 19 e5 ♗h4 20 ♖f1 ♗g3 21 ♘g5 h6 (White is over-extended) 22 ♘e6 ♗xe6 23 dxe6 dxe5 and Black was better in V.Nedela-V.Talla, Czech Junior Championship 1990.

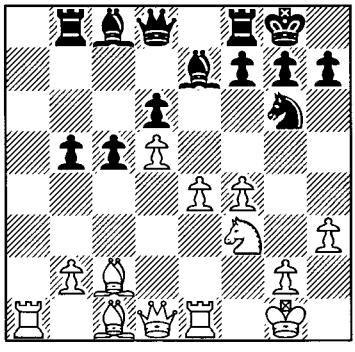
c) 18 e5 dxe5 19 fxe5 ♗b7 20 d6 ♗h4 21 ♖e2?! (critical is 21 ♖f1! ♗g3 22 ♘g5! ♘h4 with an unclear struggle in O.Korneev-A.Graf, Jakarta 1997) 21...♗g3 22 b4 c4 23 ♕d4 ♕d7 24 ♗d2 ♖ae8 favoured Black, who has little to fear from the advanced but blockaded pawns, R.Ponomariov-A.Beliavsky, Moscow Match 2002.

16...♖b8

The continuation 16...♗d7 17 f4 ♘g6 18 ♘f3 bxa4?! 19 ♗xa4 ♗xa4 20 ♖xa4 ♕d7 21 f5 ♘e5 22 ♘xe5 dxe5 23 ♗d2 left White on top in A.Volokitin-L.Gofshtein, Halkidiki 2002. However in this Volokitin gives 18...♗h4! (instead of 18...bxa4) 19 ♘xh4 ♕xh4 20 ♖f1 (20 f5!? ♘e5 21 ♗e3 keeps the game alive) 20...♗xh3 leading to a draw.

Finally, 16...b4 comes into consideration as played in the analogous position (without the knight exchange on e5), see Timofeev-Graf in the note to 15 a4.

17 axb5 axb5 18 f4 ♘g6 19 ♘f3



19...♗h4!

Instead 19...f5? is sharp but bad: 20 e5 dxe5 21 fxe5 ♗b7 22 d6 ♗h4 23 ♘xh4 ♕xh4 24 e6 ♕g3 25 ♖e2 ♘h4 26 ♖a3! (this possibility prepared by 16 a4 is decisive) 26...♘f3+ 27 ♖xf3 ♗xf3 28 ♕d3, and wins (Ponomariov and Komarov).

20 ♘xh4

After 20 ♖f1, the ...f5-break is still too dangerous but 20...♗g3! gives Black an interesting game, e.g. 21 f5 ♘e5 22 ♘g5 ♘d7!? (also possible is 22...h6, when both 23 f6 gxf6 24 ♘f3 ♔g7, and 23 ♖a3 ♗h4 24 ♘f3, and now simply 24...♗f6 are rather unclear) 23 ♖a3 ♗e5 24 h4 c4 25 ♖h3 b4 proved to be very sharp in A.Zhigalko-M.Acher, Heraklion 2003. White's attack was later worth a draw but he tried for more and lost.

Ponomariov and Komarov consider 21 ♘g5 h6 22 f5 hxg5 23 fxg6 fxg6, when Black's unique pawn structure doesn't seem that easy to attack.

20...♕xh4 21 f5 ♘e5 22 ♖f1 ♗d7 23 ♗f4 ♖a8 24 ♕d2

24 ♗xe5 dxe5 yields White a protected passed pawn, but on the negative side he is left with a poor minor piece.

24...♕e7

Black's firm grip on the centre ensures a comfortable game.

25 b4 ♘c4 26 ♕c3 cxb4 27 ♕xb4 ♕f6 28 ♕e1 ♕b2 29 ♖c1 ♖fe8 30 ♕f2 ♖a3

Black could then certainly start thinking more ambitiously with 30...f6, a suggestion of Ponomariov and Komarov

31 ♗b1 ♕xf2+ 32 ♖xf2 f6 33 ♖f3 ♖ea8 34 ♗d3 ♘e5 35 ♗xe5 dxe5

This recapture prepares a route for the king to come to the blockading d6-square.

36 ♗f1 ½-½

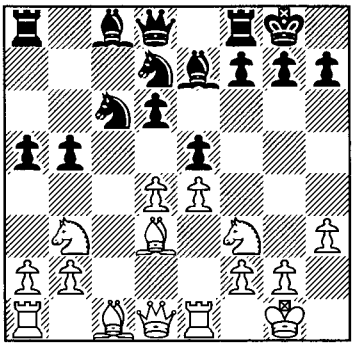
Game 26

V.Anand-Je.Piket

Wijk aan Zee 1999

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4

♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♘d7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♘c6 14 ♘b3 a5 15 ♗d3!



More testing than the older 15 ♗e3 of Game 27.

15...♗a6

The problem with 15...a4 is that White can capture the pawn (16 ♗xb5! ♕b6 17 ♗xc6 ♕xc6 18 ♘bd2) and claim that the onus is on Black to prove that he has anything in return. Anand prefers White slightly.

16 d5 ♘b4 17 ♗f1 a4

After 17...♖c8? the Indian tactician had prepared a nasty trap: 18 ♘xa5! ♕xa5 19 ♗d2 and the threat of 20 a3 wins back the piece with interest.

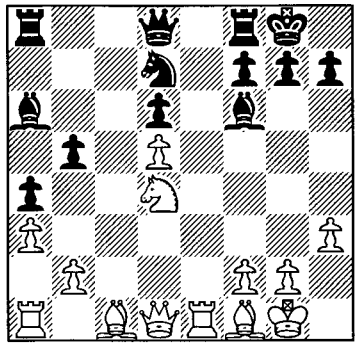
18 ♘bd4!

This temporary piece sacrifice is stronger than 18 a3 ♘xd5 19 ♕xd5 ♘b6 20 ♕d1 axb3 21 ♕xb3, which nevertheless is a shade better for White who has obtained the better pawn structure, F.Hellers-J.Timman, Amsterdam 1986.

18...exd4 19 a3 ♘xd5

The older game L.Shamkovich-J.Benjamin, USA 1976 also proved promising for White after 19...♗f6 20 axb4 ♕b6 21 b3 (opening the a-file for the rook and allowing the bishop to come to b2 hitting the loose d-pawn) 21...axb3 22 ♕xb3 ♘e5 23 ♘xe5 dxe5 24 ♖a5.

20 exd5 ♗f6 21 ♘xd4



The smoke clears and it becomes apparent that despite retaining material equality Black has an array of weaknesses on b5, c6 and d6.

21...♘c5

If 21...♕b6 22 ♘c6 (or 22 ♗e3 ♕b7 23 ♖c1, and White retains the initiative) 22...♘e5 23 ♗e3 ♕b7 24 ♘b4 ♖fe8 25 ♖c1 ♘c4 26 ♗xc4 bxc4 27 ♕d2 (D.Neeloptal-P.Thipsay, Indian Championship 2003) White has slightly the better prospects.

22 ♘c6!

White could nip off a pawn with 22 ♘xb5, but after 22...♗xb5 23 ♗xb5 ♘b3 24 ♖b1 ♘xc1 25 ♕xc1 ♕b6, or perhaps 23...♖b8 (instead of 23...♘b3) 24 ♗xa4 ♗xb2 Black would have some practical drawing chances. True to his style Anand plays for the initiative.

22...♕b6 23 ♗f4 ♖fe8

Otherwise 23...♗xb2 is met by 24 ♖a2 ♗c3 25 ♖e3 ♗f6 26 ♗xd6 giving White a clear advantage as he dominates the centre and his d-pawn is far superior to Black's queenside majority.

24 ♕c2!

After 24 ♗xd6?!, then 24...♘e4 hits both the bishop and the f2-square, whereupon the exchange 'sac' 25 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 26 ♗d3 is double-edged.

24...♘b3 25 ♖ad1

White's pieces operate harmoniously, bearing down on key central squares. In comparison Black's lack scope and co-

ordination.

25...♕c7

Piket was probably counting on 25...♘d4, but after 26 ♖xe8+ ♖xe8 27 ♘xd4 ♗xd4 White has the strong continuation 28 ♖xd4! ♕xd4 29 ♕c6. Then Black can save the exchange but not the game after the further 29...♕e4 30 ♗xd6 ♗c8 31 ♗xb5 ♖d8 32 ♕c7 ♖e8 33 ♗g3! ♗f5 34 d6 as pointed out by Anand.

26 ♖e4 ♖xe4 27 ♕xe4 ♗xb2 28 ♖e1

Apart from mate there is the threat of ♕b4 followed by ♗xd6.

28...♕d7 29 ♕b4 ♗f6 30 ♗xd6 h6 31 ♗d3 ♖e8 32 ♖xe8+

Strong but 32 ♘b8! was simpler.

32...♕xe8 33 ♗e7

White now threatens ♕e4.

33...♗b2 34 ♕e4 g6 35 ♗b4 ♕xe4 36 ♗xe4

The advanced passed d-pawn gives Black no hope.

36...♗f6 37 d6 ♗c8 38 ♗d3 ♗d7 39 ♘b8 ♗e6 40 ♗xb5 ♘d4 41 ♗xa4 1-0

Game 27

Ye Jiangchuan-J.Dorfman

Elista Olympiad 1998

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♘d7 12 ♘bd2 cxd4 13 cxd4 ♘c6 14 ♘b3

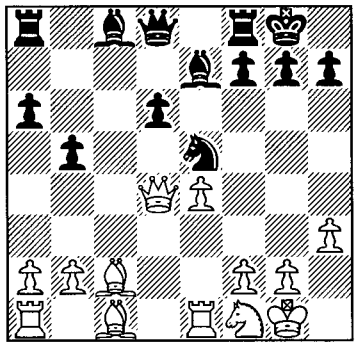
White can also move his knight to the kingside or close the centre:

a) 14 ♘f1 leads to equal chances after the most precise 14...exd4!, see 'a3':

a1) 14...♗f6 15 ♗e3 exd4 (15...♘b6 16 b3 d5 17 dxe5 ♘xe5 18 ♘d4 was unpleasant for Black in Y.Sakharov-A.Zwaig, 1963) 16 ♘xd4 ♘de5 17 ♘g3 g6 18 a4 gave a small edge to White in D.Minic-V.Ciocaltea, Reggio Emilia 1968.

a2) 14...♘b6 15 b3 ♗f6 of M.Tal-P.Keres, USSR 1963 is best met with 16 ♗e3!, when the knight on b6 is misplaced.

a3) 14...exd4 15 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 16 ♕xd4 (the centrally placed queen allows Black to gain time and thus obtain sufficient counterplay) 16...♘e5:



a31) 17 ♘e3? is rather slack due to 17...♗xh3!, J.Michielsen-A.Barbitskij, Salekhard 2003.

a32) 17 ♖d1 ♗b7 (17...♗xh3?! is now met by 18 ♕xe5! dxe5 19 ♖xd8 ♖fxd8 20 gxh3 ♖ac8 21 ♗b3) 18 ♘g3 (or 18 ♘e3 ♖c8 19 ♗b3 ♗f6 20 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 21 ♖xd6 ♗xe4 with equality V.Jansa-P.Thipsay, Calcutta 1986) 18...♖c8 19 ♗b3 ♗f6 20 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 21 ♖xd6 ♘c4, with adequate compensation as in P.Bauer-L.Pachman, Sindelfingen 1984.

a33) 17 ♕d1 ♗f6 18 ♘e3, and now it's a question of taste. Black can try the solid 18...♗e6 19 a4 ♘c6 20 ♘d5 ♗xd5 21 exd5 ♘b4 22 ♗b1 bxa4 23 ♖xa4 a5 (A.Shirov-Je.Piket, Tilburg 1997) or the dynamic 18...♘c4!? (instead of 18...♗e6) 19 ♖b1 ♗e6 20 ♗b3 ♕a5 21 ♖e2 ♖ac8 22 ♘d5 ♗xd5 23 ♕xd5 ♖c5 24 ♕d1 ♖fc8, N.Firman-R.Ziatdinov, Philadelphia 2003.

b) After 14 d5 Black obtains adequate play as follows: 14...♘b4 15 ♗b1 a5 16 ♕e2 (or if 16 a3 ♘a6 17 b4, then advisable is 17...♘b6! 18 ♕b3 ♗d7 19 ♗d3 ♘c7 20 ♖b1 ♔h8 21 ♗b2 f5 and Black took the initiative, A.Suetin-M.Tal, USSR Championship 1964/5) 16...♖b8 17 a3 ♘a6 18 ♗d3 ♘ac5! 19 b4 (19 ♗xb5? ♖xb5! 20 ♕xb5 ♗a6 21

♕c6 ♕b8 [trapping the queen] 22 b4 ♗b5 and White doesn't really have enough compensation: 23 bxc5 ♗xc6 24 cxd6 ♕xd6 25 ♘c4 ♕c7 26 dxc6 ♕xc6) 19...♘xd3 20 ♕xd3 a4, R.Tischbierek-G.Siegel, Badenweiler 1995.

14...a5 15 ♗e3

For 15 ♗d3 see Game 26.

15...a4 16 ♘bd2

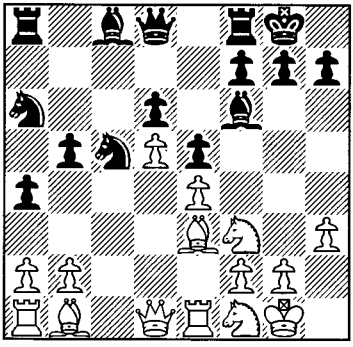
Alternatively 16 ♘c1 exd4 17 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 18 ♗xd4 ♘e5 19 ♘d3 ♗f6 20 ♘b4 ♗e6 21 ♖b1 ♖c8 22 ♗c3 ♘g6 was comfortable for Black in V.Tseshkovsky-O.Romanishin, Sochi 1983.

16...♗f6

Also possible is the opening of the game with 16...exd4 17 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 18 ♗xd4 ♘e5 19 a3 (Pe.Popovic-D.Blagojevic, Becici 1994) and now 19...♗f6 20 ♘f1 ♗e6 21 ♘e3 ♘c4 should be about equal.

17 d5 ♘b4 18 ♗b1 ♘c5 19 ♘f1 ♘ba6

White has a small but persistent space superiority, and this gives him objectively more options. However Black's centre and firmly entrenched knights create a barrier that White is unable to breach.



20 ♗c2 ♘b4 21 ♗b1 ♘ba6 22 ♕d2 ♗d7 23 ♗c2 ♕b8 24 ♖ac1 ♗d8

Seeking a more active diagonal. This theme reoccurs throughout this book where the centre is closed and the bishop isn't required for a defensive role on the kingside.

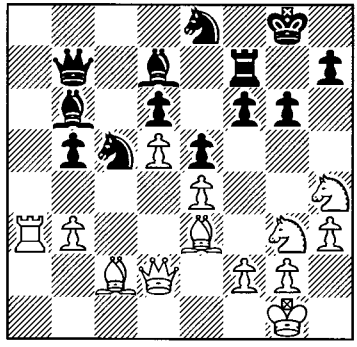
25 b4 axb3 26 axb3 ♗b6 27 ♖a1

27 b4 isn't that worrisome for Black after 27...♘a4 as Black's minor pieces shouldn't be inconvenienced for long.

27...♕b7 28 ♘g3 ♘c7 29 ♘h5 ♖xa1 30 ♖xa1 ♘e8

Keeping a careful watch over the king's safety.

31 ♖a3 f6 32 ♘h4 ♖f7 33 ♘g3 g6



White's aggressive intentions are neutralised by Black's careful defensive play.

34 ♔h2 ♘a6 35 b4 ♗xe3 36 ♖xe3 ♕b6 37 ♖a3 ♘ac7 38 ♗d1 ♔f8 39 ♗g4

Exchanging light-squared bishops weakens Black's grip on the c6-square.

39...♔e7 40 ♗xd7 ♔xd7 41 ♖c3 ♘a6 42 ♖c6 ♕b7 43 ♘e2 ♘b8 44 ♖c1 ♔d8

The centralised king is perfectly safe behind Black's watertight defensive line.

45 ♖a1 ♕b6 46 ♘c3 ♖a7 47 ♖xa7 ♕xa7 48 ♕e2 ½-½

48 ♘xb5 is countered by the reply 48...♕a4.

In the final position Black would play 48...♕d4, when after 49 ♕xb5 (or 49 ♘xb5 ♕xb4 with equality) 49...♘d7 50 ♕a5+ ♔e7 Black will regain his material with sufficient activity.

Summary

Of the rarer tries, the revitalised 11...cxd4!? is a promising area for future research whereas I'm suspicious about the soundness of Hebden's 11...♖e8.

Borisenko's 11...♘c6 loses time after 12 d4-d5, as does 11...♗b7, again due to 12 d5 as the queenside pieces will need remixing. Neither of these look fully equal but are fine for those wanting a peaceful manoeuvring game with no unpleasant surprises.

The older way of handling Keres's 11...♘d7 with 12...cxd4 is under something of a cloud due to Anand's play in Game 26, but the newer 12...exd4 of Game 25 is holding up but is very theoretical.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 d4 ♘d7 (Keres's Defence)

11...♘c6 (Borisenko's Defence) 12 d5

12...♘a7 – *Game 20*

12...♘a5 *(D)* – *Game 21*

11...♗b7

12 d5 – *Game 23*

12 ♘bd2 – *Game 22*

11...♖e8 (Hebden's Variation) – *Game 19*

11...cxd4 – *Game 18*

12 ♘bd2

12 dxc5 dxc5 13 ♘bd2 ♗b7 *(D)* – *Game 24*

12...cxd4

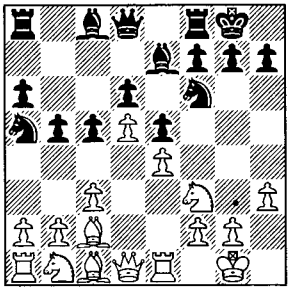
12...exd4 13 cxd4 ♘c6 – *Game 25*

13 cxd4 ♘c6 14 ♘b3

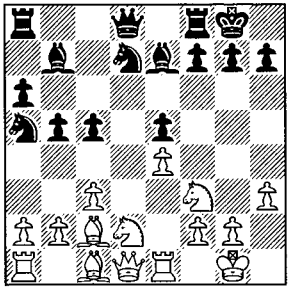
Others – *Game 27 notes*

14...a5 15 ♗d3 *(D)* – *Game 26*

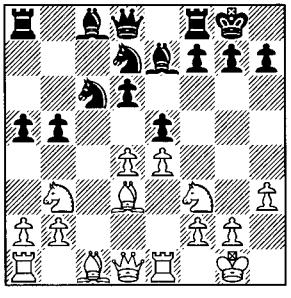
15 ♗e3 – *Game 27*



12...♘a5



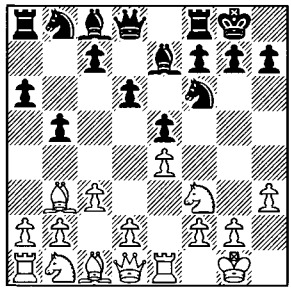
13...♗b7



15 ♗d3

CHAPTER FOUR

The Breyer System



1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8

The Breyer Variation is characterised by the manoeuvre 9...♘c6-b8 followed by ...♘d7. Black intends ...♗b7 with harmonious development, and only then will he decide when to advance his c-pawn or reorganise his kingside pieces.

He hopes to thus avoid the problems inherent in the Chigorin, where the queen's knight and queen's bishop are often stepping on each others toes.

Whilst Black carries out a general redeployment, White has the time to place his pieces ready for the middlegame to follow.

A popular line over the years as it seems positionally very sound. White's extra space gives him chances for a pull, but faced with well placed pieces and no obvious weaknesses he finds it tough to find a chink in Black's armour.

Game 28

E.Bacrot-S.Gligoric

Cannes 1998

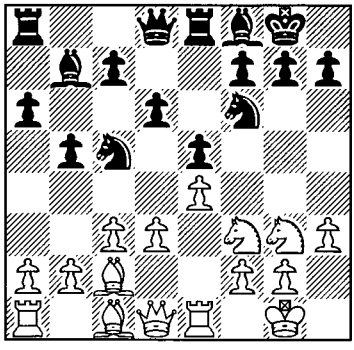
1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8

10 d4

10 d3 is hardly critical. Play can be compared to some lines from Chapter 10, various Anti-Marshall systems and even the Italian with 4 d3. White doesn't want to expand his centre early, he prefers to bring his queen's knight to g3 before committing himself.

Despite the fact that the plan is slow Black should take care not to be lulled into a false sense of equality!

10...♘bd7 (10...c5 11 ♘bd2 ♘c6 is another idea) 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♘f1 ♘c5 13 ♗c2 ♖e8 14 ♘g3 (or here 14 ♘e3 ♗f8 15 b4 ♘cd7 16 ♗b3 h6 17 c4 c5 18 a3 cxb4 19 axb4 bxc4 20 ♗xc4 d5, with equal chances, A.Matanovic-A.Hennings, Helsinki 1972) 14...♗f8



a) 15 ♘h2 is best met by central action with 15...d5, when 16 ♕f3 ♘e6 17 ♘f5 ♔h8 18 ♘g4 doesn't lead to an advantage, e.g. 18...♘xg4 19 ♕xg4 ♕f6 20 ♕g3 dxe4 21 dxe4 c5 22 ♗e3 c4 23 ♖ad1 ♖ad8, G.Tringov-E.Geller, Amsterdam 1970. Nor for that matter does 18 exd5 (instead of 18 ♕g4) 18...♗xd5 19 ♕g3 ♘h5 20 ♕g4 (20 ♕xe5?! ♕d7 21 ♘e7 ♘f6 22 ♘xd5 ♘d4! favours Black slightly, G.Tringov-M.Filip, Siegen Olympiad 1970) 20...♘f6 21 ♕g3 with a repetition.

b) 15 b4 ♘cd7 (instead 15...♘e6 16 d4 a5 17 bxa5 ♖xa5 18 ♗d2 ♕a8 19 ♕b1 ♘f4 20 c4 ♖a3, was very double-edged in O.Renet-J.Van der Wiel, Lyon 1990) and now:

b1) Black has no problems after 16 ♗b3 d5! 17 a3 c5 18 exd5 ♗xd5 19 ♗g5 ♕c7, T.Petrosian-L.Portisch, Hamburg 1965.

b2) Equally benign is 16 ♗d2 d5 17 exd5 ♗xd5 18 ♗b3 c5, P.Jaracz-A.Beliavsky, Bled 2002.

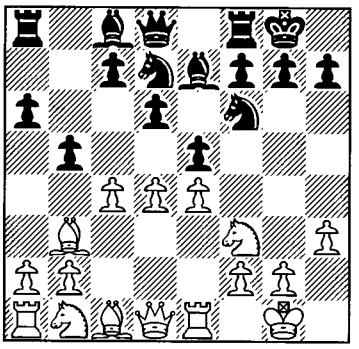
b3) Normal is 16 d4 g6, when compared to Game 30 (see 13 b4 there) White has spent an extra tempo with d3-d4, but Black has spent two, ♘d7-c5-d7. This doesn't seem to be a major issue as Black has good chances to equalise with two of the three alternatives available after 17 a4:

b31) 17...c6 however is unnecessarily passive, e.g. 18 ♗e3 ♕c7 19 ♘d2 ♗g7 20 ♖c1 ♖ad8 21 f4, and White had a promising position, D.Jakovenko-D.Khismullin, Halkidiki 2001;

b32) After 17...♘b6, in Xie Jun-N.Short, Ji Nan 2003, White tried to play safely with 18 dxe5 dxe5 19 ♕xd8 ♖axd8 20 ♗g5 ♔g7 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♖a7 ♖b8 23 ♗d3 c6 24 ♘d2 ♘a4, but Black was able to generate enough play to win.

b33) 17...♗g7 18 ♗d3 bxa4! (rather than 18...c6 19 ♗g5 h6 20 ♗e3 ♕c7 21 ♖c1 ♖ad8 22 ♕d2 ♔h7 23 ♕a2 ♖e7 24 c4, with a clear advantage to White, A.Karpov-B.Lengyel, Budapest 1973) 19 dxe5 ♘xe5 (19...dxe5 20 ♖xa4 c5, P.Keres-A.Matanovic, Winnipeg 1967, wasn't that bad either but White kept a nominal pull) 20 ♘xe5 ♖xe5 with equality, according to Matanovic.

10...♘bd7 11 c4



Instead of 11 c4, the odd-looking 11 ♘h4!? has been played by a number of top players including Fischer and Tal.

a) First of all accepting the gambit with 11...♘xe4 is possible: 12 ♘f5 ♘df6 13 ♕f3 ♗b7 14 ♗c2 ♘c5 15 ♕g3 ♘e6 16 ♗h6 ♘e8 (here Black can improve with 16...♘h5 17 ♕g4 ♘f6 18 ♕g3 ♘h5 when a draw looks like best play) 17 dxe5 dxe5 18 ♖xe5 ♗f6 19 ♖e1 and White retained an edge, E.Vasiukov-R.Kholmov, USSR 1964.

b) 11...♘b6 12 ♘d2 c5 13 dxc5 (13 ♘f5 is a mistake according to Romanishin and An.Bykhovsky because of 13...♗xf5 14 exf5 exd4 15 cxd4 c4 with the better game for Black) 13...dxc5 14 ♘f5 c4 15 ♗c2 ♗xf5 and White obtains the bishop pair, a pivot-point on e4 and play against e5. Black in return has a solid position. After the further moves 16 exf5 ♕c7 17 ♕f3 ♖ad8 18 ♘e4, as in Ma.Tseitlin-V.Liberzon, USSR Championship 1970, most players would take the white pieces if given a choice.

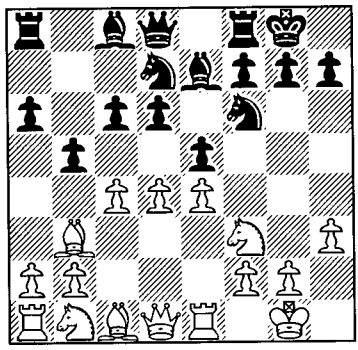
c) Stepping out of the way with 11...♖e8 12 ♘f5 ♗f8 is playable but White can create sharp complications with 13 ♘d2 ♗b7 14 ♘f3!? exd4 (14...♘xe4 15 ♖xe4 ♗xe4 16 ♘g5 ♗xf5 17 ♘xf7 leads to a draw with ♘f7-h6-f7 etc.) 15 ♘g5 d5 16 cxd4 ♘xe4 17

♕h5 ♘xg5 18 ♗xg5 f6 19 ♗d2 and White has practical chances for the pawn, J.Dueball-V.Tukmakov, USSR 1970.

d) Opening the centre is simplest: 11...exd4 12 cxd4 ♘b6 13 ♘d2 c5 14 ♗c2 cxd4 15 ♘hf3 (if this is the best they can do to follow up on White's 11th, then it's not that surprising that the line is out of sorts!) 15...♖e8 16 ♘xd4 ♗f8 17 b3 ♗b7 18 ♗b2 ♘bd7 19 ♕f3 ♖c8 with comfortable equality, R.Byrne-B.Spassky, Moscow 1971.

11...c6

The standard reply. Other moves have been tried, the best of which appears to be 11...♗b7, but after 12 ♘c3, he should really play 12...c6 anyway. Another encounter between Robert Byrne and Boris Spassky (this one from Baden 1980) led to a draw after the following moves: 13 a3 exd4 14 ♘xd4 ♘c5 15 ♗a2 bxc4 16 ♗xc4 d5 17 exd5 cxd5 18 ♗a2 ♘fe4 19 ♘f5 ♘xc3 20 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 21 bxc3 ♘e6. White has a nominal edge after ♗e3-d4, whereas the game continuation 22 ♗xd5 ♖fd8 23 c4 ♗xd5 24 cxd5 ♕c5 25 ♗e3 ♕xd5 gave nothing, and indeed at this point a draw was agreed.



12 ♘bd2

White has tried a number of alternatives but without great success. The three lines that follow all equalise for Black:

a) 12 a3 bxc4 13 ♗xc4 d5 14 exd5 cxd5 15 ♗a2 e4 16 ♘e5 ♗d6 17 ♘xd7 ♗xd7, T.Ernst-A.Ornstein, Swedish Championship 1993.

b) 12 cxb5 axb5 13 ♘c3 ♗b7 14 ♗g5 b4 15 ♘b1 h6 16 ♗h4 c5 17 dxe5 ♘xe4 18 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 19 ♗d5 (worse is the move 19 exd6?! ♕f6!, R.Fischer-B.Spassky, Sveti Stefan/Belgrade Match 1992) 19...♗xd5 20 ♕xd5 ♘g5 21 ♘bd2 dxe5!?.

c) 12 c5 ♕c7 13 cxd6 ♗xd6 14 ♗g5 exd4!? 15 ♗xf6 gxf6 16 ♘xd4 ♘c5 17 ♕c2 ♖d8 18 ♖d1 (18 ♘xc6 ♘xb3 19 axb3 ♗b7 20 ♘d4 ♕xc2 21 ♘xc2 ♗e5 gave Black excellent compensation in Jan.Gombac-J.Borisek, Slovenian Championship 2003) 18...♘xb3 19 ♘xb3 (R.Calvo-L.Portisch, Palma de Mallorca 1967) and now Portisch recommends 19...♗h2+ 20 ♔h1 ♖xd1+ 21 ♕xd1 with equality.

12...♕c7

ECO recommends 12...c5!?, based solely on a correspondence game Poleshchuk-Umansky from 1979 which continued 13 d5 ♘b6 14 ♕e2 ♘h5 15 ♗c2 ♘f4 16 ♕e3 ♗d7 (16...bxc4 looks better as White is disorganised) 17 b3 and considers the position to be unclear.

More common is 12...♗b7 13 a4!? (this idea is akin to that of Bacrot-Gligoric) 13...♕c7 14 ♕e2 ♖ab8, G.Sax-H.Stevic, Pula 1999, and now 15 axb5 axb5 16 cxb5 cxb5 17 ♕xb5 ♗xe4 18 ♕c4 is given by *ECO* as slightly better for White, but I'd be happy with Black after 18...♕xc4 19 ♗xc4 ♗xf3 20 ♘xf3 e4.

13 a4

A better try than 13 ♗c2 ♕a7 14 cxb5 axb5 15 ♘f1 c5 16 dxe5 dxe5 17 a4 ♗b7 18 ♘g3 c4, where Black had already equalised, R.Byrne-B.Abramovic, Reykjavik 1982.

13...♖b8

I'm persuaded that 13...♗b7 is better, see the note to Black's 12th.

14 cxb5 cxb5 15 axb5 axb5 16 ♘f1 ♘b6 17 ♕d3

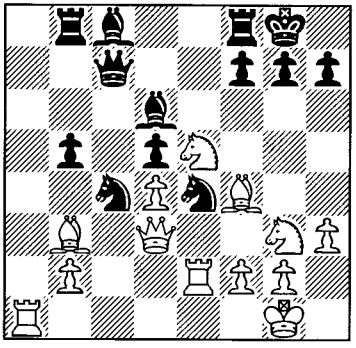
I still prefer White after the text move, but Bacrot prefers 17 ♗d2! ♘c4 (or 17...exd4 18 ♘xd4 ♘c4 19 ♖c1) 18 ♗xc4 bxc4

(18...♕xc4 is worse because of 19 dxe5 ♘xe4 20 ♖c1 ♕d5 21 ♗b4 with a big advantage) 19 ♗c3.

17...♘c4 18 ♖e2 d5!?

The veteran shows that he's not happy to settle for a passive game with 18...♗d7 19 ♖c2 ♕b7 20 d5 ♘b6 21 ♗e3, when White would retain a safe edge.

19 ♘xe5 ♘xe4 20 ♗f4 ♗d6 21 ♘g3



21...♘xg3

This move has been criticised but I don't think that Black can equalise here, for instance if 21...♘f6, then 22 ♖ae1 with continuing pressure.

Wedberg describes 21...f6!? as 'the crucial move' and after 22 ♘xe4 dxe4 23 ♘xc4! (23 ♖xe4?! fxe5 24 dxe5 ♗e7 doesn't yield enough compensation) 23...exd3 24 ♘xd6+ ♔h8 25 ♖e3 (not 25 ♘f7+? ♕xf7!) 25...♗f5 26 ♘f7+ ♖xf7 27 ♗xc7 ♖xc7 concludes that chances are equal, but here by continuing with 28 g4! ♗g6 29 f4 White is still better.

22 ♕xg3 ♗f5 23 ♖a6 ♖b6 24 ♖xb6 ♘xb6 25 ♘g6! ♗xf4

Possible is 25...♗xg6, as after 26 ♗xd6 ♕c1+ 27 ♔h2 ♖a8 28 ♕f3 ♕c6 29 ♗c5 ♘c4 30 ♖e7 White has nothing concrete.

26 ♕xf4 ♕xf4 27 ♘xf4 ♖d8 28 ♖e5

The d-pawn comes under siege and must inevitably fall. Black then wriggles but the odds are against him.

28...♗d7 29 ♗xd5 ♔f8 30 ♗f3 ♗e8 31 d5 ♘c4 32 ♖e2 ♖a8 33 g4 ♖a1+ 34 ♔g2 ♖b1 35 ♘d3 f6 36 ♗e4 ♗f7 37 f3 g6 38 ♔f2 ♘d6 39 ♘f4 ♖d1 40 ♖c2 f5 41 gxf5 gxf5 42 ♗d3 ♔e7 43 ♔e2 ♖a1 44 ♔e3 ♔f6 45 ♖c6 ♔e5

There follows a neat combination to win a further pawn.

46 ♗xb5! ♖b1

The point is that 46...♘xb5 allows mate in three: 47 ♘d3+ ♔xd5 48 ♘b4+ ♔e5 49 f4 mate.

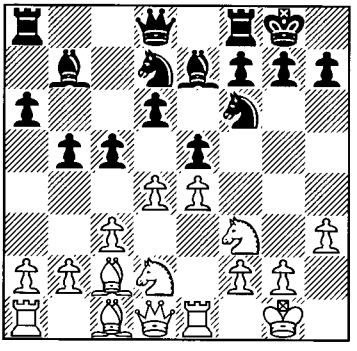
47 ♗e2 ♖a1 48 ♖c7 ♖a8 49 ♗d1 ♖e8 50 ♗a4 ♖b8 51 b3 ♖b6 52 ♘d3+ ♔f6 53 ♖c6 1-0

Game 29

A.Shirov-I.Sokolov

Sarajevo 2003

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2 c5



Provoking action immediately in the centre rather than settling for the more cautious 12...♖e8, which features in the following eight games.

Worth mentioning (and avoiding!) is 12...d5?! 13 dxe5 ♘xe4 14 ♘xe4 dxe4 15 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 16 ♖xe4 ♘xe5 17 ♖d4 with a strong initiative for White despite all the simplification, J.Hjartarson-S.Reshevsky Reykjavik 1984.

13 ♘f1

Closing the centre with d4-d5 isn't too frightening for Black as his pieces are well-placed to reorganise, but White's space advantage is perhaps worth a small pull:

a) 13 d5 g6 (13...c4!?) 14 ♘f1 ♘h5 15 ♗h6 ♘g7 16 ♘e3 ♘f6 17 a4 ♔h8 18 b3 ♖b8 19 ♕e2 ♗c8 20 axb5 axb5 21 ♖a7 ♘g8, was more-or-less OK for Black despite ceding the a-file in the famous game A.Karpov-S.Gligoric, Leningrad Interzonal 1973.

b) 13 b3 ♖e8 (preparing to open the centre) 14 d5 g6 (the more recent 14...♘b6 15 a4 ♕d7 16 a5 ♘c8 17 b4 cxb4 18 cxb4 ♗f8 19 ♘f1 ♘h5, Y.Zinchenko-E.Romanov, Budva 2003 leaves Black somewhat disorganised) 15 a4 (for the position after 15 ♘f1 see the note to White's 14th move) 15...♖b8 16 b4, gave White a nagging edge in L.Kavalek-S.Gligoric, Nice Olympiad 1974 e.g. 16...c4 17 ♘f1 ♗f8 18 ♗g5 ♗g7 19 ♕d2 ♘b6 20 a5 ♘bd7 21 g4.

13...♖e8

If Black changes the move-order of his next two moves with 13...cxd4 14 cxd4 ♖e8, White could try 15 d5. Nevertheless after 15...a5! (to keep control of the c5-square for the knight) 16 ♘e3 ♘c5 17 ♘f5 ♗f8 18 ♘h2 ♗c8 19 ♕f3 ♗xf5 20 ♕xf5 ♖c8, Black's pieces are solidly placed and the bishop pair isn't a major factor. Chances are equal, Y.Balashov-D.Bronstein, USSR Championship 1975.

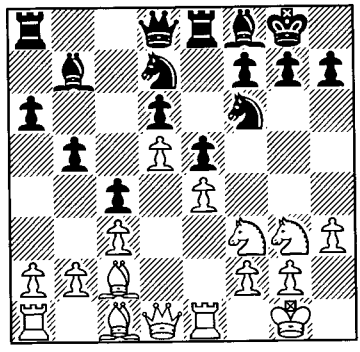
14 ♘g3

Another recent Sokolov game was instructive: 14 d5 g6 15 b3, (preparing a2-a4 but note that after the immediate 15 a4, then 15...c4 is similar to Game 35 and known to be reasonable for Black) 15...♘b6 (15...♘h5 16 a4 c4 17 b4 denies Black the use of c5 for his knight) 16 ♘e3 ♗c8 17 a4 ♗d7 18 a5 ♘c8 19 b4 c4 20 g4! (as the queenside is under control it's time to make advances on the other wing) 20...h5 21 ♘h2 hxg4 22 hxg4 ♘h7 23 ♔g2 ♗g5 24 ♖h1, with White retaining some pressure in a complex game, P.Svidler-I.Sokolov, Germany 2003.

14...cxd4

The traditional line starting 14...♗f8, played on numerous occasions by the Yugoslav Grandmaster Svetozar Gligoric, leads to closed manoeuvring. There has been renewed interest here of late in that position via the move order 12...♖e8 13 ♘f1 ♗f8 14 ♘g3 c5 15 d5 c4.

After the moves 14...♗f8 15 d5 (15 dxe5 didn't give anything following 15...dxe5 16 ♘f5 ♕c7 17 ♘h2 ♖e6 18 ♕f3 ♖ae8 19 ♘f1 c4 20 ♘1g3 ♘c5, B.Parma-S.Gligoric, Portoroz/Ljubljana 1975) 15...c4 (Gligoric used to play with 15...g6 with play akin to other lines of the Breyer, e.g. 16 b3 ♘b6 17 a4 [or 17 ♗g5 h6 18 ♗e3 ♗g7 19 ♕c1 h5 20 ♗g5 ♕e7 21 ♗d3 ♕f8 22 a4 bxa4 23 bxa4 ♖eb8, V.Ciocaltea-S.Gligoric, Portoroz/Ljubljana 1973] 17...bxa4 18 bxa4 a5 19 ♗g5 ♗g7 20 ♘d2 ♗a6, E.Gufeld-S.Gligoric, Odessa 1975) we reach the following position.

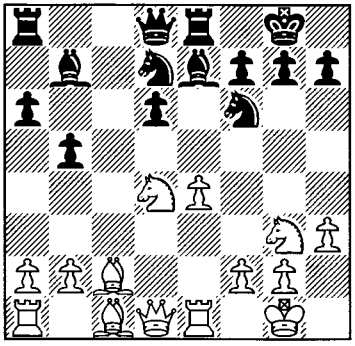


The modern interpretation involves manoeuvring *without* touching the kingside pawns. Black hopes that by giving no clear targets he will make his king quasi-impregnable whilst he gets going on the other wing. Practice suggests however that White keeps an initiative and eventually generates an attack before Black's queenside efforts can make an impression:

16 ♗g5 (or even more aggressively 16 ♘f5 ♕c7 17 g4 ♖eb8 18 g5, A.Grischuk-S.Azarov, Rethymnon 2003) 16...♕c7 17

♘f5 (Svidler often likes playing for f2-f4 e.g. 17 ♕d2 ♖eb8 18 ♘h2 ♘e8 19 ♘g4 ♗c8 20 ♖f1 a5 21 ♔h1 ♘c5 22 f4, P.Svidler-A.Delchev, French Team Championship 2003) 17...♔h8 18 g4 ♘g8 19 ♕d2 ♘c5 20 ♗e3 ♗c8 21 ♘g3 ♖b8 22 ♔g2 a5 23 a3 ♘e7 24 ♖h1 ♘g6 25 g5, and things are starting to get going on the kingside, V.Anand-V.Bologan, New Delhi 2000.

15 cxd4 exd4 16 ♘xd4



16...d5!

A freeing move introduced in this game and reminiscent of analogous positions from the Chigorin where Black's queen's knight is on a5. Here the knight is more flexibly placed as from d7 it can go to c5, e5 or f8.

White retained the initiative after the previously known 16...♗f8 17 ♗f4 ♘e5 18 ♘df5 d5 19 ♗xe5 ♖xe5 20 f4, J.Egger-J.De Toledo, Sao Paolo Zonal 1993.

17 exd5

The over-enthusiastic 17 e5? fails to 17...♗b4.

17...♗xd5 18 ♘df5 ♗f8 19 ♗e3

Black hasn't any particular problems or weaknesses. For instance after 19 ♗f4 ♖xe1+ 20 ♕xe1 ♖c8, Black has equalised.

19...♕c7

The more forcing 19...♗b4 20 ♖e2 ♗c4 21 ♗d3 ♘e5 is also equal.

20 ♕d2 ♕b7 21 ♗d4!?

Most players would have played the uninspiring 21 f3 but Shirov loves complications!

21...♗xg2 22 ♕g5 g6

Sokolov now thinks that Black should either have played 22...♗xh3, or 22...♗d5. The second of which leading to a draw with 23 ♘e4 ♘xe4 24 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 25 ♘h6+ ♔h8 26 ♘xf7+ ♔g8 27 ♘h6+. The test is risky.

23 ♘h6+ ♗xh6 24 ♕xh6 ♖xe1+ 25 ♖xe1 ♖e8 26 ♖xe8+ ♘xe8 27 ♕e3

A better try seems to be 27 ♘f5 gxf5 28 ♕g5+ ♔f8 29 ♕xg2 when the ending with two powerful bishops in an open position favours White, despite him being 'half a pawn' down, and if then 29...♕c7 30 ♗c3 ♕f4 31 ♕d5 ♕c1+ 32 ♗d1, White might be able to keep some pressure according to Sokolov.

27...♘g7 28 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 29 ♕g5 ♗xh3 30 ♘h5+ ♔g8 31 ♕d8+ ♘f8 32 ♗e4?

A time-trouble error. Instead White should simply take the draw with 32 ♘f6+ ♔g7 33 ♘e8+ ♔g8 34 ♘f6+ etc.

32...♕c8 33 ♘f6+ ♔h8

Now Black has this move available (as the knight is indirectly defended) and he is two pawns up!

34 ♕e7 ♗e6 35 ♔g2 ♘d7

Giving back a pawn for an easy life. If 35...♗xa2, White can create sufficient problems with 36 ♕e5 ♕e6 37 ♕d4 ♔g7 38 ♘e8+ ♔h6 39 ♘f6! to hold the draw.

I prefer instead 35...h6! freeing the h7-square for either king or knight.

36 ♘xd7 ♗xd7

Certainly not 36...♕xd7??, as 37 ♕f8 is mate.

37 ♕xf7 ♗e6 38 ♕f6+ ♔g8 39 a3 ♗f7 40 f3 ♕d7 41 b4 a5 42 bxa5 ♕d2+ 43 ♔h3 ♕xa5 44 ♕d6 ♕a7 45 ♔g2 ♗c4 46 ♗d5+ ♗xd5 47 ♕xd5+ ♔f8 48 ♕xb5 ♕xa3 49 ♕b8+ ♔g7 ½-½

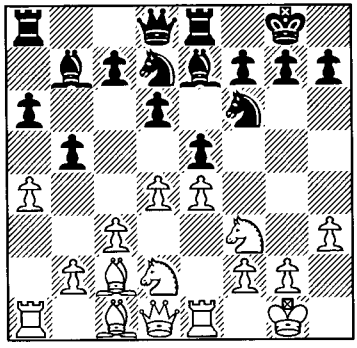
Game 30

A.Shirov-P.Leko

Ljubljana 1995

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4

♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 a4



Playing b2-b4 without a2-a4 is another idea against which Black has a number of plans. Perhaps the simplest way to equalise is as follows:

13 b4 ♗f8 14 ♗b2 ♘b6 15 a3 ♘fd7 16 ♕e2 ♖c8 17 ♖ac1 exd4 18 cxd4 c5, Y.Grünfeld-L.Portisch, Budapest 1983.

After the standard plan with 14...g6 (rather then 14...♘b6) 15 a3 ♗g7, Black has to take into account 16 c4!? (however 16 ♖c1 is no problem due to 16...d5! 17 exd5 exd4 18 ♖xe8+ ♕xe8 19 cxd4 ♘xd5, with a comfortable game for Black, O.Müller-T.Brückner, Bundesliga 1992) 16...exd4 17 cxb5 axb5 18 ♘xd4 ♘h5 (or 18...c6 19 ♘4b3 ♖c8 20 a4, B.Ivkov-M.Filip, Vrsac 1971 and now simply 20...bxa4 21 ♖xa4 ♕c7 is equal) 19 ♗c3 c6 20 ♘2b3, B.Parma-Iz.Jelen, Ljubljana/Portoroz 1977. Here *ECO* claims an edge for White but Black's position looks totally acceptable to me. The game continued 20...♕b6 21 ♘e2 c5 22 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 23 bxc5 ♘xc5 24 ♕d4+ ♘f6 25 ♘c3 ♖ac8, and Black had plenty of activity to compensate for his slightly worse structure.

13...♗f8

A more radical approach is 13...c5!? 14 b3 (14 d5 c4 can be seen in Game 35. This structure is considered acceptable for Black) 14...cxd4 15 cxd4 exd4 16 axb5 axb5 17 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 18 ♘xd4 ♕b6 19 ♗b2 ♗f8 20 ♗d3 b4, when Black was fine in V.Akopian-L.Psakhis, Haifa 1995.

14 b4

If White simply hits the b-pawn with 14 ♗d3, then Black has two replies:

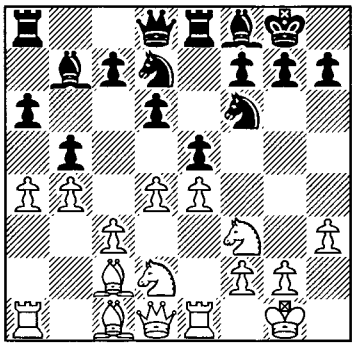
a) 14...b4 which is best met, not by capturing the pawn, but by 15 a5!, just playing for a slightly superior queenside structure (15 cxb4 exd4 16 ♘xd4 c5 offers Black lively counterplay) 15...d5 (trying to justify the previous move but after...) 16 exd5 exd4 17 ♖xe8 ♕xe8 18 c4 ♘c5 19 ♘b3, ...Black's structure is ugly, A.Khalifman-A.Beliavsky, USSR Championship 1990.

b) Black's best is considered to be the modest 14...c6, when Black hopes to equalise by timing his ...d5 counter:

b1) 15 ♘f1 d5 16 ♗g5 dxe4 17 ♖xe4 ♗e7 18 ♖e2! (18 ♖e1 exd4 19 ♘xd4 ♗f8 20 ♘f5 h6 21 ♗e3 ♘e5, is just equal, R.Hübner-P.Van der Sterren, Munich 1990) 18...exd4 19 ♘xd4 ♗f8 (also 19...g6!?, intending ...c5, comes into consideration and could simplify Black's task: 20 axb5 cxb5 21 ♗c2 ♘d5 22 ♕d2 ♗xg5 23 ♖xe8+ ♕xe8 24 ♕xg5 ♕e5 25 ♕xe5 ♘xe5 26 ♘d2 ♖d8 27 ♗e4 b4 28 cxb4, P.Svilder-E.Bacrot, New Delhi 2000 and in this equal-looking position a draw was agreed) 20 ♖d2 (keeping the rooks maintains some pressure) 20...♕c7 (20...c5? is a blunder because of 21 ♘xb5!, J.Van der Wiel-P.Van der Sterren, Dutch Championship 1990, as the pins following 21...axb5 22 ♗xb5 regain the piece with considerable interest) 21 ♗f5 c5 22 ♘f3 ♘e5 23 ♘xe5 (V.Anand-A.Beliavsky, Linares 1992) and now 23...♕xe5 24 ♘g3 h6! as suggested by Beliavsky and Mikhalchishin, should equalise.

b2) 15 b3 g6 16 ♕c2 (Black successfully equalised in J.Magem Badals-E.Vladimirov, Leon 1991 with 16 ♗a3 ♕c7 17 ♕c2 ♖ad8 18 ♖ab1 ♗g7 19 ♗f1 d5) 16...♕b6 (a good model for Black is something like 16...♖c8 17 ♗b2 ♘h5 18 ♗f1 exd4 19 cxd4 d5 20 e5 b4

21 ♘h2 c5, obtaining active play, A.Bezgodov-Y.Balashov, Perm 1997) 17 ♗f1 (best avoided is 17 ♗b2 exd4 18 cxd4 d5?! – premature – 19 e5 ♘h5 20 e6! ♖xe6 21 ♖xe6 fxe6 22 ♗xg6, M.Krakops-B.Socko, Cala Galdana 1996, where Black's kingside becomes seriously weakened) 17...exd4 18 cxd4 d5 19 exd5 cxd5, as in a couple of Spassky games including P.Leko-B.Spassky, Linz 1995.



14...♘b6

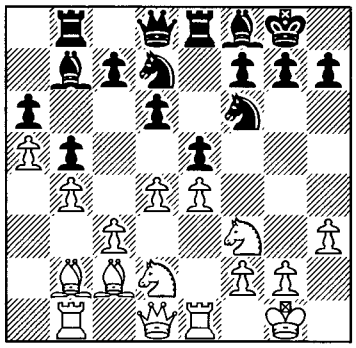
Here 14...a5 is considered to give White a tiny pull, e.g. 15 bxa5 ♖xa5 16 ♖b1 ♗a6 17 axb5 ♖xb5 18 ♖a1 ♖b6 19 ♗b3 h6 20 ♗a3 c5 21 dxc5 ♘xc5 22 ♗xc5 (to retain the superior minor pieces) 22...dxc5 23 ♗c4 ♗b7 24 ♕c2, M.Tal-V.Tukmakov, USSR Championship 1973, and now Geller suggests 24...♕b8 keeping White's advantage to a minimum.

15 a5 ♘bd7 16 ♗b2 ♖b8

Here 16...♕b8 is not so good as after 17 c4! bxc4 18 ♗a4! ♖d8 19 d5, White has a positional bind. He will regain the loose pawn and consolidate his space advantage whereas Black has a problem with his knight on d7, JS.Morgado-Muhana, corr 1979.

Another idea, 16...g6, is reasonable enough. Then 17 ♖b1 ♘h5 (17...♖b8!?) 18 c4 bxc4 19 dxe5 ♘xe5 20 ♘xe5 dxe5 21 ♘xc4 ♕f6 (or 21...♗xb4 22 ♘xe5 ♗xe1 23 ♕xe1 ♕d6 24 ♕c3 f6, when White has enough compensation for the exchange but no more, A.Schachter-L.Pantaleoni, corr 1989/90) 22 ♗a4 ♖e6 23 ♕b3 ♖b8 (23...♖d8! as suggested by Nunn) 24 ♗d7 ♖e7 25 ♗g4 turned out well for White in J.Nunn-A.Beliavsky, Brussels 1988, but Black has potential improvements along the way.

17 ♖b1



17...h6

Most often seen, and incidentally Karpov's choice is 17...♗a8, e.g. 18 ♗a1 g6 19 dxe5 (19 c4 will probably transpose) 19...♘xe5 20 ♘xe5 dxe5 21 c4 bxc4 22 ♗c3 ♗c6! (Otherwise 22...c5 23 bxc5?! ♖xb1 24 ♕xb1 ♗xc5 25 ♘xc4 ♕c7 was at least equal for Black in K.Thorsteins-J.Hjartarson, Westmann Islands 1985. However much stronger is Grünfeld's idea of 23 ♘xc4! [rather than 23 bxc5], the point being that following 23...♕xd1 24 ♖bxd1 cxb4 25 ♗xe5 ♖bc8 26 ♗xf6 ♖xc4 27 ♗b3, White has the initiative and then after the forcing line 27...♖c7 28 e5 ♖c3 29 e6 ♖xb3 30 exf7+ ♔xf7 31 ♖d7+ ♔xf6 32 ♖xe8 he wins the exchange.) 23 ♕e2 ♗b5 24 ♘xc4 c5 25 bxc5 ♖c8 26 ♗b3 ♖xc5 27 ♗b4 ♖c6 with equality, W.Browne-A.Karpov, Amsterdam 1976.

18 ♗a1 ♗a8 19 ♖e3

A better try than releasing the tension with 19 dxe5, as 19...dxe5 20 c4 c5! was equal in J.Hjartarson-A.Beliavsky, Belfort 1988.

19...g6 20 ♕e2 c6 21 c4 ♗g7?

Too passive. Black should play 21...exd4! 22 ♗xd4 bxc4 23 ♘xc4 d5, or 23...c5 with

reasonable chances.

22 dxe5 dxe5 23 c5

After this cramping move Black's light-squared bishop never sees the 'light' of day.

23...♘h5 24 g3 ♕c7 25 ♖d3 ♖bd8

If 25...♘f8 26 ♘f1 ♘e6, then 27 ♖d6 would be annoying for Black.

26 ♖d1 ♘f8 27 ♘f1 ♖xd3 28 ♕xd3 ♘f6 29 ♘e3 ♗b7 30 ♔g2 ♕b8 31 ♗b2 ♕c7 32 ♗b3 ♖e7?!

Shirov points out that Black could put up a better defence with 32...♕b8, but after 33 ♘g4 ♘xg4 34 hxg4, White's domination of the d-file ensures a clear advantage.

33 ♕d8! ♕xd8

If 33...♘xe4, then 34 ♘g4! regains the e-pawn and puts Black under strong pressure. Black's best hope would then be 34...♖d7 35 ♕xc7 ♖xc7 36 ♗xe5 ♖d7 37 ♖e1 ♘d2 38 ♘xd2 ♖xd2 39 ♘f6+ ♗xf6 40 ♗xf6 ♖d3, but White can continue with 41 ♖e8 ♖xb3 42 ♗e7 ♖d3 (or 42...♖xb4 43 ♖xf8+ ♔g7 44 ♖b8 winning) 43 ♗xf8 ♖d7 44 ♗xh6+ ♔h7 45 ♗c1, when the dreadful bishop on b7 and the threat of ♗b2 leave Black with a nigh on hopeless defensive task.

34 ♖xd8 ♘6d7

After 34...♖d7, White just sidesteps with 35 ♖b8, and if then 35...♘xe4, the menacing 36 ♘g4 turns the screw.

35 ♘h4 ♔h7 36 ♘hf5!

The simplification that follows leaves Black completely tied up and White can just push his majority to create decisive threats.

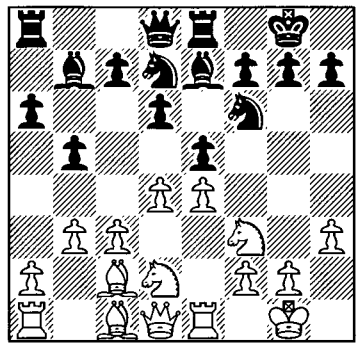
36...gxf5 37 ♘xf5 ♗f6 38 ♘xe7 ♗xe7 39 ♖e8 ♗g5 40 ♗xf7 ♔g7 41 ♗b3 ♗f6 42 f4 ♘g6 43 f5 ♘gf8 44 h4 ♔h7 45 ♔h3 ♔g7 46 g4 ♔h7 47 ♗c1 ♗g7 48 g5 hxg5 49 hxg5 ♔h8 1-0

Game 31

P.Leko-V.Kramnik

Monaco rapid 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 b3



In Games 36 and 37 White plays this move only after switching his queen's knight to g3. Here, if the knight stays on d2 for a while then the queen's bishop will probably be developed to b2 or a3.

13...♗f8 14 d5

The most common, but not the only move here. The main alternative 14 ♗b2 retains the tension, at least for the moment.

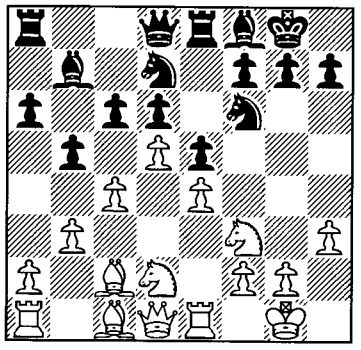
a) 14...c5 is recommended in *ECO* but this has dropped out of practice. Most folk probably play 14...g6 as this is the standard manoeuvre in most lines and move orders in the Breyer.

The move 14...c5, can be met by 15 d5, but then the bishop on b2 is on the wrong diagonal, but I don't know if this is so serious in such a closed position. *ECO* quotes the old game A.Mikhalchishin-A.Beliavsky, USSR 1988 which continued 15 a4 ♕c7 16 ♗d3 exd4 17 cxd4 bxa4 18 ♖xa4 cxd4 19 ♗xd4 ♘c5 20 ♖c4 ♕d8 with equality.

b) 14...g6 15 a4 (15 ♖c1 c6 [discouraging d4-d5] 16 c4 exd4 17 ♗xd4 ♗h6 18 ♗e3 ♗g7 19 b4 c5, gave Black adequate counter-play in P.Thipsay-K.Sasikiran, Indian Championship 2003) 15...♘h5!? (simpler is 15...♗g7 16 ♗d3 c6 17 ♕c2 ♖c8, which can transpose from 13 a4, see Game 30) 16 c4 c6 17 ♘f1 bxc4 18 bxc4 exd4 19 ♗xd4 ♕c7 20 ♖b1 ♗g7 21 ♗xg7 ♘xg7 22 ♘e3 h5,

O.Romanishin-A.Petrosian, USSR 1972, is given by *ECO* as unclear but Black's kingside seems shaky to me.

14...c6 15 c4



15...♘b6!

By hitting the c4-pawn White is temporarily stopped from pursuing the ♘d2-f1-g3 (or e3) manoeuvre.

The traditional line with 15...♕c7 is recognised as playable but not fully equal, so Kramnik's revival of Geller's move may be better, especially as he didn't seem to have any difficulties in this game. So if 15...♕c7 16 ♘f1 (Black wasn't doing badly after 16 a4 ♖ec8 17 ♖a2 bxc4 18 bxc4 a5 19 ♗d3 ♘c5 20 ♗b1 ♗a6, A.Karpov-O.Romanishin, USSR 1979) 16...♖ec8 (in the game V.Akopian-I.Ibragimov, Kazan 2001 Black preferred to keep the tension on the queenside with 16...♖ac8 17 ♘e3 g6 18 ♗d2 ♗g7 19 ♖c1 ♘c5; White then pushed with 20 dxc6 ♗xc6 21 ♘d5 ♕b7 22 ♗g5 ♗xd5 23 cxd5 h6 24 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 25 b4 ♘d7 26 ♗b3 ♘b6 27 ♖e2, but his nagging edge didn't lead to more than a draw) 17 ♘e3 g6 18 ♘h2 h5?! (this move can prove to be a major concession as the kingside is badly loosened. Beliavsky analyses instead 18...bxc4 19 bxc4 cxd5 20 cxd5 a5 21 ♗d2 ♗a6 22 ♖c1 ♘c5 23 ♘eg4 with a small edge to White.) 19 ♘hf1 a5 20 ♗d2 ♗g7 21 ♖c1 bxc4 22 bxc4 ♘c5 23 ♕f3 ♕d8 24 ♘g3, White was threatening the dangerous ♘ef5 in L.Ljubojevic-A.Beliavsky, Reykjavik 1991, and so had the better game.

16 ♗d3

The stem game continued 16 ♗b2 ♘fd7 17 dxc6 ♗xc6 18 cxb5 axb5 19 ♘f1 ♘c5 20 ♘g3 f6! (supporting e5 to prepare ...d5) 21 ♕e2 d5, J.Klovans-E.Geller, USSR 1979 and Black had a fine game. Then 23 years passed by before ...♘b6 was played again (if Megabase 2003 is anything to go by)!

16...♘fd7 17 ♗a3?!

Both 17 ♗b2 g6 and 17 dxc6 ♗xc6 18 cxb5 axb5 19 ♕e2 b4 20 ♗b5 ♕c7 are fine for Black, but the text is worse as Black now grasps the initiative.

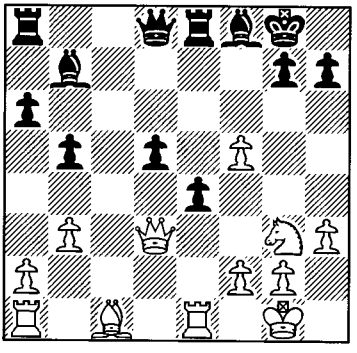
17...cxd5 18 cxd5 f5!

One of the points of having a knight on b6 and a bishop on b7 is that d5 can be undermined.

19 exf5 ♘xd5 20 ♘e4 ♘7f6 21 ♘fg5 ♘f4 22 ♗c1

A sign that things have gone wrong, but if 22 ♘e6 ♘xe6 23 fxe6 ♘xe4 24 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 25 ♖xe4 d5! then Black wins material.

22...♘xd3 23 ♕xd3 ♘xe4 24 ♘xe4 d5 25 ♘g3 e4



26 ♕d2

It must have been tempting to play 26 ♕d4, but Black holds sway as can be seen by Kramnik's analysis: 26...♗d6 27 ♗b2 ♗e5 28 ♕d2 (or if 28 ♕xe5 ♖xe5 29 ♗xe5 d4 30 ♖ad1 d3 31 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 32 ♖xe4 ♕d5 33 ♖e3 ♖d8) 28...d4 29 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 30 ♖xe4

♗h2+ 31 ♔xh2 ♖xe4 32 f3 ♕d6+ 33 ♔h1 ♖f4.

26...d4 27 ♗b2 ♗c5 28 ♖ac1 ♗b6 29 ♕f4 ♕d5!?

More solid is 29...♕e7.

30 ♖c2?

In this very unclear position, Kramnik instead suggests 30 f6! g5! 31 ♕g4 ♖e5 with complications.

30...e3! 31 fxe3 ♖ac8 32 ♖d2 ♖xe3!

Stronger than 32...♗a5 33 ♖ed1 ♗xd2 34 ♖xd2 ♖xe3, as White has dangerous counterplay with 35 f6.

33 ♖xe3 dxe3 34 ♖e2

Kramnik considers 34 ♖xd5 to be the lesser evil as after 34...e2+ 35 ♔h2 e1♕ 36 ♖d4 ♗xg2! 37 ♕d2 (37 ♕g5 ♗d5 38 ♕xg7+ ♔xg7 39 ♖d1+ ♕c3 40 ♗xc3+ ♖xc3 41 ♖xd5 is refuted by 41...♗c7) 37...♕xd2 38 ♖xd2 ♗f3, Black is better but not winning.

34...♖c2! 35 ♕g4

If 35 ♕e5 ♕xe5 36 ♗xe5, then 36...♖xa2! 37 ♖xa2 e2+.

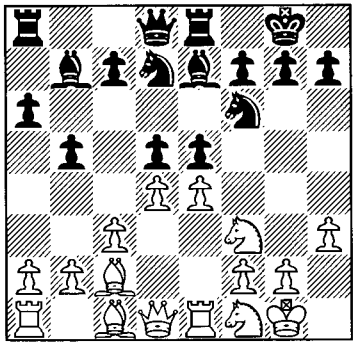
35...♖xb2! 36 f6 g6 37 f7+ ♕xf7 0-1

Game 32

E.Lobron-L.Portisch

Wijk aan Zee 1985

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1 d5?!



The d5-freeing break occurs in a number of lines in the Breyer. Here it seems unsatisfactory if White plays precisely.

14 ♘xe5!

The strongest and the main reason why 13...d5 has disappeared from tournament practice.

Until this was understood, White experimented with other moves:

a) 14 exd5 exd4 15 ♘xd4 ♗xd5 16 ♗g5 ♗f8 17 ♘e3 ♗b7 18 ♘g4 ♖xe1+ 19 ♕xe1 c5!, with equality. Now White's aggressive try 20 ♘e6 fxe6 21 ♕xe6+ ♔h8 22 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 23 ♘e5 is dead drawn after 23...♕d5 24 ♘f7+ ♔g8 25 ♘h6+, T.Giorgadze-A.Mikhalchishin, USSR 1984.

b) 14 dxe5 ♘xe4 15 ♗f4, is reminiscent of a Spanish Open (C80-3). Then after 15...♘f8 16 ♘e3, as in M.Chiburdanidze-M.Litinskaya, Tbilisi 1984 Chiburdanidze suggests 16...♘g6 17 ♗h2 ♗c5 18 ♕d3 ♕d7 19 h4 with unclear play.

14...♘xe5

Other captures don't gel either: 14...♘xe4 loses a pawn to 15 ♘xf7! ♔xf7 16 ♖xe4 (A.Sokolov-Z.Sturua, Vilnius 1984) as Black dare not take the rook (if 16...dxe4 17 ♗b3+ ♔f8 then 18 ♕h5 mates quickly) and 14...dxe4 15 ♗g5 ♘xe5 just leads to a simplified game where White keeps his nose in front: 16 dxe5 ♘d7 17 ♗xe7 ♖xe7 18 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 19 ♖xe4 ♘xe5 20 ♕e2 ♘g6 21 ♖e1 ♖xe4 22 ♕xe4, P.Korzubov-V.Antonov, Bulgaria 1984.

15 dxe5 ♘xe4 16 f3

Not dangerous is 16 ♗xe4 dxe4 17 ♗f4 ♗c5 18 ♘g3, due to 18...e3!, P.Korzubov-Z.Sturua, Vilnius 1984.

16...♘g5

Relatively best is 16...♘c5 17 b4 ♘d7 18 f4 c5 (but not 18...a5?! 19 ♕d3 g6 20 ♕xb5, S.Kindermann-B.Spassky, Bundesliga 1984 which was very bad for Black) 19 ♕d3 ♘f8 20 bxc5 ♗xc5+ 21 ♗e3 (A.Greenfeld-E.Shvidler, Israel 1984) and now Shvidler suggests 21...♖c8 22 ♗d4 b4 23 ♖ab1 with

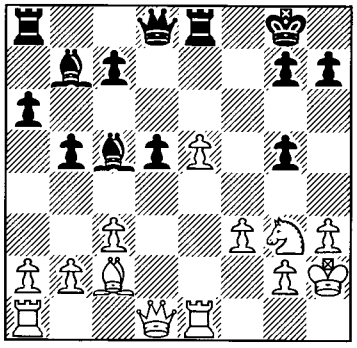
just an edge.

16...♗c5+ is dubious: 17 ♗e3 ♗xe3+ 18 ♘xe3 ♘c5 19 f4 d4 20 cxd4 ♘e6 (J.Plaskett-G.Tringov, Plovdiv 1984) and now White has 21 ♕h5! g6 22 ♕h6 ♕xd4 23 f5 ♘f8 (if 23...♕f4 then Plaskett intended 24 ♘g4!) 24 ♗b3 ♕xe5 25 f6 ♕xf6 26 ♖f1 ♕g7 27 ♗xf7+ winning material.

17 ♘g3 ♗c5+ 18 ♔h2 f6

The bishop pair will be an important factor after 18...♗f2 19 ♖e2 ♗xg3+ 20 ♔xg3.

19 ♗xg5 fxg5



White now inaugurates a clever manoeuvre to soften up Black's kingside pawns.

20 ♕b1! h6

On 20...g6, White wouldn't hesitate long before playing 21 ♗xg6.

21 ♕d1!

Coming back home, but now ♕d3 is going to be unpleasant to meet.

21...♖e6 22 ♘f5 h5?

A fatal error. After 22...♕f8 23 ♘d4 ♗xd4 24 cxd4, White would have all the fun as he can press on the c-file as well as the b1-h7 diagonal, but Black would still be on the board.

Indeed 23 ♕d3 (instead of 23 ♘d4) 23...g6 24 ♘d4 ♗xd4 25 cxd4 c5 (breathing space) 26 dxc5 ♕xc5 27 ♗b3 ♔g7 28 ♖ac1 ♕b6 29 ♕d2 ♖ae8 30 f4, M.Chandler-B.Spassky, Germany 1985, proved dicey for Black's king.

After the text White wins comfortably.

23 ♕d2 ♗f8 24 f4 gxf4 25 ♕xf4 c5 26 ♖e3

The storm clouds are gathering.

26...♕c7 27 ♖f1 ♖ae8 28 ♘d6! ♕e7 29 ♕f5 g6 30 ♖g3 ♗g7 31 ♖xg6 ♖xe5 32 ♕f7+ 1-0

Game 33

B.Fischer-B.Spassky

Sveti Stefan (Game 1) 1992

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2

The immediate ♗g5 is out of fashion as Black obtains a comfortable game e.g. 11 ♗g5 ♗b7 12 ♘bd2 h6 13 ♗h4 and now there are two ways:

a) 13...♖e8 14 ♗c2 c5 15 ♗g3 ♗f8 16 ♖e3 cxd4 17 cxd4 exd4 18 ♘xd4 ♕b6 19 ♘4b3 ♖ac8 20 ♖c1 a5, and Black was ready to take the initiative in A.Zapata-B.Spassky, Salamanca 1991.

b) 13...c5 14 a4 ♕c7 15 ♕e2 c4 16 ♗c2 ♖fe8 17 b4 ♘f8 (otherwise 17...cxb3 18 ♗xb3 ♕xc3, then 19 ♖ec1 ♕b4 20 ♖c7 ♗xe4 21 ♗xf7+ ♔xf7 22 ♘xe4 is double-edged, White having enough compensation for his pawn or two deficit) 18 dxe5 dxe5 19 ♗g3, J.Kostro-A.Matanovic, Vrnjacka Banja Zonal 1967, and here a draw was agreed.

11...♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1

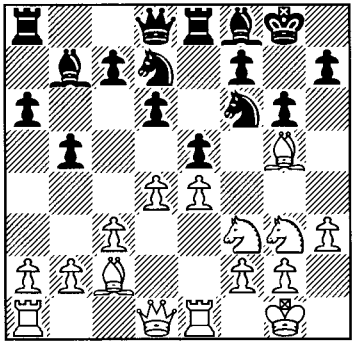
Twenty years earlier, Fischer played 13 b4 in the tenth game of his famous match against Spassky and won a fine game. See game 30 for how Black should react.

13...♗f8 14 ♘g3

After 14 ♗g5 h6, White is rather committed to 15 ♗h4, as retreating to d2 loses the e-pawn. Then 15...g6 (15...g5!? 16 dxe5 ♘xe5 17 ♗g3 ♘g6 is playable, A.Mikhalchishin-N.Hemmassi, Vienna 1982 but unnecessarily risky when the text leads to equal chances. White might be able to create some play against the weakened kingside with 18 ♘3d2! ♗g7 19 ♕f3.) 16 ♘3d2 ♗g7 17 d5 c6 18 c4

♕c7 19 ♘e3 ♘b6 20 dxc6 ♗xc6 leads to equal chances, A.Sokolov-A.Beliavsky, Belfort 1988.

14...g6 15 ♗g5



The best moment to try this pin.

15...h6

Unpinning in this way is standard practice these days.

The older 15...♗g7 allows White to build up pressure with 16 ♕d2 c6 17 ♖ad1 ♕e7 18 ♘h2(!). The concluding moves of D.Velimirovic-P.Thipsay, Yugoslavia-Asia 1984 were then very instructive: 18...♕f8 19 dxe5 dxe5 20 ♘g4 h5 21 ♘h6+ ♔h7 22 ♘hf5! (the attack is slow but unpleasant to face, as Black's pieces are too lethargic to do much about it) 22...gxf5 23 ♘xf5 c5 24 ♖e3 ♖e6 25 ♕e2 ♗c6? (25...♕c8!, intending to meet 26 ♖g3 with 26...♗f8, is Black's only chance to resist) 26 ♖g3 ♗h8 27 ♖xd7! 1-0. Black resigned as 27...♗xd7 28 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 29 ♕xh5+ ♖h6 30 ♘xh6 ♕xh6 31 ♕xf7+ ♗g7 32 ♕xd7 wins easily.

16 ♗d2 ♗g7

In later games of the match Spassky switched to 16...exd4!?, which is more double-edged than the text, e.g. 17 cxd4 c5 18 d5 (18 ♗f4? quickly turned in Black's favour after 18...cxd4 19 ♘xd4 ♘e5 20 b3 d5! 21 ♕d2 dxe4 22 ♘xe4 ♘d5, R.Fischer-B.Spassky, 3rd match game, Sveti Stefan/Belgrade 1992) 18...♘b6 19 ♗a5 ♘fd7 20 b3 ♗g7 21 ♖c1 b4!?, K.Thorsteins-I.Sokolov, Akureyri 1994, with a complex position offering chances for both sides. Rather than 21...b4, the fifth match game saw Spassky trying 21...♕f6 (R.Fischer-B.Spassky, Sveti Stefan/Belgrade Match 1992), but this now looks suspicious after Chandler's suggested 22 h4 h5 23 e5 dxe5 24 ♘e4, with useful compensation.

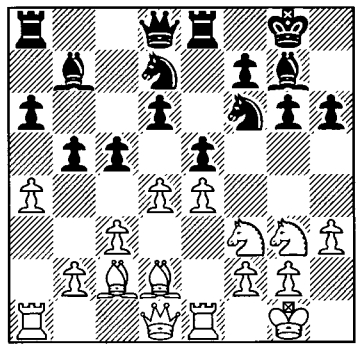
17 a4!?

It's remarkable that Spassky had had this position a couple of times 26 years earlier as White!

17 ♖c1 d5! (although 17...c5 18 d5 ♘b6 19 ♗d3 offers some chances for pressure, Black held after 19...♗c8 20 ♘h2 ♕e7 21 ♖f1 ♖a7 etc. B.Spassky-N.Krogius, Sochi 1966) 18 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 19 dxe5 ♘xe4 20 ♘xe4 dxe4 21 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 22 ♖xe4 ♗xe5 23 ♕e2 ♗g7 (Unzicker claims equality which seems fair enough as...) 24 ♖e1 ♖xe4 25 ♕xe4 ♖c8 26 ♗e3 (...is nullified by...) 26...c6.

Instead after 17 ♕c1 ♔h7 18 h4, Black can either go for the line opening 18...d5!? or the more calm 18...♘f8 19 h5 ♘g4 20 ♕d1 ♘e6, Y.Liao-J.Smejkal, Thessaloniki Olympiad 1984.

17...c5



There are a couple of alternatives at this point:

a) 17...♘b6 was a shade better for White after 18 axb5 axb5 19 b3 ♘fd7 20 ♗d3 b4 21 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 22 dxe5 ♘xe5 23 ♘xe5 dxe5 24 ♕c2 bxc3 25 ♗xc3, A.Karpov-

V.Korchnoi, Leningrad Match 1971.

b) 17...exd4 (should be compared with the note dealing with 16...exd4) 18 cxd4 c5 19 d5 ♘b6 20 ♕c1 ♔h7 21 ♗a5 ♘fd7 with equality, R.Kuczynski-A.Kveinys, Warsaw 1989, but Beliavsky and Romanishin prefer White after 19 ♗f4 which (compared with the Fischer-Spassky game from the note to 16...exd4) now has the advantage of hitting the d-pawn.

18 d5 c4 19 b4!?

A new idea at the time. After a routine continuation such as 19 ♗e3 ♘c5 20 ♕d2 h5 21 ♗g5 ♕c7 22 ♘h2 ♖ab8 23 axb5 axb5 24 ♗h6 ♗c8 25 ♖f1 ♕e7, A.Bellaïche-A.Shchekachev, French Team Championship 2003, it's difficult for White to make progress. Black is ready for anything and his secure knight on c5 enables him to look forward to the rest of the game with confidence.

19...♘h7?!

Passive and allowing White something of a free hand. If instead 19...cxb3 20 ♗xb3 ♘c5 21 c4! (more precise than 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♗c2 ♖xa1 23 ♕xa1 ♘xd5!? 24 exd5 ♗xd5, which left Black with enough practical compensation for the piece, M.Dutreeuw-P.Short, Clichy 1993) 21...bxc4 22 ♗xc4, White retains a small pull according to Chandler.

20 ♗e3 h5 21 ♕d2 ♖f8 22 ♖a3 ♘df6

After 22...h4 23 ♘f1 f5 24 exf5 gxf5 25 ♘g5 ♘xg5 26 ♗xg5 ♗f6 27 ♗h6 ♗g7 28 ♗xg7 ♔xg7, Chandler recommends 29 f4, and Matanovic 29 axb5 axb5 30 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 31 ♖a1, with the better chances for White in either case.

23 ♖ea1 ♕d7 24 ♖1a2 ♖fc8 25 ♕c1 ♗f8 26 ♕a1 ♕e8

White piles up on the a-file but Black holds firm, so now Fischer needs to find another way to tighten the screw.

27 ♘f1!

Heading for new vistas!

27...♗e7 28 ♘1d2

Keeping total control with 28 ♘3d2!? ♔g7 29 f3 is the most precise; now Spassky succeeds in mixing it.

28...♔g7 29 ♘b1! ♘xe4!

The docile 29...♘d7 loses to 30 axb5 axb5 31 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 32 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 33 ♕xa8 ♗xa8 34 ♘a3. The point of the White's manoeuvre becomes clear... the b5-pawn falls!

30 ♗xe4 f5

The cool 30...♘f6, as pointed out by Chandler, was also worth thinking about.

31 ♗c2 ♗xd5 32 axb5 axb5 33 ♖a7! ♔f6 34 ♘bd2 ♖xa7 35 ♖xa7 ♖a8

White has a piece for two pawns, but his minor pieces lack targets. He therefore needs to create weak points to attack.

36 g4! hxg4 37 hxg4 ♖xa7

If 37...fxg4 38 ♘h2, Black's king is suddenly exposed. Matanovic considers 37...f4 to be a better chance, but White still retains winning chances after 38 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 39 ♕xa8 ♗xa8 40 ♗b6.

38 ♕xa7 f4 39 ♗xf4!

A strong combination leaving Black's king in trouble.

39...exf4 40 ♘h4! ♗f7

For the record Black can fight on with 40...♘f8, but then the continuation 41 ♕d4+ ♔e6 42 ♘xg6 ♘xg6 43 ♗f5+ ♔f7 44 ♕xd5+ (44 ♗xg6+ ♔xg6 45 ♕xd5 ♔g7! favours White but doesn't yet look winning) 44...♔g7 45 ♕e4 wins a pawn.

41 ♕d4+ ♔e6 42 ♘f5! ♗f8 43 ♕xf4 ♔d7 44 ♘d4 ♕e1+ 45 ♔g2 ♗d5+ 46 ♗e4 ♗xe4+ 47 ♘xe4

Black's attempt at counterplay has fizzled out and White can hone in on the booty.

47...♗e7 48 ♘xb5 ♘f8 49 ♘bxd6 ♘e6 50 ♕e5 1-0

Game 34

R.Aarthie-E.Vladimirov

Hyderabad 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 h3 d6 9 c3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2

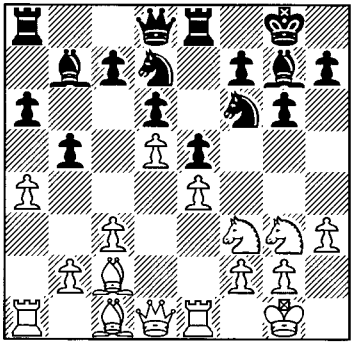
♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1 ♗f8 14 ♘g3 g6 15 a4 ♗g7

There are a number of options for Black at this point, of which the other principal alternative 15...c5 is the subject of Game 35.

Curiously 15...c6 is rather unkindly given a question mark by *ECO*, but after 16 ♗g5 ♕c7 17 ♕d2 ♗g7 18 b3, H.Stefansson-P.Acs, Cuba 2000, we have transposed to Game 36 which is not too bad for Black.

Lastly 15...exd4 16 cxd4 c5 (here 16...♗g7, as in R.Lau-Y.Kraidman, Israel 1982, can be met by the annoying 17 ♗f4) 17 d5 ♗g7 18 ♖b1 ♕c7 19 b3 ♖e7 20 ♗g5 h6 21 ♗f4 ♖ae8 22 ♕d2 ♔h7 23 ♖ec1, B.Damljanovic-Y.Kraidman, Hastings 1976/7, generates Modern Benoni style play. Black has less space and his queenside is coming under scrutiny, so an edge for White seems a fair judgement.

16 d5



In the game F.Hellers-G.Giorgadze, Debrecen 1992 White tried to keep the centre fluid: 16 ♗d3 c6 17 ♗g5 h6 18 ♗e3 ♕e7 19 ♕c2 ♕f8 20 ♖ad1 ♖ac8 (Black has less space but builds up patiently waiting for the right moment to counter in the centre) 21 ♗c1 ♖c7 22 b3 d5! 23 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 24 dxe5 ♘xe4 25 ♘xe4 dxe4 26 ♖xe4 c5, with easy equality for Black.

16...♕b8

Alternatives have fared less well in practice:

a) After 16...♕e7 17 b3 c6 18 c4 bxc4 19 bxc4 cxd5?! (19...♘c5 is a recent attempt to improve but after 20 a5! ♖ec8 21 ♗g5 ♖c7 22 ♕d2 ♗c8 23 ♖ab1, White kept an edge in C.Daly-P.Short, Irish Championship 2003. Perhaps Black should try 19...a5, but then the queen would be better on c7 to cover the a5-pawn.) 20 cxd5 a5 21 ♗d3 ♘c5 22 ♗b5 ♖ec8 23 ♗a3 ♗a6 24 ♖b1, White kept control, A.Gipslis-T.Stanciu, Lublin 1969.

b) 16...♘b6 seems to be inferior after 17 a5 ♘bd7 18 ♗e3 h6 19 c4! bxc4 20 ♗a4, with positional pressure that induced a desperate piece sacrifice in M.Nizynski-M.Stoinev, Copenhagen 1989, i.e. 20...♖f8 21 ♕c2 ♘xd5!? 22 exd5 ♗xd5 23 ♕d2 ♗xf3 24 gxf3 ♔h7 25 ♗c6 but White was on top in the complications that followed.

17 b3 c6 18 c4 b4!?

A new way of handling the position. Previously seen were two alternatives:

a) 18...♕c7 19 a5 c5 20 ♘h2 ♘f8 21 ♗d3 b4 22 ♖a2, M.Ghinda-J.Kostro, Bath 1973, is a shade better for White. Black lacks space and White has some chances to get going on the kingside. However, as I've mentioned in analogous positions, it's often difficult for him to achieve anything concrete if all the play is to be only on one wing.

b) 18...bxc4 19 bxc4 a5 20 ♗e3 ♕c7 21 ♕d2 (or here 21 ♘e2 ♗a6 22 ♘d2 ♖eb8 23 ♖c1 ♖b4, with adequate chances for Black, A.Grischuk-E.Vladimirov, Russia 2001. Does this later game suggest that Vladimirov prefers 18...bxc4 after all, or was he just avoiding preparation?) 21...♗a6 22 ♖ac1, and now an important choice for Black:

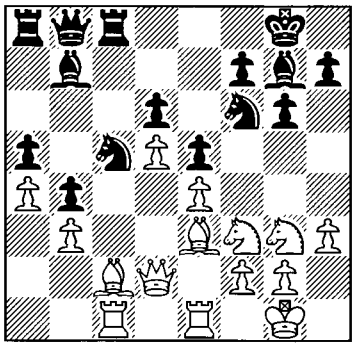
b1) 22...♖eb8 is considered imprecise as after 23 c5! cxd5 24 exd5 dxc5 25 d6 ♕d8, Y.Grünfeld-R.Lev, Tel Aviv 1990, then 26 ♗h6 gives dangerous play for the pawn.

b2) 22...♖ab8 is proposed by Romanishin as an improvement on the above. However he still gives White an edge, but with ...♖b4 threatened it doesn't look that clear to me (note that with a rook on e8, defending the

e5-pawn, the breakthrough with c4-c5 is no longer convincing).

b3) Kunte has shown that the provocative 22...♘c5!? deserves some thought, e.g. 23 ♗xc5 dxc5 24 ♖ed1 ♖ab8, R.Leitao-A.Kunte, Istanbul Olympiad 2000. White messes up Black's pawns and can even contemplate a disruptive push of the d-pawn, but this comes at the price of being short of dark-squared control. This double-edged strategy has earned the Indian a couple of fine victories including that particular game which continued 25 ♕e3 ♗f8 26 ♕g5 ♗g7 27 d6 ♕d8 28 ♕e3 ♘d7 29 ♗b3 ♖b4 30 ♘e1 ♕h4! and the weak dark squares became a significant factor.

19 ♗e3 a5 20 ♕d2 cxd5 21 cxd5 ♖c8 22 ♖ac1 ♘c5



Black's plan seems very logical. The knight on c5 is supported by the rook and White has targets on b3 and e4 thus tying down the light-squared bishop.

23 ♗h6 ♗xh6 24 ♕xh6 ♖c7 25 ♕e3 ♕d8 26 ♗d1

White would like to establish a presence on the c4-square, but his pieces need time to reorganise.

26...♘fd7 27 ♘d2 ♘b6 28 ♗e2 ♕h4!

Just as White is getting himself together on the queenside, Black switches the action elsewhere.

29 ♘c4 ♘xc4 30 ♗xc4 ♖f8 31 ♘f1 f5 32 exf5 gxf5

Black has seized the initiative, so White hurries to exchange queens, but even so Black still retains the better options.

33 ♕g3+ ♕xg3 34 ♘xg3 f4 35 ♘e4 ♘xe4 36 ♖xe4 ♖c5

Clearly 36...♗xd5?? just loses as 37 ♗xd5+ is check.

37 ♖d1 ♗c8 38 f3 ♗f5 39 ♖e2 ♖fc8 40 ♖b2 ♖xc4!

An excellent exchange sacrifice. Note how White's rooks are impotent.

41 bxc4 ♖xc4 42 ♖dd2 ♖c3 43 ♔f2 b3 44 g4 fxg3+ 45 ♔xg3 ♔f7 46 h4 ♗c2 0-1

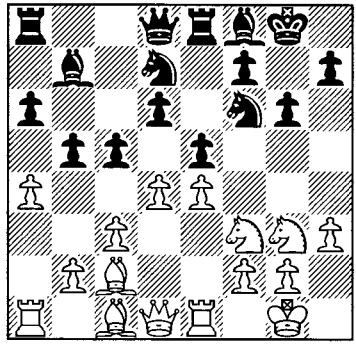
Hecht proposes the plausible continuation 47 ♔f2 ♖c4 48 ♔e3 ♖xa4 49 ♖dxc2 bxc2 50 ♖xc2 ♖d4 51 ♖c7+ ♔g6 52 ♖d7 ♖xd5 etc. and as he has nothing better, White resigned.

Game 35

Ki.Georgiev-R.Ponomariov

Moscow 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1 ♗f8 14 ♘g3 g6 15 a4 c5



The main line which has occurred in literally hundreds of games.

16 d5

16 ♗e3 allows Black to capture the e-pawn as follows: 16...exd4 17 cxd4 ♗xe4 18

♘xe4 ♘xe4 19 ♗xe4 ♖xe4 20 dxc5 ♘xc5 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♕d5 ♖e8 (but not 22...♖c8? 23 b4! ♖xb4 24 ♖a7 ♕f6 25 ♘g5 ♕f5 26 ♕d2, with a strong attack in V.Kotronias-Ki.Georgiev, Manila Olympiad 1992 as White hits both f7 and the rook) 23 ♘g5 ♘e6 24 ♘xe6 fxe6 25 ♕xb5 ♖b8, with approximate equality, Z.Gyimesi-G.Sax, Lilafüred 1999.

These two games references remind one as to how many of the world's best grandmasters play the principal Spanish variations with *both* colours.

16...c4

Black assures the use of the c5-square for his cavalry. From there a knight points at some key squares which seriously diminishes White's hopes of over-running the kingside.

Instead 16...♘b6 17 ♕e2 ♘xa4, is now considered to be an inferior plan and is rarely played, i.e. 18 ♗xa4 bxa4 19 ♖xa4 ♗c8 20 ♗e3 ♖b8 21 ♖ea1 ♖e7 22 ♖4a2 (pressure on the a-pawn ties Black down, but to make progress White needs to create other threats such as ♘f3-d2-c4-a5-c6) 22...♖eb7 23 ♕c2 ♘e8 24 ♘d2 ♕h4! 25 ♖b1 (avoiding 25 ♘c4? f5!) 25...♘g7 26 ♖xa6! ♖xb2 27 ♖xb2 ♖xb2 28 ♕xb2 ♗xa6 29 ♕b6, with a nagging pull, V.Anand-Je.Piket, Monaco rapid 2000.

17 ♗g5 h6

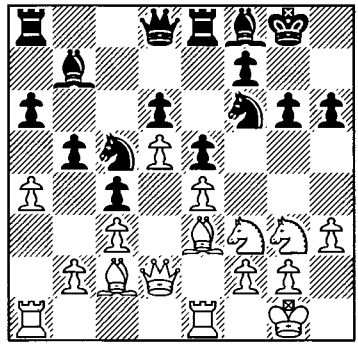
Black sometimes tries to avoid touching his h-pawn, but this leaves him a little passive and lacking space for manoeuvre, e.g. 17...♗g7 18 ♕d2 ♕e7 19 ♘h2 ♕f8 20 f3 ♘c5 21 ♘g4 ♘fd7 22 ♘h6+ ♔h8 23 h4 ♗f6 24 f4 ♕g7 25 ♖f1, with a persistent initiative, Z.Lanka-C.Kunze, Bundesliga 1998.

18 ♗e3 ♘c5

This is by far the most popular move as Black doesn't fear 19 ♗xc5, bearing in mind the importance of the dark-squared bishop to White. The ♗e3xc5 theme does crop up later in this game, but only as part of a forcing sequence when Black is off-balance.

So the preparatory 18...♕c7 is unnecessary (but prudent later – see move 23!), and 18...♗g7 is committal as it's not yet clear where this bishop wants to move to next.

19 ♕d2



The normal move.

19...h5!?

Not everyone likes to weaken the g5-square and so 19...♔h7 has also been popular over the years. A recent example that shows that Black is also happy in that line too: 20 ♖a3 ♘fd7 21 ♘h2 ♗g7 22 ♖ea1 ♕c7 23 ♕c1 ♘b6 24 axb5 axb5 25 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 26 ♖xa8, when a draw was agreed in T.Luther-P.Acs, Yerevan 2001.

20 ♗g5

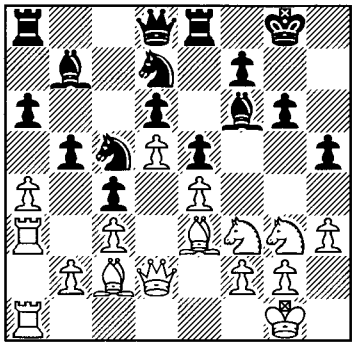
Here 20 ♘g5 has been abandoned as Black obtains a good game after 20...♗h6! 21 f4 (or 21 ♖e2 ♕e7 22 ♖f1 h4 23 ♘h1 ♖f8, K.Mokry-J.Smejkal, Timavia Trnava 1989) 21...h4! 22 fxe5 ♖xe5 23 ♘f3 ♗xe3+ 24 ♕xe3 ♘xd5!, J.Nunn-A.Beliavsky, Linares 1988.

If instead 20 ♖a3 ♘fd7 21 ♖ea1 ♗g7 22 ♗g5 ♗f6 23 ♗h6 ♕e7, Black is also rock-solid. Then after the further 24 ♕c1 bxa4 25 ♗xa4?! h4, M.Sion Castro-G.Giorgadze, Terres Catalanes 1997, Black took the initiative.

20...♗e7 21 ♖a3 ♘fd7 22 ♗e3

Exchanging bishops just eases the defenders task.

22...♗f6 23 ♖ea1



23...♘b6?

An instructive mistake. Instead Black is fine after 23...♕c7, which links rooks and maintains a firm grip on to c5, e.g. 24 ♕e2 ♘b6 25 axb5 axb5 26 ♘d2 ♖xa3 27 ♖xa3 ♗c8 with equality, A.Martin Gonzalez-G.Giorgadze, Benasque 1999.

A new and slightly risky idea was seen in S.Ganguly-S.Kayumov, Doha 2003: 23...♖b8!? 24 ♘e2 bxa4!? 25 ♘g3 h4 26 ♘f1 a5, when Black managed to get adequate piece play for his dodgy pawns.

24 axb5 axb5 25 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 26 ♖a5

Hitting the b5 soft spot and forcing Black to take action.

26...h4

Relatively best. Otherwise 26...♘xd5?! favours White after 27 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 28 ♗xc5 dxc5 29 exd5, followed by ♘e4, and the passive 26...♕d7?! can be met by 27 ♗xc5 dxc5 28 ♘xh5! gxh5 29 ♕h6 with a strong attack.

27 ♘f1?!

Here 27 ♗xc5! dxc5 (after 27...hxg3 28 ♗b4 gxf2+ 29 ♕xf2 White drops the b5-pawn) 28 ♘e2 ♘xd5 29 ♖xb5 leaves White with a clear advantage.

27...♘xd5! 28 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 29 ♗xc5?!

Probably not best. Kostiakov prefers 29 exd5! ♘d3 30 ♗xd3 cxd3 31 ♗g5 ♗xg5 32 ♕xg5, with advantage to White as Black's king is exposed to attack.

29...dxc5 30 exd5 e4 31 ♘3h2 ♗g7

With two pieces for the rook, one feels that White should be on top, but Black's last move prepares ...f5 using his pawns to restrict the White minor pieces. Play now becomes double-edged.

32 d6 ♕c6 33 ♕f4?

White can organise his pieces with 33 d7 ♖d8 34 ♕f4 f5 35 f3 exf3 36 ♘xf3, and as the h4-pawn will fall White can still claim an edge.

33...f5 34 f3 e3 35 ♘xe3 ♗e5 36 ♕h6?

An error too far. Here after 36 ♕g5!, a draw would have been logical, i.e. 36...♗xh2+! (Black can not play as in the game as 36...♕xd6 37 ♘hf1 ♗f4 would then be met by 38 ♘xf5) 37 ♔xh2 ♕xd6+ 38 ♔g1 ♕g3 39 ♕h6 etc.

36...♕xd6 37 ♘hf1 ♗f4 38 ♘xf5 gxf5 39 ♕h5 ♖e1 40 g3 ♗e3+ 0-1

A neat finish would be 41 ♔g2 ♕xg3+! 42 ♘xg3 ♖g1+ 43 ♔h2 hxg3 mate.

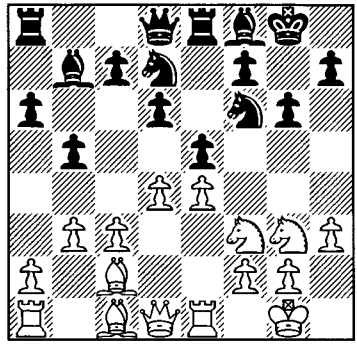
Game 36

E.Van den Doel-Z.Gyimesi

Vlissingen 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1 ♗f8 14 ♘g3 g6 15 b3

At present this is considered the most difficult for Black to meet.



Now the main reply is 15...♗g7 which is covered in Game 37. However as White seems to then retain an edge, the alternatives examined here are worth a closer look.

15...c6

With this move Black hopes to keep the tension in the centre as White can't seriously consider d4-d5. However his own light-squared bishop becomes less influential and consequently doesn't press onto the e4-point.

The alternative 15...c5, when met by the natural 16 d5, isn't bad and transposes to Game 29, note to Black's 14th move (via the move-order 12...c5 13 ♘f1 ♖e8 14 ♘g3 ♗f8 15 d5 g6 16 b3).

Black's sharpest and most provocative try is 15...d5!? 16 ♗g5 (16 exd5 plays into Black's hands as c3 is weak: 16...♘xd5 17 dxe5 ♘xc3 18 ♕d3 ♘d5 19 ♗g5 ♕c8 20 ♕d4 ♗g7, and Black had an edge in J.Polgar-A.Beliavsky, Munich 1991) 16...h6 (16...dxe4? – a *finger-fehler*? – 17 ♘xe5 h6 [17...♘xe5 18 dxe5 ♕xd1 19 ♖axd1 ♘d5 20 ♘xe4 also leaves Black a pawn light] 18 ♘xd7 hxg5 19 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 20 ♗xe4, and White was already winning, R.Kasimdzhanov-A.Beliavsky, Hyderabad 2002) 17 ♗h4!? (Black is OK after 17 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 18 exd5 exd4 19 ♘e4 ♕b6). A critical piece sacrifice that most theoreticians up to now judge as preferable for White, but is this correct?

a) 17...dxe4 18 ♘xe4 g5 (or 18...♗e7 19 dxe5 ♘xe4 20 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 21 ♖xe4 ♗xh4, and now White retains the advantage with 22 ♘xh4! ♖xe5 23 ♖d4 c5 24 ♖xd7 ♕xh4 25 ♖xf7!, as pointed out by Van der Sterren in *New in Chess Yearbook 66*) 19 dxe5 ♘xe4 20 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 21 ♖xe4 gxh4 22 ♖d4 ♖e7 23 e6 fxe6 24 ♘e5, was much better for White, J.Polgar-B.Spassky, Budapest Match 1993.

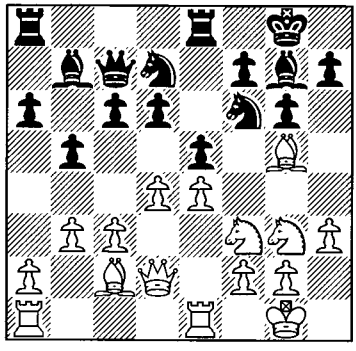
b) 17...g5 18 ♘xg5 hxg5 19 ♗xg5 dxe4 (a possible improvement is 19...exd4! 20 e5 ♖xe5 21 ♖xe5 ♘xe5 22 ♕xd4, when Van der Sterren claims a clear advantage to White, but after 22...♕d6! 23 ♘f5 ♕e6 [Wolff] Black could well be defending) 20 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 21 ♖xe4 (White can obtain a slightly favourable endgame with 21 ♘xe4 ♗e7 22 ♘xf6+ ♗xf6 23 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 24 dxe5 ♕xd1 25 ♖axd1 ♘h7 26 f4, but the text is probably even stronger!) 21...♕c8 22 ♖h4 exd4 23 cxd4 ♗g7 (Sherzer prefers 23...♕b7 24 ♘f5 ♕d5 25 ♕d3, but Black still has big problems to defend) 24 ♘f5 ♘f8 25 ♕f3 ♖e6 26 d5 ♖e5 27 ♘h6+ ♗xh6 28 ♗xf6 and White's attack was just too strong, A.Sherzer-A.Lesiege, Biel Interzonal 1993.

So summing up, the correctness of 15...d5 depends on Wolff's defence following 19...exd4 etc. in line 'b'.

16 ♗g5 ♗g7

Also possible is 16...h6, for instance 17 ♗e3 ♗g7 18 ♕d2 ♔h7 19 ♘h2 ♕c7 20 ♘g4 (If 20 f4 then Leko rates 20...c5! highly, when 21 d5 allows 21...exf4 22 ♗xf4 ♘e5, when Black has a firm hold of the e5-square, and the other possibility 21 fxe5 dxe5 22 d5 he considers to be unclear. However White may still have an edge as the open f-file and protected passed d-pawn should enable him to pressurise Black, who is a long way from establishing a knight on the blockading d6-square.) 20...♘xg4 21 hxg4 d5! (one of the points behind the flexible 15...c6) 22 g5 hxg5 23 ♗xg5 exd4 24 cxd4 c5!, with adequate play, P.Leko-P.Svidler, Groningen 1995. Here we see another aspect of 15...c6, Black can advance further when the time is right!

17 ♕d2 ♕c7



18 a4

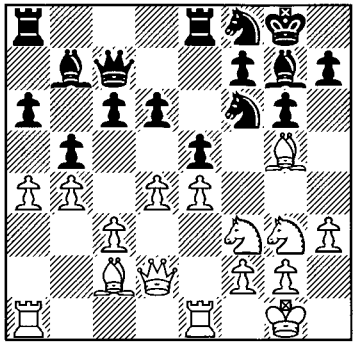
The flexible black set-up reminds one of other ...g6 systems such as a Philidor (C41 where Black sometimes plays ...♗e7-f8 and a later ...g6 and ...♗g7), Classical Pirc (B08) or the Modern Steinitz (C76) in the Spanish.

Examples follow to illustrate that it's no easy matter for White to convert his slightly more active set-up into anything concrete:

a) 18 ♖ad1 ♘f8 19 ♗h6 ♘e6 20 a4 c5 21 d5 ♘f8 22 ♖a1 ♖ab8 23 ♕g5 ♗c8 looks threatening but White didn't get very far in A.Sherzer-Z.Gyimesi, Hungarian Team Championship 1998.

b) 18 ♗h6 ♘f8 19 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 20 ♕g5 ♘g8! (stepping out of any trouble) 21 ♘h5+ ♔h8 22 ♘f6 ♘xf6 23 ♕xf6+ ♔g8 24 b4 a5 25 bxa5 ♖xa5 26 ♗b3 ♕e7 27 ♕xe7, P.Svidler-V.Yemelin, St.Petersburg 1996, and a draw was agreed.

18...♘f8 19 b4



19...♖ad8

White can also hope to keep something out of the opening against alternatives:

a) 19...♘6d7 proved to be a shade better for White after 20 ♗b3 c5 21 bxc5 dxc5 22 d5 c4 23 ♗c2, in P.Svidler-Liang Chong, Russia-China 2001.

b) The problem with 19...exd4 20 cxd4 c5 21 d5 is that White has essentially a promising Modern Benoni, with pressure on Black's queenside majority. The greedy 21...♘h5? then loses to 22 ♘xh5 ♗xa1? 23 ♖xa1 gxh5 24 ♗f6.

c) 19...♘e6 20 ♗e3 ♘d7 21 ♗b3 also leads to White obtaining a nice game, e.g. 21...♖ac8 22 axb5 cxb5 23 d5 ♘f4?! 24 ♖ac1 ♘b6 25 ♗xf4 exf4 26 ♕xf4, and Black didn't really have enough compensation despite his superb dark-squared bishop, H.Stefansson-P.Acs, Cuba 2000.

20 ♗b3

The bishop sits comfortably on this useful diagonal.

20...♘e6 21 ♗h6 ♕e7 22 ♘f5!?

Very enthusiastic but White should probably play the prudent 22 ♖ad1, bringing his last piece into play and thus retaining the better prospects.

22...gxf5 23 exf5 e4! 24 fxe6 fxe6 25 ♕g5 ♔h8 26 ♘d2

An imprecision. Gyimesi instead points out 26 ♗xg7+ ♕xg7 27 ♕xg7+ ♔xg7 28 ♘d2 d5 29 ♗c2 e5 30 ♘b3, with the superior ending as the knight heads for c5 or a5 and chastises the opposing bishop.

26...♗xh6 27 ♕xh6 d5 28 f3 ♖g8!

With the queens still on the board things are far from clear, despite Black's light-squared bishop being relegated to the role of a bystander.

29 fxe4 ♖g6 30 ♕f4 ♕g7 31 ♖e2 ♖g8 32 ♕h2?

An ugly square. White should have played 32 ♕f2 with everything to play for.

32...♖g3

White's queen is locked out of play and the storm clouds around his king start to become ominous.

33 e5 ♘h5 34 ♖f1 ♕h6 35 ♖f3 ♘f4!

Crunch!

36 ♖xf4

Or 36 ♖xg3 ♘xe2+.

36...♕xf4 37 ♘f1 ♖f8 38 ♘e3

38 ♘xg3 ♕c1+ mates and 38 ♕xg3 ♕xf1+ 39 ♔h2 ♕xe2 costs a rook.

38...♕xe3+!

Simplest.

39 ♖xe3 ♖xe3 0-1

Game 37

P.Leko-A.Beliavsky

Bled Olympiad 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1 ♗f8 14 ♘g3 g6 15 b3 ♗g7 16 d5 ♘b6

The critical move although Black's principal alternatives are worth mentioning:

a) 16...♗f8 17 ♗g5 h6 18 ♗e3 c6 19 c4 a5 20 ♕d2 ♔h7 21 ♘h2 b4?! (Ftacnik suggests instead 21...a4) 22 ♘g4 ♘xg4 23 hxg4 ♕h4? 24 g5 favoured White in J.Polgar-B.Spassky, Budapest Match 1993.

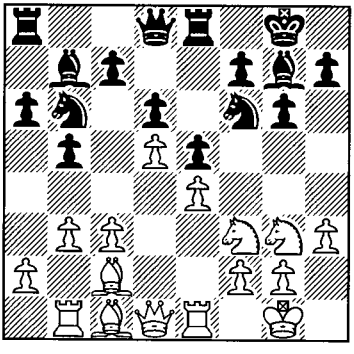
b) 16...♖c8!? and now three tries:

b1) 17 ♗e3 c6 18 c4 ♕c7 19 ♖c1 b4 20 ♕d2 a5 21 ♗b1 c5 22 ♖f1 ♖a8 23 ♘h2 a4 should be OK for Black, V.Anand-P.Van der Sterren, Wijk aan Zee 1998.

b2) 17 c4 c6 18 ♗d2 ♘c5 19 ♖c1 a5 20 a3 bxc4 21 bxc4 ♘fd7 22 ♗b1 ♗a6 23 ♘f1 a4 was also rock-solid in M.Krakops-C.Gabriel, Pula 1997.

b3) After 17 ♗g5, in R.Kasimdzhanov-N.Short, Scanderborg 2003, Black played aggressively: 17...c6 18 c4 h6 19 ♗e3 ♘b6 20 ♖b1 cxd5 21 cxd5 ♘bxd5!? 22 exd5 ♘xd5 23 ♗d2 f5 and obtained interesting play. I predict that we'll see more of 16...♖c8.

17 ♖b1!



The key move.

White is thus able to maintain his centre due to the fact that the bishop on b7 is undefended. Moving the rook off the long diagonal (note the bishop on g7) also diffuses otherwise dangerous piece sacrifices on d5. These points become apparent in the examples that follow:

a) 17 ♗e3 ♖c8 18 ♕e2 c6 19 c4 cxd5 20 cxd5 ♘bxd5! 21 exd5 ♘xd5 promised Black good compensation for the piece in G.Kamsky-P.Van der Sterren, Wijk aan Zee Match 1994.

b) 17 ♗d3 c6 18 c4 cxd5 19 cxd5 ♘bxd5! 20 exd5 e4 21 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 22 ♘xe4 ♖xe4 23 ♖xe4 ♗xa1 24 ♗g5 ♗f6 favoured Black in R.Lindroos-R.Kotka, corr 1971.

c) 17 a4 is met by 17...bxa4 18 bxa4 c6, dissolving the white centre.

17...c6

The recent try 17...c5!? has merit. White is unlikely to be able to attack successfully on the kingside without some tension on the other wing, so White is unwise to allow everything to become totally blocked: 18 a4! bxa4 (18...b4 19 cxb4 cxb4 20 ♗e3 favours White somewhat. Black's knight is misplaced on b6 and White will hope to use the c4-square.) 19 bxa4 ♗c8 20 ♘d2 ♗d7 21 a5?! (21 ♘gf1 is recommended instead by Almasi, when White aims for ♘e3-c4) 21...♘c8 22 ♖a1 (22 ♘c4?! ♗b5 23 ♘b6 ♘xb6 24 axb6 ♖b8 must favour Black) 22...♖b8 23 ♗d3 ♗b5, with a satisfactory game in J.Polgar-Z.Almasi, Budapest 2003.

18 c4 ♕c7

Otherwise 18...cxd5 19 cxd5 ♕c7 20 ♗e3 ♖ec8 21 ♗d3 ♘bd7 22 ♕e2 left White with all the options in E.Anka-K.Pilgaard, Aarhus 1996.

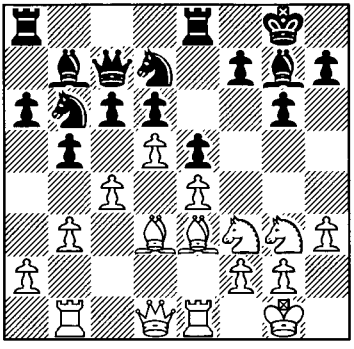
Borrowing an idea from above (see notes to Black's 16th and White's 17th), here 18...♖c8!? can be tried as if 19 ♗e3 then 19...cxd5 20 cxd5 ♘bxd5!? 21 exd5 ♘xd5 follows, with the same position as in the game Kasimdzhanov-Short except that the

pawn is on h7.

19 ♗d3 ♘fd7

After 19...♘bd7, White was still able to keep an edge in a game from six rounds later than the main game: 20 ♗d2 bxc4 21 bxc4 a5 22 ♕c1 ♘c5 23 ♗f1 ♖eb8 24 ♕a3, K.Spraggett-Z.Sturua, Bled Olympiad 2002.

20 ♗e3



20...♘c5

Black's difficulties in this line are also demonstrated in another game where yet again White improves while Black just runs out of ideas: 20...♖ec8 21 ♕d2 bxc4 22 bxc4 ♘a4 23 ♗h6 f6 24 ♘h4 ♘ac5 25 ♗e2 ♘f8 26 ♗e3 ♘fd7 27 ♗g4! ♖d8 28 ♖ed1 cxd5 29 cxd5 ♖ac8 30 ♖bc1 ♕b6 31 ♗e6+ ♔h8 32 ♗h6 ♗xh6? 33 ♘xg6+!, A.Sherzer-P.Wells, Hungarian Team Championship 1995.

21 ♗f1 bxc4 22 bxc4 ♘bd7 23 ♕d2 ♖ab8 24 ♗h6

Black's pieces are well entrenched on the queenside, but his kingside is rather depopulated. White's advanced pawn centre creates problems for Black's pieces to switch wings effectively.

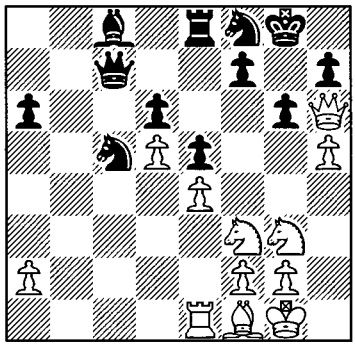
24...♗xh6

If 24...♘f8 then Leko intended the threatening 25 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 26 ♕g5.

25 ♕xh6 ♘f8 26 h4!

Further ammunition is brought up to the front.

26...cxd5 27 cxd5 ♗c8 28 ♖xb8 ♕xb8 29 h5 ♕c7



30 ♘d2!

The star move. The Hungarian maestro will combine threats on the kingside with the annoying ♘c4 bearing down on d6.

30...♗d7?

Although 30...f6, to meet 31 ♘c4 with 31...♖d8, is objectively better White still retains persistent pressure.

31 ♘c4 f6

Unfortunately for Black, 31...♗b5 allows a winning attack with 32 ♘f5! gxf5 33 ♘xd6, e.g. 33...♗d7 34 ♕g5+ ♘g6 35 ♕f6.

32 ♖e3 ♖e7 33 hxg6 hxg6

Now that the softening-up process has taken its toll, White is ready for the *coup de grâce*.

34 ♘h5! gxh5

Leko intended to meet 34...♖f7 with an elegant continuation: 35 ♖g3 ♗b5 36 ♖xg6+ ♘xg6 37 ♕xg6+ ♔f8 38 ♘e3! ♗xf1 39 ♘xf6! when the attack leads to a win, e.g. 39...♘xe4 40 ♕h6+ ♖g7 41 ♘xe4 ♗d3 42 ♘xd6 ♔g8 43 ♘ef5 ♗xf5 44 ♘xf5 ♖f7 45 d6, and ♘e7+ is threatened.

35 ♖g3+ ♗g4 36 ♕xh5 ♘xe4 37 ♕xg4+ ♘g5 38 ♘e3 e4 39 ♕f4 1-0

Apart from the threat of ♕xf6, White has ♘g4xf6+ to demolish what's left of Black's kingside defences.

Summary

White has a wide choice as to his handling of the Breyer but 15 b3, featured in Games 36 & 37, is the most likely to yield an edge. Black can go for solidity, but there is a danger of slipping into passivity, both in these games and elsewhere. Instead Games 34 and 35 show that 15 a4 is easier to defend against.

A more dynamic approach is becoming popular as Sokolov in Game 29, and Kramnik in Game 30 have exemplified. Even in Game 37, Black can avoid the tortures of the main game by varying on moves 16, 17 and 18 such as in Kasimdzhanov-Short.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘b8 (The Breyer System)

10 d4

10 d3 – *Game 28 notes*

10...♘bd7 11 ♘bd2

11 ♗g5 – *Game 33 notes*; 11 ♘h4 – *Game 28 notes*; 11 c4 – *Game 28*

11...♗b7 12 ♗c2 ♖e8

12...c5 *(D)* – *Game 29*; 12...d5 – *Game 29 notes*

13 ♘f1

13 b4 – *Game 30 notes*; 13 a4 – *Game 30*; 13 b3 – *Game 31*

13...♗f8

13...d5 – *Game 32*

14 ♘g3

14 ♗g5 – *Game 33 notes*

14...g6 15 b3

15 ♗g5 – *Game 33*

15 a4 Bg7 – *Game 34*

15...c5 – *Game 35* 16 d5 c4 *(D)*

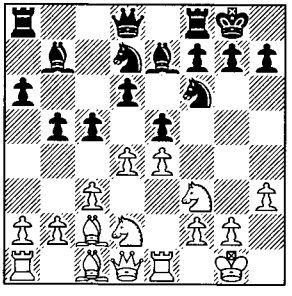
15...♗g7

15...c5 – *Game 36 notes*

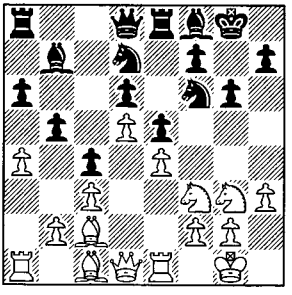
15...d5 – *Game 36 notes*

15...c6 – *Game 36*

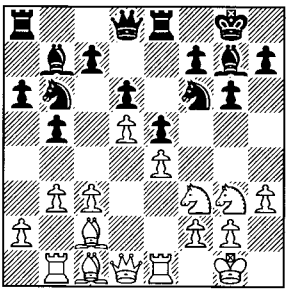
16 d5 – *Game 37*



12...c5



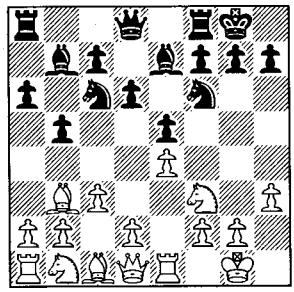
16...c4



16 d5

CHAPTER FIVE

The Zaitsev Variation



1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7

The Zaitsev is one of Black's most popular options these days. Black essentially tries to obtain an active version of Smyslov's variation which is seen in Chapter 7. This is achieved by delaying or even omitting ...h6, gaining a tempo for piece development. Comparison with other chapters may indeed be of benefit to the reader as Black may even employ ...♘c6-b8-d7 as in the Breyer. This generally occurs under special circumstances, i.e. once the central situation has clarified.

This emphasis on piece development gives Black extra time to rapidly bear down on the e4-square, with ...♖e8 and ...♗f8, as well as ...♗b7. In practice, sufficiently rapid as to render the typical Spanish manoeuvre ♘bd2-f1-g3 more difficult to achieve.

The main line, where Black provokes a crisis in the centre with ...cxd4, ...♘b4 and ...c5, features regularly at the highest level because these rich and complex positions are so fascinating.

One feature of the Zaitsev is the popular move order starting with 9...♖e8, and only then following up with ...♗b7, a move or two later, with probable transposition.

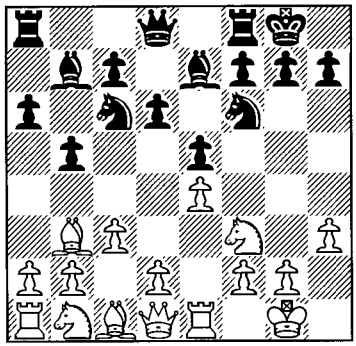
The naming of variations is an arbitrary affair but the 'Zaitsev' variation has had many contributions made by former world champion Anatoly Karpov. So don't get confused with the 'Karpov' variation which follows in Chapter 6! There have been many Kasparov-Karpov encounters in various variations of the Zaitsev, so I've started with one as it illustrates a rare black win at world championship level.

Game 38

G.Kasparov-A.Karpov

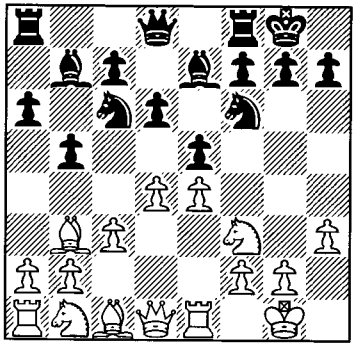
World Ch'ship (Game 5), Moscow 1985

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7



10 d4

10 d3 is not particularly critical but typical of what one might face in practice. This is similar to positions covered in Chapter 10 except that the extra moves h2-h3 for White and ♗c8-b7 for Black have been played. These extra moves ease Black's task and a continuation such as 10...♘a5 11 ♗c2 c5 12 ♘bd2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1 ♗f8 14 ♘g3 d5 15 exd5 ♕xd5 gives Black an easy game.



10...♖e8

There are four lesser alternatives at this point:

a) The older line 10...♘a5 11 ♗c2 ♘c4 is not bad but less dynamic: 12 b3 ♘b6 13 ♘bd2 (capturing the pawn is not a good idea, because 13 dxe5 dxe5 14 ♕xd8 ♖axd8 15 ♘xe5 ♗xe4 16 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 is equal, as 17 ♖xe4 is met by 17...♖d1+) 13...♖e8 14 ♘f1 (White has time to get his knight to g3) 14...♗f8 15 ♘g3 c5 (with 15...h6, Black has achieved a position from the Smyslov handled in Game 58) didn't equalise in A.Beliavsky-J.Klovans, USSR 1977 after 16 a4! c4 17 a5 exd4 18 cxd4 cxb3 19 ♗xb3 ♘c4 20 ♗xc4 bxc4 21 d5.

b) 10...exd4 (releasing the tension immediately is now a discredited line) 11 cxd4 d5 12 e5 ♘e4 13 ♘c3 ♘a5 14 ♗c2 f5 15 exf6 ♗xf6 16 ♘xe4 dxe4 17 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 18 ♖xe4 c5 19 ♖g4 cxd4 20 ♗g5, with a clear advantage to White, M.Tal-H.Lehmann, Hamburg 1960.

c) 10...♕d7 (looks like a good surprise weapon) 11 ♘bd2 ♖ad8:

c1) 12 d5 ♘b8 13 ♘f1 c6 14 dxc6 ♗xc6 15 ♘g3 ♕b7 16 ♕e2 ♘bd7 17 ♗c2 ♖fe8 18 ♘f5 ♗f8, JA.Gutierrez-E.Geller, Bogota 1978, and in the game Black took the initiative after 19 ♘h2 d5. Geller instead suggests 19 ♗g5, but after 19...h6, White doesn't have an easy decision to make;

c2) After 12 a4 exd4 13 cxd4, 13...♘b4 is critical, e.g. 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♕e2 c5!?.

c3) 12 ♘f1 exd4 13 cxd4 d5 14 e5 ♘e4 15 ♘g3 ♘a5 16 ♗c2 f5 obtains a position similar to the 10...exd4 line in 'b', except that White's knight, has taken four moves to challenge the knight outpost on e4: 17 exf6 ♗xf6 18 ♘xe4 dxe4 19 ♗xe4. Compared to the 10...exd4 line, Black has the two extra moves ...♕d7 and ...♖ad8. This enables him to keep the balance with. 19...c5 with equal chances according to Vojna.

d) The move 10...♘d7 is very much on a par with the Karpov Variation, see Chapter 6, but does have some independent significance. If Black opts instead for the move-order 9...♘d7 10 d4 ♗f6, then White cannot play 11 ♘bd2 as the d-pawn is hanging. So then White can't bring his knight to g3 whilst retaining the tension in the centre, whereas with the Zaitsev move order he can. 11 ♘bd2 (for 11 a4 ♗f6, see Games 52-55) and now Black can now hold his ground or liven things up with ...exd4 at various moments:

d1) 11...♗f6 12 ♘f1 ♖e8 (12...exd4 is the more ambitious try: 13 cxd4 ♘a5 14 ♗c2 c5 15 ♘e3 cxd4 16 ♘xd4 ♘c5 17 ♘g4 ♗xd4 18 ♕xd4 ♖e8 19 b4 ♘e6, S.Grigoriants-J.Radulski, Pancevo 2003, with adequate piece activity) 13 ♘g3 (after 13 ♘1h2?! exd4 14 cxd4 ♘a5 15 ♗c2 c5 16 ♘g4 cxd4 17 ♘xd4 ♗xd4 18 ♕xd4 ♖c8 19 ♘e3 ♘f6 20 f3 d5, Black was even better in N.De Firmian-L.Fressinet, Selfoss 2003) 13...g6 14 ♗h6 ♘a5 (Can Black try and revive 14...exd4 in this position? e.g. 15 cxd4 ♘a5 16 ♗c2 c5 17 ♖c1 ♖c8 18 b3 ♘c6 19 ♗e3, E.Szalancy-

P.Wells, Balatonbereny 1992, and although this game led to a white win the idea has potential. What had the generally well-prepared Fressinet up his sleeve if De Firmian had played 13 ♘g3? Something along these lines perhaps!?) 15 ♗c2 c5 16 d5 ♘c4 17 ♕c1 ♗g7 18 a4, which gave White pressure in L.Ljubojevic-A.Karpov, Turin 1982.

d2) Black can even play the immediate 11...exd4, e.g. 12 cxd4 ♘b4 13 ♘f1 c5 14 ♗f4 c4 15 ♗c2 ♘xc2 16 ♕xc2 ♘f6 (Kotronias suggests 16...f5!? as superior, continuing 17 exf5 ♗xf3 18 gxf3 ♘f6 19 ♘e3 ♖a7 20 ♖ad1 ♕a8 21 d5 ♖c8 22 ♔h2, but in both cases White is rather better) 17 d5 ♘d7 18 b4! cxb3 19 axb3 ♖c8 20 ♕d1, V.Kotronias-A.Goldin, Moscow 1989.

11 ♘bd2

At this point 11 ♘g5 ♖f8 12 f4 introduces a sharp line that can catch out the unprepared. Black has at least equality if he knows his stuff however: 12...exf4 13 ♗xf4 ♘a5 14 ♗c2 ♘d5 15 exd5 ♗xg5 16 ♕h5 h6 17 ♘d2 (or 17 ♗g3 g6 18 ♕f3 ♘c4 19 ♘a3 ♘b6 20 ♗b3 h5 21 ♘c2 ♕d7 22 h4 ♗h6 23 a3 a5 24 ♘e3 ♖fe8, R.Barsenilla-R.Henao, Thessaloniki Olympiad 1988 where Black has the better long-term options) 17...♗xd5 18 ♘e4 ♗xf4 19 ♕f5 g6 20 ♘f6+ ♔g7 21 ♘h5+ ♔h8!? (here Black has a draw with 21...gxh5 22 ♕h7+ ♔f6 23 ♕f5+) 22 ♕xf4 ♕g5 23 ♕xg5 hxg5 24 ♘f6 ♗e6 25 g4 d5 26 ♖e5 ♘c4 27 ♖xg5 ♔g7!, (a novelty!) I.Glek-A.Khalifman, Tashkent 1987, and after 28 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 29 ♖xd5 ♘e3 30 ♖e5 ♘xc2 31 ♖c1 ♘xd4, a draw was agreed.

11...♗f8 12 a4 ♕d7

Although 12...h6 is the most common move here, the move ...♕d7 crops up frequently at various moments in the Zaitsev. Compare Games 39, 43, 44 and 61.

Exchanging first on d4 however gives an inferior version as after 12...exd4 13 cxd4 ♕d7 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 16 ♘g5 ♘d8, White has 17 e5! with dangerous play, e.g. 17...♘d5 18 ♘df3 g6 19 ♘e4 ♗g7 20 ♗h6, Z.Almasi-A.Ivanov, New York 1993.

Otherwise slightly unusual is 12...♘a5!?, then after 13 ♗a2 (staying on the active diagonal) 13...c5 14 b4 cxb4 15 cxb4 ♘c6 16 ♕b3 ♕c7 17 d5 ♘e7 18 ♗b1 bxa4 19 ♕xa4 ♖eb8 20 ♕a5, V.Ivanchuk-A.Beliavsky, Lvov 2000, White had an edge.

13 axb5

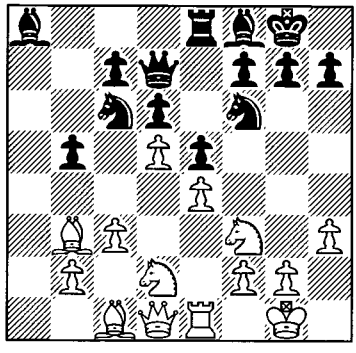
For 13 ♗c2 see Game 61 by transposition.

13 d5 is important: 13...♘e7 14 c4 ♘g6 15 ♗c2 c6 16 b3 ♕c7 (16...b4 releases the tension but reduces Black's options more than White's: 17 ♘h2 ♕c7 18 ♘g4 ♗e7 19 ♘f1, R.Hübner-L.Portisch, Brussels 1986 and now best could be 19...c5 20 g3 ♗c8 21 ♘fe3, when Black is somewhat passive. Portisch preferred 19...cxd5 but soon lost control of the c-file) 17 ♘f1, and now Black's best is 17...bxc4 18 bxc4 a5. This plan prepares activity for his minor pieces, and Black had a solid game after both 19 g3 ♘e7 20 ♘e3 ♘c8 21 ♘d2 ♘b6, J.Van der Wiel-A.Karpov, Tilburg 1988, and 19 ♘g3 ♗a6 20 ♗d3 ♖ec8 21 ♗e3 ♖ab8 22 ♖c1 ♘d7, I.Smirin-A.Goldin, Novosibirsk 1995.

13...axb5 14 ♖xa8 ♗xa8

The other recapture 14...♖xa8? is an error e.g. 15 ♘g5 ♘d8 16 ♘df3 c5 17 dxe5 dxe5 18 ♕xd7 ♘xd7 19 ♘xf7!, V.Ivanchuk-L.Portisch, Linares 1990, as 19...♘xf7 is met by 20 ♗e6, threatening ♘g5 as well as ♗xd7.

15 d5



Where should Black place his knight?

15...♘a5

Karpov has also experimented with a couple of Black's alternatives:

a) In their previous match, Karpov tried 15...♘d8, but this proved to be too passive: 16 ♘f1 h6 17 ♘3h2 ♘b7 18 ♗c2 ♘c5 19 b4 ♘a6 20 ♘g4 ♘h7 21 ♘g3 c6 22 dxc6 ♗xc6 23 ♗b3 ♘c7 24 ♕f3 ♘e6 25 h4 with a clear advantage, G.Kasparov-A.Karpov, Moscow (game 46) 1984/85.

b) One of Kasparov's later opponents played 15...♘b8 16 ♘f1 ♘a6, which looks less time-consuming but still doesn't equalise: 17 ♗g5 ♗e7 18 ♘g3 g6 19 ♕d2 ♗b7 20 ♖a1 ♖a8 21 ♗c2 c6 22 dxc6 ♗xc6 23 ♖d1, G.Kasparov-J.Smejkal, Dubai Olympiad 1986, and now 23...♕e6 keeps White's advantage down to a minimum.

c) In later years Karpov settled on 15...♘e7 with which he has obtained good results: 16 ♘f1 h6 17 ♘g3 (in A.Sokolov-A.Karpov, Linares 1989 White didn't achieve anything with the continuation 17 ♘3h2 c5 18 dxc6 ♘xc6 19 ♘g4 ♘xg4 20 hxg4 b4 21 g5 hxg5 22 ♗xg5 ♘a5 23 ♗a4 ♗c6) 17...c6 18 dxc6 ♗xc6 19 ♘h2 d5 20 ♘h5 (White's best try could be 20 ♘f3!?, when after 20...♘g6 21 exd5 ♗xd5 22 ♘h5! ♖d8 23 ♘xf6+ gxf6 24 ♗c2, he maintained a slight edge into the endgame, V.Ivanchuk-A.Goldin, Irkutsk 1986. Presumably Karpov was aware of this and must have had something ready when he was preparing for his match with Timman. It may have been 21...♘xd5, instead of 21...♗xd5) 20...♘xe4 21 ♘g4 ♕f5 22 f3 (22 ♖xe4!? dxe4 23 ♘g3 ♕c8 24 ♘xe5 ♔h7 yields unclear complications according to Karpov) 22...♘xc3 23 bxc3 ♕xh5 24 ♖xe5 ♕h4, with a balanced game, J.Timman-A.Karpov, Kuala Lumpur 1990.

16 ♗a2 c6 17 b4 ♘b7 18 c4

Instead An.Bikhovsky proposes 18 ♘f1 cxd5 19 exd5 ♖c8 20 ♗g5 ♗e7 21 ♕d2 with an edge to White.

18...♖c8 19 dxc6 ♕xc6 20 c5?!

Tempting as it loosens Black's central defences, but it soon rebounds as Black is better able to exploit the consequent open centre. Safe was 20 ♗b2, or 20 ♕e2 bxc4 21 ♗xc4 ♘d8 22 ♕d3 ♘e6 23 ♕b3 ♕d7 24 ♗b2, as mentioned by An.Bikhovsky.

20...♘d8 21 ♗b2 dxc5 22 bxc5

22 ♗xe5 is even worse after 22...♘d7 23 ♗b2 c4 24 ♗c3 ♘e6.

22...♕xc5 23 ♗xe5 ♘d7 24 ♗b2 ♕b4 25 ♘b3

Probably 25 ♕b1 would have been a lesser evil.

25...♘c5 26 ♗a1

Although 26 ♘xc5 ♕xb2 27 ♕b3 ♕xb3 28 ♘xb3 ♘e6 is unpleasant for White, the text is hardly better.

26...♗xe4 27 ♘fd4 ♘db7 28 ♕e2 ♘d6

White has nothing for the pawn. In the next phase Karpov reorganises his forces before using his trump card – the passed pawn.

29 ♘xc5 ♕xc5 30 ♕g4 ♖e8 31 ♖d1 ♗g6 32 ♕f4 ♕b4 33 ♕c1 ♗e4 34 ♖e1 ♕a5 35 ♗b3 ♕a8 36 ♕b2 b4

The safe way is often the right way, but for the record 36...♗xg2 was possible as tricks with 37 ♖xe8 ♘xe8 38 ♘f5 are comfortably countered with 38...♕c6.

37 ♖e3 ♗g6 38 ♖xe8 ♕xe8 39 ♕c1 ♘e4 40 ♗d5 ♘c5 41 ♘b3 ♘d3 0-1

Game 39

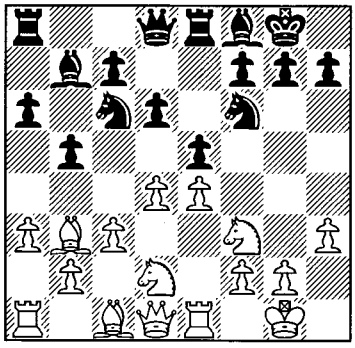
E.Bacrot-I.Sokolov

Reykjavik 2003

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a3

In this way White avoids those highly analysed variations in which Black plays ...exd4 followed by ...♘b4. As in various lines of the Breyer or Smyslov, a2-a3 can be used to support the cramping b2-b4 and gives the option

of keeping the bishop on the a2-g8 diagonal.



12...♕d7

Not by any means the only move. Here 12...h6 transposes directly to the Smyslov variation, see Games 59 & 60, but Black's other main option is 12...g6.

With the fashionable 12...g6, Black hopes to 'get away' without spending a tempo on ...h6:

a) 13 ♗c2 ♗g7 14 d5 (if 14 ♘f1, then 14...d5!, M.Adams-Pr.Nikolic, Manila Interzonal 1990, solves all Black's problems) 14...♘e7 15 c4 c6 16 dxc6 ♘xc6 17 b4 ♖c8 18 cxb5 axb5 19 ♗b2 d5, with full equality, J.Benjamin-A.Ivanov, Philadelphia 1988.

b) 13 ♗a2 ♗g7 14 b4 and then the second of Black's options seems more to the point:

b1) It seems a shame to have got so far without it and only now play 14...h6?! (as in a Smyslov), when it isn't really necessary. J.Hjartarson-N.Short, Belfort 1988 continued 15 ♗b2 ♘h5 16 d5 ♘e7 17 ♘b3 ♖f8 18 c4 bxc4 19 ♘a5 ♗c8 20 ♖c1 f5 (Hjartarson suggests 20...♔h8 as an improvement giving 21 ♖xc4 ♘f4 22 ♗c1 g5 23 ♗xf4 exf4 24 e5 dxe5 25 ♘xe5 as only a slight edge for White) 21 exf5 ♘f4 22 ♖xc4, with problems for Black. It's like a King's Indian where White has made useful progress on the queenside.

b2) 14...a5! 15 d5 ♘e7, and now a further split:

b21) After 16 ♘b3 axb4 17 cxb4, Black broke out with a typical combination in M.Chiburdanidze-Alexa..Ivanov, USSR 1980, 17...♘xe4! 18 ♖xe4 ♗xd5 19 ♖e1 e4 20 ♘fd4 c5, with adequate compensation.

b22) If 16 bxa5!, then Gutman suggests 16...c5!? (safer is An.Bikhovsky's 16...♖xa5 17 c4 bxc4 18 ♘xc4 ♖a6, but White is still a shade better) 17 dxc6 ♗xc6 18 c4 bxc4 19 ♗xc4 ♕xa5, and if 20 ♕b3 then 20...d5 21 exd5 ♗a4 22 ♕a2 e4, but I don't like this as 23 d6! seems too strong.

b23) 16 ♗b2 ♘h5 (the most recent try is 16...c6!? 17 dxc6 ♘xc6 18 a4 axb4 19 axb5 bxc3 20 ♗xc3 ♘a7 21 ♗c4, and in Z.Efimenko-E.Dervishi, Istanbul 2003 Black was successful as after 21...♘c8 22 ♕b3 ♖e7 23 ♕b4 ♖xa1 24 ♗xa1 d5, he had equalised) 17 ♘b3 axb4 18 axb4 (or perhaps 18 cxb4 ♗c8 19 ♘a5 ♘f4 20 ♗c1 ♗h6 21 ♖b1 ♔h8 22 ♖b3 f5, V.Kuporosov-I.Ibragimov, Gorky 1989, although in this Adams considers White to be a shade better after 20 ♖c1) 18...♗c8 19 ♘a5 ♘f4 20 c4 g5 21 cxb5 g4 22 ♘h2 gxh3 23 g3, with unclear complications, M.Adams-A.Grischuk, Wijk aan Zee 2002.

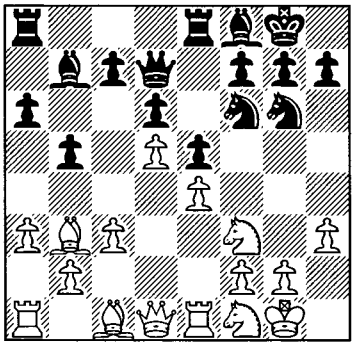
13 d5

A slightly committal move. Again White can just move his bishop keeping the tension for the moment and play d4-d5 a move or two later, e.g. 13 ♗c2 ♖ad8 14 ♘b3 h6 15 d5 ♘e7 16 ♘a5, L.Psakhis-Y.Balashov, USSR Championship 1980/1, or 13 ♗a2 ♖ad8 14 d5 ♘e7 15 c4 c6 16 b3 a5 17 ♘f1 a4 18 dxc6 ♗xc6 19 cxb5 ♗xb5 20 ♗g5, L.Bruzon-I.Morovic, Havana 2002, and in both cases White retains an edge.

13...♘e7 14 ♘f1

A natural move but 14 c4 is arguably the consistent follow-up. Then after 14...c6 (if 14...bxc4? Black has problems after 15 ♘xc4 intending ♗a4 and ♘a5) 15 ♗c2 h6 16 b4 a5 17 ♗b2 axb4 18 axb4 ♖xa1 19 ♗xa1 bxc4 20 ♗a4 ♖b8 21 ♘xc4, Liu Wenzhe-Xu Jun, Chinese Championship 1997, Black is under pressure.

14...♘g6



15 ♗c2

According to Sokolov, 15 ♘g3 h6 16 ♘h2 was the right way to proceed, when he prefers White slightly.

15...c6

Liquidating the White d-pawn and gaining valuable space for his forces.

16 dxc6 ♗xc6 17 ♗g5 ♘h5 18 ♘h4 ♘gf4 19 ♕g4?!

The exchange of queens suits Black fine. Sokolov suggests instead 19 ♘f5 with the plausible continuation 19...h6 20 ♗h4 g6 21 ♘5e3 ♗e7 22 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 leading to equal chances.

19...♕xg4 20 hxg4 ♘e6 21 ♗d2 ♘f6 22 g5 ♘d7 23 ♖ad1 a5 24 ♗c1

Threatening ♘f5 to bear down on d6.

24...g6

But now White's forces find it hard to create any genuine threats whereas Black intends a minority attack on the queenside.

25 ♘h2 b4 26 axb4 axb4 27 ♘g4 ♖eb8 28 ♘h6+

Putting the knight offside doesn't seem right.

28...♔g7 29 g3 bxc3 30 bxc3 ♖a2 31 ♗d3 ♘dc5 32 f4?

32 ♗c4 was a better chance, but Sokolov then suggests 32...♖a1 33 f4 ♘xe4 34 f5 ♖xc1 35 f6+ ♘xf6 36 gxf6+ ♔xh6 37 ♖xc1 d5, and Black retains a strong initiative.

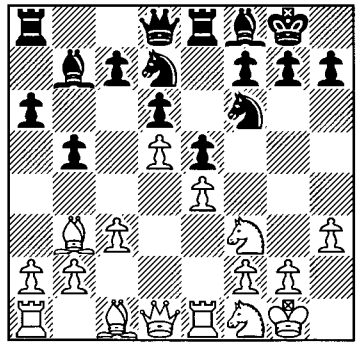
32...♘xd3 33 ♖xd3 ♘c5 34 ♖f3 ♗xe4 35 ♖ff1 ♗d3 36 fxe5 ♗xf1 37 ♖xf1 dxe5 38 ♖xf7+ ♔h8 39 ♖f1 ♘e4 0-1

Game 40

M.Adams-R.Ponomariov

Linares 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♖e8 10 d4 ♗b7 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 d5 ♘b8 13 ♘f1 ♘bd7



14 ♘3h2

The most commonly played move here has been the logical 14 ♘g3, when I believe that Black's best option is 14...♘c5. Here are the details:

a) In V.Anand-V.Ivanchuk, Linares 1997 Black played 14...h6 15 ♘h2 c5, (closing the wing is a slightly unusual strategy in the generally dynamic Zaitsev) and after 16 ♗c2 ♗c8 17 ♗e3 ♘b6 18 b3 a5 19 ♗d3 ♗a6 20 ♕e2 c4!?, he generated some action on the queenside.

b) Instead there is 14...g6, as favoured by Ivanchuk in the mid-nineties:

b1) The Ukranian came under pressure following 15 ♘h2 h5 (stopping ♘h2-g4 but weakening the king further) 16 ♘f3 ♘c5 17 ♗c2 c6 18 b4 ♘cd7 19 dxc6 ♗xc6 20 ♗b3 ♘b6 21 ♗g5 ♗d7 22 ♘h4 ♗e6 23 ♕f3, V.Anand-V.Ivanchuk, Dos Hermanas 1996.

b2) Black also watch 15 ♗e3, e.g. 15...♘c5 16 ♗c2 c6 17 b4 ♘cd7 18 dxc6

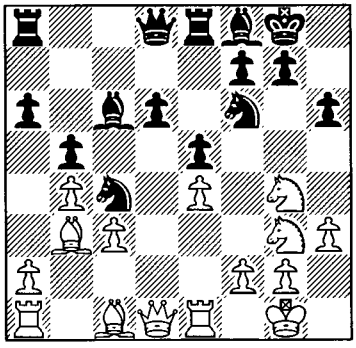
♗xc6 19 ♗b3 ♘b6 20 ♕d3. Ivanchuk has tried two moves but now prefers another:

b21) 20...♖a7 21 a4 bxa4 22 ♗xa4 ♗xa4 23 ♗xb6 ♕xb6 24 ♖xa4 ♖c7 25 ♖ea1 ♕b5, V.Anand-V.Ivanchuk, Monaco rapid 1994.

b22) 20...♖b8 21 ♖ad1 ♖b7 22 ♘h2 ♗d7, N.Short-V.Ivanchuk, Amsterdam 1994 and now 23 f4 yields an edge.

b23) 20...♕c7 21 ♘g5 ♘c4 22 ♗xc4 bxc4 23 ♕xc4 ♕b7, with compensation according to Ivanchuk. However when facing Anand in 1997 he varied as early as move 14 playing 14...h6, see 'a'.

c) 14...♘c5 15 ♗c2 c6 16 b4 ♘cd7 17 dxc6 ♗xc6 18 ♗b3 h6 (inferior is 18...♘b6? e.g. 19 ♗g5 h6 20 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 21 ♘h2 ♘c4 22 ♘g4 ♕e6 23 ♘e3 ♖ac8 24 ♕d3 ♗b7 25 a4, M.Loeffler-J.Klovans, Schwarzach 1998) 19 ♘h2 ♘b6 20 ♘g4 ♘c4

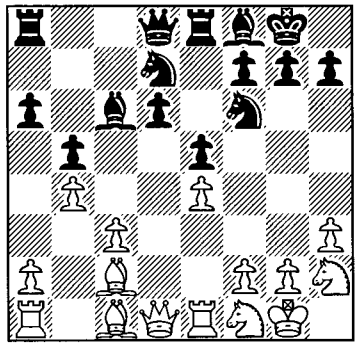


and here not 21 a4, but rather 21 ♘f5:

c1) 21 a4 ♘xg4 22 ♕xg4 ♗d7 23 ♘f5 ♔h7 24 axb5 axb5 25 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 26 ♕f3 ♗e6, Pe.Popovic-S.Gligoric, Yugoslav Championship 1995, allowed Black a comfortable game.

c2) 21 ♘f5!? ♘xe4? and now White has a beautiful win (possible is 21...♗xe4 but Magomedov still prefers White slightly after 22 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 23 ♘xh6+ gxh6 24 ♖xe4) 22 ♕f3! d5 23 ♖xe4! dxe4 24 ♘fxh6+ gxh6 25 ♘f6+ ♔g7 26 ♗xh6+! ♔g6 27 ♕g4+, 1-0 R.Magomedov-J.Isaev, Dushanbe 1997. Some good players still play this line for Black, so there must be an improvement in here somewhere. I suggest 21...♔h7!, as for instance 22 a4 ♘xg4 23 ♕xg4 ♗d7 transposes to safe territory (see 'c1').

14...♘c5 15 ♗c2 c6 16 b4 ♘cd7 17 dxc6 ♗xc6



18 ♗g5

Adams had previously played 18 ♘g4 here. Following 18...♘xg4 19 hxg4 ♘b6 20 ♕d3 (after 20 ♘e3 d5 – the classic freeing idea – 21 exd5 ♘xd5 22 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 23 ♕xd5 ♗xd5, G.Kasparov-V.Ivanchuk, Linares 1998, it was about equal) 20...g6 21 ♖d1 ♕c7 22 ♕f3 ♗d7 23 ♗b3 ♗e6 24 ♗g5 a5!, M.Adams-A.Beliavsky, Leon 2001, Black had adequate counterchances.

The text tries to 'punish' Black for never getting round to playing ...h6, and has the clear intention of clamping down on the d5-square.

18...h6

Or in the case of 18...♕c8, White exchanges off one of the defenders of d5, as in the game, with 19 ♗xf6, i.e. 19...♘xf6 20 ♘g4 ♘xg4 21 hxg4 ♗d7 (forking two pawns but it seems that White has more than enough play) 22 ♘e3 ♕xc3 (Otherwise 22...♖a7 23 ♗b3 ♕xc3 24 ♘d5 ♕c8 25 ♘b6 ♕d8 26 ♘xd7 ♕xd7 27 ♗d5 gives White excellent compensation. Even if things go wrong Black should never be able to win the opposite bishop ending, Z.Hracek-A.Beliavsky, Bundesliga 2000) 23 ♘d5 ♕c6

24 ♗b3 ♖ac8 25 g5 ♗e6 26 ♖e3 (White has dangerous play for his pawn) 26...♗e7 27 ♕h5 ♕b7 28 ♖g3 ♔h8 29 ♖e1 ♖f8 30 ♘f6 h6 31 gxh6 g6, D.Isonzo-E.Dervishi, Bratto 2003, and now simply 32 ♕f3 keeps the advantage.

19 ♗xf6

Similar is 19 ♗h4 ♕c7 20 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 21 ♘g4 ♘xg4 22 hxg4 ♗e7! 23 ♗b3 ♗g5 (the bishop frustrates the knight's attempt to get to its ready-made outpost on d5) 24 ♕f3 ♖f8 25 ♖ad1 ♗d7 26 ♖d3 ♗e6 27 ♖ed1 ♖fd8 28 ♘e3 ♗xe3 29 ♖xe3 and a draw was agreed as Black has held firm, Z.Almasi-A.Beliavsky, Austrian Team Championship 2001.

19...♘xf6 20 ♘g4 ♘xg4 21 ♕xg4

Here if 21 hxg4, then 21...d5! is fine.

21...d5?!

Now this move is premature as White is well placed to exploit any line opening. Safer is 21...♗d7 22 ♕f3 ♖c8, when after 23 ♗b3 ♗e6 24 ♖ac1, White's plans to install his knight on d5 with ♘f1-e3-d5, are thwarted with 24...♗e7! intending ...♗g5, and Black is therefore able to keep the balance.

22 exd5 ♕xd5

On 22...♗xd5?, then 23 ♖ad1 will pin and win.

23 ♗b3 ♕d8

If 23...♕d7, then 24 ♕h5 anyway, e.g. 24...a5?! (24...♕c7 must be tried) 25 bxa5 ♕e7 26 ♘e3 ♖xa5 27 ♘g4, and White was already winning in L.McShane-H.Stefansson, Reykjavik 2002.

24 ♕h5 ♖a7!?

A practical decision to give the pawn up now when at least Black's bishops can have a say in matters. Otherwise 24...♕c7 25 ♘e3?! ♖ad8 26 ♘g4 ♗d5 holds firm, but White can improve on this with 25 ♖ad1!, keeping up the pressure.

25 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 26 ♕xe5 ♕g5 27 ♕xg5 hxg5 28 ♘e3 g6 29 ♖d1 ♖c7

Black relies on the backward c-pawn and the bishop pair to obtain drawing chances, but he is playing one of the world's best end-game players.

30 ♔f1 ♔g7 31 ♔e2 ♗e7 32 ♗d5 ♗d7 33 ♖d3 ♗f6

Possible was 33...♗f5, when White has nothing better than 34 ♘xf5+ gxf5, allowing opposite bishops and realistic drawing chances.

34 c4 bxc4 35 ♗xc4 ♗c8 36 a3 ♗b2 37 ♔d2 f5 38 ♔c2! ♗xa3

After 38...♗e5 39 ♔b3, White's king supports the majority and Black's activity has basically died a natural death.

39 ♖xa3 f4 40 ♔b3 fxe3 41 fxe3 ♖e7 42 ♔a4!

Threatening to go even further.

42...♖e5 43 ♖d3 ♗f5 44 ♖d2 ♖xe3 45 ♗xa6

Now the b-pawn is passed, but in order to win Adams needs to retain a pawn on the other wing as well.

45...♗e4 46 ♖f2 ♔h6 47 ♗f1 g4 48 hxg4 ♖e1 49 ♗e2 ♖a1+ 50 ♔b3 ♖b1+ 51 ♔c3 ♖c1+ 52 ♔d4 ♗b7 53 ♗f3 ♗a6 54 ♖b2 ♗b5 55 ♗e2 ♗c6 56 ♗f3 ♗b5 57 ♗e2 ♗c6 58 ♗a6 ♖g1 59 b5 ♗xg2 60 b6 ♔g5 61 ♗c8 ♔f4 62 ♔c5

But not 62 b7?, as after 62...♗xb7 63 ♖xb7?, the coming skewer with 63...♖d1+, followed by ...♖c1+ wins back the bishop.

62...♗e4

Equally hopeless is 62...♖c1+, after 63 ♔d6 ♖xc8 64 ♖xg2.

63 ♖b4 ♔e5 64 b7 ♖c1+ 65 ♔b5 ♗xb7 66 ♗xb7 ♔f6 67 ♖c4 ♖b1+ 68 ♔c6 ♔g5 69 ♗c8 ♖d1 70 ♗d7 ♔h4 71 ♔c7 ♖d2 72 ♔d8 ♖e2 73 ♖c6 g5 74 ♗f5 ♖e3 75 ♖e6 ♖g3

A generous way of resigning!

76 ♖h6 mate

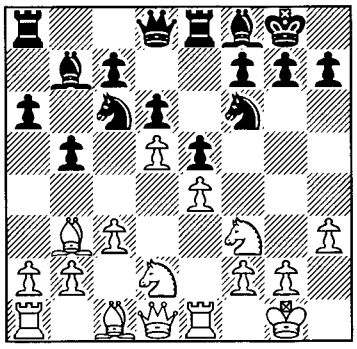
Game 41

G.Milos-Z.Win Lay Zaw

Bali 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8

c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 d5



12...♘e7

Apart from 12...♘b8, which was the subject of the previous game, Black also has the possibility of playing 12...♘a5, but White seems to gain the advantage by force.

So after 12...♘a5, then 13 ♗c2 c6 14 b4 ♘c4 15 ♘xc4 bxc4 16 dxc6 (not 16 ♗a4?!, as Black has 16...cxd5! 17 ♗xe8 ♕xe8 18 exd5 ♘xd5 19 ♗d2 ♕c6, with a pawn, the bishop pair and central dominance [hence excellent compensation] for the exchange, R.Torella-J.Rubinetti, Mar del Plata 1990) 16...♗xc6 17 ♗g5.

Here White seems to be able to claim an edge against all replies and could also consider 17 a4 ♕c7 18 ♗g5, JP.Boudre-D.Jeanjean, St.Affrique 1994, which cuts out the 17...a5 defence. After 17 ♗g5 Black has four tries:

a) 17...♖e6 18 ♕e2 ♖c8 19 ♕xc4 (or 19 a4 h6 20 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 21 ♘d2 ♖g6 22 ♘f1 f5, S.Dolmatov-I.Zaitsev, Moscow 1992, with complications that probably favour White) 19...d5 20 exd5 ♗xd5 21 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 22 ♕h4, V.Kirpichnikov-I.Zaitsev, Daugavpils 1974, and Black could find nothing better than 22...e4 23 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 24 ♖xe4 ♕d3 25 ♖e3 ♕c2 26 a3 ♖xc3 with minimal compensation for the pawn. However as Zaitsev was willing to repeat this (18 years later!) presumably he didn't consider Black's chances to be so bad.

b) 17...h6 18 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 19 ♘h2 ♕e6 20 ♘g4 ♖ad8, O.Korneev-M.Grabarczyk, Wisla 1992, and now the simplest way to keep an edge is 21 ♘e3!.

c) 17...♖c8 was recently tried in C.Lutz-H.Kallio, Bled Olympiad 2002 and after 18 ♗a4 ♗e7 19 ♗xc6 ♖xc6 20 a4 ♘d7 Black managed to defend successfully. I suggest 20 ♗xf6! (instead of 20 a4) 20...♗xf6 21 a4, with a positional advantage, as the break with 21...d5 fails to 22 exd5 ♖d6 23 ♕e2 e4 24 ♖ac1 ♖xd5 25 ♕xc4.

d) 17...a5 18 a3 h6 19 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 20 ♘d2 ♕e6 21 ♕g4 axb4 22 axb4 ♗b5 23 ♘f1 and the knight heads for e3 and ultimately d5, giving White the advantage in V.Anand-L.Ljubojevic, Monaco rapid 1994.

13 ♘f1

Following 13 c4, Black hits back at the centre with 13...c6 14 ♗c2 bxc4 15 dxc6 ♘xc6 16 ♘xc4 ♘d4! (an energetic way of solving the problem of the backward pawn) 17 ♘xd4 exd4 18 ♗g5 (if 18 ♕xd4, then 18...d5 19 ♘b6 dxe4) 18...d5 19 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 20 e5 ♕h6 21 ♘d2 (as Topalov points out Black also equalises after 21 ♘a5 ♗b4 22 ♘xb7 ♗xe1 23 ♕xe1 ♕c6 24 ♘d6 ♕xc2 25 ♘xe8 ♖xe8) 21...♗b4 22 ♖e2 ♗xd2 23 ♕xd2 ♕xd2 24 ♖xd2 ♖xe5 and chances were equal in V.Topalov-Je.Piket, Amsterdam 1996.

13...♘g6 14 a4

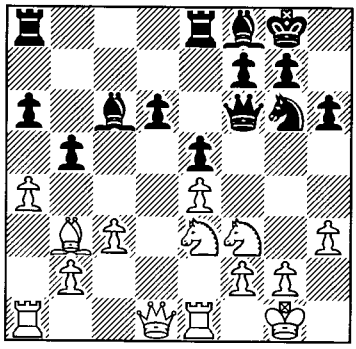
After 14 ♘3h2, the natural 14...♕d7 looks sensible (in V.Topalov-Je.Piket, Wijk aan Zee 1996, Black came up with another plan: 14...♘d7 15 a3 ♘c5 16 ♗a2 ♘f4, which is given by some sources as equal, but the game continuation 17 c4 c6 18 cxb5 cxb5 19 ♗b1 a5 20 h4 g6 21 g3 suggests that White still has hopes of an edge) and after 15 ♘g4 ♘xe4 16 ♖xe4 f5 17 ♖e1 fxg4 18 ♕xg4 ♕xg4 19 hxg4 e4 20 ♘g3 ♘e5 Black had created counter-chances in Z.Hracek-J.Stocek, Czech Team Championship 2003. A draw was actually agreed at this point.

14...c6?!

Inaccurate as White quickly gets control of the d5-square.

Correct is 14...h6 (cutting out ♗g5) 15 ♘h2 ♘d7 16 ♗c2 c5 (Piket later suggested the more active 16...c6 as an improvement) 17 b3, C.Lutz-Je.Piket, Nussloch 1996, and White's space advantage and general control nevertheless give him an edge.

15 dxc6 ♗xc6 16 ♗g5 h6 17 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 18 ♘e3!



18...♘f4

Instead 18...♗xe4 can be met by 19 ♘g4 (or even by 19 ♗d5 ♗xf3 20 ♗xf3 ♖ab8 21 ♘d5 ♕d8 22 axb5 axb5 23 ♖a7, which also gives promising compensation) 19...♕f4 20 ♖xe4 ♕xe4 21 ♗d5 ♕f4 22 ♗xa8 ♖xa8 23 axb5, regaining the pawn with a positional advantage.

19 ♘d5 ♗xd5 20 ♗xd5 ♖ab8

Black is hampered by White's grip on d5 and the repercussions on other light-squares. The dark-squared bishop on f8 is an unhappy spectator as White builds up the pressure.

21 axb5

Also strong was the pawn sacrifice 21 b4!? played in K.Asrian-S.Virovlansky, St.Petersburg 1999. Then after 21...♕g6 22 g3 ♘xh3+ 23 ♔f1 ♖e7 24 axb5 axb5 25 ♖a6 White had excellent play.

21...axb5 22 ♔h2

Milos prefers a safer approach. Black has no counterplay as he takes total command.

22...b4 23 c4 ♗e7 24 ♖a6 ♖ec8 25 ♕d2 ♖c5 26 b3 ♘xd5?!

Not really what Black wants to play but he is running out of things to do. If he seeks some activity with 26...♕g6 27 g3 ♕h5 28 ♘g1 ♗g5, then simply 29 ♕d1, and the ending after 29...♕xd1 30 ♖xd1 ♘xd5 31 exd5 ♗e7 32 ♖da1 is also unpleasant.

27 exd5

Threatening to capture on e5.

27...♕f5 28 ♘d4! exd4

Otherwise the knight will impose its will from the c6-square.

29 ♖xe7 ♕f6 30 ♖e4 d3 31 ♖e3 ♖cc8 32 ♖xd3

The win is a question of time, and after Black's following blunder, not very much!

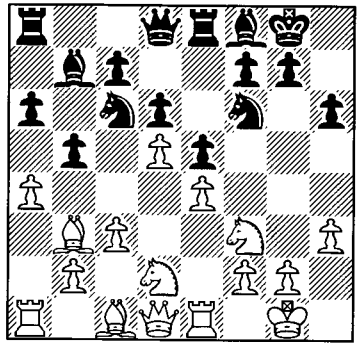
32...♖xc4? 33 bxc4 b3 34 ♖xb3 1-0

Game 42

P.Svidler-A.Grischuk

Panormo 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♖e8 10 d4 ♗b7 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a4 h6 13 d5



This standard idea is comparable to 12 d5, as in Games 40 & 41, except White has played the extra move a2-a4, and Black h7-h6.

13...♘b8

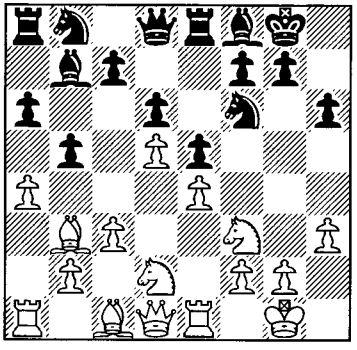
Black has also tried the three other plausi-

ble knight moves:

a) The worst of the bunch is 13...♘a5?!, as after 14 ♗a2 c6 15 b4 ♘c4 16 ♘xc4 bxc4 17 ♗xc4 cxd5 18 ♗xd5 ♘xd5 19 exd5 e4 20 ♘h2 ♕c7 21 ♕b3 ♖ac8 22 ♗b2, A.Morozevich-A.Gelman, Jurmala 1992, Black has nothing much for his pawn.

b) For 13...♘e7 14 ♘h2 (or in the case of 14 c4 bxc4 15 ♘xc4 c6 16 dxc6 ♘xc6! see below, notes to Black's 14th) 14...♕d7 15 ♘df1 ♘g6, compare with game 41.

c) The unnatural-looking 13...♘a7!? has dropped out of favour. But I suspect that this is largely because of fashion. The knight will eventually be redeployed via c8 and b6 with play similar to other lines: 14 ♘f1 c6 15 ♘3h2 cxd5 16 exd5 ♘c8, J.Nunn-J.Smejkal, Dubai Olympiad 1986, could have been followed up with 17 axb5 axb5 18 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 19 ♘g4 ♘xg4 20 hxg4 ♘b6 21 ♘g3 when Nunn judges that White retains an edge.



14 c4

By playing 14 ♕e2 White hits the b5-point a second time:

a) 14...c6 15 dxc6 ♗xc6 16 axb5 ♗xb5 17 c4 ♗c6 18 ♗a4 leads to white light-squared control. Black's best then may be 18...a5 19 ♘b1 ♕c7 20 ♘c3 ♘bd7, Franzen-S.Webb, corr 1996/7, when 21 ♘d5 keeps just a small edge.

b) 14...♘bd7 is a practical choice, sacrificing the pawn for active play: 15 axb5 axb5 16 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 17 ♕xb5 ♘c5 18 ♗c2 ♗a6 19 ♕a5 ♗d3 20 ♕xa8 ♖xa8 21 b4 (or 21 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 22 ♖d1 ♘c5 23 ♘e1 ♘fxe4 and a draw was agreed, S.Kindermann-P.Lukacs, Austria 1995) 21...♗xc2 22 bxc5 dxc5 23 ♘xe5 ♖e8 24 f4 ♗d6, R.Kaufman-K.Sasikiran, Hampstead 1998.

14...c6

If the text move proves to be inadequate, Black players can consider capturing on c4 first. Experience hints that Black is happy here, but only if he follows up with 16...♘xc6.

So the variation continues as follows: 14...bxc4!? 15 ♘xc4 (more testing than 15 ♗xc4 c6 16 dxc6 ♗xc6 17 b3 ♘bd7 18 ♗a3 ♕b8, M.Palac-H.Sonntag, Toulouse 1990) 15...c6 16 dxc6 and now:

a) 16...♗xc6 17 ♗c2 ♕c7 (otherwise 17...♘xe4 18 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 19 ♖xe4 d5 20 ♖xe5 dxc4 21 ♕c2 left White with an edge due to Black's shaky c-pawn, S.Kindermann-A.Greenfeld, Beersheba 1984) 18 ♗d2 ♘bd7 19 ♘a5 ♘c5 20 b4 ♘e6 21 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 22 ♗d3 ♕b7 23 ♖b1! ♘f4 24 ♗c4 ♖ac8 25 ♕b3, M.Krakops-E.Najer, Zagan 1997, and White's bishop plus queenside majority give him the better game.

b) 16...♘xc6! 17 a5 (17 ♗e3 ♘d4! 18 ♗xd4 exd4 19 e5 dxe5 20 ♘cxe5 ♗d5 21 ♗xd5 ♕xd5 22 ♕xd4 ♕xd4 23 ♘xd4 ♖ab8, gave Black enough compensation for the pawn in K.Arakhamia-Grant-C.Foisor, Debrecen 1992) 17...♖b8 18 ♗d2 ♘d4 19 ♗a4 ♘xf3+ 20 ♕xf3 ♖e6 21 ♘b6 d5! and Black even has the better of it, M.Tseitlin-Z.Szymczak, 1989.

15 axb5 axb5 16 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 17 cxb5

17 dxc6 has also been frequently played, but is probably less dangerous for Black:

a) 17...b4!? is condemned by theory because of 18 ♗a4 ♘xc6 19 ♘f1 ♕b8 20 g4 ♖c8 21 ♘g3 ♘d8 22 g5 hxg5 23 ♘xg5 ♖xc4 24 ♗b3 ♖d4 25 ♕c2, G.Kasparov-J.Dorfman, USSR Championship 1978, and White picked up the exchange and won a complicated game. Black however has im-

provements such as 23...♘e6!? or later with 24...♖c7. So Kasparov's plan of g2-g4-g5 is double-edged rather than advantageous.

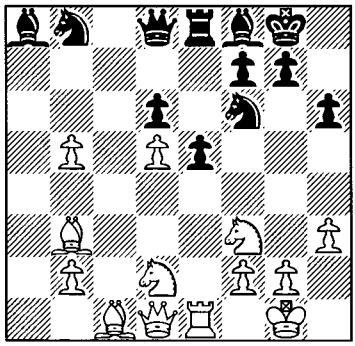
b) Following 17...♘xc6 18 cxb5 ♘b4 19 ♗c4 d5 20 exd5 e4 21 ♘d4 ♗xd5 22 ♘c6 ♕d7, Black had enough compensation in J.Rowson-P.Acs, Budapest 1996.

c) 17...bxc4 18 ♗xc4 ♗xc6 19 ♕b3 ♕d7 20 ♘h2 ♕b7 was equal in R.Barcenilla-S.Mannion, Manila Olympiad 1992.

17...cxd5

Svidler considers the quieter 17...cxb5 to be slightly better for White.

18 exd5



18...♘xd5?!

Not good is 18...♘bd7?, as 19 ♘b1! ♘c5 20 ♘c3, P.Svidler-Z.Almasi, Dortmund 1998, clearly favoured White. Svidler instead proposes 18...♗xd5! 19 ♗xd5 ♘xd5 20 ♘c4 ♘b6 21 ♘fxe5 ♕c7! 22 ♘xb6 ♕xb6 23 ♘f3 ♖xe1+ 24 ♕xe1 ♕xb5 with equality.

However it may not be that simple for Black. The more recent game I.Sudakova-I.Pisakov, Russia 2002 continued 21 ♘xb6 (rather than 21 ♘fxe5) 21...♕xb6 22 ♕d5 ♘d7 23 ♗e3 ♕b8 24 ♖c1 ♘f6 25 ♕b3 ♕b7 (if 25...d5, then 26 ♖c6 ♗d6 27 b6) 26 b6 ♘d5 (or here 26...d5 is answered by 27 ♖c7) 27 ♕b5 ♖b8 28 ♖c6 ♘xe3 29 fxe3 ♕d7 30 e4 with advantage to White.

19 ♘e4 ♘b4?

Better would have been 19...♘f6 20 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 21 ♗d5 ♘d7 22 ♗e3, with just an edge according to Svidler. Clearly Grischuk didn't appreciate the danger...

20 ♗g5!

A shocking blow, exploiting the weakness of the f7-square and the lack of piece cover for Black's king.

20...♕d7

White wins material after 20...hxg5 21 ♘fxg5 g6 (otherwise ♕h5 was mating) 22 ♕f3 ♕e7 23 ♕xf7+.

21 ♗xh6! d5

Naturally after 21...gxh6 there would follow 22 ♘f6+.

22 ♗d2! ♘d3

If 22...dxe4, then 23 ♘g5, whereupon both of Black's defences fail: 23...♘d5 24 ♕h5 ♕f5 25 g4 ♕g6 26 ♕xg6 fxg6 27 ♖a1 ♗b7 28 ♖a7, and 23...♗d5 24 ♗xb4 ♗xb4 25 ♗xd5 ♗xe1 26 ♗xf7+ ♔f8 27 ♕xe1.

23 ♘fg5 ♕f5

Here 23...♘xe1 24 ♕h5 ♕f5 is met by the picturesque 25 ♘f6+!, when 25...gxf6 26 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 27 ♕xe8 fxg5 28 ♗xe1 ♘d7 29 ♕xa8 ♕b1 30 ♕a5, leaves Black two pawns down for nothing.

24 ♖e3 ♘xf2?!

Losing material to White's next.

The best chance was 24...♘f4, but White seems to be clearly better anyway, e.g. 25 ♖c3 ♖c7 26 g4 ♕d7 27 ♗xf4 exf4 28 ♘c5 ♕xb5 29 ♗xd5, and if 29...♕xb2, then 30 ♘a4 followed by ♗xa8.

25 ♕f1 f6

Following 25...♘xh3+ 26 ♖xh3 ♕xf1+ 27 ♔xf1, Black can hardly retake the piece with 27...dxe4 because of 28 ♗xf7 mate.

26 ♖f3 ♕g6 27 ♖xf2 fxg5 28 ♕d3 ♔h8 29 ♗xd5 ♗c5 30 ♗xa8 ♗xf2+ 31 ♔xf2 1-0

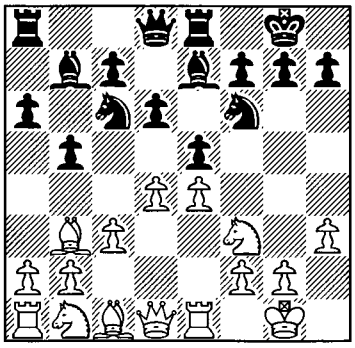
Game 43

A.Shirov-I.Sokolov

Reykjavik 2003

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8

c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8



11 ♘g5

Creating a direct threat which gives Black little choice. The move is commonly played, but there is little independent theory as either the game ends with a three-fold repetition, or one of the players varies and play transposes to other lines!

Another line that can transpose, but only if White chooses, starts with 11 a4 h6 12 d5 (12 ♘bd2 gets back to the standard position) 12...♘a5 13 ♗a2 c6 14 ♘a3 (bearing down on b5 – the point of playing a4 and d4-d5 without ♘bd2) 14...cxd5 (in V.Savon-A.Karpov, Moscow rapid 1992 Black played the double-edged 14...♕c7!? 15 b4 cxd5 16 bxa5 dxe4 17 ♘h2 d5!? with an unclear position) 15 exd5 ♕d7 16 b4 ♘c4 17 ♘xc4 bxc4 18 ♗xc4 ♖ec8 19 ♕b3 ♖c7, D.Velimirovic-S.Smagin, Zenica 1989, and Black will soon regain the pawn with a reasonable game.

11 ♗g5, on the other hand, is uncommon and goes its own way:

a) 11...h6 12 ♗h4 ♘d7 13 ♗g3! ♗f6 14 ♕d3 ♘a5 15 ♗c2 (the bishop on g3 bears down indirectly on d6 making the more active idea ...exd4 followed by ...c5 less attractive) 15...c5 16 d5 ♘c4 17 b3 ♘cb6 18 ♘bd2 ♘f8 19 c4, A.Kapengut-L.Psakhis, Moscow 1981, and White had maintained a nice space plus.

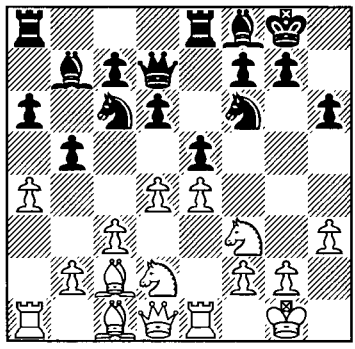
b) 11...♘xe4!? (the most dynamic) 12 ♗xe7 ♘xe7 13 dxe5 d5 14 ♘bd2 ♘g6 15 ♗c2 (15 ♘xe4 dxe4 16 ♕xd8 ♖axd8 17 ♘g5 ♘xe5 favours Black, G.Forsyth-L.Hazai, Gold Coast 1999) 15...f5 16 ♘b3, G.Laketic-Z.Ilincic, Yugoslav Championship 1990, and now simply 16...♕c8 is fine for Black.

c) 11...♘d7 (the most solid) 12 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 13 ♘bd2 ♘f6 14 a4 ♘a5 15 ♗c2 c5 16 axb5 axb5 17 d5 c4 18 ♕e2 ♕c7 19 ♖a3 ♖a6 20 ♖ea1 ♖ea8 and drawn, R.Byrne-S.Gligoric, Vienna 1980.

11...♖f8 12 ♘f3

The sharp but unconvincing 12 f4 is covered in the notes to White's 11th move in Game 38.

12...♖e8 13 a4 h6 14 ♘bd2 ♗f8 15 ♗c2 ♕d7



Each player has used two tempi on the early repetition, so normally the diagram would be reached with both sides having spent 13 moves.

Here we deal with Black's alternatives to 15...cxd4, (or in most cases 13...cxd4!) which has become extremely theoretical over recent years and is the subject of Games 45-48.

Apart from 15...cxd4 and 15...♕d7, Black has two other reasonable options:

a) 15...♖b8 (used to be a favourite of Gligoric and Karpov, but has dropped out of favour) 16 axb5 axb5 17 ♗d3 ♗c8 (so one of the ideas of ...♖b8 is to defend the b-pawn) 18 ♘f1 b4 (another is to push it!) 19 ♘g3 bxc3 20 bxc3 exd4 (or 20...g6 21 ♗e3

♗g7 22 ♕d2 ♔h7 23 d5 with a small edge according to V.Kovacevic) 21 cxd4 ♘b4 22 ♗b1 c5 23 ♗f4 ♖b5 24 ♕d2 ♖a5 25 ♖xa5 ♕xa5, and here both 26 d5, J.Timman-A.Karpov, Tilburg 1986, and V.Kovacevic's 26 ♕b2 are a shade better for White.

b) 15...♘b8 (keeping an eye on e4 and instigating the Breyer manoeuvre) 16 ♗d3 c6 17 ♘f1 ♘bd7 18 ♘g3. White's pieces and structure are more active. Black will try to get in a timely ...d6-d5 in order to negate White's pull. Compared to a Breyer, Black has played ...h6 quite early (a tempo spent on a move he can sometimes live without), so it's not quite a simple task to equalise:

b1) 18...♕c7 19 ♗d2 g6 20 ♕c1 ♔h7 21 b3 (the point of this move is prophylactic as if immediately 21 ♕c2, then Black has 21...c5!) 21...♗g7 22 ♕c2 ♘f8 (here 22...d5?! is too dangerous due to 23 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 24 dxe5 ♘xe4 25 ♘xe4 dxe4 26 ♖xe4 c5 27 ♖g4 ♕xe5 28 ♗xg6+, with a strong attack) 23 ♗e3 and White maintained his advantage, G.Kasparov-A.Karpov, World Championship (game 9), Moscow 1985.

b2) 18...g6 19 b3 (less testing is 19 ♗e3 ♗g7 20 ♕d2 ♔h7 21 ♘h2 d5!, K.Lahno-Pr.Nikolic, Rethymnon 2003) 19...♗g7 20 ♕c2 ♕c7 21 ♗e3 d5!? (a slightly ambitious break for freedom) 22 dxe5 dxe4 23 ♗xe4 ♘xe5 24 ♘xe5 ♕xe5 25 ♗xg6 fxg6 26 ♕xg6 ♘e4 27 ♗xh6 ♕f6 28 ♕xf6 ♘xf6 29 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 30 ♘f5+ ♔g6 31 ♘d6 ♖xe1+ 32 ♖xe1 ♗c8 and Black should probably hold the ending, G.Rechlis-Y.Kraidman, Jerusalem 1986.

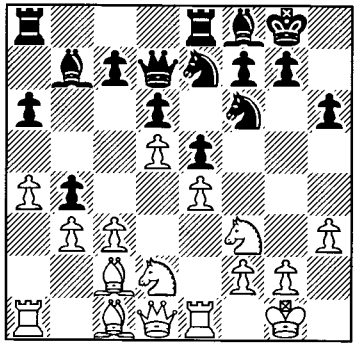
16 b3

Keeping the tension. Over the years most have preferred 16 d5, as White hopes to count on his space advantage. However, with accurate play Black can generate counter-chances: 16...♘e7 17 c4 c6 18 b3 g6 (also possible is 18...♘g6 19 ♗d3 ♘f4 20 ♗f1 b4 21 ♔h2 g6 22 g3 ♘4h5 23 ♘h4 ♔h7 24 ♗g2 ♘g8, A.Galkin-I.Ibragimov, Russia 1998, and the manoeuvres have yet to yield anything concrete) 19 ♗b2 (or if 19 ♘f1 ♘h5 20 ♘e3 cxd5 21 cxd5 ♗g7 22 ♖a2 ♘f4 23 ♔h2 f5, H.Kotz-I.Ibragimov, Graz 1994, Black obtains counterplay) 19...♗g7 20 dxc6 ♗xc6 21 c5 ♘h5, was very comfortable for Black in F.Nijboer-Zhang Zhong, Wijk aan Zee 2003.

16...b4

Critical is 16...exd4 17 cxd4 ♘b4 18 ♗b1 g6, which transposes to Game 44 via 13...exd4 (or here 15...exd4) 14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗b1, and then 15...♕d7 16 b3 g6.

17 d5 ♘e7



18 c4

Grabbing a pawn with 18 cxb4 allows Black to open the centre with 18...c6, when Shirov gives 19 dxc6 (if 19 ♘c4 then 19...cxd5) 19...♘xc6 20 ♗a3 d5 21 b5 axb5 22 ♗xf8 ♔xf8 23 axb5 ♖xa1 24 ♕xa1 ♘b4 25 ♗b1 dxe4 26 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 27 ♗xe4 ♕xb5 with equality.

18...c5

Black is under no immediate danger in these type of positions, but as a rule I believe that he should avoid blocking the queenside completely. So throughout the book I have tried to suggest alternative ways of defending than that of 'pulling up the drawbridge and hoping the walls will hold' mentality. White has more space and is able to eventually obtain chances on the kingside whereas Black is largely passive and cannot create a diversion to keep White occupied. Apart from the dis-

comfort of having limited room for manoeuvre, the psychological problem of having to defend for many moves with no real hope of winning shouldn't be underestimated.

19 ♘f1 ♔h8 20 ♘3h2 ♘g6 21 ♘e3 ♖ad8 22 ♘f5 ♗c8 23 ♕f3 ♘h7 24 ♗d2 ♘e7 25 h4 ♘g8!

Here 25...♘xf5 26 exf5 helps White who can roll his kingside pawns forward and has the useful pivot point on e4.

26 g4 g6 27 ♘e3 ♗g7 28 ♔h1 ♘e7 29 ♖g1 ♖g8

Battening down the hatches with 29...g5!? is ugly, but can White find a way to breakthrough?

30 ♖g2 ♖df8 31 ♖ag1 ♕d8 32 ♘hf1 a5 33 ♖h2 f6 34 ♘g3 ♖f7 35 ♔g2

White shows his intention to move his king to relative safety on d1 before provoking a crisis with ♘g3-e2, ♕g3 and f2-f4.

35...f5?

Losing patience, but Sokolov had clearly decided that this was the best moment to try and break out as the White king is temporarily exposed.

36 gxf5 gxf5 37 exf5 e4?!

Consistent but insufficient.

38 ♗xe4 ♗e5 39 ♔f1 ♘f6

Black's pieces find some freedom and reasonable squares; however White can easily consolidate.

40 ♗d3 ♖fg7 41 ♖hg2 ♕e8 42 ♘e4

With a couple of extra pawns and no soft spots in his position, White must be objectively winning.

42...♖xg2 43 ♖xg2 ♖xg2 44 ♔xg2 ♘h5 45 ♔f1 ♕f7 46 ♘g4

The capture on e5 leads to the creation of a passed pawn.

46...♘xf5 47 ♘xe5 dxe5 48 ♔e1 ♕g6 49 ♘xc5 ♔g8 50 ♗e3

Shirov mentions that 50 d6! wins, bearing in mind that 50...♕xd6 is refuted by 51 ♕xh5.

50...♕g1+ 51 ♔d2 ♘xe3 52 ♕xe3 ♕a1 53 ♗c2 ♕b2 54 ♕d3 ♘f4 55 ♕e3?

It's more complicated now, but Shirov analyses a white win starting with 55 ♕h7+ ♔f8 56 ♕xh6+ ♔g8 57 ♕h7+ ♔f8 58 ♘e4 ♕d4+ 59 ♔c1 ♕a1+ 60 ♗b1 ♗g4 61 f3 ♗h3 (61...♗xf3? 62 ♕f5+ forces mate) 62 ♔c2! when Black's counterplay is ineffective.

55...♗f5 56 ♘e4 ♔f8 57 f3 h5 58 d6 ♗xe4 59 ♕xe4 ♔e8 60 ♔d1 ♕a1+ 61 ♗b1 ♕c3?

In this sharp ending, Shirov points out that Black misses a chance to draw with 61...♔d8!, when after 62 c5 ♔d7, (it's zugzwang!) the continuation 63 ♕b7+ ♔e6 64 ♕c8+ ♔d5 leads to a draw as perpetual check is on the cards.

62 ♕a8+ ♔f7 63 ♕a7+ ♔g8 64 ♕h7+ ♔f8 65 ♕f5+ ♔g7 66 ♕e4 ♕xb3+

66...♔f8 lasts a little longer but is equally hopeless: 67 d7 ♔e7 68 ♕h7+ ♔d8 69 ♕g8+ ♔xd7 70 ♕f7+ ♔d6 71 ♕f8+ ♔c6 (71...♔c7 72 ♕e7+ ♔b6 73 ♕d6+ ♔a7 74 ♕c5+ is mate in eleven!) 72 ♗e4+ ♔d7 73 ♗f5+ ♘e6 74 ♕f7+ ♔d8 75 ♕f6+ ♔c7 76 ♕e7+ ♔b8 77 ♕d6+ ♔a7 78 ♕d7+ ♔b8 79 ♕b5+ ♔c7 80 ♕xa5+ ♔c6 81 ♕d5+ ♔c7 82 ♗xe6 (Shirov).

67 ♗c2 ♕c3 68 d7 ♕a1+ 69 ♗b1 ♕xa4+ 70 ♔e1 1-0

Game 44

V.Anand-G.Kamsky

Las Palmas (Game 9) 1995

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♖e8

Many games in the Zaitsev variation start with 9...♖e8, with ...♗f8 and ...♗b7 coming soon. The drawback for Black is the move 10 ♘g5, when there's nothing better than 10...♖f8, and if then 11 ♘f3 what next? So to put it bluntly, it's OK to play the modern 9...♖e8 move order if you don't mind a draw, or your opponent wants to play, but if you want a more rewarding game of chess then

something else is required! I suggest switching to 11...♗b7 after repeating once. There's nothing wrong with it and you are, by implication, telling your opponent that you mean business!

In this present game 9...♖e8 10 d4 (if instead 10 ♘g5 ♖f8, apart from coming back to f3, White has also tried 11 d4 ♗b7, but then yet again 12 ♘f3 seems to be White's best, coming back to normal lines) 10...♗b7 transposes to the normal position after Black's tenth move (whereas 10...♗f8 gives White the added option of 11 ♗g5!?).

10 d4 ♗b7 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a4 h6 13 ♗c2 exd4 14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗b1 ♕d7

Avoiding the main theoretical discussion of 15...c5, see Games 45-48. Otherwise Black has experimented with 15...g6 and 15...bxa4:

a) After 15...g6, (this has been more or less abandoned after the following high profile first game of their match) as in V.Anand-G.Kamsky, Las Palmas Match 1995, the continuation 16 ♖a3 ♗g7 17 e5 dxe5 18 dxe5 ♘h5 19 axb5 axb5 20 ♕b3 c5 21 ♘e4 ♗xe5 22 ♘xc5 ♗xf3 23 ♕xf3 ♖c8 24 ♘e4 ♔g7 25 ♖d1 ♕e7 26 ♗e3 ♖ed8 27 ♖a7 left White with the advantage. Look at the relative safety of the kings.

b) The strange move 15...bxa4 leads to a slightly compromised pawn structure, but Black has queenside activity to compensate. The main problem is that White is left in control of the centre and seems to be better as a result: 16 ♖xa4 a5 17 ♖a3 (instead 17 b3!? ♖a6 18 ♖a1 g6 19 ♗b2 ♗g7 20 ♗c3 d5 21 e5 ♘d7 22 h4 c5 23 h5 led to chances for both sides in F.Nijboer-P.Van der Sterren, Den Bosch 1999) 17...♖a6 and now:

b1) 18 ♘h2 g6 19 f3 ♗g7 (19...♕d7?! 20 ♘c4 ♕b5 21 ♖c3 ♗c8 22 ♗e3 ♔h7 23 ♕c1 c6 24 ♘g4 ♘g8 25 ♗xh6! was crushing in G.Kasparov-A.Karpov, World Championship (game 2), Lyon/New York 1990) 20 ♘c4 ♕a8 21 d5 ♖d8 22 ♗d2 c6 23 dxc6 ♘xc6 24 ♖d3, E.Liss-E.Shvidler, Tel Aviv 1991, with an edge to White.

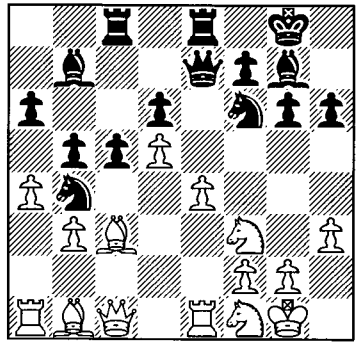
b2) 18 ♖ae3 a4 19 ♘f1 d5 20 e5 ♘e4 21 ♘1d2 c5 22 ♘xe4 dxe4 23 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 24 ♖xe4 c4 25 e6 ♖exe6 26 ♖xe6 fxe6 27 ♘e5 ♕d5 28 ♕h5 ♖a7 29 ♕g6, A.Sokolov-D.Bronstein, Reykjavik 1990, with a dangerous initiative against Black's weakened kingside.

16 b3

After 16 ♖a3 the disruptive 16...bxa4! gains a tempo on the 15...bxa4 variation above and constitutes a more principled choice than 16...♖ad8 17 axb5 axb5 18 ♖ae3 c5 19 d5 g6 20 ♘f1 ♗g7 21 ♗d2, which left White with a small edge in R.Hübner-L.Portisch, Tilburg 1981.

After 16 ♖a3 bxa4 17 ♖xa4 a5 18 ♖a3 ♕b5 19 d5 (or if 19 ♘h2 g6 20 ♘g4 ♘xg4 21 ♕xg4 S.Dvoirys-K.Lerner, Kharkov 1985, then An.Bikhovsky proposes 21...c5! 22 e5 dxe5 23 ♗xg6 fxg6 24 ♕xg6+ ♗g7 25 ♖g3 ♕d7 26 ♘e4 ♗xe4 27 ♖xe4 ♖a6, which he judges as 'chances for both sides', but Fritz considers Black to be better) 19...c6 20 ♘d4 ♕b6 21 dxc6 ♘xc6 22 ♘f5 ♘e5 23 ♖g3 ♔h8 24 ♘f1 d5 25 ♗e3 ♕d8 with only a slight initiative for White, K.Aseev-Y.Kruppa, USSR 1985.

16...g6 17 ♗b2 ♗g7 18 ♕c1 ♖ac8 19 ♗c3 c5 20 d5 ♕e7 21 ♘f1



21...♘h7?

The wrong way. Instead Black has a reasonable game after 21...♘d7 22 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 23 ♘e3 h5.

22 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 23 ♘e3 h5

After 23...♕f6, Anand would have had few qualms about going for 24 ♘g4! ♕xa1 25 ♕xh6+ ♔g8 26 e5 with a vicious attack for the rook.

24 ♕d2 ♔g8 25 axb5 axb5 26 ♘d1!

Stopping any ideas of ...♘g5 and heading for the soft spot on b5. Black is driven onto the back foot.

26...♘a6 27 ♘c3 b4

A concession but there's not much else he can do.

28 ♘b5 ♘c7 29 ♗d3 ♘xb5 30 ♗xb5 ♖ed8 31 ♗c4

White has a clear positional advantage. Black's position reminds one of a Modern Benoni gone wrong, with his queenside majority blocked and preparation underway for the killing blow e4-e5.

31...♘f6 32 ♕h6 ♕f8 33 ♕g5 ♕g7 34 ♖a7 ♖c7 35 ♗a6 ♖b8 36 e5! ♘e8 37 ♖xb7 ♖cxb7 38 ♗xb7 ♖xb7 39 ♕d8 ♕f8 40 ♖a1 ♘c7 41 ♕d7 ♕b8 42 ♕xd6 c4

A last gasp try to create counterplay.

43 bxc4 b3 44 ♖b1 b2 45 ♕c5 ♖b3 46 ♕d4 ♕b4 47 ♘g5 ♖c3 48 ♕f4 f6 49 exf6 ♘xd5 50 f7+

1-0

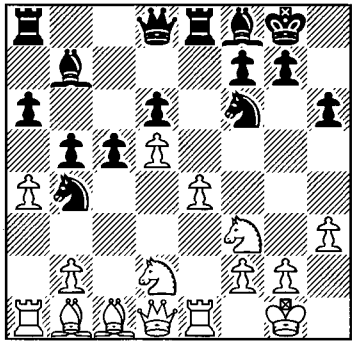
Game 45

A.Shirov-D.Lekic

Bosnia 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a4 h6 13 ♗c2 exd4 14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗b1 c5 16 d5

This move is almost automatic nowadays. The other try 16 b3, doesn't seem to give anything for White, e.g. 16...cxd4 17 ♘xd4 ♕b6 18 ♗b2 bxa4 19 ♖xa4 d5 20 e5 ♘e4 21 ♘xe4 dxe4 22 ♗xe4 ♖xe5 23 ♗xb7 (23 ♗h7+ ♔xh7 24 ♖xe5 ♕g6 25 g4 ♘d3 26 ♖e2 ♗c5 gives Black excellent compensation for the exchange) 23...♖xe1+ 24 ♕xe1 ♕xb7, Ki.Georgiev-J.Hjartarson, Groningen 1993.



16...♘d7

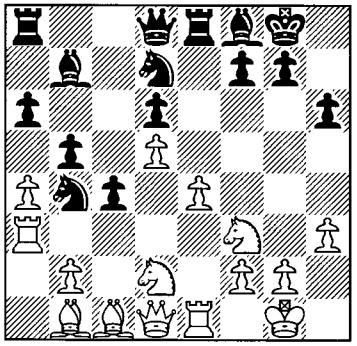
Again pretty much standard. The rather old-fashioned 16...g6 looks playable albeit a little slow. The pawn structure is as in a Modern Benoni where the crisis will come much later than in the main lines. Black's king is safer here but so is White's centre: 17 ♘f1 ♗g7 18 axb5 (after 18 ♖a3 ♘d7 19 a5 ♘e5 20 ♘xe5 ♗xe5 21 ♘h2, V.Kotronias-G.Doumas, Patras 2001, Black could try the reasonable-looking 21...h5!?) 18...axb5 19 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 (or following 19...♗xa8 20 ♗d2 ♘a6 21 ♕c1 [Black's queenside pieces need some time to come into play] 21...h5 22 ♗h6 ♗h8 23 ♘g3 c4 24 ♕f4 White had the initiative in a complex position, Y.Grünfeld-P.Shterenberg, Israeli Championship 1984) 20 ♗f4 ♘d7 21 ♕d2 (Grünfeld suggests either 21 b3, or 21 ♗xd6 ♗xb2 22 ♕d2 ♗g7 23 ♘e3 h5 24 ♗xc5 ♘xd5 25 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 26 ♗d4 ♗xd4 27 ♕xd4 ♗e6 28 ♘g5 as giving White an edge) 21...♕a1, Y.Grünfeld-A.Greenfeld, Israeli Championship 1984, was not clear.

17 ♖a3

17 ♘f1 is relatively less dangerous for Black: 17...f5 18 exf5 ♖xe1 (18...♘f6 19 ♖a3 ♘bxd5 20 ♘1h2 is also very unclear, e.g. 20...♕d7 21 ♘g4 b4 22 ♖d3 c4 23 ♖d4 ♖ac8 24 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 as in G.Andersson-Franzen, corr 1987) 19 ♕xe1 (or 19 ♘xe1 ♘xd5 20

♖a3, A.Sokolov-L.Psakhis, USSR Championship 1985, and now Sokolov suggests 20...♘7f6, which he considers to be... unclear!) 19...♗xd5 20 ♖a3 bxa4! 21 ♘1h2 ♗b3 22 ♖xb3! axb3 23 ♕e6+ ♔h8 24 f6! ♘xf6 25 ♘h4 g5!, A.Kosteniuk-S.Karjakin, Hastings 2002/3, and now Karjakin and Borovikov give 26 ♘g4! ♘bd5 27 ♗e4 ♘xe4 28 ♘xh6 ♗xh6 29 ♕xh6+ ♔g8 30 ♕e6+ as leading to a draw but in this line Black can play for more with 27...♕e8!.

17...c4



Once considered critical it's now been largely superseded by the super-sharp 17...f5. The disadvantage of this move is allowing White access to the d4-square which is an ideal posting for a White knight. Compare with Game 46, note to Black's 18th, where Black plays ...c4 with the extra moves 17...f5 18 ♘h2 included, i.e. when the knight is further away from d4.

18 axb5

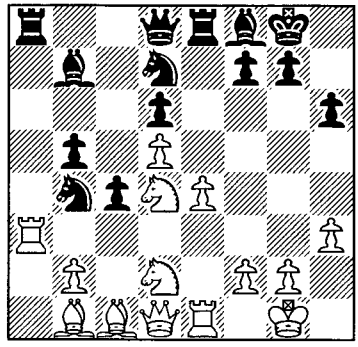
Shirov chose 18 ♘d4 the last time that he had this line. Then after 18...♘d3 19 ♗xd3 b4 20 ♗xc4 bxa3 21 bxa3 ♘c5 22 ♗b2 g6 23 ♘c6, A.Shirov-Z.Almasi, Dresden rapid 1997, he obtained good compensation for the exchange.

Stronger for Black is 18...♕f6 (rather than 18...♘d3) 19 ♘2f3 and now either knight move:

a) 19...♘c5 (gives up a pawn to get neatly installed on d3) 20 axb5 axb5 21 ♘xb5 ♖xa3 and after both recaptures Black is considered to have enough compensation for the b-pawn: 22 bxa3 ♘bd3 23 ♖e3 ♕a1 24 ♗d2 ♕b2 25 ♘c3 ♗a6, C.Storey-K.Sasikiran, Scarborough 1999, and 22 ♘xa3 ♗a6 23 ♖e3 ♖b8 24 e5 dxe5 25 ♘xe5 ♘cd3 26 ♘g4 ♕h4 27 ♖g3 ♔h8 28 ♗d2 ♗d6 29 ♖f3 ♘xb2, J.Nunn-L.Psakhis, Hastings 1987/8.

b) 19...♘d3 20 ♖xd3 (or 20 ♗xd3 b4 21 ♗xc4 bxa3 22 b3 ♘c5 23 ♕c2 ♕g6 24 ♘h4 ♕f6 25 ♘hf3 ♕g6 26 ♘h4 ♕f6 27 ♘hf3 and draws, V.Anand-G.Kamsky, Las Palmas 1995) 20...cxd3 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♘xb5 ♖a1 23 ♗xd3 ♗a6 24 ♘fd4 was unclear in E.Pupo-R.Leyva, Cuba 1997.

18...axb5 19 ♘d4



19...♘e5!?

A critical choice:

a) 19...♖xa3 20 bxa3 ♘d3 21 ♗xd3 cxd3 22 ♖e3:

a1) 22...♘e5 23 ♘4f3 f5 (otherwise 23...♘c4 24 ♖xd3 ♕d7 25 ♘xc4 bxc4 26 ♖e3 f5 27 ♘d2 turned out well for White in V.Ivanchuk-Y.Kruppa, Frunze 1988, although in this Ivanchuk's suggested improvement 24...g6 limits the damage) 24 ♘xe5 ♖xe5 25 ♗b2 ♖e7 26 exf5 ♖xe3 27 fxe3 ♗xd5 28 ♕g4 ♕g5 29 ♕xg5 hxg5 30 ♔f2, J.Klovans-V.Kazak, USSR 1990, and White's better pawn structure was more important than the bishop pair.

a2) 22...♘c5 23 ♗b2 ♗c8 (or 23...♕a5 24 ♘f5 g6 25 ♘g3 ♗g7 26 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 27

♘b3 ♕xa3 28 ♘xc5 ♕xc5 29 ♖xd3 and with the smoke clearing, White has the better pawn structure, V.Kotronias-S.Gligoric, Niksic 1997) 24 ♘c6! ♕h4 25 ♗d4 f5 26 ♘f3 ♕h5 27 e5!, as in V.Anand-A.Beliavsky, Madrid 1988, left White clearly on top.

b) Another idea is 19...♕b6, but Black has to try to stem White's attack after 20 ♘f5:

b1) 20...♖xa3?! 21 bxa3 ♘d3 22 ♗xd3 cxd3 23 ♘xh6+ gxh6 24 ♕g4+ gave White the advantage in J.Gdanski-M.Grabarczyk, Bielsko-Biala 1991.

b2) 20...g6 21 ♖g3 and now 21...♖a1!? (Lukacs and Hazai's move) could be stronger than 21...♔h7 22 ♘f3 ♘d3 23 ♗xd3 cxd3 24 ♕d2 ♕d8 25 ♘xh6 ♕f6 26 ♘xf7!, P.Konguvel-S.Rathore, Indian Championship 1999.

b3) 20...♘e5!? 21 ♖g3 g6 22 ♘f3 ♘ed3 23 ♗e3 ♕d8 24 ♗d4!? was murky in P.Konguvel-NS.Babu, India 1999, as is 24 ♘xh6+ ♗xh6 25 ♗xh6 ♕f6 26 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 27 ♖e2 as analysed by Romanishin and An.Bikhovsky.

20 ♖xa8

If 20 ♘xb5 ♕b6 21 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 22 ♘a3 ♗a6 23 ♖e3 ♗e7 24 ♘f3 ♗f6! 25 ♘xe5 ♗xe5, as in A.Villavicencio-A.Brito Garcia, Gran Canaria 1989, Black had enough play.

20...♕xa8 21 ♘xb5 ♖c8

21...♕a5 is very complex, but one gets the impression that Black doesn't quite have enough to justify his missing pawn: 22 ♘a3 ♗a6 23 ♖e3 ♕c5 24 ♖c3 ♘ed3 25 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 26 ♕f3 ♘e5 27 ♕e2 and with the knight getting to d4 White takes the advantage, V.Anand-G.Kamsky, Las Palmas 1995.

22 ♘f3!

Shirov's novelty. Previously known was 22 ♘a3 ♗a6 23 ♖e3 ♘bd3 24 ♗xd3 cxd3 25 b3 ♗e7 26 ♘dc4, N.De Firmian-Alexa.Ivanov, USA Championship 1996, at which point Black has the neat equalising idea 26...♘xc4! 27 bxc4 ♗xc4 28 ♘xc4 ♕a1!.

22...♘ed3 23 ♖f1 ♕a1 24 ♗d2

Or possibly 24 ♗xd3 cxd3 (if 24...♘xd3, simply 25 ♘fd4) 25 ♗f4 ♕a6 26 ♘bd4 with an edge, according to Shirov.

24...♕xb2?

Better was either 24...♗a6 25 ♗xd3 ♕xd1 26 ♖xd1 ♘xd3 27 ♘c3 ♘xb2 28 ♖a1, or 24...♘xb2 25 ♕e2 ♕a4 26 ♘fd4 ♘2d3 27 ♕g4, but in both cases White keeps an edge.

25 ♗c3 ♕b3 26 ♕d2 ♕a4 27 ♘fd4 ♗a6?

This eases White's task. Instead 27...♖a8 is more robust, when Shirov intended to push on the kingside with 28 ♔h2 (rather than go for 28 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 29 ♖a1 ♕xa1+ 30 ♗xa1 ♖xa1+ 31 ♔h2, which wins the queen but is technically difficult due to Black's activity) 28...g6 29 f4.

28 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 29 ♖a1

Winning the queen under very favourable circumstances.

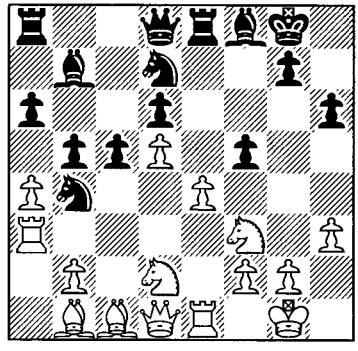
29...♗xb5 30 ♖xa4 ♗xa4 31 ♔h2 ♘c5 32 f3 g6 33 ♘e2 ♘d3 34 ♕e3 ♗g7 35 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 36 ♕b6 1-0

Game 46

J.Ehlvest-P.Acs

Ohrid 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a4 h6 13 ♗c2 exd4 14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗b1 c5 16 d5 ♘d7 17 ♖a3 f5



18 ♘h2

The most popular amongst the various options but, as many of the lines are 'unclear' throughout, there's no guarantee that it will stay this way:

a) 18 ♖ae3 used to be popular, but Black seems to be doing well in the following line: 18...f4 19 ♖3e2 ♘e5 20 ♘f1!? (the more solid 20 ♘xe5 dxe5 21 ♘f3 ♗d6 22 b3 is given by Karpov as unclear) 20...♘xf3+ 21 gxf3 ♕g5+ 22 ♔h1 ♗c8 23 ♘h2 ♗xh3 24 ♖g1 ♕e5 25 ♗d2 ♘xd5 26 ♕c1 ♕h5 27 ♖ee1 ♘b4 28 ♗xf4 ♖e6, A.Bezgodov-D.Jakovenko, Tomsk 1998.

b) The capture 18 exf5 remains critical:

b1) Dubious seems to be 18...♖xe1+ 19 ♕xe1 ♗xd5 20 ♘e4 ♗f7 21 f6! (creating strong threats on the b1-h7 diagonal) 21...g6 22 ♘h4 d5 23 ♖g3 ♕e8 24 ♘xg6 ♗xg6 25 f7+ ♕xf7 26 ♘d6 1-0, V.Ivanchuk-P.Lukacs, Debrecen 1988.

b2) Better is 18...♗xd5 19 ♘e4 ♗f7 20 axb5 d5 21 ♘c3 ♖xe1+ 22 ♘xe1 d4 23 ♘a2 ♘xa2 24 ♗xa2 c4, which was unclear in G.Kasparov-A.Karpov, World Championship (game 22) New York/Lyon 1990.

b3) 18...♘f6 has the advantage of blocking the f-pawn:

b31) 19 ♖xe8 ♕xe8 20 ♘h4 ♗xd5 21 ♘g6 ♕f7 22 ♘f1 bxa4 23 ♕xa4 ♗e4 24 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 with equality, A.Sokolov-J.Hjartarson, Manila Interzonal 1990.

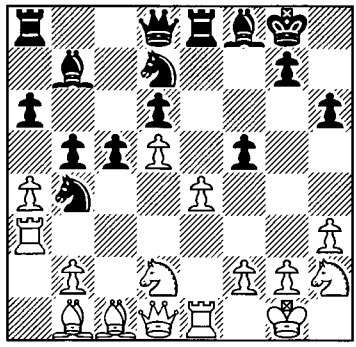
b32) 19 axb5 axb5 20 ♘e4 ♗xd5?! 21 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 22 ♘xf6+ gxf6 23 ♖e6 ♖xe6 24 fxe6 ♕e8 25 ♕e2 ♗d5 26 ♗f5 gave White a strong attack in F.Bellia-E.Dervishi, Bratto 2003, but here 20...♘bxd5! is better.

b33) 19 ♘f1 transposes to Game 45, notes to White's 17th move.

b34) 19 ♘e4 ♗xd5 (or possibly 19...♘bxd5!? 20 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 21 ♖e6 d5 22 ♘h2 c4 23 ♖g3 ♘e4, F.Bellia-E.Dervishi, Bratto 2002) 20 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♖xe8 ♖xe8 23 g4 with double-edged play, J.Sprenger-L.Ostrowski, Pardubice 2003.

c) 18 e5!? dxe5 (better than 18...♘xe5 19 ♘xe5 ♖xe5 20 ♖xe5 dxe5 21 ♗xf5 ♘xd5 22 ♗e6+ ♔h8 23 ♖d3 c4 24 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 25 ♘xc4 bxc4 26 ♖xd5 ♕c7 27 ♗d2 with an edge to White due to the superior pawn structure, P.Morris-P.H.Nielsen, Copenhagen 1993) 19 ♗xf5 ♘xd5, as in K.Beaton-S.Mannion, Scottish Championship 1991, is OK for Black.

d) 18 g4!? f4 19 ♘b3 c4!? 20 ♘bd4 ♘c5 21 ♗xf4 ♕b6 (Black comes into the d3-outpost and thus has enough compensation) 22 ♗h2 ♘bd3 23 ♗xd3 cxd3 24 axb5 axb5 25 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 26 b4 ♘xe4 27 ♕xd3 ♗xd5 28 ♕xb5, and here a draw was agreed in F.Hellers-Z.Almasi, Malmö 1994.



18...♔h8

The alternative 18...c4 had been generally discredited largely because of the game V.Ivanchuk-A.Karpov, Monaco rapid 1993, which continued 19 exf5 ♘c5 20 ♖xe8 ♕xe8 21 ♖g3 ♘bd3 22 f6 g6 23 b3 ♗xd5 24 bxc4 bxc4 25 ♗a3 ♘f4 26 ♖g4 ♘ce6 27 ♘df3 ♗xf3 28 ♘xf3 h5 29 ♘g5, with advantage to White. When I first prepared this chapter I originally wrote that this looks sufficiently unclear to merit further investigation, only to find that Zaitsev specialist Vescovi has recently given it a try. That game, And.Volokitin-Gio.Vescovi, Bermuda 2003 continued in equally murky fashion: 19 ♖g3 ♘c5 20 exf5 ♖xe1+ 21 ♕xe1 ♘bd3?! (Now Vescovi considers 21...♘cd3 to be more accurate [cutting out the b2-b4 disruptive

idea] and his main line goes as follows: 22 ♕d1 ♗xd5 23 ♘g4 h5 24 ♘h6+ ♔h8 25 ♘xc4 bxc4 26 ♕xh5 ♕e8 27 ♘f7+ with a draw) 22 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 23 ♕e6+ ♔h8 24 ♘g4 ♕e8, with a winning position for Black due to the dead meat on c1. However there are improvements in this according to Vescovi in *Informator 86*, who in particular suggests 22 ♕d1! (rather than 22 ♗xd3) that may indeed be strong:

a) 22...♗xd5 23 b4! ♘xb4 24 ♘g4 ♔h8 25 ♘xh6!, or

b) 22...♘xc1 23 ♕xc1 ♗xd5 24 ♘g4 h5 25 f6! hxg4 26 ♕c2 ♕xf6 (26...♘d3? is bad news for Black after 27 ♖xd3) 27 ♕h7+ ♔f7 28 ♕h5+ ♔e7 29 ♕xd5.

In any case I'm sure that we've not heard the last of 18...c4.

19 g4

White has three alternatives worth investigating:

a) 19 ♖ae3 c4 20 b3 ♘e5 21 bxc4 bxc4 22 exf5 ♘xd5 23 ♖g3 ♕b6 24 a5, F.Hellers-E.Solozhenkin, Parthenay 1992, and now 24...♕b4 25 ♗a3 ♕xa5 is better for Black according to Solozhenkin.

b) 19 exf5 ♖xe1+ 20 ♕xe1 ♘xd5 21 ♘g4 ♕e8 22 ♘e4 ♕f7 23 ♕d1 b4 24 ♖g3 ♖e8 25 b3 ♘7f6 26 ♘exf6 ♘xf6 27 ♗b2 ♗e7 28 ♕c1 ♘xg4 29 ♖xg4 ♗f6 30 ♖g6 ♕e7 31 ♗xf6 (or 31 ♖xh6+ ♔g8!) 31...♕e1+ 32 ♕xe1 ♖xe1+ 33 ♔h2 gxf6, and Black had the slightly better ending in L.Dominguez-P.Acs, Oropesa 1998.

c) 19 ♖g3 ♘f6, and now there's a further split:

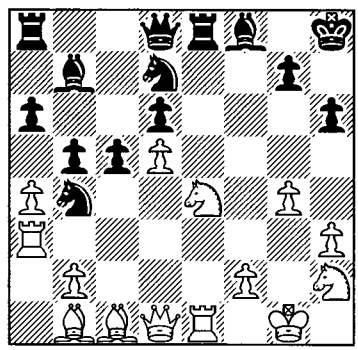
c1) 20 ♘hf3 fxe4 21 ♘xe4 (better than 21 ♘h4?! ♗xd5 22 ♘g6+ ♔g8 23 ♘f1 ♖a7 24 ♘e3 ♗e6 25 ♘g4 ♘xg4 26 hxg4, P.Smirnov-O.Svirin, Smolensk 2000, as 26...d5 27 g5 ♗d6 28 ♗f4 ♗f7 clearly favours Black) 21...♗xd5 22 ♘xf6 ♖xe1+! (better than the older 22...♕xf6) 23 ♕xe1 ♕xf6 24 ♗d2 (24 ♖g6!? has been suggested as a better try) 24...♕e7 25 ♗xb4 cxb4 26 ♕xb4 ♖c8 and Black's bishop pair offered him the better chances, V.Kotronias-D.Jakovenko, Batumi 2002.

c2) 20 b3 fxe4 21 ♘xe4 ♗xd5 22 ♘xf6 ♕xf6 23 ♗d2 ♖xe1+ 24 ♗xe1 ♕e6 25 ♖e3, and now instead of 25...♕g8? 26 ♘g4, V.Topalov-Z.Almasi, Monaco blind 2001, Black can try 25...♕f7! 26 ♗xb4 cxb4 27 ♕d3 g5 with unclear play according to Lukacs and Hazai.

19...fxe4

The idea of 19...f4, aiming to close off the lines of attack towards the black king worked well in V.Malakhov-E.Dervishi, St.Vincent 2000, which continued 20 ♘df3 g5 21 h4 (Lukacs and Hazai suggest 21 ♗d2 ♗g7 22 ♗c3 with an edge, but this needs testing) 21...♗g7 22 a5 ♖c8 23 ♔g2 c4 24 hxg5 hxg5 25 ♖h1 ♔g8 26 ♘e1 ♘c5 27 ♗d2 ♘bd3 28 ♘xd3 cxd3 29 b4 ♘xe4 30 ♖xd3 ♕d7.

20 ♘xe4



20...♖e5

Black's best at this point hasn't yet crystallised:

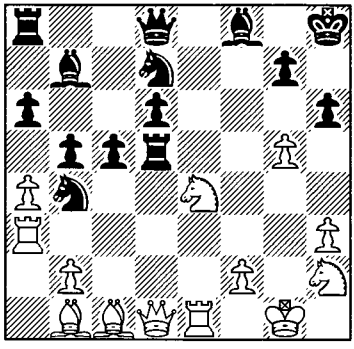
a) If 20...♘xd5, then 21 g5 followed by ♖g3 yields an initiative.

b) White's attacking chances would also offer him compensation for the pawn in the line 20...♗xd5 21 g5 ♗xe4 22 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 23 ♗xe4 d5 24 ♗b1, according to Lukacs and Hazai.

c) If 20...♘f6 21 g5 ♘xe4 22 ♖xe4 ♗xd5 23 ♖xe8 ♕xe8 24 gxh6 gxh6 25 ♖g3, then Black's best seems to be 25...♗g7! (but not

25...♕f7?! 26 ♘g4 ♕h5 27 ♗d2 ♗g7 28 ♗c3 ♖a7 29 ♕d2, when Black had serious problems in K.Aseev-E.Solozhenkin, St.Petersburg 1995) 26 ♗d2 ♕e6 27 ♗xb4 cxb4 28 ♖g6 (or 28 ♕d3 ♕g8) 28...♕e5, and the result would be very much in doubt.

21 g5 ♖xd5



22 ♕e2

Otherwise 22 ♗d2 ♘e5 23 gxh6 ♘c4 24 ♖g3 ♘xd2 25 ♘xd2 gxh6 26 ♗e4 ♗g7 27 ♗xd5 ♘xd5 28 ♘e4 ♕f8 29 ♘g4 ♖e8 30 axb5 axb5 is given by Acs and Hazai as unclear.

22...♖e5 23 ♗f4

Equally murky would be 23 ♘f3 ♖e6 24 ♘h4 ♕e8 25 ♖e3 d5 26 ♘f6! ♖xe3 27 ♗xe3 gxf6 28 ♘g6+ ♔g8 29 gxh6 with compensation, (Acs and Hazai); then 29...♗xh6 30 ♗xh6 ♕xe2 31 ♖xe2 ♘c6 32 ♘e7+ ♔h8 33 ♘xc6 ♗xc6 34 ♖e7 ♘e5 seems to defend.

23...♖e6 24 ♕g4

It's too soon for 24 gxh6?!, which seems to release the tension prematurely and a line such as 24...gxh6 25 ♕g4 ♕e7 26 ♖ae3 ♘d5, favours Black, who covers the h7-square more easily than in the game.

24...♕e7 25 ♖ae3 ♘d5 26 ♘xd6!

Giving up the exchange, but then all White's remaining pieces contribute to the attack.

26...♘xe3 27 ♖xe3 ♖xe3 28 fxe3 ♗d5 29 ♘f3 ♗xf3

Here 29...♗e6 just helps White after 30 ♕h5, with strong threats such as ♘h4. Apparently the log-jam in Black's position should be cleared with the remarkable 29...♘f6! 30 gxf6 ♕xf6 31 ♕h5 ♗xd6 32 ♕xd5 ♖d8 33 ♕e4 ♔g8, with only a small advantage to White according to Acs and Hazai, for instance 34 ♗xd6 ♕xd6 35 ♔g2.

30 ♕xf3 ♖d8 31 ♕h5

Now the threat of mate with ♕g6 etc. gives Black little choice.

31...♘e5 32 gxh6 ♘f3+

32...♖xd6 fails to the forcing sequence 33 hxg7+ ♔xg7 34 ♕h7+ ♔f6 35 ♕f5+ ♔g7 36 ♗xe5+ ♔g8 37 ♗xd6 ♕xe3+ 38 ♔f1 ♗xd6 39 ♕g6+.

33 ♔f2 g6 34 ♕xg6 ♖xd6 35 ♗xd6 ♘h4 36 ♗e5+

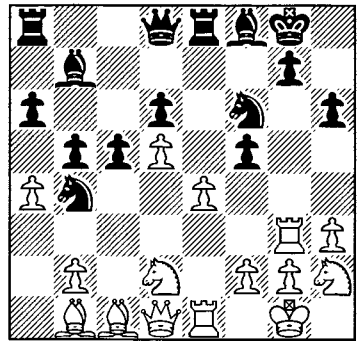
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Game 47

A.Grischuk-E.Bacrot

Enghien-les-Bains 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘g5 ♖f8 12 ♘f3 ♖e8 13 ♘bd2 ♗f8 14 a4 h6 15 ♗c2 exd4 16 cxd4 ♘b4 17 ♗b1 c5 18 d5 ♘d7 19 ♖a3 f5 20 ♘h2 ♘f6 21 ♖g3



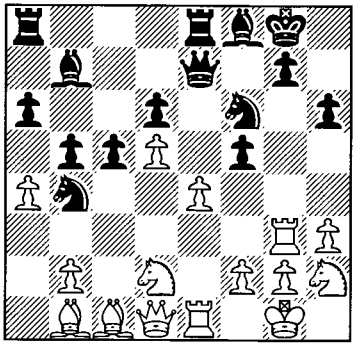
Alternatives are covered in Game 48, but remember to look at White's 19th move there!

21...♕e7

Bacrot's move was considered to be strong novelty when it was played in 2001, but 21...♕d7 seems a playable alternative, Beliavsky even goes as far as giving it an exclamation mark.

22 b3 fxe4 (the 22...♕f7 23 ♗b2 ♖ad8, of V.Bashkov-Z.Szymczak, Karvina 1992, is probably not bad either) 23 ♘xe4 ♘bxd5 24 ♘g4 (if 24 ♗xh6, Black can simplify as follows: 24...♘xe4 25 ♗xe4 ♖xe4 26 ♖xe4 ♘c3 27 ♖xc3 ♗xe4 with an acceptable game) 24...♘xg4 25 hxg4 ♘f6 26 ♘xf6+ gxf6 27 ♗g6 ♖xe1+ 28 ♕xe1 ♗d5 with chances for both sides, M.Pavlovic-S.Gligoric, Yugoslav Championship 1999.

Here the move 21...♔h8 transposes to Game 46, notes to White's 19th move, variation 'c'.



22 ♖f3

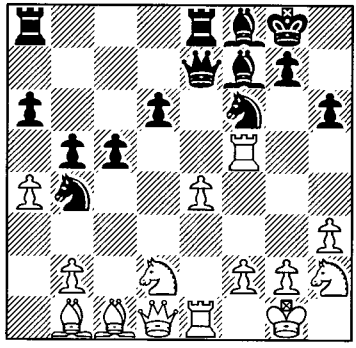
Alternatives perhaps need a closer look to see if White can find anything better:

a) 22 ♖ge3 ♕d7 (the queen sidesteps back to d7 now that the rook has been coerced to a less active square, compare with the previous note) 23 axb5 axb5 24 exf5 ♘bxd5 25 ♖xe8 ♖xe8 26 ♘e4 ♘xe4 27 ♗xe4 ♘e3 28 ♖xe3 ♖xe4, and Black isn't in any danger after so many exchanges and with the bishop pair he might even claim an edge.

b) 22 ♘hf3 fxe4?! (Vescovi and Ch.Toth suggest 22...♕f7! as a possible improvement) 23 ♘xe4 ♗xd5 24 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 25 ♗d2 ♗f7 26 ♗c3, gave White a strong attack in the game V.Topalov-Gio.Vescovi, Moscow 2001.

c) 22 e5 f4 (I prefer 22...dxe5 23 ♗xf5 ♘bxd5 24 ♘df3 e4 25 ♗xh6 ♕c7 26 ♘h4 e3) 23 ♖g6 dxe5 24 ♘g4 ♘xg4 25 ♕xg4 ♗c8 (Dovzik considers 25...♘xd5 to be superior, but still prefers White after 26 ♖xh6 ♘f6 27 ♕g6 e4 28 ♖h4) 26 ♕h5 ♘xd5 27 ♘f3 ♘f6 28 ♕xh6 e4, J.Dovzik-P.Palecek, Slovenia 2001, and now 29 ♖xe4! (crunch!) 29...♘xe4 30 ♗xe4, with a winning attack as ♘g5 is coming.

22...♗xd5 23 ♖xf5 ♗f7



24 ♘df3?

Either an oversight or a result of excessive optimism. Grischuk loses/sacrifices the exchange and is unable to justify it against Bacrot's cool defensive technique.

Bringing the rook back from danger with 24 ♖f3! was recommended by various commentators after the game. This was tested in Ye Jiangchuan-Gio.Vescovi but many unanswered questions remain:

a) 24...♘c6 25 ♖fe3 g6 (25...♘d4 is given by Beliavsky as... well, what else? ...unclear!) 26 e5!? (speculative, whereas the safer 26 ♘hf3 comes into consideration) 26...dxe5 27 ♖g3 ♔h7 28 ♘e4, Ye Jiangchuan-Gio.Vescovi, Hyderabad 2002, and now Vescovi recommends 28...♘d4 when if we go further 29 ♗g5!? ♗g7 30 ♘xf6+ ♗xf6 31 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 32 ♘g4 ♕g7 33 ♖ge3 ♖ad8

looks fairly balanced.

b) The Hungarian analysts, Lukacs and Hazai, have investigated 24...d5 25 e5 d4 (after 25...♘d7 26 e6 ♗xe6 27 ♗g6 d4 28 ♗xe8 ♖xe8 29 axb5 axb5 30 ♖a3, White may be slight favourite) 26 ♗f5 ♔h8 27 e6 ♗g8 28 ♘e4 ♘xe4 29 ♖xe4 ♖ad8 30 ♘g4, but are unable to give a clear assessment.

24...♗e6 25 g4

Equally 25 ♘h4 ♗xf5 26 ♘xf5 ♕e6 is also inadequate for White.

25...♗xf5 26 gxf5 ♕b7 27 ♘g4 ♘xe4

Bacrot is not afraid of White's next.

28 ♗xh6 ♘f6

Also good but rather messy is 28...gxh6 29 ♗xe4 d5. The text is simpler.

29 ♗e3 ♘xg4 30 hxg4 ♕d5 31 ♘d2 c4 32 g5 ♘d3

Cutting the bishop on b1 out of any possible attack.

33 ♗xd3 cxd3 34 ♕g4

34 ♕h5 now fails to 34...♕xf5.

34...♖e5 35 f6 ♕e6 36 ♕g3 d5 37 ♖c1 ♗d6 38 ♖c6 d4

Possibly 38...♕d7 is a more straightforward way to win.

39 f7+

If 39 ♗f4, then simply 39...♖e1+ 40 ♔g2 ♕d5+.

39...♕xf7 40 ♖xd6 dxe3 41 ♕xe5 ♖e8 42 ♕xe3

What else? Both 42 ♕d5 ♕xd5 43 ♖xd5 exd2 44 ♖xd3 ♖e1+ 45 ♔g2 d1♕, and 42 ♕c3 ♕xf2+ 43 ♔h1 exd2, are immediately resignable.

42...♖xe3 43 fxe3 ♕f5 44 g6 ♕g4+ 45 ♔f2 ♕e2+ 46 ♔g3 ♔f8 47 ♘f3 ♕xe3 48 axb5 axb5 49 b4 ♔e7 50 ♖d5 ♔e6 51 ♖d8 ♔f5 52 ♔g2 ♔xg6 53 ♖xd3 ♕e2+

Certainly not 53...♕xd3? 54 ♘e5+.

54 ♔g1 ♔h6 55 ♖d6+ g6 56 ♖f6

White loses more slowly after the alternative 56 ♘h2 ♕e1+ 57 ♘f1 ♕xb4, but just as surely.

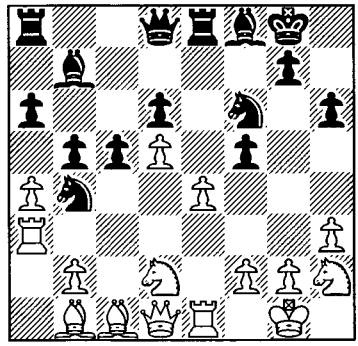
56...♔g7 0-1

Game 48

A.Morozevich-A.Grischuk

Dubai 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♖e8 10 d4 ♗b7 11 a4 h6 12 ♘bd2 ♗f8 13 ♗c2 exd4 14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗b1 c5 16 d5 ♘d7 17 ♖a3 f5 18 ♘h2 ♘f6



19 ♖f3

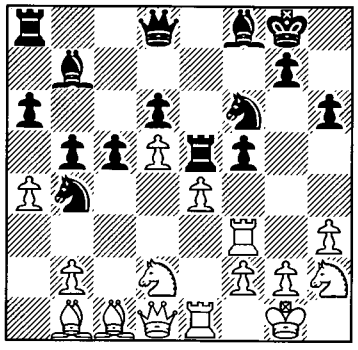
For 19 ♖g3 see Game 47, whereas White's alternatives below seek to resolve the tension concerning Black's e-pawn:

a) If 19 exf5, Black has 19...♖xe1+ 20 ♕xe1 ♕e7! (also possible is 20...♗xd5 21 ♘g4 ♗e7, [recommended by Lukacs and Hazai] and then following 22 ♘e4 ♘xg4 23 hxg4, M.Pavlovic-L.Hazai, Vrnjacka Banja 1988, Black can think about 23...bxa4!) 21 ♕f1 (if 21 ♕e6+, then 21...♔h8!, and the d-pawn will drop) 21...♖e8 22 axb5 ♕e1 23 ♘g4 ♘xg4 24 hxg4 axb5, and the position already favours Black, E.Vasiukov-Y.Razuvaev, Moscow 1987.

b) 19 g4!? (forces Black to make a decision about his f-pawn) 19...fxe4 20 g5 (softens up Black's kingside structure) 20...hxg5 21 ♘xe4 ♘bxd5! (generally accepted as an improvement on 21...♗xd5 22 ♗xg5 ♗xe4 of T.Luther-I.Stohl, Bundesliga 1996, and now Stohl suggests 23 ♖xe4!, e.g. 23...♖xe4 24

♗xe4 d5 25 ♗xf6 gxf6 26 ♗f5, when the white attack will surely be worth more than a pawn) 22 ♗xg5 ♕d7 23 ♗xf6 (otherwise 23 ♖g3 ♘xe4 24 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 25 ♗xe4 ♘c3! [exchanging off one of the attacking pieces] 26 bxc3 ♗xe4 27 ♘g4 ♕f5 28 ♗e7 ♔h8 29 ♕xd6, and despite all White's fury, after the cool 29...♗b7, Black seems to be better, D.Salinnikov-A.Sulypa, Alushta 2000) 23...♘xf6 24 ♘xf6+ gxf6, and now rather than 25 ♘g4?! ♗g7 26 ♖g3 ♖xe1+ 27 ♕xe1 ♔f8 28 ♗g6 f5, when Black was better in P.Leko-Z.Almasi, Dortmund 1988, White should try Almasi's suggestion of 25 ♖g3+, as 25...♗g7 26 ♗g6 ♖xe1+ 27 ♕xe1 ♔f8 leads to an unclear game.

19...♖e5

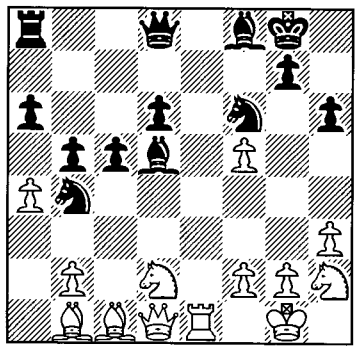


20 ♖xf5

Although 20 b3 is playable, when 20...fxe4 21 ♖xf6 (or 21 ♘xe4 ♘xe4 22 ♖xe4 ♗xd5 23 ♖xe5 ♗xf3 24 ♕xf3 dxe5 25 ♘g4, with compensation according to Khalifman) 21...♕xf6 22 ♘g4 ♕f7 23 ♘xe5 dxe5 24 ♘xe4 ♗xd5 25 ♕g4, V.Dimitrov-A.Brito Garcia, Las Palmas 1993 is complex, a question needs to be asked: why does White want his pawn on such an exposed square as b3? Is the bishop really effective on b2 (it's usually happy bearing down on g5 and h6)?

This line has been abandoned, so it seems clear that the leading players don't seem keen to spend a tempo to put their bishop on the long diagonal.

20...♖xf5 21 exf5 ♗xd5



22 ♘g4

This seems best. After 22 ♘e4?! ♗xe4 23 ♗xe4 d5 24 ♗f3 (24 ♗b1 d4 25 ♘g4 d3 favours Black) 24...c4 25 ♖e6 ♘d3 26 ♗e3, as in A.Khalifman-A.Karpov, Reggio Emilia 1991/2, there is some disagreement over what is best. Karpov played 26...d4 ('!' according to Khalifman), Beliavsky prefers 26...♘xb2, and after the modest 26...♔h8 27 ♗d4 ♘f4 28 ♖b6 ♕c7 29 ♘g4 ♗e7, Black was able to hold in T.Luther-M.Solleveld, Cappelle-la-Grande 2002. In Khalifman-Karpov after the further moves 26...d4 27 ♗xh6 ♘xb2 28 ♕c2 ♘xa4 29 ♗g5 d3 30 ♕d2, Black wasn't worse if he'd continued with 30...c3.

22...♗f7

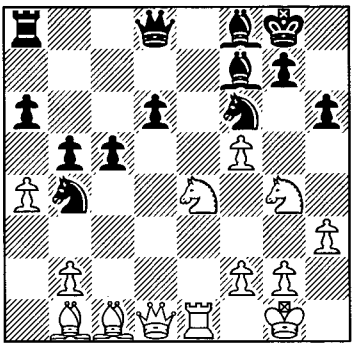
If the main line proves to be better for White then Black needs to find an improvement somewhere. Here could be a good time.

Almasi has suggested 22...bxa4!? and Beliavsky has had a chance to introduce the original 22...♖a7!?, whereupon 23 ♘e4 ♗xe4 24 ♗xe4 ♘xg4 25 ♕xg4 d5 26 ♗b1, A.Morozevich-A.Beliavsky, Hyderabad 2002, if followed up with 26...♕f6 27 ♖e6 ♕d4, would give Black good counterplay according to Beliavsky.

23 ♘e4

The most precise. Instead, note that 23 ♘xf6+ doesn't necessary transpose, as after

23...♕xf6 24 ♘e4 Black can try 24...♕xf5!?.



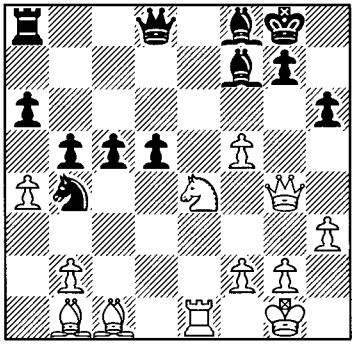
23...♘xg4

As Almasi points out, 23...♘xe4 24 ♗xe4 d5 25 ♗b1 leaves Black with a weakened e5-square that could be of use for the white knight

24 ♕xg4

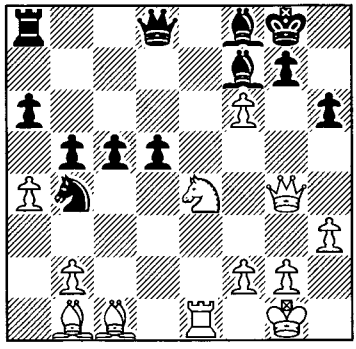
The alternative 24 hxg4 has been ignored by everyone since a fascinating correspondence game ended in a fighting draw: 24...d5 25 ♘c3 d4 26 ♘e4 d3 27 g5 hxg5 28 ♗xg5 ♕d4 29 ♗d2 c4 30 ♗c3 ♕b6 31 ♘f6+ gxf6 32 ♕g4+ ♗g7 33 ♖e3 ♘d5 34 ♖g3 ♔f8 35 ♕xg7+ ♔e7 36 ♖e3+ ♘xe3 37 ♗b4+ ♔d8 38 ♕f8+ ♗e8 39 ♕e7+ ♔c8 40 ♕xe8+ ♔b7 41 ♕e7+ ♕c7 42 ♕e4+ ♕c6 43 ♕e7+, Lecroq-Franzen, corr 1994/5.

24...d5



25 f6!

This is the move that is causing Black problems at the moment. Others don't seem to be a problem, for instance 25 ♘g3 ♕f6 26 ♘h5 ♕d4 27 ♕xd4 cxd4 28 ♘f4 bxa4, R.Cleto-F.Cerqueira, corr 2000 and 25 ♖d1 ♕c8 26 ♘f6+ ♔h8 27 ♘h5 d4 28 ♘f4 ♘d5 29 ♘e6 ♘f6, S.Neuschmied-P.Marczell, corr 1996.



25...dxe4

There are a couple of other tries, but they don't seem to offer anything better for Black:

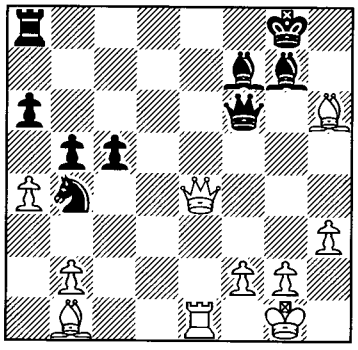
a) 25...g6?! 26 ♘g5! hxg5 27 ♕xg5 ♗h6 28 ♕xh6 ♕xf6 29 ♗g5 ♕g7 30 ♕h4 left Black too weak around his king in Massetti-A.Petrillo, corr 2000/02.

b) 25...h5 26 ♕f5 ♕c8 27 ♕g5! (an improvement on 27 ♕xc8 ♖xc8 28 fxg7 ♗xg7 29 ♘d6 ♖d8 30 ♘b7 ♖c8, which was only equal in P.Leko-Z.Almasi, Monaco blindfold 2002) 27...dxe4 (Nijboer analyses 27...♕e6 as yielding an edge to White after the following long variation: 28 fxg7 ♗xg7 29 ♖e3 dxe4 30 ♗xe4 ♖e8 31 ♖g3 ♕e5 32 ♕xe5 ♖xe5 33 ♗h6 ♖xe4 34 ♖xg7+ ♔h8 35 ♖xf7) 28 fxg7 ♗xg7 29 ♗xe4 ♘c6 30 ♗f4 bxa4 (Nijboer points out that Black must play 30...♘d4! 31 ♗xa8! ♕xa8, when the attack is staved off, but Black's exposed king and fairly balanced material should mean White retains an edge) 31 ♖e3 ♘d4 32 ♗e5 ♘e6 33 ♕f5 ♘f8 34 ♖g3 ♗g6 35 ♖xg6 ♘xg6 36 ♕xg6 ♖a7 37 ♗d5+, 1-0 F.Nijboer-M.Solleveld, Amsterdam 2002.

26 fxg7 ♗xg7 27 ♗xh6 ♕f6

Otherwise 27...♕d4 is inadequate because of 28 ♖xe4 ♕xb2 29 ♗xg7 ♕xg7 30 ♕h4 ♖e8 31 ♖g4.

28 ♕xe4



28...♘d5

Black has alternatives here, but it's hard to generate much enthusiasm about any of them:

a) 28...♖d8? loses to 29 ♕h7+ ♔f8 30 ♕h8+ ♗g8 31 ♗h7, as mentioned by Almasi.

a) 28...♗d5 29 ♕h7+ ♔f8 30 ♗xg7+ ♕xg7 31 ♕f5+ ♕f7 32 ♕e5 ♕g7 33 ♕d6+ ♔g8 34 ♗e4 and White was winning in A.Giuliani-V.Maffei, corr 2000/02.

b) 28...♗xh6 29 ♕xa8+ ♔g7 30 ♖e4 ♗f4 31 g3 ♗g5 32 ♖g4 ♗e6 33 ♕a7+, as given by Massetti, also looks difficult for Black.

29 ♕h7+ ♔f8 30 ♕h8+ ♗g8 31 ♗h7 ♔f7 32 ♗xg7 ♕xg7 33 ♗xg8+ ♕xg8 34 ♕h5+ ♔f8 35 ♖e5

Black's extra piece won't be much consolation if his king is mated. With that in mind Black decides to try his luck in a dubious rook ending.

35...♕xg2+ 36 ♔xg2 ♘f4+ 37 ♔f3 ♘xh5 38 ♖xh5 ♔g7

Another problem is that 38...♖c8?? loses to 39 ♖h8+.

39 axb5 c4! 40 ♔e3 ♔g6 41 ♖c5 axb5 42 ♖xb5 ♖d8

If Black can exchange off the queenside then we would reach the notorious ending of Rook plus 'f' and 'h' pawns against rook. It's drawn in theory, but in practice...

43 ♖b4 ♖d3+ 44 ♔e2 ♖xh3 45 ♖xc4 ♖b3 46 ♖c2

Two extra pawns should be enough, but Black has drawing chances as he is so active. Another factor is that this is a rapid game, and naturally time shortage doesn't engender precise technique.

46...♔f5 47 ♔d1 ♔e4 48 ♖d2?!

The right way is 48 ♔c1! (intending ♖c3) 48...♔d4 (or 48...♖f3 49 ♖e2+ ♔d3 50 ♖e3+) 49 ♔b1 ♖b8 (if here 49...♖f3 then 50 ♔a2) 50 ♖c3, with considerably better winning chances than in the game.

48...♖b8 49 ♔c2 ♖c8+

Black has sufficient distance between the white king and the rook to render progress problematic.

50 ♔b1 ♖b8 51 ♖c2 ♔f3 52 ♔a2 ♖a8+ 53 ♔b3 ♖b8+ 54 ♔a4 ♖a8+ 55 ♔b5 ♖b8+ 56 ♔a6 ♔e4 57 ♔a5 ♔d3 58 ♖c3+ ♔d4 59 ♖c2 ♔d3 60 ♖c3+ ♔d4 ½-½

Summary

The Zaitsev is such a jungle of wild variations and as there is so much scope for new ideas, any conclusions should be taken as provisional.

If White wishes to avoid having to learn vast and ever-evolving theory then 12 d5 is a safe line with some bite. As for the main lines with 13...exd4, then 15...♕d7 in Game 44 is a sideline worthy of a closer look. Critical is 19 ♖f3 in Game 48, but although White looks on top in the principal variation, Black has respectable-looking alternatives up to move 22.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4

10 d3 – *Game 38 notes*

10...♖e8

Others – *Game 38 notes*

11 ♘bd2

11 ♗g5 – *Game 43 notes*; 11 ♘g5 ♖f8 12 f4 – *Game 38 notes*; 11 a4 – *Game 43 notes*

11...♗f8 12 a4

12 a3 – *Game 39*

12 d5

12...♘b8 – *Game 40*; 12...♘e7 – *Game 41*; 12...♘a5 – *Game 41 notes*

12...h6

12...♕d7 – *Game 38*; Others – *Game 38 notes*

13 ♗c2

13 d5 – *Game 42*

13...exd4

13...♕d7 – *Game 43*; Others – *Game 43* notes

14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗b1 c5

15...bxa4 – *Game 44 notes*; 15...g6 – *Game 44 notes*; 15...♕d7 – *Game 44*

16 d5

16 b3 – *Game 45 notes*

16...♘d7 17 ♖a3

17 ♘f1 – *Game 45 notes*

17...f5

17...c4 – *Game 45*

18 ♘h2

Others – *Game 46 notes*

18...♘f6

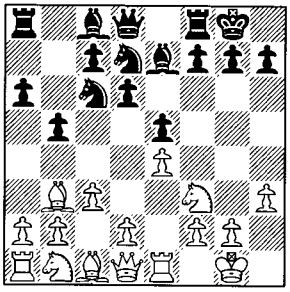
18...♔h8 – *Game 46*; 18...c4 – *Game 46 notes*

19 ♖f3 – *Game 48*

Others – *Game 48 notes*; 19 ♖g3 *Game 47*

CHAPTER SIX

The Karpov Variation



1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘d7

There is hardly a consensus over the choice of name for the 9...♘d7 defence: Suetin (1991) calls it the 'Classical Chigorin', Lane (1991) calls it the 'Keres System'. Anic in 2003 calls it the 'Ragozin-Petrosian (Keres Line)'!

I've rejected all of these. The first two can be confused with other lines, and Anic's is too much of a mouthful. I've decided to stick with Anatoly Bikhovsky who in 1993 named it after Karpov, because the former World Champion re-popularised the system after employing it on several occasions at world championship level.

Whatever the name, the strategy stays the same. The retreat 9...♘d7 over-protects the e5-point, but is not only a defensive move. By following up with ...♗f6, Black bears down on the d4-square. White will soon have to make a decision about the d-pawn, and in the typical case of d4-d5, the e7-square is freed for a further knight retreat.

The Karpov System is characterised by a certain flexibility of purpose. A variation with chameleon-like qualities. At times Black sharpens the struggle with ...exd4 and ...c5 (Game 50), but more often than not he will be faced with an early d4-d5 by White. Svidler in Game 53 reacted to the closed centre with a timely ...c7-c6, whereas in Game 55 he organised his pieces for...f7-f5.

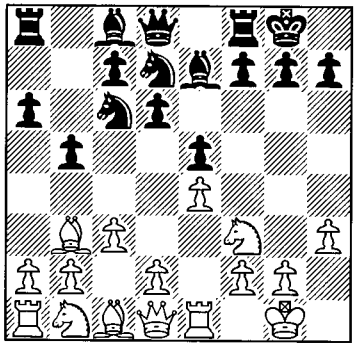
White often plays an early a2-a4 with ideas of opening the a-file and putting pressure on the b5-pawn. In Game 48, Black plays 10...♘b6 to dissuade White from that approach.

Game 49

P.Leko-L.Fressinet

Cannes 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘d7



10 d4

When White employs the restrained d2-d3 in the Spanish Black usually has a wide choice of plans. Here there is no reason for Black not to then play in 'Chigorin-style' with 10 d3 ♘a5 11 ♗c2 c5, for instance 12 ♘bd2 ♘c6 13 ♘f1 ♖e8 14 ♘g3 ♘b6 15 d4 cxd4 16 cxd4 exd4 17 b3 d3 18 ♗xd3 ♗f6, E.Lobron-V.Hort, Thessaloniki Olympiad 1984, or 13 a4 ♘b6 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♖xa8 ♘xa8 16 ♘f1 ♗f6 17 ♘e3 ♘b6, Z.Almasi-Peng Xiaomin, Las Vegas rapid 1999, and in both cases, Black can look forward to the middlegame with confidence.

10...♘b6

Less common than 10...♗f6 which is featured in Games 50-55.

11 ♘bd2

White's most interesting alternative is 11 a4, when Black should react with 11...bxa4 12 ♗xa4 ♘xa4. In this way Black obtains the bishop pair but has an isolated a-pawn: 13 ♖xa4 (or 13 ♕xa4 ♗d7 14 ♕c4 ♕c8 15 ♘bd2 ♕b7 16 ♘f1 exd4 17 cxd4 ♘b4 18 ♘e3 c5 with counterplay, L.Aronin-V.Antoshin, USSR Championship 1957) 13...exd4 (opening the position for the bishops seems logical and is preferable to 13...♗f6?! 14 d5 ♘e7 15 c4 ♘g6 16 ♘c3 ♖e8 17 ♗e3, when White had a small edge in H.Sameeh-W.Sarwat, Egyptian Championship 2003) 14 cxd4 d5 15 exd5 ♘b4 16 ♘c3 ♗b7 17 ♕e2 ♗d6 18 ♗g5 ♕d7 19 ♘e5 ♕f5, K.Klundt-H.Hecht, Völklingen 1970, and Black was fine.

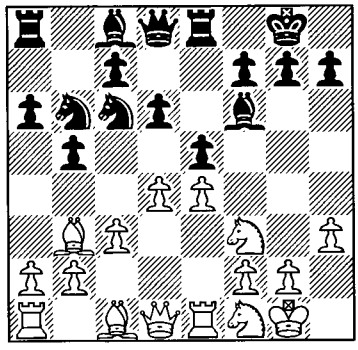
11...♗f6

The Svidler-Adams game in 'b' below seems to have put Black defenders off the previously popular 11...exd4. Then after the natural reply 12 cxd4, Black has a choice:

a) 12...d5 is considered a little shaky: 13 exd5 ♘xd5 14 ♘e4 ♘a5 (a better try than 14...♗f5?! 15 ♗d2 ♘db4 16 ♖c1 ♘a5 17 ♘c5, when in V.Jansa-M.Milicevic, Kragujevac 1984 Black had problems) 15 ♗c2 ♗b7, with an edge to White according to *ECO*. He has attacking chances and access to the c5-square.

b) 12...♘b4 13 ♘f1 c5 14 a3 ♘c6 15 ♗e3 (15 d5 ♘e5 16 ♘xe5 dxe5 17 ♗e3, A.Shirov-Je.Piket, Linares 1997, is not so clear after Piket's suggestion of 17...c4 18 ♗c2 a5) 15...♘a5 (otherwise 15...c4 16 ♗c2 d5 17 ♘e5 ♕c7 18 ♘g3 ♗d6 19 ♘xc6 ♗xg3 20 fxg3 ♕xc6 21 e5 f5 22 ♖f1 gave White attacking chances with his bishops in V.Bologan-R.Slobodjan, Calcutta 1999) 16 ♗c2 ♘bc4 17 ♗c1 cxd4 18 ♘xd4 ♗f6 19 ♖b1 (White is ready to push the knight away and then consolidate, so Black aims for complications that however prove to be insufficient) 19...d5 20 b3 dxe4 21 ♗xe4 ♗xd4 (Svidler proposes instead 21...♖b8 22 bxc4 ♕xd4 23 ♗f4 ♕xd1 24 ♖bxd1 ♖b6 25 ♗c7 ♘xc4 26 ♗xb6 ♘xb6, with some compensation for the exchange) 22 bxc4 (if 22 ♗xa8 ♗f5 23 bxc4 ♗xb1 24 ♗d5, White can also claim an edge) 22...♖b8 23 ♗f4 ♖b6 24 cxb5 ♖xb5, P.Svidler-M.Adams, Linares 1999, and now 25 ♖b4! gives White a clear advantage as Black's pieces find themselves on tactically suspect squares.

12 ♘f1 ♖e8



13 ♗c2

There are two principal alternatives:

a) 13 ♘g3 g6 14 ♗h6 ♘a5 (in G.Sax-M.Tal, Skelleftea 1989, Black tried 14...a5!? [but then Black has to be careful about his b-pawn becoming weak] 15 ♗c2 ♗d7 16 d5

♘e7 17 ♕e2 ♗g7 (the exchange of these bishops is potentially dangerous for the dark-squares) 18 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 19 ♗d3 f5! (counterplay!) 20 exf5 ♘exd5 21 fxg6 ♘f4 22 ♕e4 hxg6 23 ♘h5+ (the attack!) 23...gxh5 24 ♕h7+ ♔f6 25 ♘g5 ♖g8 26 ♕h6+ ♔e7 27 ♕h7+ ♔f6 28 ♕h6+ ♔e7 29 ♕h7+, an exciting draw) 15 ♗c2 c5 16 d5 ♗d7 17 ♕c1 ♗g7 18 h4 ♕e7 19 b3 ♘b7 20 h5 a5 21 a4 c4 22 axb5 cxb3, M.Chandler-B.Spassky, Bundesliga 1988 and a draw was agreed at this point.

b) 13 ♘1h2 is perhaps more testing: 13...exd4 14 cxd4 ♘a5 15 ♗c2 c5 16 b3 (White achieved nothing with 16 ♘g4 ♗xg4 17 hxg4 cxd4 18 g5 ♗e5 19 ♘xd4 g6 20 ♘f3 ♗g7, V.Topalov-L.Fressinet, Cannes 2002) 16...♘c6 17 ♗b2, and now Black has yet to show a route to equality:

b1) 17...♖a7 18 e5 dxe5 19 dxc5 ♘d5 20 ♘g4, Pe.Popovic-V.Salov, Manila Interzonal 1990, and White went on to win.

b2) 17...cxd4 18 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 19 ♗xd4 ♘d7 20 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 21 ♕d4 with a pleasant edge, A.Antunes-B.Ivkov, Seville 1989.

b3) 17...♗e6 18 ♕d2 ♖c8 19 ♖ad1 cxd4 20 ♗b1 and White retains a small edge, O.Romanishin-E.Scholl, Amsterdam 1973.

I suspect that Laurent Fressinet would have had something prepared in this line, so there could easily be an improvement hidden in there somewhere.

13...♗d7

A new move but on the evidence of the present game Black would do better to follow L.Ljubojevic-B.Spassky, Linares 1990 which continued 13...exd4 14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗b1 c5 16 ♘g3 cxd4 17 ♘xd4 ♘c4 18 a3 ♕b6! with plenty of activity to compensate for the isolated d-pawn.

14 ♘e3 g6

It's already a little late for 14...exd4, as compared to the previous note, the inclusion of ...♗d7 for Black and ♘e3 for White, favours the first player. Leko then analyses 15 cxd4 ♘b4 16 ♗b1 c5 17 e5 dxe5 18 dxc5 ♘a4 19 a3 ♘c6 20 ♘d5, with attacking chances.

15 d5 ♘a5 16 ♘g4 ♗g7 17 ♘h6+ ♔f8 18 b3 ♘b7

Leko intended to meet 18...c6 with 19 ♕d2!.

19 h4!

Leko claims a clear advantage, as he has a strong attack against Black's king. Black's knights are not participating in the defence.

19...c6 20 ♕d2 f6

Black gets into hot water after 20...cxd5 21 ♘g5!.

21 h5 g5 22 dxc6 ♗xc6 23 ♘f5 ♔g8 24 ♗a3 ♗f8

Holding on grimly. The knight on f5 bears down on the d6-weakness and Black's kingside.

25 ♖ad1 ♗d7 26 ♘e3

A wise retreat as Black still has to contend with his holes. Note that 26 ♘xd6 is premature as Black obtains counterplay after 26...♘xd6 27 ♗xd6 ♗g4!.

26...♗e6 27 ♘h2 ♕c7 28 ♘hg4 ♕f7 29 ♕e2 ♖ac8 30 ♕f3 ♘d7 31 ♘d5

White's domination forces Black onto the back foot. Fressinet therefore hopes that provoking the opening of the game will give him more freedom.

31...♔h8!? 32 ♘gxf6 g4 33 ♘xg4 ♕xh5 34 ♘h2 ♕xf3 35 ♘xf3 ♗xd5 36 exd5 ♖xc3

Restoring material equality, but White still retains the initiative.

37 ♗f5 ♘f6 38 ♘g5 a5 39 ♗b2 ♖c5 40 f4

In time trouble, Leko misses a beautiful combination 40 ♘e6! ♖xd5 41 ♖xd5 ♘xd5 42 ♘xf8 ♘e7 (42...♖xf8 allows the fatal skewer 43 ♗e4) 43 ♗e6! ♖xf8 44 ♖xe5!, and the long diagonal is opened with decisive effect.

40...♘xd5 41 ♗d4

Simpler perhaps was 41 fxe5 ♘c3 42 ♗xc3 ♖xc3 43 e6 as Leko pointed out in *Informator 84*.

41...♘c3 42 ♗xc5 ♘xc5

Finally the knights get some activity, but only at the cost of the exchange (as otherwise 42...♘xd1 is met by 43 ♗d4, trapping the wayward steed).

43 ♖d2 e4

Black's last hope is that the e-pawn can create some havoc, but Leko is able to keep control.

44 ♘f7+ ♔g7 45 ♘xd6 ♗xd6 46 ♖xd6 ♘xa2 47 ♖d5 ♘xb3 48 ♖xb5 a4 49 ♖b7+ ♔f6 50 ♗xh7 ♘c3 51 g4 ♘d4 52 ♔f2 e3+ 53 ♔g2 e2 54 ♖d7 1-0

54...♘b3 55 ♖h1 e1♘+ (otherwise 55...♖e7 56 g5+ ♔e6 57 ♗f5+ ♔xf5 58 ♖xe7 etc.) 56 ♔f1 would have made an amusing final position!

Game 50

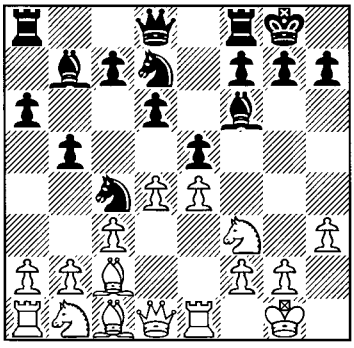
A.Morozevich-R.Ponomariov

Moscow 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘d7 10 d4 ♗f6 11 ♗e3 ♘a5

Taking the opportunity to boot both of White's bishops back. This gain of time is only temporary, as the knight will in turn be forced to retreat after b2-b3, but then Black hopes for play on the a1-h8 diagonal and against some generally loosened squares.

12 ♗c2 ♘c4 13 ♗c1 ♗b7



14 a4

Notable was the continuation of V.Anand-P.Svidler, Haifa rapid 2000: 14 b3 ♘cb6 15 ♗e3 ♖e8 16 d5 ♗e7! (defending the d6-point to prepare ...c6) 17 ♘bd2 c6 18 c4 cxd5 19 cxd5 f5! (now we can see that 16...♗e7 also releases the f-pawn) 20 exf5 ♘xd5, and by dissolving the centre Black obtained good counter-chances.

14...exd4

Another way of opening the centre starts with 14...d5, a move originally introduced by Karpov:

a) 15 exd5 ♗xd5 16 b3 ♗xf3 17 ♕xf3 ♘d6 18 ♕d3 g6 19 axb5 axb5 20 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 (E.Schmittdiel-P.Wells, Bundesliga 1998) and White couldn't find anything to give him a pull.

b) 15 axb5 dxe4 (invoking colourful complications; the straightforward 15...axb5 is more solid) 16 bxa6 exf3 17 ♕d3 g6 18 ♕xc4 exd4 19 ♗h6, A.Khalifman-P.Wells, London 1991. Khalifman now proposes 19...♘b6 as Black's best with unclear play.

c) 15 ♘xe5 ♗xe5!? 16 dxe5 dxe4 17 b3 ♘cxe5 18 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 19 ♖xe4 ♘f6 20 ♖d4 ♕e7 with a solid enough game for Black, M.Sion Castro-V.Topalov, Terrassa 1992.

15 cxd4

In practical terms 15 ♘xd4 is not a bad choice: 15...bxa4 16 ♖xa4 ♘cb6 17 ♖a1 ♖e8 18 ♘d2 g6 19 ♘4b3 ♖b8, B.Hatanbaatar-C.Arduman, Bled Olympiad 2002, with a tense position.

15...c5 16 axb5

Instead 16 ♕d3?! g6 17 b3 is dubious, as after 17...cxd4! 18 bxc4 ♘c5 19 ♕a3 d3, D.Velimirovic-M.Trifunovic, Pozarevac 1995, Black is better in the complications.

16...cxd4!?

Not so surprising, as this capture has been known for many years. Black sacrifices a pawn to obtain active piece-play.

The alternative 16...axb5 can also require letting a pawn go:

a) 17 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 18 dxc5 (on 18 b3, Ti-

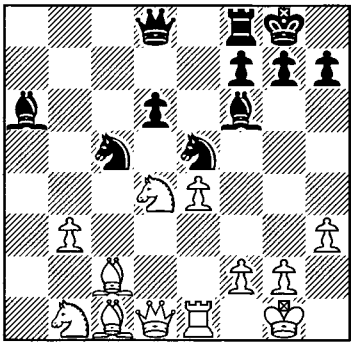
moshenko suggests 18...♘cb6 19 d5 b4 20 ♗f4 ♘e5 as unclear) 18...♘xc5 19 b3 ♘e5 20 ♘xe5 ♗xe5 21 f3 ♘e6 was fine for Black in the game Z.Almasi-G.Timoshenko, Budapest 1991.

b) 17...♗xa8 18 ♕d3 g6 19 b3 ♘a5 20 dxc5 dxc5 21 ♕xb5 ♗c6 22 ♕a6 ♗b7 23 ♕d3 ♘c6 24 ♖d1 ♘d4, M.Mrdja-G.Timoscenko, Padova 1999, with some compensation, but I'm not sure that it's fully worth a pawn.

17 bxa6 ♖xa6 18 ♖xa6 ♗xa6 19 b3

White simplified the pawn structure obtaining the nominal advantage of 4 v 3 on the kingside after 19 ♘xd4 ♕b6 20 ♘f5 ♘xb2 21 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 22 ♘xd6 ♘c5, V.Ivanchuk-A.Karpov, Reggio Emilia 1989/90, but Black was active enough to hold.

19...♘ce5 20 ♘xd4 ♘c5



21 ♗e3

Not the only move here:

a) Perhaps White could consider 21 ♘f5!? ♘cd3 22 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 23 ♖e3 ♘xc1 (23...♗g5? loses material to 24 ♖xd3 ♗xd3 25 ♗xg5 ♕xg5 26 ♕xd3) 24 ♕xc1 d5 (if 24...♗g5, there is 25 ♕b2) 25 exd5 ♗c8 26 ♘g3 ♕xd5 27 ♕d2, and again he stays a pawn up, but facing those bishops could be nerve-racking.

b) 21 ♘f3 is known, e.g. 21...♘ed3 22 ♖e3 ♘xc1 23 ♕xc1 ♕a5 24 ♕d2 ♕xd2 25 ♘bxd2 ♖b8, A.Antunes-J.Van der Wiel, Novi Sad 1990, and Black's active pieces stopped White making any progress.

21...♘ed3 22 ♗xd3 ♘xd3 23 ♖e2 d5 24 e5

Choosing the safe option, but critical is 24 exd5 ♕xd5 25 ♘f3 ♖b8 26 ♖a2, where White retains his extra pawn, and therefore some winning chances. Morozevich must have decided that in such an open position the bishop pair and an imposing knight give Black fair compensation.

24...♗xe5

Black can also consider 24...♘xe5 25 ♖a2 ♕c8.

25 ♘c6 ♗h2+ 26 ♔xh2 ♕d6+ 27 ♔g1 ♕xc6 28 ♖d2 ♕g6 29 ♘c3 ♗b7!?

There's nothing wrong with the natural 29...♖d8.

30 ♕g4

Heading towards a balanced endgame. Too dangerous would be 30 ♖xd3?!, in view of 30...d4 31 g4 ♕c6.

30...♕xg4 31 hxg4 ♘e5 32 f3 ♖d8 33 g5 f6 34 gxf6 gxf6 35 ♘e4 ♔f7 36 ♘c5 ♗c6 37 ♖d4 ♘g6 38 ♖b4 ♘e7 39 ♗f2 ♖a8 40 ♖b6 ♖a1+ 41 ♔h2 ♖a2 42 ♗d4 ♖d2 43 ♗e3 ½-½

Game 51

E.Solozhenkin-R.Kholmov

Russian Ch., Elista 1995

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 c3 d6 9 h3 ♘d7 10 d4 ♗f6 11 a4 ♖b8

Being considered a shade slow, this move is out of favour these days.

12 axb5 axb5 13 ♗e3

The direct 13 d5 didn't lead to any advantage in J.Nunn-A.Karpov, Rotterdam 1989: After 13...♘e7 14 ♗e3 ♘c5 15 ♗c2 c6 16 b4 ♘a6 17 dxc6 ♘xc6 18 ♘a3 ♘c7 19 ♕e2 ♕e8 20 ♖ed1 ♗e7 21 ♗d3 ♘d8, the position was balanced.

A more recent try didn't give White anything either: 14 ♘a3 (instead of 14 ♗e3) 14...b4 15 cxb4 ♖xb4 16 ♗c2 ♘c5 17 ♕d2

♖b3 (a bit cheeky!) 18 ♕d1 ♖b4 19 ♖b1 c6 20 ♗d2 ♖b8 21 dxc6 ♘xc6 22 b4 ♘e6, Z.Hracek-D.Blagojevic, Yugoslav Team Championship 2001 with unclear play.

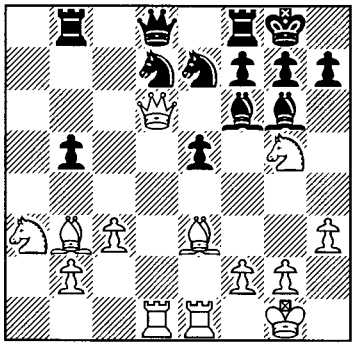
13...♗b7?!

Experience (particularly this present game!) suggests that this natural developing move is an error. Better seems to be 13...♘e7, anticipating the d4-d5 advance and keeping the rook in contact with the b-pawn. Then after 14 ♘bd2 (or 14 d5 ♘c5 15 ♗c2 b4 [otherwise White plays b2-b4] 16 c4 ♘a6 17 ♘bd2 c5 18 dxc6 ♘xc6 19 ♗a4! [finding an active role for the light-squared bishop outside the pawn chain] 19...♘a5 20 ♗b5 ♘c5 21 ♗xc5 dxc5 22 ♕a4 ♖a8 23 ♘b3, P.Svidler-L.Yudasin, St.Petersburg 1997, and White keeps some pressure) 14...♗b7 (Czech GM Pavel Blatny has experimented with 14...c5!? here, but C.Lutz-P.Blatny, Austrian Team Championship 2003 continued 15 ♘f1 g6 16 ♘g3 exd4 17 cxd4 c4 18 ♗c2 d5 19 ♕d2 ♗g7 20 ♗g5 and White was much better) 15 ♗c2 ♖a8 16 ♕e2 c6 17 dxe5 dxe5 18 b4 ♕c7 19 ♘b3 ♘g6 20 ♘a5, Ki.Georgiev-A.Karpov, Reggio Emilia 1989/90, White keeps a small pull.

14 d5 ♘e7 15 ♘a3 c6

The consistent continuation but it proves to be inadequate.

16 dxc6 ♗xc6 17 ♕xd6 ♗xe4 18 ♘g5 ♗g6 19 ♖ad1



19...♘f5

This move is given a question mark by Gliese, but after 19...♖b7, White has 20 ♘e6! fxe6 21 ♗xe6+ ♖f7 22 ♗xd7 ♘d5 23 ♕xd5 ♖bxd7 24 ♕f3 and Black has no real compensation for the pawn. With the game continuation also being unpleasant, it's clear that Black is already in trouble.

20 ♕xd7 ♘xe3 21 ♘xf7!

A nice blow to be able to deliver, but even the alternative 21 ♖xe3 ♗xg5 22 ♖xe5 b4 23 ♕xd8 ♗xd8 24 ♖b5 is promising.

21...♕xd7

It suffices to say that 21...♗xf7 22 ♗xf7+ ♖xf7 23 ♕xd8+ ♗xd8 24 ♖xe3 ♗b6 25 ♖e2 is also pretty grim for Black.

22 ♖xd7 ♗xf7

Neither 22...♘c4? 23 ♘xe5 ♗xe5 24 ♖xe5 ♗f7 25 ♖xb5!, nor 22...♖xf7? 23 ♖xe3 ♔f8 24 ♗xf7 offers any hope.

23 ♖xf7 ♖xf7 24 ♖xe3 b4 25 ♗xf7+ ♔xf7 26 ♘c4 bxc3 27 bxc3 ♖b1+ 28 ♔h2 ♖c1 29 ♘d6+ ♔e6 30 ♘e4

White consolidates his extra pawn and the game enters a technical phase. Although such positions should be won, it's worth noting that strong GMs are not in a rush to finish off their opponent. 'Slow but sure' is the motto, gradually improving one's pieces and restricting the opponent's before going for any pawn breaks or onto the attack.

30...♗e7 31 ♔g3 h5 32 ♔f3 ♖c2 33 ♖e2 ♖c1 34 ♖a2 ♖e1 35 ♖a6+ ♔d5 36 ♖a7 ♔e6 37 c4

The pawn plays the role of a decoy to deviate Black's rook, but also controls the d5-square restricting the opposing king.

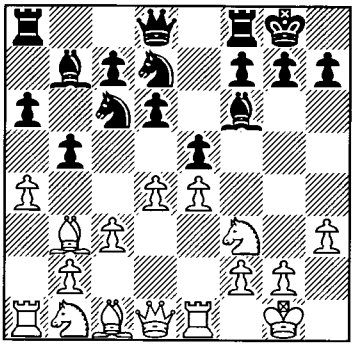
37...g5 38 ♖a6+ ♔f7 39 ♘g3 ♗c5

Free at last, but the kingside pawns are now hopelessly weak.

40 ♘xh5 ♖c1 41 ♖f6+ ♔e7 42 ♖f5 ♔e6 43 ♖f6+ ♔e7 44 ♔g4! ♖xc4+ 45 ♔xg5 ♖c2 46 ♘g3 ♗xf2 47 ♘f5+ ♔d7 48 ♖d6+ ♔c7 49 ♖e6 ♖e2 50 g4 ♗e1 51 h4 e4 52 ♘d4 ♗d2+ 53 ♔h5 ♖e1 54 g5 e3 55 g6 ♖g1 56 ♘f5 ♔d7 57 ♖e7+ ♔d8 58 ♖e4 1-0

Game 52
An.Volokitin-D.Blagojevic
Halkidiki 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘d7 10 d4 ♗f6 11 a4 ♗b7



12 ♘a3

The last chance to close the centre is 12 d5. After 12...♘e7 13 ♘a3 ♘c5 14 ♗c2 c6 15 b4 ♘xa4 16 ♗xa4 bxa4 17 c4 cxd5 18 cxd5 ♖c8 19 ♗e3 ♕d7 20 ♘d2, M.Apicella-G.Miralles, French Teams Championship 1997, Miralles played the dynamic 20...♘xd5!? 21 exd5 ♗xd5 with an interesting struggle ahead.

12...exd4 13 cxd4 ♖e8 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♗f4 ♘a5 16 ♗c2 b4 17 ♘b5 ♘f8!

A meritorious novelty.

Blagojevic seeks to avoid the beaten track: 17...♗c6 18 ♕d3 (instead 18 ♗d3 was unclear after 18...♕b8 19 ♕e2 ♕b6 20 d5 ♗b7 21 ♗e3 ♘c5, A.Toth-D.Belmonte, Rio de Janeiro 1998) 18...b3 (but perhaps not 18...♘f8 19 d5 ♗d7 20 e5, as White had a strong initiative in B.Gelfand-P.Svidler, Biel 2000) 19 ♗b1 ♕b8 20 ♘c3 g6 21 ♖c1 ♘b6, and C.Lutz-S.Smagin, Essen 2001 gave White chances in the centre but Black's b-pawn and knights cramp down on the queenside. It's complex but most players would prefer White.

18 ♕d2

Volokitin mentions Ivanchuk's suggestion 18 e5, and then 18...dxe5 19 dxe5 ♕xd1 20 ♖axd1 ♗d8 21 ♘bd4, claiming an edge because of 21...♘c4 (21...c5?! is met by 22 ♗a4) 22 ♗b3 ♘xb2 23 ♖d2 ♘a4 24 e6 '!', but I can't see any problem for Black after the natural continuation 24...fxe6 25 ♘xe6 ♘xe6 26 ♖xe6 ♖xe6 27 ♗xe6+ ♔f8.

18...♘e6

Black needs to give counterplay a high priority as the b-pawn is very insecure.

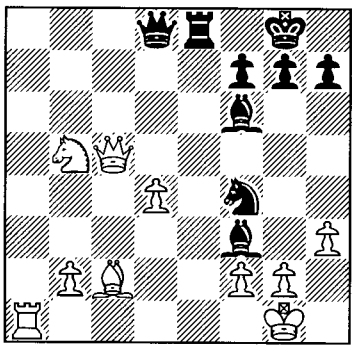
19 ♕xb4 c5 20 ♕d2

Or 20 dxc5 dxc5 21 ♕d2 ♘c4 which is roughly equal.

20...♘c4 21 ♕c3 ♖xa1 22 ♖xa1 ♘xf4

Here 22...d5!? is an interesting move. Volokitin then gives 23 ♗g3 cxd4 24 ♘bxd4 ♘xd4 25 ♘xd4 ♕b6 26 e5 ♘xe5 27 ♕b3 ♕xb3 28 ♗xb3, but after 28...♘d3 Black is certainly OK.

23 ♕xc4 d5 24 exd5 ♗xd5 25 ♕xc5 ♗xf3



26 gxf3

Given a question mark by Volokitin because he rates 26 ♕f5 so highly due to the following attacking variation: 26...♘e2+ 27 ♔h1 ♗c6 28 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 29 ♖a7 ♗xg2+ 30 ♔h2 etc. However 27...♗c6 is a duff move, whereas 27...♗xg2+! 28 ♔xg2 g6 29 ♕f3 ♘xd4 favours Black.

26...♗e5! 27 dxe5! ♕g5+ 28 ♔f1

♕g2+ 29 ♔e1 ♕g1+

If 29...♕xf3?, then White runs to freedom with 30 ♔d2!

30 ♔d2 ♕xa1 31 ♘d6 ♖f8 32 b4 ♘e6 33 ♕e3 ♘d4 34 ♗e4!

A tough struggle follows with both players missing chances.

34...♕b2+ 35 ♔d3 ♘c2 36 ♕c5 ♘xb4+ 37 ♔e3 ♘a6 38 ♕c4 ♕b6+ 39 ♔f4 ♘c7 40 ♔g3 ♘e8 41 ♘c8?

Naturally 41 ♘b5 would have been more sensible but the text plays for a trap.

41...♕d8!

Not falling for 41...♕c7? 42 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 43 ♕h4+ ♔g8 44 ♘e7+.

42 f4 ♘f6 43 ♘d6 ♘xe4+ 44 ♕xe4 ♕e7 45 f5 ♖b8 46 ♕d5 ♔f8?

A blunder that hands the advantage to White. Preferable is 46...♖d8.

47 ♘xf7! ♖e8

47...♕xf7?? loses to 48 ♕d6+.

48 e6 ♔g8 49 ♕d7 ♔f8 50 h4 ♕a3+

Risky, but Black has to do something. Volokitin confidently gives '50...♕xd7 with equality', but the ending after 51 exd7 ♔xf7 52 dxe8♕+ ♔xe8 53 ♔f4 looks distinctly unpleasant for Black.

51 f3 ♕e7 52 ♘g5?!

The right way was 52 ♘e5! ♕f6 53 ♘c6, which is actually zugzwang!

52...h6 53 ♘f7 ♕f6 54 h5 ♖a8 55 ♕d5 ♕a1 56 ♕d6+?

Here 56 ♕c5+ ♔g8 57 ♘d6 ♕e1+ 58 ♔g4 ♖a4+ 59 ♘e4 would give White an advantage according to Romanishin.

56...♔g8 57 ♕d2 ♕g1+ 58 ♕g2 ♕xg2+ 59 ♔xg2 ♖a5 60 f4 ♔f8 61 ♘e5 ♖a3 62 ♘f3

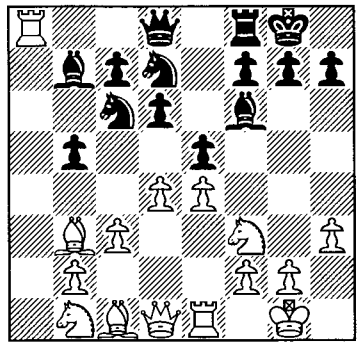
½-½

Game 53

N.De Firmian-P.Svidler

Esbjerg 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘d7 10 a4 ♗b7 11 d4 ♗f6 12 axb5 axb5 13 ♖xa8



So how should Black recapture?

13...♕xa8

Probably the best choice. Nigel Short had some experiences with 13...♗xa8 in the late-eighties, but nowadays it's fallen out of favour. White plays 14 d5 and then:

a) 14...♘a5?!, an experiment that was soon shown to be suspect in M.Panarin-V.Tseshkovsky, Kubanskaja 2002, as after 15 ♗a2 ♘b6 16 ♘a3 c6 17 dxc6 ♗xc6 18 ♕d3 ♘ac4 Black didn't obtain enough compensation for the pawn. However 18...♕d7 (rather than 18...♘ac4) 19 b4 ♘b7?! loses a pawn under even worse circumstances following 20 ♗d5(!).

b) 14...♘e7 15 ♘a3 ♘c5 (if 15...♕b8, then White can play the cheeky 16 ♘xb5! as in S.Kindermann-Z.Sturua, Biel 1991) 16 ♗c2 c6 17 b4 ♘a6 18 dxc6 ♗xc6 19 ♕d3 ♘c7 20 ♖d1 ♕a8 21 ♕xd6, R.Hübner-N.Short, Skelleftea 1989, and Black had problems.

14 d5 ♘a5

The alternative 14...♘e7 is covered in Games 54-55.

15 ♗c2 ♘c4

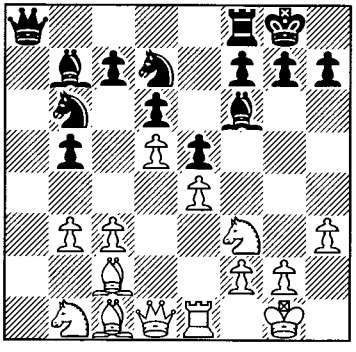
The retreat 15...♗e7!? enables Black to follow up with ...c6 (the b-pawn will soon require support) as the d-pawn is now defended: 16 ♘a3 c6 17 dxc6 ♗xc6 18 ♕e2 ♕a6 (although Black's concerted defence of

the b-pawn gives the appearance of being rather clumsy, the rook will soon help out, enabling an eventual redeployment of his queen) 19 ♘d2 ♖b8 20 b4 ♘b7 21 ♘b3 ♘f6 22 ♗d3 ♘d8 (this knight heads for ...e6) 23 ♘a5 ♗e8 (Polovodin's apparent improvement over the old game M.Tal-L.Stein [from the 1964/5 USSR Championship) where 23...♗d7 was played, although Black didn't seem to have any major problems there either] 24 ♗d2 ♘e6 25 ♖a1, and now rather than 25...g6, A.Galkin-I.Polovodin, St.Petersburg 1998, Galkin's suggestion of 25...♕b6!, followed by the continuation 26 ♘c2 ♕c7 27 c4 bxc4 28 ♗xc4 d5 29 exd5 ♘xd5 30 ♗xd5 ♕xc2 31 ♗xe6 ♖d8!?, justifies the choice of e8 rather than d7 for the bishop!

16 b3

If 16 ♘h2 ♗e7 17 ♘g4, Black has 17...f5! (this active counter-thrust illustrates another point behind the ...♗f6-e7 retreat) 18 exf5 ♗xd5 19 b3 ♘cb6 20 ♘e3 ♗e4 21 ♘d2 ♗xc2 22 ♕xc2 ♘d5, A.Shirov-Je.Piket, Montecatini Terme 2000, and Black had an adequate game.

16...♘cb6



17 ♗a3!?

The text is perhaps more dynamic than 17 ♘a3 ♗a6 18 ♗d3 c6 19 dxc6 ♕xc6, when the bishop will have to defend the c-pawn from the relatively inactive squares b2 or d2.

This point is illustrated by the continuation of a famous encounter: 17 ♘a3 ♗a6 18 ♘h2 c6 19 dxc6 ♕xc6 20 ♗d2 ♗e7 21 ♘g4 ♖a8 22 ♘e3, G.Kasparov-A.Karpov, World Championship (game 6), New York/Lyon 1990 and now Karpov played too passively and ceded the initiative with 22...♘f6?! 23 ♘f5 ♗f8 24 ♗g5 ♘bd7?! 25 c4! and Kasparov sacrificed a pawn for dangerous play. Georgadze instead suggests 22...♗b7 23 ♘f5 ♗f6, with ...d5 in the air. Even later, 24...d5!? (rather than 24...♘bd7) was probably better.

17...♗e7 18 ♕e2 ♗a6 19 ♗d3 c6 20 dxc6 ♕xc6 21 ♗b4 ♘c5 22 ♗c2 ♘bd7 23 ♘a3 ♖b8

With development complete and nothing concrete in view, the players indulge in some manoeuvring. From a theoretical point of view the position is equal.

24 ♘d2 ♘f6 25 ♗b1 ♗d8 26 ♕f3 ♗c8! 27 c4!?

If White just waits then Black would play ...♘a6 'trapping the bishop' so White felt the need to liven things up. However he has to cede the bishop pair anyway.

27...bxc4 28 ♗xc5 ♕xc5 29 ♘axc4 ♗e6

Black's pieces now become the more active.

30 ♖d1 ♕b4 31 ♗d3 ♖a8 32 ♗f1 ♖a2 33 ♕d3 ♗c7 34 ♖b1 g6

Not just giving the king some air, but also preparing a sneaky trap.

35 g3?

An oversight. Instead 35 ♖c1 would keep things tight at the back.

35...d5 36 exd5 ♗f5 37 ♕f3 ♖xd2

A prudent choice as 37...♗xb1 38 ♕xf6!?, with d5-d6 to follow, might give White some swindling chances.

38 ♘xd2 ♕xd2 39 ♖d1 ♕b4 40 ♕e2

40 g4 is met by 40...♘xg4, e.g. 41 hxg4 ♗xg4, or 41 d6 ♗xd6 42 ♖xd6 ♕xd6 43 hxg4 ♗e6, with an extra pawn and the safer king.

40...♕xb3 41 g4 ♗d7 42 d6 ♗b6 43 ♗g2 ♗d4 44 ♔h1 ♗b5 45 ♕f3 ♕xf3

46 ♗xf3 ♘e8

The d-pawn drops and then the three minor pieces will be too strong.

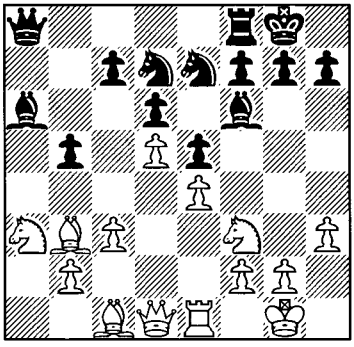
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Game 54

A.Morozevich-N.Short

Hyderabad 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘d7 10 d4 ♗f6 11 a4 ♗b7 12 d5 ♘e7 13 axb5 axb5 14 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 15 ♘a3 ♗a6



16 ♘h2

White has tended to score well in practice with 16 ♗e3, but the theory is less convincing:

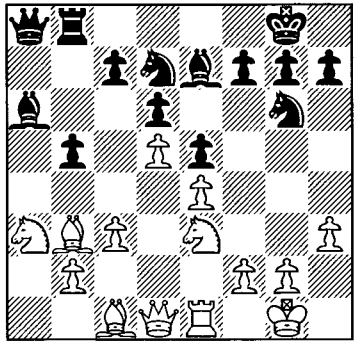
a) Possible is then 16...♖b8, as in A.Savanovic-D.Blagojevic, Herceg Novi rapid 2003, which continued 17 ♘c2 ♘c5 18 ♗xc5!? dxc5 19 ♘e3 c4 20 ♗c2 ♘g6 21 ♘g4 ♖b6 22 h4 ♕e8, whereupon Savanovic claims an edge to White with 23 g3 ♗c8 24 ♘fh2, due to the annoying threat of h4-h5.

b) 16...♘c5 seems adequate: 17 ♗c2 c6 18 b4 (18 ♘xe5!? ♗xe5 19 f4 isn't a problem after 19...♗f6! 20 e5 ♘xd5 21 exf6 ♘xf6 22 ♕xd6 ♘ce4 with equality, rather than 16...♘xd5?! 20 exd5 ♗f6 21 ♗xc5 dxc5 22 d6, when the d-pawn gave White the advantage in T.Wedberg-J.Barkhagen, Örebro 2000) 18...♘d7 19 c4 bxc4 20 ♗a4, P.Svidler-C.Gabriel, Bad Homburg 1998, and now Black has the double-edged possibility 20...cxd5! 21 ♗xd7 d4 when he isn't worse.

16...g6

Another idea is 16...♘g6, avoiding potential weaknesses on the kingside. This was first played by Blagojevic in 1996 and has since become commonplace. A typical example is 17 g3 ♖b8 18 ♗d2 ♗e7 19 h4 ♘c5 20 ♗c2 ♗c8 21 ♕a1 c6, Z.Lanka-P.Svidler, Pula 1997, and Black had more or less equalised.

Recently this has become more popular than the text, e.g. 17 ♘g4 ♗e7 18 ♘e3 ♖b8



a) 19 ♗d2 ♗g5 20 ♗c2 ♗c8 21 ♕a1 ♕b7 22 c4 bxc4 23 ♘axc4 ♘f6, P.Svidler-A.Grischuk, Esbjerg 2000, and even taking a turn with White Svidler couldn't break the deadlock.

b) Critical for White is 19 ♘ec2!, e.g. 19...♘c5 (or 19...♗f6 20 ♘b4 ♘c5 21 ♗c2 ♘e7 22 ♕f3, G.Milos-G.Soppe, Sao Paulo 2003) 20 ♘b4 ♗c8 21 ♘c6, M.Adams-S.Haslinger, British Team Championship 2003 and in each case White was better.

17 ♕g4

A new move. The older continuation 17 ♗c2 ♕b7 18 b4 ♗g7? 19 c4! ♖d8 (or 19...bxc4 20 b5 ♗xb5 21 ♘xb5 ♕xb5 22 ♗a4 etc.) 20 ♗g5 f6 21 cxb5 fxg5 22 ♗d3, clearly favoured White in V.Anand-J.Speelman, Thessaloniki Olympiad 1988; however in this 18...♘b6 would have been playable.

17...♕c8 18 ♗c2 c6

The common break leading to a, by now, familiar pawn structure.

19 dxc6 ♕xc6 20 ♖d1 h5 21 ♕f3 ♗g7 22 ♗g5

White's pressure is annoying, so Short makes a practical decision to fight for the initiative, at the risk of some weaknesses.

22...f6 23 ♗e3 ♘c5 24 ♘f1 ♗b7 25 ♘d2 ♔h7

Black's structure has potential weaknesses on all fronts and requires some attention to detail. However there doesn't seem to be anything clear for White.

26 c4!?

A slower idea is 26 ♕e2 ♗a6 27 b4, in order to disorganise his opponent.

26...b4

But not 26...bxc4? 27 ♘dxc4, which just helps White who threatens the d6-pawn as well as ♘c4-a5.

27 ♘b5 ♘c8 28 ♘b3 ♘xb3 29 ♗xb3 ♖d8

With d6 now well covered White pays attention to the b4 isolani.

30 ♗d2 ♕c5 31 ♕e3 ♘b6 32 ♗e1

If 32 ♕e2, threatening ♗e3, then the simplest defence would be 32...♗h6.

32...♕c6

Instead 32...♖d7 is refuted by 33 ♖xd6, and 32...♕xe3 33 fxe3 would leave both d6 and b4 hopelessly weak. In that case, winning back the e4-pawn would only be scant compensation.

33 ♘a7 ♕c7 34 ♗xb4!

Building the pressure on d6 with 34 ♕d3 ♕c5 35 ♘b5 can be met by 35...♗h6! (whereas 35...♗f8 is rather passive as it allows 36 ♗d2, with ♗e3 to come), as 36 ♘xd6 is then a risky self-pin due to 36...♗c6!, whereupon White would be wise to bail out with 37 ♘b7 ♖xd3 38 ♘xc5 ♖xd1 39 ♗xd1 ♘xc4 with a draw seeming likely.

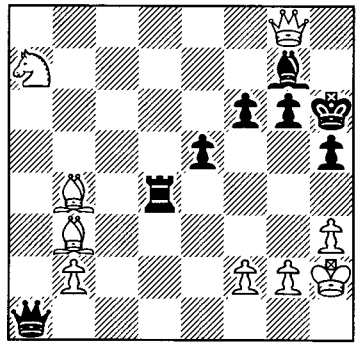
34...♘xc4 35 ♕c3 d5 36 exd5 ♖xd5 37 ♖c1 ♗a6

Hanging on grimly by tactical means as now 38 ♗xc4 ♗xc4 39 ♕xc4?? fails to 39...♖d1+.

38 ♖a1 ♕b7 39 ♖xa6 ♕xa6 40 ♕xc4 ♕a1+ 41 ♔h2

Natural and strong, but only if followed up precisely. The alternative 41 ♕f1 leads to an ending with two pieces against a rook and so excellent winning chances for White.

41...♖d4 42 ♕g8+ ♔h6



43 ♘c6?

The win now slips through the Russian's fingers. Instead 43 ♗f8! ♗xf8 (if 43...♕xa7? Black gets mated by 44 ♗f7!) 44 ♕xf8+ ♔g5 45 ♘b5 ♕c1 46 g3 should eventually win.

43...♕c1 44 ♘xd4 ♕f4+ 45 ♔g1 ♕c1+ 46 ♔h2 ♕f4+ ½-½

Game 55

P.Leko-P.Svidler

Frankfurt 1999

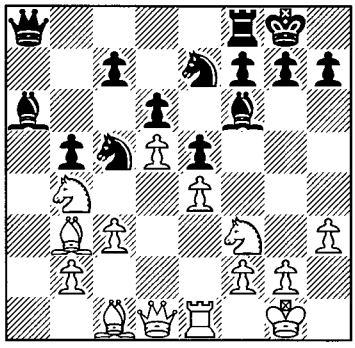
1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 c3 d6 9 h3 ♘d7 10 d4 ♗f6 11 a4 ♗b7 12 d5 ♘e7 13 axb5 axb5 14 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 15 ♘a3 ♗a6 16 ♘c2 ♘c5 17 ♘b4

I have a sneaking suspicion that keeping the bishop with 17 ♗a2!? is better:

a) 17...♗c8 18 ♘b4 ♘a6 19 ♘d3 c6 20 dxc6 ♕xc6 21 ♘h2 ♗e6 22 ♗xe6 fxe6 23 ♘g4, and White retained a small pull due to a more solid pawn structure, V.Iordachescu-

I.Zaja, Porto San Giorgio 2001.

b) 17...♗b7 18 ♗b1 (costs time but avoids exchanging off his bishop) 18...♖d8 19 ♘b4 ♘a6 20 ♘xa6 ♕xa6 21 ♘h2 ♘g6 22 ♘g4 ♗e7 23 g3 ♗c8 24 h4 ♘f8 25 ♘e3 h6 26 ♗d3 ♘h7 27 ♗d2 ♗d7 28 ♕e2 and White maintained some pressure in A.Kovacevic-M.Tosic, Serbian Team Championship 2001.



17...♗c8

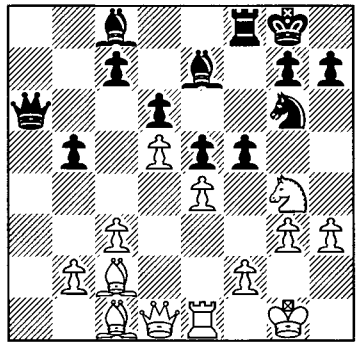
Also pretty solid is 17...♘xb3 18 ♕xb3 ♗c8 19 ♗e3 ♗d7 20 ♖c1 ♖b8 21 ♕d1 ♕b7 22 ♘h2 ♘g6 23 ♖a1 ♖a8 24 ♘f3 h6 25 ♕b1 ♖xa1 26 ♕xa1 c5, and Black had finally equalised in K.Nikolaides-S.Skembris, 2000. One of the advantages of exchanging off the light-squared bishop is that White has less say over squares such as b5, d5 and f5 when the position does finally open up.

18 ♗c2 ♘a6

The standard challenge to White's well-posted knight.

19 ♘xa6 ♕xa6 20 ♘h2 ♘g6 21 ♘g4 ♗e7 22 g3 f5!?

An interesting break for freedom. In this position from C.Hartmann-J.Barkhagen, Stockholm 1995, Black continued instead with the more cautious 22...♗d7 23 h4 ♖b8 24 ♘e3 ♘f8, but here White should be able to keep a certain control. White however played 25 ♘f5?!, which I consider to be premature, as after 25...♗xf5 26 exf5 ♘d7 27 b4 ♗f6 Black shouldn't be worse.



23 exf5 ♗xf5 24 ♗xf5 ♖xf5 25 ♕d3 ♖f7 26 h4

This move proves to be too loosening. If White is to prove an edge here, he needs to find an alternative. I suggest 26 ♖e4!?, hoping to come to b4 to chastise the b-pawn. Then if 26...♕a1, simply 27 ♕f1, when ♖b4 looks quite a strong threat, or if 26...♕c8, then 27 ♔g2 ♕f5 28 f3 with ♕d3-e2 followed by ♖b4 in mind.

26...♕c8 27 f3 ♗xh4! 28 gxh4 ♘xh4

Black obtains two pawns plus play against White's king.

29 ♖e3 ♖f4?!

The natural move 29...♘xf3+ takes a third pawn. White can then hold his position together with 30 ♖xf3 ♕xg4+ 31 ♖g3, leaving chances about equal.

30 ♘f2 ♕f8 31 ♘h3 ♖f5

If 31...♘xf3+ 32 ♔h1 ♖f6, White can even try 33 ♕xb5 ♘g5 34 ♔g2.

32 ♕e4

The most testing is 32 ♔f2!, when Black may start to regret not having taken on f3 when he had a chance!

32...♘xf3+ 33 ♔g2 ♘g5 34 ♘xg5 ♖xg5+ 35 ♖g3 ♖xg3+ 36 ♔xg3 ♕f1

Black now has full compensation for the piece and a draw is the logical result.

37 ♗d2 h6 38 ♕f3 ♕g1+ 39 ♔h3 ♕b1 40 b4 e4 41 ♕e3 ♕f1+ 42 ♔h2 ♕f5 43 ♕d4 ♕h5+ 44 ♔g1 ♕d1+ 45 ♔f2 ½-½

Summary

From White's point of view, one gets the feeling from Games 54 & 55 that he may be able to keep a tiny pull, but nothing much. Otherwise 14...♘a5, in Game 53, makes a refreshing change from the more common 14...♘e7, but both are adequate.

It's a fair reflection that more than half of the main games in this section were drawn. Basically the Karpov is one of Black's most solid and sound Spanish Defences. White's two wins in Games 48 and 50 were against inferior interpretations, but even in those cases Black had chances to improve.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♘d7 10 d4

10 d3 – *Game 49* notes

10...♗f6

10...♘b6 *(D)* – *Game 49*

11 a4

11 ♗e3 – *Game 50*

11...♗b7

11...♖b8 – *Game 51*

12 axb5

12 d5 – *Game 52 notes*

12 ♘a3 – *Game 52* 12...exd4 13 cxd4 ♖e8 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♗f4 *(D)*

12...axb5 13 ♖xa8 ♕xa8

13...♗xa8 – *Game 53 notes*

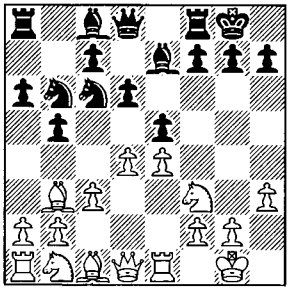
14 d5 ♘e7

14...♘a5 – *Game 53*

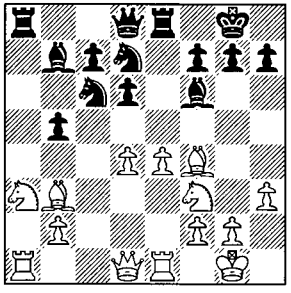
15 ♘a3 ♗a6 *(D)* **16 ♘c2** – *Game 55*

16 ♘h2 – *Game 54*

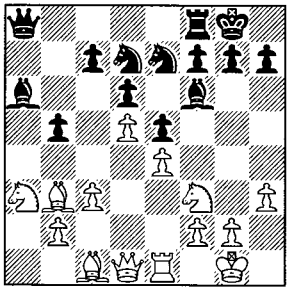
16 ♗e3 – *Game 54 notes*



10...♘b6



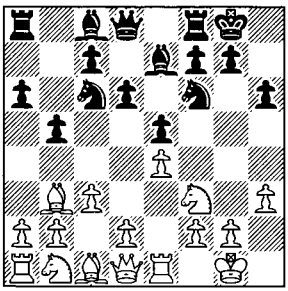
15 ♗f4



15...♗a6

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Smyslov Variation



1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 h6

The Smyslov is generally considered sound, but not as dynamic as some of Black's other systems. Black's 9th move prepares ...♖e8 and ...♗f8 (to tidy up his kingside pieces) before deciding what to do about his queen's bishop and for that matter how to generate counterplay. Depending on White's plan of action Black will then decide whether to place his bishop on b7 or d7.

The disadvantage of the Smyslov is that the slow 9...h6 is played early. This expense of a tempo for defensive purposes allows White an easier time of keeping the centre under control. Black's counterplay is thus harder to come by.

In both the Zaitsev and Breyer, ...h6 may well be played, but at a later stage when Black has already reorganised or developed his pieces. Comparison between these three chapters can be a useful exercise and transpositions abound. So before continuing with the first game, a brief discussion about the various move-orders may clarify their distinction.

After the moves **1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3**, the Smyslov Variation typically continues with **9...h6 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8**, as covered in this chapter. Alternatives are comparable and can indeed transpose:

After 9...♘b8 (as in the Breyer, Chapter 4) 10 d4 ♘bd7 11 ♘bd2 ♗b7 12 ♗c2, there is no longer any pressure on f7. Black has the choice as to whether or not ...h6 is useful. He often plays in the same manner as the Smyslov variation but without having played ...h6. This 'saved' tempo may prove useful elsewhere e.g. 12...♖e8 13 b4 ♗f8 14 ♗b2 (here 14 a4 is covered in Game 30) 14...♘b6 (instead 14...g6 15 a3 is analogous to the last game in this chapter (see game 60) except that Black hasn't played ...h6) 15 a3 ♘fd7 (15...h6 transposes directly to Smyslov's Variation) 16 ♕e2 ♖c8 and Black does without ...h6 using the extra time to prepare ...c5.

Here 9...♖e8 (the neo-Zaitsev!?) 10 d4 (after 10 ♘g5 ♖f8 11 ♘f3, if Black wants to play a game he should avoid 11...♖e8) 10...♗b7, can be defined as a Zaitsev but see what happens in Game 59.

9...♗b7 (the Zaitsev, Chapter 5) 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a4 (12 a3 g6 (12...h6 transposes to the Smyslov and was the actual move-order in Zhang Pengxiang-Lin Ta, Game 60) 13 ♗a2 ♗g7 14 b4 a5 with counterplay. Black uses the Zaitsev move order to

do without the ...h6 move and thus can claim to have gained a tempo.) 12...h6, is a Zaitsev as in Games 42-8 in Chapter 5.

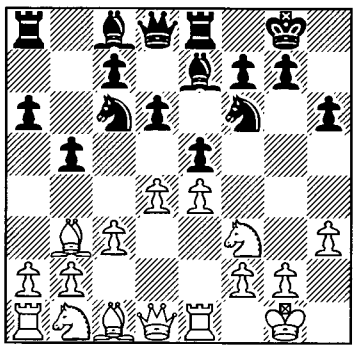
The Smyslov can be thought of as a classical foundation chapter against which virtually all non-Chigorin variations should be compared.

Game 56

L.Dominguez-I.Sokolov

Bled Olympiad 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 h6 10 d4 ♖e8



11 ♘bd2

The early development of the bishop to e3 has the disadvantage that the queen's knight may be unable to come to g3 because of pressure on the e4-pawn, e.g. 11 ♗e3 ♗f8 12 ♘bd2 ♗b7 13 ♕b1 (after 13 d5, Ivkov recommends 13...♘a5 14 ♗c2 c6, but 13...♘e7 (intending ...c6) is also fairly typical of such positions) 13...♘b8 (combining the Breyer manoeuvre with further scrutiny of e4) 14 a4 ♘bd7 15 ♗c2 c5 16 b3 b4 17 dxe5 bxc3 18 exf6 cxd2 19 ♘xd2 ♘xf6 20 ♗f4, H.Mecking-L.Portisch, San Antonio 1972, where Black was equal with 20...g6, but he could even try for more with 20...d5!? 21 exd5 ♕xd5 22 ♘f3 ♕h5.

11...♗f8 12 ♘f1 ♗d7 13 ♘g3 ♘a5 14 ♗c2 c5

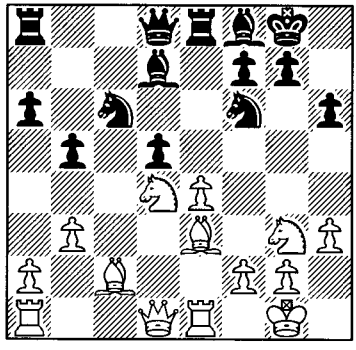
The alternative 14...♘c4!? comes into consideration. From here the knight can choose between retreat squares b6 or a5 when hit by b2-b3:

a) 15 a4 c5 16 b3 ♘a5 17 axb5 axb5 18 d5 ♕c7 19 ♗e3 ♖ec8 20 ♘h2 ♘b7 21 ♕e2, Z.Almasi-Peng Xiaomin, Yerevan 1996, gives White his typical pull due to the space advantage and the awkward knight on b7.

b) 15 b3 ♘b6 16 ♘h2 (after 16 ♗e3 c5 17 d5, Black created play on the queenside in E.Van den Doel-Xie Jun, Wijk aan Zee 1998 with 17...a5 18 ♘d2 a4 19 ♕e2 ♕c7 20 ♗d3 ♖eb8) 16...c5 17 f4 cxd4 18 cxd4 ♕c8 19 ♖e2 ♕c3 20 ♗e3 exd4 21 ♗f2 ♖ac8, M.Tal-E.Geller, USSR Championship 1977, and now Tal suggests 22 ♗d3 ♕c7 23 ♘f3 g6 24 ♗xd4 ♗g7 keeping an edge.

Black isn't doing so badly in these lines but the direct 14...c5 is now the most fashionable.

15 b3 ♘c6 16 ♗e3 cxd4 17 cxd4 exd4 18 ♘xd4 d5



19 exd5 ♘b4

Another idea is 19...♘xd5!?, when Ki.Georgiev-A.Beliavsky, Cacak 1996 continued 20 ♗e4 ♘xe3 21 ♖xe3 ♖c8 22 ♘xc6 ♗xc6 23 ♕f3 ♗xe4 24 ♘xe4 ♖e6!, and Black's position was already slightly better.

20 ♘c6

Dominguez analyses 20 ♕f3 as leading to unclear play, e.g. 20...♖c8 21 ♗f5 ♘bxd5 22 ♗d2 ♖xe1+ 23 ♖xe1 ♗c5 24 ♗xd7 ♕xd7

25 ♘df5, or 20...♘bxd5 21 ♘e4 ♘xe3 22 ♖xe3 ♘d5 23 ♖e2 ♕b6 24 ♖d1 ♖ad8.

20...♘xc6 21 dxc6 ♗xc6 22 ♕xd8

22 ♖c1 has been played before but that too seems fairly drawish.

22...♖axd8 23 ♖ad1 ♘d5 24 ♗e4 ♘xe3

Black could obtain the slightly better ending after 24...♗b4!, according to Dominguez, i.e. 25 ♗d2 ♘c3 26 ♗xc3 ♗xc3 27 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 28 ♖c1 ♗xe4 29 ♖xc3 ♖d1+ 30 ♔h2 ♗d5, and the bishop is the better minor piece here as it has influence on both wings at once.

25 ♗xc6 ♖xd1 26 ♖xd1 ♖e6 27 ♖c1 ♗a3 28 ♖c3 ♗b4 29 ♖c1

Again 29 ♖xe3 ♖xc6 gives Black the edge due to the advantage of bishop versus knight.

29...♗a3 30 ♖c3 ♗b2 31 ♖c5 ♘d1 32 ♗e4 g6 33 ♖c6

With opposite bishops a draw is virtually assured.

33...♖xc6 34 ♗xc6 ♗d4 35 ♔f1 ♗xf2

Otherwise 35...♘xf2 keeps the knights on, but after 36 b4 ♘d3 37 a3 ♗b2 38 ♗b7 ♗xa3 39 ♗xa6, White liquidates the queenside.

36 ♔e2 ♗xg3 ½-½

Game 57

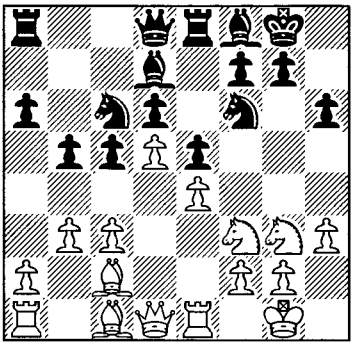
V.Dimitrov-A.Beliavsky

Yugoslavia 1996

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 h6 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 ♘f1 ♗d7 13 ♘g3 ♘a5 14 ♗c2 c5 15 b3

15 dxe5 seems rather ineffective here. The game W.Unzicker-S.Reshevsky, Santa Monica 1966 was agreed drawn after the following moves: 15...dxe5 16 ♘f5 ♘c4 17 ♘h2 ♗xf5 18 ♕xd8 ♖axd8 19 exf5 e4 20 ♘g4 ♘xg4 21 hxg4 e3! 22 ♔f1 (22 fxe3?! ♘e5 23 ♗d1 c4 gives more than enough compensation).

15...♘c6 16 d5



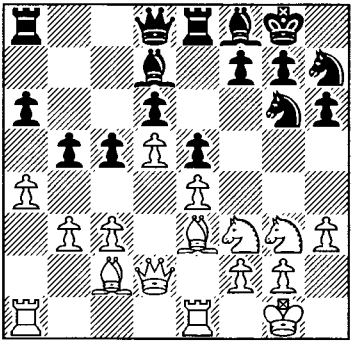
16...♘e7 17 ♗e3 ♘g6 18 ♕d2

Beliavsky points out that 18 ♘f5 leads to a murky position after 18...♗xf5 19 exf5 ♘e7 20 c4 e4 21 ♘h4.

If White tries the immediate 18 c4, then perhaps Black could play 18...♘h7, as in the main game. Instead after 18...♘f4 19 ♕d2 ♘6h5 20 ♗d1 ♘xg3 21 fxg3, Pe.Popovic-S.Djuric, Sarajevo 1984, White has the better options despite the slight inconvenience to his pawn structure.

18...♘h7 19 c4

White has at times created problems with a plan based on play on the a-file: 19 a4!



From this position Black can't have been that satisfied with 19...♘h4 20 ♘h2!? ♗e7 21 b4 c4 22 ♖a3 ♕c8 23 ♕e2 ♗g5 24 ♖ea1, Yu Shaoteng-Liu Dede, Shenyang 1999, nor for that matter after 20 ♘xh4 (rather than 20

♘h2) 20...♕xh4 21 ♕e2 ♕d8 22 b4 ♕c7 23 ♖ec1 c4 24 ♖a3 ♖ec8 25 ♖ca1, Deep Blue-G.Kasparov, New York Match 1997.

However the following may represent salvation for Black: 19...♗e7! 20 ♘f5 ♗xf5 21 exf5 ♘h4! 22 ♘xh4 ♗xh4 23 axb5 axb5 24 ♗d3 ♖xa1 25 ♖xa1 ♕d7 26 ♕e2 c4, Z.Hracek-I.Sokolov, Selfoss 2002, with equality.

19...♘h4 20 ♘h2 ♗e7 21 ♗d1

Opening the queenside with 21 b4 cxb4 22 ♕xb4 a5 23 ♕b3 b4 24 a3 is interesting. Beliavsky considers this to be unclear.

21...♗g5 22 ♗g4

So both players are intent on exchanging their respective potentially 'bad' bishops.

22...♖b8 23 ♖ac1 b4

If 23...♖f8 then possibly 24 b4!?.

24 ♗xg5 ♘xg5 25 f4?

Beliavsky thinks that White should prefer action on the queenside with 25 ♖a1 aiming for a2-a3 and an open a-file.

25...exf4 26 ♕xf4 ♗xg4 27 ♘xg4?

Although 27 ♕xg4 ♘g6 is promising for Black who will lay claim to the e5-square, the text just loses material.

27...♘hf3+!

A tactical blow that wins the exchange.

28 ♔h1

The point is that 28 gxf3 drops the queen to 28...♘xh3+.

28...♘xe1 29 ♖xe1

White doesn't have any compensation but he puts up a fight.

29...f6 30 ♘f5 h5 31 ♘f2 g6 32 h4 ♘f7 33 ♘e3 ♕e7 34 g4 ♕e5 35 ♕f3 ♘h6 36 ♖g1 ♔f7 37 ♖g2 hxg4 38 ♘exg4 ♘xg4 39 ♘xg4 ♕a1+ 40 ♔h2 ♖h8 41 ♖f2 ♖xh4+ 42 ♔g3 ♖xg4+

Giving back the exchange to obtain an ending with an extra pawn. A technique recommended by Capablanca in his day.

43 ♕xg4 ♕g1+ 44 ♔f3 ♕xg4+ 45 ♔xg4 ♖e8 46 ♔f3 ♖h8 47 ♔g2 ♖b8 48 ♔f3 a5 0-1

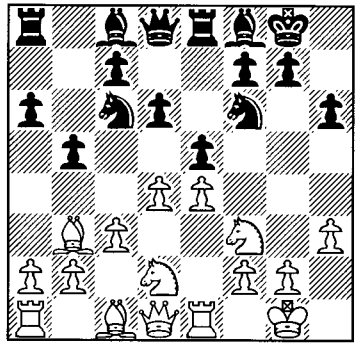
At first sight a premature resignation; however White would endure only further suffering after something like 49 ♖h2 ♔g7 50 ♔f4 a4 51 ♔g3 a3 52 ♔f4 ♖h8 53 ♖e2 ♖h1 54 ♔g3 ♖b1 55 ♔f3 ♖b2 and exchanging into a pawn ending makes the win trivial.

Game 58

E.Berg-T.Ernst

Swedish Ch. 2003

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 h6 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8



12 ♘f1

There are two principal alternatives:

a) 12 ♗c2 (this move has some independent significance but can transpose to games elsewhere)

a1) 12...♗b7 13 a3 transposes to Games 59 & 60.

a2) Former ladies world champion Xie Jun likes 12...g6 in this position:

a21) 13 d5 ♘e7 14 a4 ♗d7 15 b3 c5 16 dxc6!? (otherwise the blocked centre will make it hard to make progress) 16...♘xc6 17 ♘f1 ♗e6 18 ♘e3 bxa4 19 b4 ♕c8 20 ♖xa4 ♖d8 21 c4 a5 22 b5 ♘b4 23 ♗d2 ♕c5, A.Galliamova-Xie Jun, Kazan/Shenyang Match 1999, and now with 24 ♕b1 ♗xc4 25 ♘xc4 ♕xc4 26 ♗xb4 axb4 27 ♖xb4 White retains an edge due to the passed pawn and influence on the light-squares.

a22) Or more recently 13 ♘f1 ♗b7 14 d5 ♘b8 15 b3 (to support the extended d5-pawn) 15...c6 16 c4 ♘bd7 17 ♘g3 ♕c7 18 ♗e3 ♖ec8 19 ♖c1 bxc4 20 bxc4 a5 21 ♕d2 ♔h7 22 ♗a4, Alexa.Ivanov-Xie Jun, Seattle 2001, with a pull for White. It was convenient that the a4-square was available for the bishop, because in analogous positions where the White a-pawn is already on a4 then Black would have less to worry about.

a3) 12...♗d7:

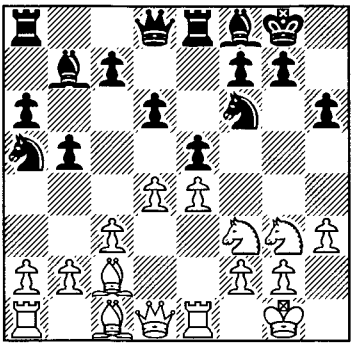
a31) 13 a3 now transposes to 'b' below.

a32) Following 13 ♘b3 a5 14 ♗e3 a4 15 ♘bd2 ♘a5 16 ♘h2 c5, L.Stein-E.Geller, USSR 1968, Black obtains a version of the 9...a5 variation (see Games 62-64) where White has lost time with ♘bd2-b3-d2.

a33) 13 ♗d3 (a slightly laborious manoeuvre that is known from other variations) 13...g6 14 a3 ♗g7 15 b3 ♘h5 16 ♗b2 ♘f4 17 ♗f1 f5 18 dxe5 fxe4 19 ♖xe4 (or 19 ♘xe4 ♘xe5 20 ♘xe5 ♗xe5 with equality according to Ernst) 19...dxe5 20 c4 ♗f5 21 ♖e3 e4 22 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 23 cxb5 axb5 24 ♗xb5 exf3 25 ♘xf3 ♕f6 26 ♖c1, T.Ernst-E.Geller, Helsinki 1992 and now Ernst recommends 26...♖ad8! 27 ♖xe8 ♖xd1+ 28 ♖xd1 ♘e7 29 ♗c4 c6 when he prefers Black. The queen and minor pieces should be able to create mischief around the white king.

b) Again there are some move-order and transpositional ideas after 12 a3 ♗d7 (12...♗b7 transposes to Games 59 & 60) 13 ♗c2 a5!? (13...g6 14 d5 ♘e7 15 c4!? bxc4 16 ♘xc4 ♗b5 17 ♘e3 a5 18 a4 ♗a6 [an unusual way for the bishop to make it to the a6-square!] 19 ♘h2 ♗g7, and Black had a reasonable game in J.Dworakowska-R.Shetty, Koszalin 1998) 14 a4 (14 ♘f1 a4, is as in Game 64, except that White has played the committal a2-a3, whereas the plausible continuation 14 ♗d3 ♕b8 15 d5 ♘e7 16 b4 c6, is given by Petrosian as equal) 14...b4 15 d5 bxc3 16 bxc3 ♘b8 17 ♘c4 c6 18 dxc6 ♗e6 19 ♘cxe5 dxe5 20 ♕xd8 ♖xd8 21 c7 ♖c8 22 cxb8♕ ♖axb8, B.Parma-A.O'Kelly de Galway, Büsum 1968, when Black has enough compensation. Indeed a draw was agreed at this point.

12...♗b7 13 ♘g3 ♘a5 14 ♗c2



14...♘c4

Here we see a significant difference between lines with 12...♗d7 and 12...♗b7. There (with 12...♗d7) 14...c5 is the favourite choice, whereas here (with 12...♗b7) after 14...c5 15 d5, Black's bishop is somewhat misplaced on b7. Indeed, so much so, that it's typical to then play 15...♗c8 with ...♗d7 to follow.

After 14...g6 15 a4 ♕d7 16 b3 ♗g7 17 ♗d2 ♘c6 18 ♗d3 ♘a7 19 d5, White kept a pull in the game V.Korchnoi-V.Smyslov, Rovinj/Zagreb 1970.

15 b3 ♘b6 16 ♗b2

Over the years, 16 a4 has received great attention, but it's still not clear if Black has found a path to equality:

a) If 16...d5 17 ♘xe5 dxe4, as in B.Ivkov-S.Gligoric, Yugoslavia 1972, White should have the courage to take on e4 with 18 ♘xe4, when he should eventually get untangled, e.g. 18...♘xe4 19 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 20 ♖xe4 f6 21 ♘c6 ♕d5 22 ♖xe8 ♖xe8 23 axb5 axb5 24 ♘a5, with not enough play for Black.

b) Best is 16...bxa4 17 bxa4 a5 18 ♗d3 (18 d5 is met by 18...c6) and now a moment of decision:

b1) 18...♗c6 19 d5 ♗d7 20 ♗b5 favoured White in V.Anand-G.Kamsky, Linares 1991.

b2) Interesting is 18...♕d7 19 ♗b5 c6! 20 ♗d3 ♗a6, an idea of Romanishin and An.Bykhovsky.

b3) The main line is 18...♗a6!? 19 ♗xa6 ♖xa6 20 dxe5 dxe5 21 ♕xd8 ♖xd8 22 ♘xe5 ♗d6, with some compensation for the pawn in R.Winsnes-Y.Balashov, Stockholm 1992/3, but is it enough?

b31) The stem game continued 23 ♘c6 ♖e8 24 e5 ♘c4 25 ♗f4 ♖xc6 26 exd6 ♘xd6 27 ♗xd6 with equality.

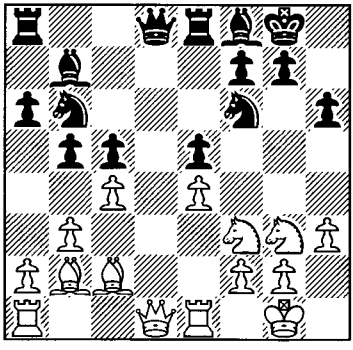
b32) 23 ♘f3 ♗xg3 24 fxg3 ♖d3 25 ♗e3 ♖xc3 26 ♗d4 ♖c6, A.Gavrilov-Y.Balashov, St.Petersburg 2001, didn't seem to be any improvement.

b33) Critical however is 23 ♗f4 g5 24 ♘g4 ♗xf4 25 ♘xf6+ ♔f8 26 ♘e2 ♗e5 27 ♘g4 ♗g7 28 ♘e3 ♖d3 29 ♖eb1, E.Innarkiev-Y.Zilberman, Pardubice 2003, and White managed to grind out a win.

16...c5 17 dxc5

After 17 d5 c4! 18 b4 a5 19 a3 ♗c8 20 ♕e2 ♗d7 21 ♔h2 g6 Black has no worries, E.Torre-S.Gligoric, Manila 1968.

17...dxc5 18 c4



A position that was mainly investigated in the late 60's and early 70's. We have the same pawn-structure as in Game 24 from the Keres variation, but where Black's pieces are on rather different squares.

18...♕c7

Gligoric considers the alternative 18...♘bd7! to be superior: 19 ♕e2 b4 20 ♖ad1 ♕c7 21 ♘f1 (or 21 ♘h2 ♘b8 22 ♘f5 ♘c6, E.Geller-S.Gligoric, Sochi 1968) 21...a5 22 ♘e3 ♘xe4, with complicated play, J.Smejkal-B.Ivkov, Skopje 1972.

Black's most precise defence is well illustrated by a later meeting between Geller and Gligoric: 20...♕a5! (rather than 20...♕c7) 21 ♗b1 ♖e6 22 ♘f5 ♖ae8 23 ♘e3 ♘b8 24 ♘d5 ♘c6 25 ♖d2, E.Geller-S.Gligoric, USSR v World Belgrade 1970, when a draw was agreed.

Black did without ...♕c7, a square where the queen will eventually be hit by ♘d5. The move ...♘bd7 prepares an eventual ...♘b8-c6, and Black can access his own ready-made outpost on d4.

19 ♘d2!? bxc4!?

Going for a more open game than in the old days. Presumably Black was concerned that after 19...♖ad8 20 ♕e2 b4 21 ♘df1, White will quickly follow up with ♘e3-d5.

20 bxc4 ♖ad8 21 ♕e2 ♗c6 22 ♘df1 ♘a4

Consistent as this exchanges off one of White's bishops and gives Black some breathing space, but White rapidly comes to d5 anyway.

23 ♗xa4 ♗xa4 24 ♘e3 ♕c6 25 ♘d5

The knight can't be allowed to stay here indefinitely and after its inevitable exchange Black's passed, but isolated, c-pawn is easily blockaded.

25...♘xd5 26 cxd5 ♕b5 27 ♕d2 ♖b8 28 ♗c3 c4

With Black's queenside pieces all dressed up but nowhere to go, White switches his attention to the under-defended king.

29 ♘f5 ♔h7 30 f4 exf4 31 ♕xf4 ♕d7 32 ♔h1

The storm clouds gather. The two central pawns keep the defender inactive and the bishop on a4 is not yet able to challenge the f5-knight.

32...f6

Closing the diagonal but now the e6-square is available for an attacking piece. It's

rather passive for Black, but not yet hopeless.

33 ♖e3 ♗c2 34 ♘d4 ♗d6 35 ♕f3 ♗d3 36 ♘e6 ♖e7 37 ♕f5+ ♔g8 38 ♖f3 ♖f7 39 ♖e1 ♖e8 40 ♕g4 ♔h7 41 ♕h5 ♗b8?

Black finally cracks. Instead 41...♖ee7 would plaster everything together, well at least for the time being!

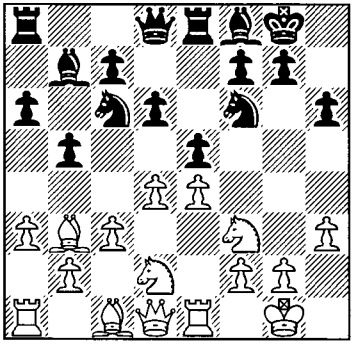
42 ♘g5+ ♔g8 43 ♘xf7 ♕xf7 44 ♕xf7+ ♔xf7 45 e5 1-0

Game 59

V.Bologan-A.Beliavsky

Enghien-les-Bains 1999

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♖e8 10 d4 ♗b7 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a3 h6



13 ♗c2

Dropping the bishop back the other way has its points. It frankly seems such a shame to leave the a2-g8 diagonal after playing a2-a3! However after 13 ♗a2, in response, both defences below seem playable:

a) 13...♕d7 14 b4 a5 15 d5 ♘e7 16 c4 axb4 17 cxb5 ♕xb5 18 ♖b1 c5!, A.Shabalov-A.Goldin, New York 1993.

b) 13...♘b8 (with threats against e4, immediately hoping to profit from the absence of the bishop from its defence) 14 d5 c6 15 dxc6 (15 c4 didn't give anything either in A.Colovic-K.Pilgaard, Subotica 2003, after 15...bxc4 16 dxc6 ♗xc6 17 ♗xc4 d5 18 exd5 ♗xd5 19 b4 e4 20 ♘d4 ♖a7) 15...♗xc6 16 ♘h2, V.Bologan-D.Suhl, Berlin 1995, and now Black should take the opportunity to play 16 ..d5(!).

13...♘b8

The play that follows can be compared to the Breyer. Often the only difference is that Black has played the move ...h6 and White has had this tempo to get his queenside sorted out.

14 b4

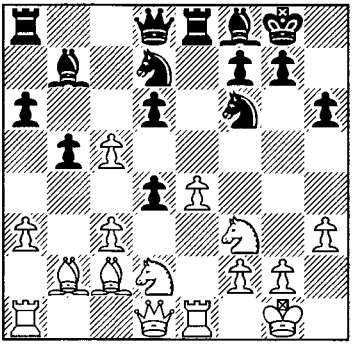
In the following games after 14 b3, White wasn't really able to use the extra tempo that he has available (compared with analogous positions from the Breyer): 14...♘bd7 15 ♗b2 g6 and now:

a) 16 ♖c1 ♖c8 17 d5 c6 18 c4 a5 19 a4 bxa4 20 bxa4 ♗a6 21 ♗a3 cxd5 22 cxd5 ♘c5, P.Leko-Z.Almasi, Hungarian Championship 1992.

b) 16 ♗d3 c6 17 ♖c1 ♗g7 18 ♕c2 ♖c8 19 ♕b1 ♘h5 20 ♗f1 ♕b6 21 ♕a1 ♖e7 22 ♖e3 ♖ce8 23 ♖ce1 c5, A.Galkin-S.Virovlansky, St.Petersburg 1999.

c) 16 a4 ♗g7 17 ♗d3 c6 18 ♕c2 ♖c8 19 c4 exd4 20 ♗xd4 ♘h5 21 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 22 ♗f1 ♕f6, K.Aseev-A.Goldin, Klaipeda 1988, and in each case Black had, in practical terms, equalised.

14...♘bd7 15 ♗b2 c5 16 bxc5 exd4



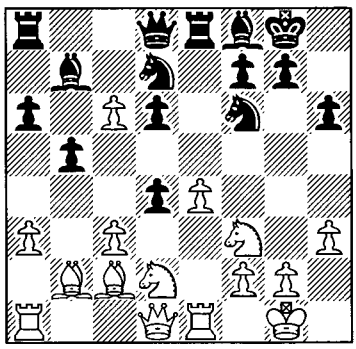
This sharp position was particularly fashionable in 1988.

17 c6

Alternatives are at present considered acceptable for Black:

a) 17 cxd6 dxc3 18 ♗xc3 ♗xd6 19 e5 ♘d5 20 ♗b2 ♗c7 21 ♖c1 ♘f4 with equality, Tan Chengxuan-Lin Ta, Chinese Championship 1988.

b) 17 cxd4 dxc5 18 ♖c1 (murky was 18 d5 ♕c7 19 ♘f1 c4 20 ♘g3 a5, J.Hjartarson-J.Smejkal, Munich 1988) 18...♖c8 19 ♗b1 ♘h5 20 e5 ♘f4 21 ♘e4 c4! (better than 21...cxd4?! 22 ♖xc8 ♕xc8 23 ♕xd4, J.Nunn-A.Greenfeld, Groningen 1988, when White had a pleasant edge) 22 ♕d2 ♘g6 23 ♘c3 ♘b6 is unclear according to Ftacnik.



17...d3!?

A new move which is more solid than the alternatives:

a) Wedberg doesn't like 17...♗xc6?! because after 18 cxd4 d5 19 e5 ♘h5 20 ♗b1, White has the threats of ♕d1-c2 and e5-e6.

b) 17...dxc3 18 cxb7 cxd2! (Various sources quote Bologan's analysis giving 18...cxb2 19 bxa8♕ bxa1♕ 20 ♕xa6 ♕xd1 21 ♖xd1 ♕a8 22 ♕xb5 ♕xa3 with equality. However there is a hole: 20 ♕xd8 [rather than 20 ♕xa6] 20...♕xd1 21 ♕c7 wins on the spot!) 19 ♕xd2 (or similarly 19 bxa8♕ dxe1♕+ 20 ♕xe1 ♕xa8) 19...♖b8 20 ♘d4 ♖xb7 21 ♘f5 ♘e5 22 ♗d4 ♖d7, Tan Chengxuan-Lin Ta, China 1988, when White has some compensation for the pawn due to his active pieces and bishop pair, but it's not clear if it's enough.

18 cxb7 dxc2 19 ♕xc2 ♖b8 20 a4 ♖xb7 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♗a3 ♕b6

The more ambitious 22...d5!? is met by 23 e5, but after 23...♘h7 24 ♕d3 ♗xa3 25 ♖xa3 ♘c5 26 ♕e3 ♘e6, Black seems to be OK.

23 ♘d4 ♖c8 24 ♕d3 ♘e5 25 ♕g3 ♘h5 26 ♕e3 ♗e7 27 g3!

Restricting Black's pieces as now ...♗g5 will be met by f2-f4. White's bishop is the more active of the two and Black has two isolated pawns compared to White's one. White therefore is slightly better.

27...♘c6 28 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 29 ♗b4

It may be more precise to play 29 ♘b3!, as Bologan later suggested. The knight heads for d4 or a5 and Black dare not capture on c3 because of 30 ♖ac1.

29...♘f6 30 ♔h2 ♖e8?!

Wedberg considers that now is the time to play the liberating 30...d5(!).

31 ♘b3 ♕c8 32 ♕d3 ♗f8 33 ♘d4 ♕c4 34 ♕xc4 bxc4 35 ♘f5 g6?

A surprising mistake. Instead Black has two satisfactory options:

a) Wedberg suggests 35...♖xe4 36 ♖xe4 (if 36 ♗xd6 then 36...♖b5!) 36...♘xe4 37 ♖a8 g6 38 ♘xd6 ♖xb4 39 ♘xe4 ♖b2.

b) Bologan prefers 35...d5 36 ♗xf8 ♖xf8 37 exd5 ♘xd5 with a draw on the cards.

36 ♘xd6 ♗xd6 37 ♗xd6 ♘xe4 38 ♗c5!

Heading for d4 leaving Black with chronic dark-square problems.

38...f5 39 ♗d4 ♔f7 40 ♖a6 ♖ee7 41 ♖e2 ♖bd7 42 ♔g2 ♖d6 43 ♖a8 ♖de6 44 ♖h8 g5 45 ♖b2 g4 46 h4 ♖e8 47 ♖h7+ ♔g6 48 ♖g7+ ♔h5 49 ♖b5 ♖f8 50 f3! gxf3+ 51 ♔h3! 1-0

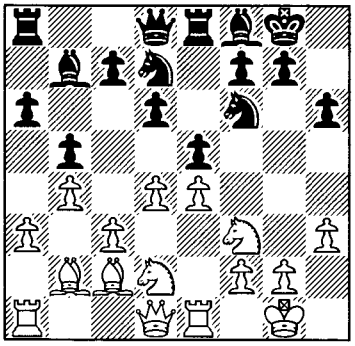
Game 60

Zhang Pengxiang-Lin Ta

Chinese Team Championship 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8

c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a3 h6 13 ♗c2 ♘b8 14 b4 ♘bd7 15 ♗b2



15...g6

Black has a wide choice of moves here, but 15...g6 is the most popular choice.

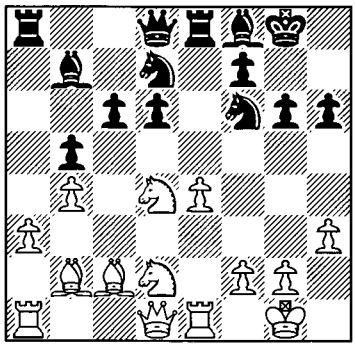
Black's other main alternative (apart from 15...c5 which was the subject of Game 59) is the immediate 15...a5, i.e. 16 ♗d3 c6 17 ♘b3 axb4 18 cxb4 ♖b8 19 dxe5 dxe5 20 ♖c1 ♕b6 21 ♕c2 ♖bc8 22 ♕e2 c5, B.Socko-M.Grabarczyk, Polish Championship 2001, with adequate counter-chances for Black.

16 c4

White can try to build up slowly with 16 ♕b1, which maintains the e-pawn allowing the knight to come over to a5. However this plan doesn't seem that worrisome for Black either. This can be seen from the following examples: 16...♗g7 (or 16...♖b8 17 ♘b3 ♗a8 18 d5 c6 19 dxc6 ♗xc6 20 ♘a5 ♗a8 21 c4 ♘c5!, Z.Lanka-C.Foisor, Hyères 1992) 17 ♘b3 ♖c8 18 ♘a5 ♗a8 19 d5 ♘b6 20 a4 ♘xa4 (even 20...c6 21 dxc6 ♗xc6 22 ♘xc6 ♖xc6 23 axb5 axb5 24 ♖a5 ♘c4 25 ♖xb5 ♘xb2 26 ♕xb2 ♕c7 also gives chances for equality, D.King-P.Lukacs, Kecskemet 1988) 21 ♗xa4 bxa4 22 ♖xa4 ♕d7 23 ♕a2 ♘h5 24 ♘c6 ♗b7 25 c4 ♘f4, V.Bologan-Z.Almasi, Dresden 1997, and Black doesn't seem to be worse.

16...exd4 17 cxb5 axb5 18 ♘xd4 c6

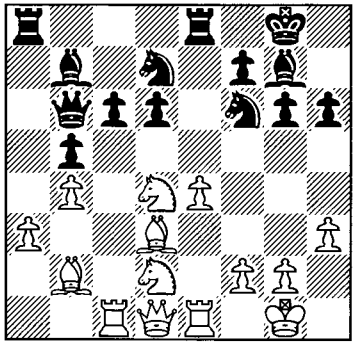
We have a position analogous to one touched on in Games 30 & 31 in the Breyer. There Black has played ...♗g7 instead of ...h6.



19 ♖c1

The most testing try. Instead after both 19 a4 bxa4 20 ♗xa4 ♕b6 21 ♗c3 d5, C.Joecks-P.Svidler, Groningen 1990, and 19 ♘2b3 ♖c8 20 ♘a5 ♗a8 21 ♕d2 ♕b6 22 ♘db3 c5, J.Klovans-A.Goldin, Tashkent 1987, Black achieved a very comfortable game.

19...♕b6 20 ♗d3 ♗g7



21 ♕b3

Or here 21 ♘2b3, as in A.Sokolov-F.Izeta, Bilbao 1987, and now Romanishin and An.Bykhovsky suggest 21...♖ac8, rather than the game continuation 21...c5 22 ♘xb5 ♗xe4 23 ♗xe4 ♖xe4 24 ♖xe4 ♘xe4 25 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 26 ♕d3 ♘df6 27 bxc5 dxc5 28 ♕c4 ♘d6 29 ♘xd6 ♕xd6 30 a4, where White retained an edge.

21...♖e7

In E.Szalancy-P.Petran, Budapest 1987 Black first played 21...♘g4 22 ♘2f3 ♘ge5 23 ♗f1, and only now 23...♖e7 24 ♘d2 ♖ae8 25 ♖ed1 ♕a7. The Black position was sound and White didn't find a way to prove an advantage.

22 ♘4f3 c5!

Black could consider 22...♖ae8, but the knight on f6 is less active than in Szalancy-Petran above.

23 e5?!

Inaugurating sharp complications which however don't quite work. The correct choice, leading to an equal game was 23 bxc5 e.g. 23...♘xc5 24 ♕xb5 ♕xb5 25 ♗xb5 ♘fxe4 26 ♗xg7 ♔xg7.

23...c4 24 ♗xc4 dxe5!

Clearly the right choice as 24...bxc4? looks distinctly dubious because of 25 ♘xc4 ♕d8 26 exf6, or even 26 ♘xd6 ♗d5 27 ♕d3.

25 ♗f1 e4!

More ambitious than 25...♖ae8, which is however safe enough.

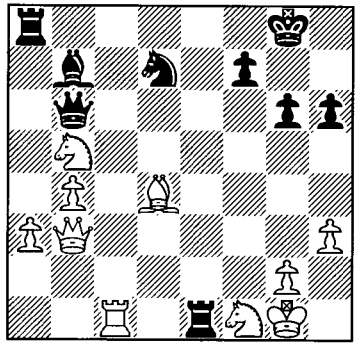
26 ♘d4 ♘d5 27 ♘xb5 e3 28 fxe3 ♘xe3

Also possible is 28...♖xe3, when the complications seem to favour the second player, e.g. 29 ♖xe3 ♘xe3 30 ♗xg7 ♘xf1+ 31 ♗d4 ♘xd2 32 ♕d3 (32 ♕e3 fails to 32...♕xb5 33 ♕xh6 ♘e5) 32...♗e4 33 ♕e2 ♕a6.

29 ♗xg7 ♘xf1+!

Incorrect is 29...♘c2+?, as after 30 ♔h2 ♘xe1 31 ♗d4 ♕d8 32 ♕g3, Black's knight on e1 is lost.

30 ♗d4 ♖xe1 31 ♘xf1



31 ♖xe1 also favours Black after 31...♘xd2 32 ♕d3 ♕c6.

31...♖xc1??

The text turns out to be bad as White obtains a decisive initiative against the loose black pieces. Instead Black is close to winning after 31...♖e2! 32 ♗xb6 (or 32 ♘e3 ♕xb5) 32...♖xg2+ 33 ♔h1 ♖g3+ 34 ♔h2 ♖xb3.

32 ♗xb6 ♘xb6 33 ♕e3 ♖c6 34 ♕e7 ♗a6

If 34...♖b8, then 35 ♘d6.

35 ♘c7 ♘d5 36 ♘xd5 ♖c1 37 ♘f6+ ♔g7 38 ♘e8+ ♔g8 39 ♕e5 ♖xf1+ 40 ♔h2 ♔f8 41 ♘c7 1-0

Summary

With the prudent 9...h6 played so early, Black tends to be in a slightly more cautious frame of mind than in the Zaitsev. Games 59 & 60 are very similar to the Breyer, but the slower ...h6 doesn't seem to be easy to exploit.

The Smyslov is indeed solid and sound throughout.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 h6 (Smyslov Variation)**10 d4 ♖e8** *(D)* **11 ♘bd2**

11 ♗e3 – *Game 56 notes*

11...♗f8 12 ♘f1

12 ♗c2 – *Game 58 notes*

12 a4 – (Zaitsev Variation), *Games 42-48*

12 a3 ♗d7 – *Game 58 notes*

12 a3 ♗b7

13 ♗a2 – *Game 59 notes*

13 ♗c2 ♘b8

14 b3 – *Game 59 notes*

14 b4 ♘bd7 15 ♗b2 c5 – *Game 59*

15...a5 – *Game 60 notes*

15...g6 – *Game 60*

12...♗d7

12...♗b7 – *Game 58* 13 ♘g3 ♘a5 14 ♗c2 ♘c4 *(D)*

13 ♘g3 ♘a5 14 ♗c2 c5

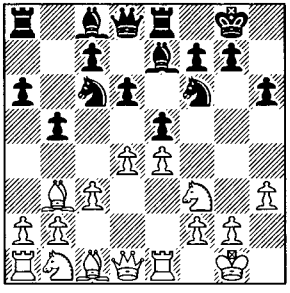
14...♘c4 – *Game 56 notes*

15 b3

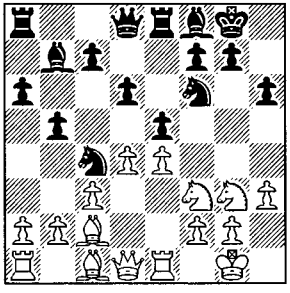
15 dxe5 – *Game 57 notes*

15...♘c6 *(D)* **16 d5** – *Game 57*

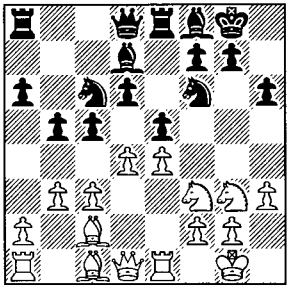
16 ♗e3 – *Game 56*



10...Re8



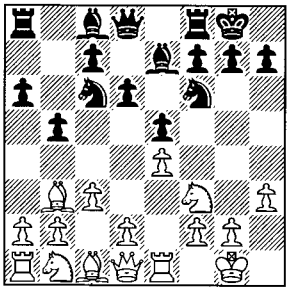
14...♘c4



15...♘c6

CHAPTER EIGHT

Black's Ninth Move Alternatives



1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3

The three moves covered here are rarely seen. Each has its plus and minus points.

The move 9...♕d7 generally prepares ...♗b7, so play can be compared with that of the Zaitsev, where the queen can also be thus developed in some of the lesser variations. Indeed Game 61 transposes to a variation that could equally occur from Chapter 5.

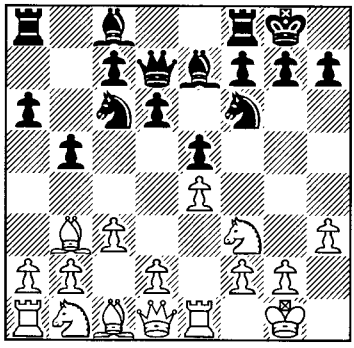
The queenside advance 9...a5 (in Games 62-64) has its points but White has various ways to counter this time spent on the queenside. White's most logical counter is to angle to obtain a grip on the central arena.

Playing 9...♗e6 in order to exchange light-squares bishops is out of favour, as the critical lines from 11 axb3 (Games 66 & 67) have been worked out to an edge to White.

Each of these three moves have surprise value but can objectively be considered inferior if one's opponent has the possibility of thorough preparation.

Game 61
V.Kotronias-V.Milov
Groningen 1997

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♕d7!?



A slightly clumsy-looking move. However as the bishop will soon go to b7 there is no real problem to continue developing normally. One of the points is that it frees the d8-square for the knight, which means that Black can continue with ...♖e8 without being inconvenienced by ♘f3-g5.

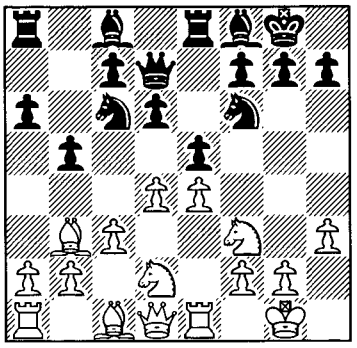
10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2

As mentioned above, 11 ♘g5 is met by 11...♘d8, when the game S.Dvoirys-A.Malevinsky, Kazan 1980 led to easy equality after 12 f4 ♗b7 13 ♗c2 ♗f8 14 dxe5 dxe5 15 ♕xd7 ♘xd7 16 f5 c5 17 ♗e3 c4 18 ♘d2 ♗c5.

Another idea is 11 ♗g5, which can be met

by 11...h6 12 ♗h4 ♘h7, as in Alexa.Ivanov-A.Malevinsky, Kostroma 1985, which continued 13 ♕d3 ♗xh4 14 ♘xh4 ♘a5 15 ♗c2 ♕e7 16 ♘f3 c5 17 ♘bd2 cxd4 18 cxd4 ♘c6, and Black should be OK. The exchange of dark-squared bishops reduces White's pressure.

11...♗f8



Now White has a choice.

12 ♗c2

The most popular, but two other moves need paying attention to:

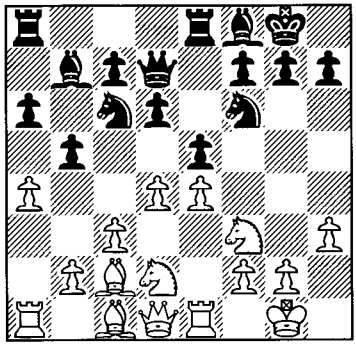
a) Interesting is 12 a3, which was employed more frequently in the seventies e.g. 12...♘d8 (Smyslov's improvement over 12...g6 13 ♗a2 ♗g7 14 b4 ♘h5 15 ♘f1 ♗b7 16 ♗b2 ♘f4 17 ♘g3 ♕e7 18 ♘e2, G.Kuzmin-V.Smyslov, Moscow 1974, when White retained a pull) 13 ♗c2 g6 14 b4 ♘h5 15 ♗b2 ♘e6 16 ♗d3 ♗g7 17 ♗f1 exd4 18 cxd4 c5, G.Kuzmin-V.Smyslov, Lvov Zonal 1978, and this time against the same opponent, but four years later, Black obtained good play.

b) 12 d5 ♘e7 13 ♘f1, and now:

b1) 13...g6?! has been out of favour since R.Fischer-R.Wade, Buenos Aires 1960, as 14 c4 ♗g7 15 c5 ♘h5 16 a4 gave White a strong queenside initiative and after the further 16...dxc5 17 axb5 ♗b7 18 bxa6 ♗xa6 19 ♗e3 c4 20 ♗a4 ♗b5 21 ♗xb5 ♕xb5 22 ♕c2, Black's forward c-pawn was very weak.

b2) 13...h6 (preparing ...c6 but first of all assuring the security of f7 by cutting out ♘f3-g5) 14 ♘3h2 c6 (using the queen's special placing to dissolve the centre) 15 dxc6 ♕xc6 16 ♕f3 d5 17 ♘g3 ♗e6 18 ♘g4 ♘xg4 19 hxg4 dxe4 20 ♘xe4 ♗xb3 21 axb3 ♖ed8, O.Nikolenko-D.Lobzhanidze, Tula 1999, with a satisfactory game.

12...♗b7 13 a4



We have transposed to a sideline of the Zaitsev. This position would normally occur from 9...♗b7 10 d4 ♖e8 11 ♘bd2 ♗f8 12 a4 ♕d7!? 13 ♗c2!?.

Instead of the text move, 13 d5 ♘e7 14 b3 c6 15 c4 enables White to avoid any opening of the centre and is perhaps a more accurate move order.

13...g6

Black could opt for 13...h6, which is not bad, but it's not altogether necessary here.

The most dynamic is 13...exd4 14 cxd4 g6 15 b3 ♗g7 16 ♗b2 ♘b4 17 ♗b1 a5 18 axb5 (no better was 18 ♗c3 ♘h5 19 ♘f1 c5 with equality Zso.Polgar-A.Goldin, Rishon le Ziyon 1996) 18...♕xb5 19 ♕c1 d5!, P.Svidler-A.Goldin, Yugoslav Team Championship 1995, with adequate counter chances.

14 d5 ♘e7 15 c4

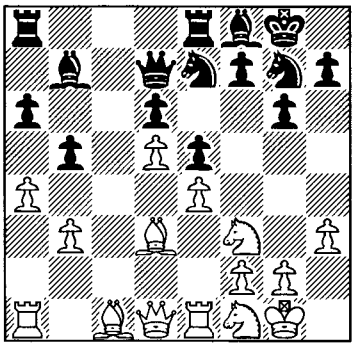
Gutman suggests 15 ♘b3, heading for the sensitive a5-square e.g. 15...c6 16 ♗g5 ♗g7 17 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 18 dxc6 ♗xc6 19 ♘a5 with an edge.

15...c6 16 b3 ♘h5

Possible is 16...cxd5 17 cxd5 ♗g7 18 ♘f1

♘h5 19 ♘e3 ♘f4 20 ♗d2, A.Suetin-I.Zaitsev, Sochi 1977, and now 20...f5, (as suggested by Romanishin and An.Bykhovsky) would yield counterplay.

17 ♘f1 ♘g7 18 ♗d3 cxd5 19 cxd5



19...f5!?

Black really needs to play this move if he wants to seek counterplay; however there is an ever present risk that the kingside will become weak.

20 ♘e3 ♔h8 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 23 ♘g5 fxe4 24 ♗xe4 ♘ef5 25 ♘g4

Black has to be a little careful, but there doesn't seem to be anything concrete for White.

25...♗e7 26 ♘f7+ ♔g8 27 ♘gh6+ ♘xh6 28 ♘xh6+ ♔h8 29 ♗d2

Playing for more than a repetition, but giving Black time to activate his minor pieces.

29...♘h5 30 ♘g4 ♗d8!

Switching to greener pastures on the queenside as the queen can adequately defend the king.

31 ♗e3 ♗a5 32 ♖f1 ♗c3 33 ♕f3 ♕e7 34 ♗h6 b4 35 ♖d1 ♔g8 36 g3 ♕f7 37 ♕e3 ♗c8 38 ♗g5 ♗xg4

By exchanging off White's dangerous knight any attacking ambition is put to rest.

39 hxg4 ♘f6 40 ♗f3 ♘d7 41 ♗e2 ♘c5 42 ♗c4 ♗d4 43 ♖xd4

Forced, as 43 ♕e2? ♕xf2+ 44 ♕xf2 ♗xf2+ 45 ♔xf2 ♘e4+ loses.

43...exd4 44 ♕xd4 ♕f3 45 ♗h6 ♖a7 46 ♗e3 ♖e7 47 ♕f4 ♕xf4 48 ♗xf4

A pair of bishops and a pawn seem adequate compensation for the exchange.

48...♖e4 49 ♗xd6 ♖xc4! 50 bxc4 b3 51 ♗e5

But not 51 ♗xc5?? which allows the b-pawn to get through with 51...b2.

Now by giving up the bishop for the b-pawn White can draw by getting his king into the black pawns.

51...♘d3 52 ♗d4 ♔f7 53 f4 b2 54 ♗xb2 ♘xb2 55 c5 ♘a4 56 c6 ♔e7 57 ♔g2 ♘b6 58 c7 ♔d7 59 ♔h3 ♘xd5 60 ♔h4 ♘xc7

Or 60...h6 61 f5 gxf5 62 gxf5 ♘f6 63 g4 and Black runs out of pawns.

61 ♔g5 ♔e6 62 ♔h6 ♘d5 63 ♔xh7 ♔f7 64 ♔h6 ♔f6 65 g5+ ♔f7 66 ♔h7 ♘e3 67 ♔h8! ½-½

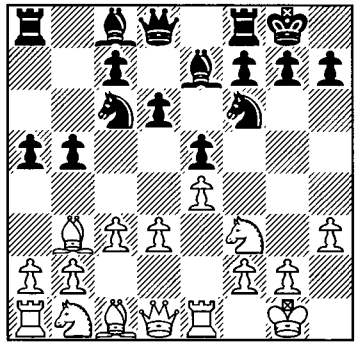
Black cannot make any progress: 67...♘f5 (or 67...♘g4 68 ♔h7) 68 g4 ♘e7 69 f5 gxf5 (69...♘xf5?? would even lose after 70 gxf5 gxf5 71 ♔h7) 70 gxf5 ♘xf5 with a draw.

Game 62

V.Bologan-Xie Jun

Shanghai 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 a5 10 d3



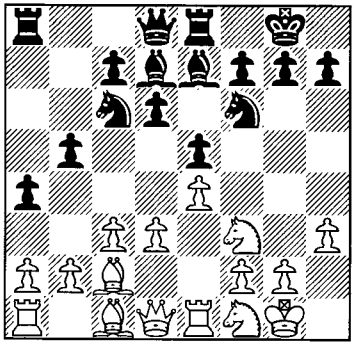
A slow plan where White decides to virtually ignore Black's queenside advance.

10...a4 11 ♗c2 ♗d7

I quite like 11...♗e6!? e.g. 12 ♘bd2 ♖e8 (12...d5!? 13 exd5 ♕xd5 14 ♕e2 ♖fe8, Borsony-Bernstein, corr 1963 is worth investigating as 15 ♘xe5, is then met by 15...♗xh3! 16 gxh3 ♘xe5) 13 d4 ♗d7, transposes to game 64, with both players having 'wasted' one tempo.

12 ♘bd2 ♖e8 13 ♘f1

Bringing the knight to the kingside before undertaking d3-d4 is the standard method. White's philosophy is that it's more difficult for Black to organise counterplay with the pawn on d3 as there is nothing to hit back at.



13...h6

A little over-cautious. I prefer 13...♗f8:

a) 14 ♗g5?! h6 15 ♗d2 allowed the liberating 15...d5! in Y.Kruppa-I.Zaitsev, Minsk 1993.

b) After 14 ♘3h2, White soon found himself in trouble in K.Jakubowski-Pi.Staniszewski, Polish Championship 2003 following 14...d5! 15 exd5 ♘xd5 16 ♘g3 b4 17 ♕f3?? bxc3! 18 bxc3 (18 ♕xd5 ♘b4 regains the piece and more) 18...♘xc3 as White was basically busted.

c) 14 ♘g3 g6 15 d4 ♗g7 16 ♗g5 h6 17 ♗e3 ♕e7 18 ♕d2 ♔h7 19 ♖ad1 ♖ed8, E.Raaste-P.Lehtivaara, Finnish Team Championship 1995, with a tense position. Black is ready for anything in the centre and his early queenside advance may come in useful.

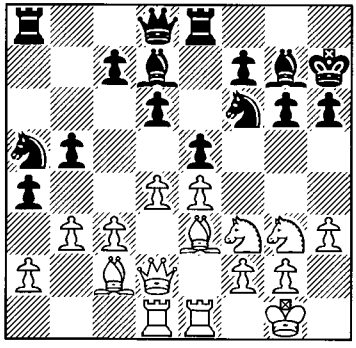
14 ♘g3

White can also try 14 a3 to stabilise the queenside pawns. He was thus able to obtain some light-squared pressure in the following two examples: 14...♘a5 15 ♘g3 ♗f8 16 ♘h2 d5!? 17 exd5 ♘xd5 18 ♘g4 ♗xg4 19 ♕xg4 ♖a6 20 ♗d2 ♘f6 21 ♕f3 ♖ae6 22 ♖ad1, S.Smagin-M.Hebden, Hastings 1990, and 19 hxg4 (rather than 19 ♕xg4) 19...c6 20 ♕f3 ♕d7 21 ♘e4, A.Galkin-L.Gorin, Koszalin 1999.

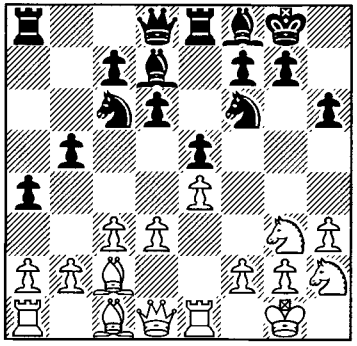
14...♗f8 15 ♘h2

White continues with a comparable plan to Game 64 except that the d-pawn is only on d3. Most players have decided that this is the moment to play 15 d4, but curiously Bologan never gets round to playing this natural move. Black then has an extra tempo, and can certainly consider 15...♘a5, but starting with 15...g6 also seems sensible.

So after 15 d4 g6 16 ♗e3 ♗g7 17 ♕d2 ♔h7 18 ♖ad1 ♘a5 19 b3, we reach the following position:



19...♕b8! (getting out of trouble on the d-file and ultimately preparing ...b4) 20 ♘h2, and now K.Arakhamia-P.Griffiths, Stockholm 1994 continued 20...axb3 21 axb3 ♘c6!? 22 f4?! (Consistent but weak. Instead 22 d5 is reasonable, but after 22...♘e7 Black is fairly comfortable with a plan based on ...♖d8 and ...c6. Otherwise 22 b4!? is interesting.) 22...b4!, with counterplay.



15...♘a5

Bologan recommends 15...d5 16 exd5 ♘xd5 17 ♗d2 ♗d6 18 a3, but still favours White slightly. As we saw in the note to White's 14th he will continue with ♘h2-g4 to retain the initiative.

16 f4 c5

With the pawn only on the restrained d3, Black doesn't have access to the c4-square, but in return there is only limited pressure on Black's centre.

17 ♘f3 ♘c6 18 a3 ♕c7 19 ♖f1 ♖a6 20 ♗e3 ♖c8 21 ♖c1 ♘a5 22 ♗b1

White perhaps retains a pull, but Black is gradually organising counterplay.

22...♖c6 23 ♖c2 b4 24 ♖cf2 bxc3 25 bxc3 ♘b3 26 ♘d2

Wedberg gives 26 ♘h4 d5 27 fxe5 ♕xe5 28 ♕f3 ♕xc3 29 exd5 as offering White an attack, but Black can cross this with 28...♗d6!.

Bologan instead suggests a refinement on the game with 26 ♗c2 ♖b6, and only now 27 ♘d2, when after 27...♘xd2 28 ♕xd2 ♗e7 29 ♕d1, Black's isolated a-pawn will require defending and so White can play for d3-d4 under potentially favourable circumstances.

26...d5! 27 fxe5 ♕xe5 28 ♘e2 ♘xd2 29 ♕xd2 ♗d6?

Leading to a forcing line that should be better for White. Instead there's nothing wrong with 29...dxe4.

30 ♗f4 ♕e7 31 exd5 ♘xd5 32 ♗xd6 ♖xd6 33 ♖xf7 ♕e3+

If 33...♕xf7, then 34 ♖xf7 ♔xf7 35 ♗a2.

34 ♕xe3 ♘xe3 35 ♗a2! c4 36 ♖1f3?

36 ♗xc4! would give White a clear endgame advantage after 36...♘xc4 37 dxc4 ♗e6 38 c5! ♖xc5 39 ♖f8+ ♔h7 40 ♘d4 ♗d5 41 ♖8f5.

36...♗c6 37 ♖xe3 ♔xf7 38 ♗xc4+ ♗d5 39 ♗xd5+ ♖xd5 40 c4 ♖d6 41 ♘c3 ♖b8 42 ♘b5 ♖f6 43 d4 ♖e8 44 ♖xe8 ♔xe8 45 c5 ♔d8!

45...♔d7? loses a tempo and allows 46 d5 ♖f5 47 c6+ ♔d8 48 c7+ ♔d7 49 c8♕+ winning.

46 ♘c3 ♖f4 47 ♘b5 ♖f6 48 ♘c3 ♖f4 49 ♘b5 ♖f6 ½-½

Game 63

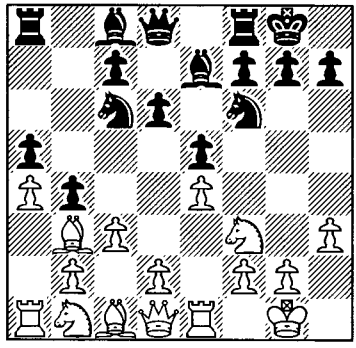
E.Gufeld-P.Blatny

Honolulu 1997

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 a5 10 a4

Blocking the advance of Black's a-pawn.

10...b4



11 d4

The restrained 11 d3 is comparable to 10 d3, see Game 62. Black can place his bishop on the active a6-f1 diagonal, an unusual idea so early in the Spanish, but White has the possibility of placing a piece on c4 which is perhaps his best chance of retaining a pull.

So 11 d3 ♗a6 12 ♕c2 ♖b8 13 ♘bd2 (White has access to the c4-square, so Black now gets ready) 13...♕c8:

a) White retained a small edge after 14 ♗c4 bxc3 15 bxc3 ♗xc4 16 ♘xc4 ♕e6 (16...♕a6, followed by doubling on the b-file is an alternative plan) 17 ♕e2 ♖fe8 18 ♗d2 ♗f8 19 ♖ab1 h6 20 ♖b5 ♖xb5 21 axb5 ♘a7 22 ♘xa5 ♘xb5 23 d4, S.Dolmatov-Y.Balashov, Moscow 2002.

b) 14 ♘c4 ♕b7 15 ♖b1 bxc3 16 bxc3 ♗xc4 17 dxc4 ♕a6 18 c5, A.Galliamova-Xie Jun, Kazan/Shenyang Match 1999, and now Black should probably play Tsaturian's suggestion of 18...dxc5 19 ♗d5 ♖xb1 20 ♕xb1 ♗d6, when she shouldn't be worse. The game continued instead with 18...♘d7?! 19 cxd6 ♗xd6 20 ♕a2, when Black had to face light-squared pressure.

11...bxc3 12 bxc3

It's logical to support the centre with a pawn but 12 ♘xc3 has been played several times over the years. The earliest example on my database seems the most convincing for Black: 12...♘xd4 13 ♘xd4 exd4 14 ♕xd4 ♖b8 15 ♗c4 c6 16 b3 ♘d7 17 ♗f4 ♗f6 18 ♕e3 ♘e5, A.Konstantinopolsky-I.Bondarevsky, USSR Championship 1948, and Black has the most dynamic possibilities.

12...exd4 13 cxd4

Capturing with the knight avoids allowing Black's knight to b4, but shouldn't lead to any advantage, e.g. 13 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 14 cxd4 d5 15 e5 ♘e4:

a) In M.Apicella-L.Kotan, Cappelle-la-Grande 2002 Black drifted into problems after 16 ♘d2 ♗f5?! 17 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 18 ♗c2 ♗xc2 19 ♕xc2 ♕d7 20 ♗a3, as White has the better pawn structure. But these problems can be avoided if Black instead plays 16...♘xd2! 17 ♗xd2 c5, with equality.

b) The other try 16 ♗a3 ♗b4! 17 ♗xb4 axb4 18 f3 ♘g5 19 f4 ♘e4 20 ♘d2 ♘c3 21 ♕h5 c5, as in R.Hübner-S.Agdestein, Wijk aan Zee 1988, leads to a complicated struggle where Black is probably better.

13...d5 14 ♘e5

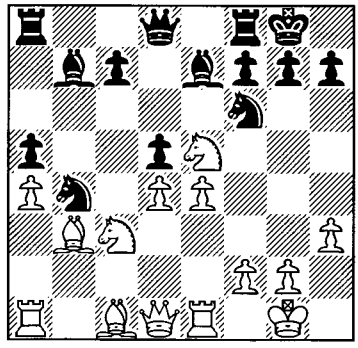
Black obtains actively placed pieces following 14 e5 ♘e4 15 ♘bd2 (equally so after 15 ♗f4 ♘b4 16 ♘a3 ♗a6, K.Lahno-V.Shinkevich, St.Petersburg 2002) 15...♗f5 16 ♗a3 ♘b4 17 ♘f1 c5, F.Hellers-V.Kupreichik, Malmo 1987/8.

Otherwise, the 14 ♘c3, of S.Joachim-LB.Hansen, Bundesliga 1999, should be met by Hansen's suggested 14...♗b4, when he considers 15 ♖e3 ♗xc3 16 ♖xc3 dxe4 17 ♖xc6 exf3 18 ♗g5 to be unclear.

14...♘b4

The inclusion of ...a5 by Black, and a4 by White, enables Black to sit snugly on this outpost.

15 ♘c3 ♗b7



16 ♗g5?!

Unnecessarily risky. Normal would be 16 exd5! ♘fxd5 17 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 18 ♕g4, when Black has to be careful. He could then try 18...♖a6, but White retains some chances.

16...♘xe4! 17 ♘xe4

If 17 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 18 ♘xe4 dxe4 19 ♖c1 ♖ad8, White doesn't obtain much compensation.

17...♗xg5 18 ♕h5 ♗e7 19 ♘c5 ♗xc5 20 dxc5 ♖a6

A neat move covering the third rank. In this variation Black has been able to use the a6-square for his bishop, queen and now rook. An evident justification for 9...a5!

21 ♖ad1 ♖h6 22 ♕f3 ♖f6 23 ♕c3 ♖e8

With the pressure off the f7-square Black can finally develop this rook. White retains only enough pressure to win back his pawn.

24 ♘c4 ♖xe1+ 25 ♕xe1 ♖e6 26 ♕c3 c6 27 ♘xa5??

A dreadful blunder from an experienced grandmaster. White should first play 27 ♖d4 (preparing to capture on a5) and if 27...♗a6 28 ♘xa5 ♘d3, then this is refuted by the combination 29 ♘xc6! ♖xc6 30 ♗xd5 ♖xc5 31 ♗c4. So Black should meet 27 ♖d4 with the prudent 27...♗c8 28 ♘xa5 ♕xa5 29 ♖xb4 h6, and settle for equality.

27...♕xa5 28 ♖d4 ♖e4

White doesn't win back his piece and can already resign.

29 ♖xe4 dxe4 30 ♕d2 e3 31 fxe3 ♕xc5 32 ♕d7 ♕xe3+ 33 ♔h1 ♕e1+ 34 ♔h2 ♕e5+ 35 ♔g1 ♕b8 36 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 0-1

Game 64

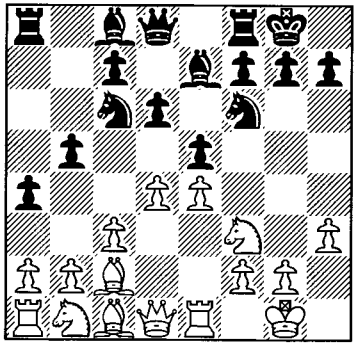
F.Vallejo Pons-R.Ponomariov

Leon 2003

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 a5 10 d4 a4

Black continues the a-pawn advance to gain space and push the bishop to a less active square.

11 ♗c2



11...♗d7

Opening the centre with 11...exd4?! is wrong. It allows White to obtain attacking chances due to the freeing up of the b1-h7 diagonal e.g. 12 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 13 cxd4 d5 14 e5 ♘e4 15 ♘d2 ♘xd2 16 ♗xd2 ♗e6 17 ♗h6! (ouch!), B.Martin-C.Garcia Palermo, Benasque 1990, and after the further 17...gxh6 18 ♕d3 f5 19 exf6 ♖xf6 20 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 21 ♗g6, Black was in serious trouble.

12 ♘bd2

Here 12 ♘a3 hits the b5-pawn which will now require some attention: 12...♕b8 13 d5 (better than 13 ♗d3 exd4 14 cxd4 ♘b4 15 ♗f1 ♕b7 16 d5 ♘a6 17 ♘d4 b4 18 ♘c4 ♘c5 19 f3 ♖fe8, C.Bauer-M.Nezar, Montpellier 1999, when Black had no particular problems) 13...♘a7 14 ♗d3 h6 15 ♗d2 c6 16 dxc6 ♗xc6 17 ♘c2 ♕b7 18 ♕e2 ♗d7 19 ♘h2 ♖fe8 20 ♘g4 gave White a small initiative in Z.Hracek-D.Blagojevic, Yugoslavia Team Championship 2001 (there's the plan of occupying the d5-square with the knight).

Less challenging is 12 ♗e3, which can be met by 12...exd4 13 cxd4 ♘b4, when White must part with his 'Lopez bishop'. The game L.Psakhis-S.Smagin, Sochi 1988, then continued 14 ♘c3 ♘xc2 15 ♕xc2 b4 16 ♘e2, when 16...c5 17 d5 ♖e8 wasn't bad, but Romanishin's 16...d5 17 e5 ♘e4 with equality is simpler.

12...♖e8 13 ♘f1 h6

Instead 13...♗f8 is likely to transpose, but note the unique continuation of Liang Jinrong-V.Tkachiev, Manila Olympiad 1992: 14 d5 ♘a5 15 b3 ♘xb3 16 axb3 axb3 17 ♖xa8 bxc2 18 ♖xd8 cxd1♕ 19 ♖xe8 ♕d3 20 ♖d8 h6, when things were far from clear.

14 ♘g3 ♗f8 15 ♗d2!

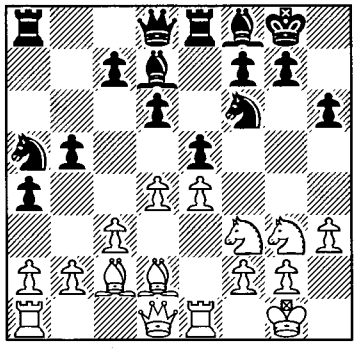
Stronger than the more popular 15 ♘h2:

a) In Y.Balashov-S.Smagin, Berlin 1990, Black tried the provocative 15...g6!? 16 f4 a3 17 bxa3 exf4 18 ♗xf4 ♖xa3 19 ♕d2 ♘a5.

b) More common is 15...♘a5 16 f4 (here 16 b3!?, can be met with 16...axb3 17 axb3 b4) 16...♘c4 (but not 16...c5? 17 dxe5 dxe5 18 fxe5 ♖xe5 19 ♗f4, which left Black in

trouble in J.Benjamin-I.Ivanov, USA Championship 1989) 17 ♖b1 c5 18 fxe5 dxe5 19 b3 axb3 20 axb3 ♘a3 21 ♗xa3 ♖xa3 22 dxe5 ♘h7 23 ♘f5 ♗c6 24 ♕f3 ♖xe5, P.Wolff-Y.Razuvaev, New York 1989, and Black was fine. The lack of a dark-squared bishop limits White's attacking chances.

15...♘a5



16 b3!

Cutting short Black's plans of coming to c4. The FIDE World Champion isn't able to find an active role for the knight on a5 and he now slips into a passive game.

16...axb3 17 axb3 c5

Unlike in the analogous position in the note to White's 15th, here 17...b4? is not possible, as 18 cxb4 ♘c6 19 d5, is horrible for Black.

Otherwise 17...c6 18 ♗e3 ♕c7 19 ♘d2 c5 20 d5 was also unpleasant for Black, B.Spassky-A.Arutiunov, Moscow 1965

18 d5 ♕c7 19 ♘h2 c4 20 b4 ♘b7

As in a number of Chigorin lines this knight on b7 has nowhere much to go. The idea of ...f6 and ...♘f7 crops up in the Chigorin but, as always, requires preparation.

21 ♕f3 ♘h7 22 ♘g4 ♖ec8 23 ♗e3 ♕d8!

With two ideas in mind. Exchanging rooks on the a-file and keeping a check on kingside developments.

24 ♗a7 g6 25 ♗e3 ♕h4 26 ♕e2 h5 27 ♘h2 ♕d8

Again diverting White with the intention of exchanging rooks, and after...

28 ♗a7

...taking the c1-h6 diagonal with...

28...♗h6 29 ♖a6 ♕e7 30 ♖ea1 f6?!

Up to here Ponomariov has defended cautiously, but he probably should have avoided this tempting (to get the knight to f7) but weakening move. It would have been better to avoid touching his pawns for the moment as White doesn't have any clear targets.

31 ♘f3 ♘d8 32 ♘h4 ♗e8?

If 32...♘f8, then 33 ♘xg6!? ♘xg6 34 ♕xh5 ♕g7 35 ♖xd6 would offer White three pawns and continuing threats for the piece, but it would still be a better option than the game.

33 ♖1a5?

Time trouble was probably the reason why White missed 33 ♘gf5! gxf5 34 ♘xf5 ♕f8 35 ♘xd6 ♖c7 36 ♗c5, leaving Black in a tangle.

33...♗g5 34 ♘f3 ♗f4 35 ♗e3 ♖xa6 36 ♖xa6 ♘f7

Finally getting out of the way! From f7 the knight helps cover d6 and the king.

37 ♕d2 ♗xe3 38 ♕xe3 ♕d8 39 ♘h4 ♘f8

Although Black is still passive, the fact that the bishop on c2 doesn't contribute limits the effect of the bind.

40 ♕a7 ♖c7 41 ♕b6 ♖c8 42 ♕a7 ♖c7 43 ♕e3 ♖c8 44 ♕a7 ♖c7 ½-½

Game 65

J.Polgar-H.Schussler

Vejstrup 1989

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗e6

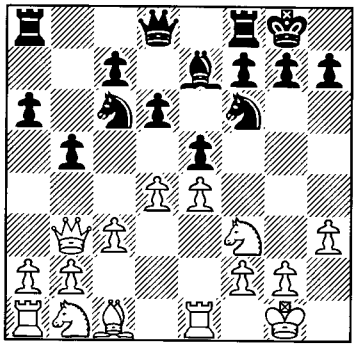
Black hopes to ease his defence by exchanging a pair of bishops.

10 d4

Although 10 ♗xe6 fxe6 temporarily doubles Black's pawns, this is at the cost of

opening the f-file for Black. Furthermore if White is to play d2-d4, to challenge Black's central pawn mass, they may not stay doubled for long: 11 d4 exd4 (11...♕e8!? 12 ♘bd2 ♕g6 is interesting. Black gets good piece play in the case of 13 dxe5 dxe5.) 12 cxd4 d5 13 e5 ♘d7 14 ♗e3 ♕e8 15 ♘bd2 ♘b4, P.Wolff-S.Conquest, Hastings 1990, and Black was fine.

10...♗xb3 11 ♕xb3



11...d5!?

An energetic response. If however the main game proves to be somewhat superior for White, as I suspect, then Black players may well like to think about seeking an alternative here.

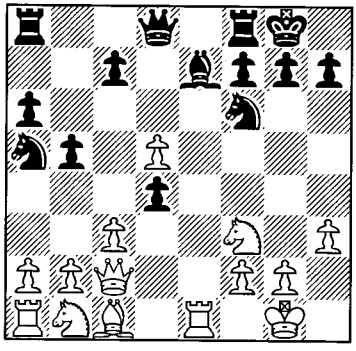
It perhaps useful to remark that with a queen on b3 Black often gains a timely tempo with ...♘a5, and without light-squared bishops, the opening of the centre doesn't give White so many possibilities. Bearing these thoughts in mind, let's see how Black has got on in practice:

a) Black was able to equalise after 11...♕d7 12 ♘bd2 ♘a5 13 ♕c2 exd4 14 cxd4 c5 15 e5 dxe5 16 dxc5 ♕c7 17 ♘xe5 ♕xc5 18 ♕xc5 ♗xc5 19 ♘df3 h6, A.Matanovic-H.Pfleger, Hamburg 1965, but as this hasn't been tested recently there's obviously plenty of scope for improvement.

b) 11...♖e8 12 ♘bd2 exd4 13 cxd4 ♘a5 14 ♕d1 (after 14 ♕c2 c5 15 b3 cxd4 16 ♘xd4 ♖c8 17 ♕d3 ♘c6 18 ♘xc6 ♖xc6 19 ♗b2 ♘d7 20 ♘f3 ♗f8, A.Kosten-V.Smyslov, Hastings 1988/89 was agreed drawn, but White may still have a slight pull) 14...c5 15 ♘f1 ♗f8 16 ♘g3 cxd4 (an attempted improvement on their 4th match game which continued 16...♘c6 17 d5 ♘e5 18 ♘xe5 ♖xe5 19 ♗f4 ♖e8 20 ♕f3, N.Ioseliani-M.Chiburdanidze, Telavi Match (game 4) 1988, with some pressure for White) 17 ♘xd4 g6 18 ♗f4 ♕b6 19 ♖c1 ♗g7 20 ♘f3 ♘c4, N.Ioseliani-M.Chiburdanidze, Telavi Match (game 6) 1988, and with the knight coming to e5 Black was OK.

The paucity of material makes any conclusions premature, but there's certainly scope for individual input. However finding an antidote to 11 axb3, see Games 66-67, is an even greater challenge for the second player.

12 exd5 ♘a5 13 ♕c2 exd4



14 cxd4

The other recapture 14 ♘xd4 comes into consideration, but according to Dorfman and Nikitin Black can equalise with 14...♖e8 15 ♗g5 ♘xd5 16 ♗xe7 ♘xe7 17 ♘d2 ♘ac6! 18 ♘xc6 ♘xc6 19 a4 ♕d5.

14...♘xd5 15 ♘c3 c6

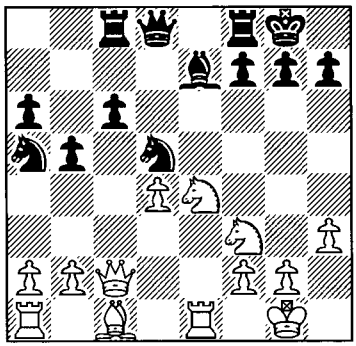
According to Short, 15...♘xc3 doesn't equalise: 16 ♕xc3 ♘c4 17 ♗f4 ♗d6 (or if 17...a5, then 18 ♖e2 ♗d6 19 ♗xd6 cxd6 20 b3 ♘b6 21 ♖ae1, with the better game for White, N.De Firmian-L.Christiansen, USA Championship 1986) 18 ♗xd6 ♕xd6 19 ♖ac1 ♖ac8 20 b3 ♘b6 21 ♘e5 ♖fe8 22 ♘c6

♘d5 23 ♕a5 ♖xe1+ 24 ♕xe1 g6, N.Short-P.Van der Sterren, Wijk aan Zee 1986, and now instead of 25 ♖c5, White can obtain an advantageous rook ending after 25 ♕e5 ♕xe5 26 dxe5 ♔f8 27 ♖c5 ♘e7 28 f4 ♔e8 29 ♔f2 ♔d7 30 ♘xe7 ♔xe7 31 ♖c6.

16 ♘e4

16 b3 is similar to the note to White's 17th; Black should continue with 16...♖c8, with ...♘b7 to follow.

16...♖c8



17 ♘c5

A number of players have tried 17 b3, but have failed to retain anything from the opening: 17...♘b7 18 ♗g5 (if 18 ♗d2, then 18...c5, Pe.Popovic-Pr.Nikolic, Belgrade 1989) 18...f6 19 ♗d2 ♖e8 20 ♖ad1. This move at least makes ...c5 less desirable, unlike in L.Brunner-Pr.Nikolic, Lucerne 1989, where 20 ♖e2 was immediately countered by 20...c5. Nevertheless, Black doesn't seem too concerned, e.g. 20...♕d7 21 ♖e2 ♗f8 22 ♖de1 ♖e7 23 ♕d3 ♖ce8 24 ♔f1 g6 and Black has more or less equalised, N.Short-J.Van der Wiel, Rotterdam 1989.

17...♗xc5 18 ♘g5!

Judit Polgar, true to her style, tries to liven things up. Instead 18 dxc5 ♕f6 19 ♗g5 ♕g6 20 ♕xg6 hxg6 21 b3 ♘b7 22 ♖ac1 ♖fe8, J.Timman-Pr.Nikolic, Tilburg 1990, led to a balanced ending.

18...♘f6 19 dxc5 ♕d5 20 ♗f4 ♖fe8 21 ♖ad1?!

This pawn sacrifice is dangerous but probably not best. Instead I prefer 21 b4! ♕c4 22 ♕d2 ♘b7 23 ♗e5 etc.

21...♕xa2 22 ♗e5 h6 23 ♗xf6 hxg5 24 ♗c3!?

More tricky than 24 ♗xg5 ♘c4 25 ♗c1 ♕a5, when Black is getting organised.

24...b4!

Rather then 24...♘c4, which would leave the queen estranged from her king after 25 ♕f5!.

25 ♗xb4 ♕b3 26 ♕d2 ♘c4 27 ♖xe8+

Polgar probably rejected the immediate 27 ♕d7 because of 27...♖ed8! 28 ♕xd8+ ♖xd8 29 ♖xd8+ ♔h7.

27...♖xe8 28 ♕d7 ♖e6 29 ♗c3 ♘xb2 30 ♖c1 ♘a4 31 ♗a1 f6 32 ♔h2 ♔h7 33 ♕d4 ♖e2 34 ♕g4 ♕b8+ 35 ♔g1 ♕e8??

After a sturdy defence Black finally cracks. Here 35...♕f4! was necessary and strong. Then White's best is 36 ♕h5+ (36 ♕xe2?! ♕xc1+ 37 ♔h2 ♔h6! gives serious winning chances for Black) 36...♔g8 37 ♕xe2 ♕xc1+ 38 ♔h2 ♔f8 39 ♕xa6 ♕xa1 40 ♕c8+ ♔e7 41 ♕c7+, with a probable draw.

36 ♕xa4 ♖e1+ 37 ♖xe1 ♕xe1+ 38 ♔h2 ♕xa1??

In time trouble, Black clearly overlooked that this bishop was defended.

39 ♕xa1 1-0

Game 66

V.Anand-M.Adams

Linares Match (Game 3) 1994

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗e6 10 d4 ♗xb3 11 axb3

White captures towards the centre and obtains influence on the a-file.

11...exd4

Opening the centre seeking activity. This approach has the advantage of devaluing the doubled b-pawns and obtaining access to the b4-square. In return White obtains a mobile

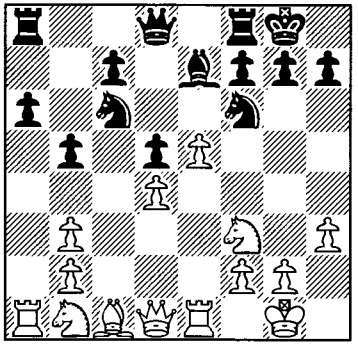
pawn centre.

The problem with the alternatives outlined below is that White can play d4-d5, and then c3-c4 when the forward b-pawn helps to support the centre.

a) Against 11...♕d7, the immediate 12 d5 is recommended. The main line is then 12...♘d8 13 c4 c6 14 ♘c3 b4 15 dxc6 ♕xc6 16 ♘d5 ♘xd5 17 cxd5 ♕b5 18 ♕e2 ♘b7 19 ♗e3 ♘a5 20 ♘d2, A.Cherepkov-V.Tarasov, USSR Championship 1961, when White keeps an edge.

b) 11...♖e8 12 d5 ♘b8 13 c4 c6 14 dxc6!? (otherwise after 14 ♕d3 b4 15 ♗d2 c5 16 ♗e3 ♘bd7 17 ♘bd2 h6 18 ♘f1 ♘h7 19 ♘g3 ♗g5 20 ♘f5, Black has to watch the usual kingside manoeuvres plus the constant pressure on the semi-open a-file, L.Psakhis-S.Smagin, Protvino 1988) 14...♘xc6 15 ♗g5 bxc4 16 bxc4 ♕b6 (after the continuation 16...♘d7 17 ♗e3 ♕b8 18 ♖e2 ♖c8 19 ♘c3 ♘b4 20 b3, S.Dolmatov-Pr.Nikolic, Hastings 1989/90, White retained a small edge) 17 ♖e2 ♘a5 18 ♘bd2 ♖eb8 19 b3 h6 20 ♗e3 ♕c7, S.Smagin-A.Villeneuve, Paris 1990, and White didn't have much. The knight on d2 defends well, but is more active if it can get to c3 as in Dolmatov-Nikolic. With this in mind White should have gone for 18 ♗xf6! (instead of 18 ♘bd2) 18...♗xf6 19 ♘c3, with a clear advantage as 19...♘xc4? is strongly met by 20 ♘d5 ♕d8 21 ♖c2.

12 cxd4 d5 13 e5



13...♘e4

Instead 13...♘d7 14 ♘c3 ♘b4 15 ♗e3 ♖b8 16 ♘a2 ♘xa2 17 ♖xa2 ♖b6 18 ♗d2 ♘b8 19 b4 gave White a clear positional advantage in Ki.Georgiev-B.Ivanovic, Belgrade 2000.

14 ♘c3 f5 15 exf6 ♗xf6!?

This complicated pawn sacrifice received much interest in the mid-nineties.

After the alternative line 15...♘xf6 16 ♗g5, experience favours White:

a) Black didn't have enough for the pawn in V.Dimitrov-Pr.Nikolic, Elenite 1993 after 16...♘b4 17 ♘xb5! h6 18 ♗h4 ♕d7 19 ♘c3 ♗d6 20 ♕b1 ♘h5 21 ♘e5!.

b) Nikolic's more recent try was 16...b4 17 ♘e2 ♘e4 18 ♗e3 ♗d6 19 ♕d3 ♕c8 20 ♘e5 ♕b7 21 ♘f4 ♘xe5 22 dxe5 ♗xe5 23 ♘xd5 ♖fe8 24 ♖ad1, V.Anand-Pr.Nikolic, Monaco rapid 1999, when White kept a slight pull as his pieces were better co-ordinated.

c) 16...h6 17 ♗h4 ♘h5 18 ♗xe7 ♘xe7 19 g3 leaves White somewhat better according to Efimov.

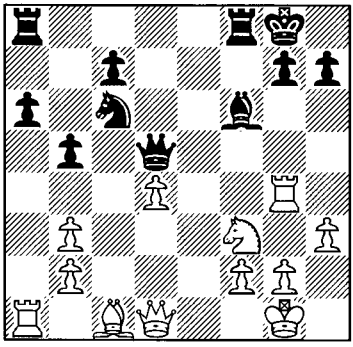
16 ♘xe4

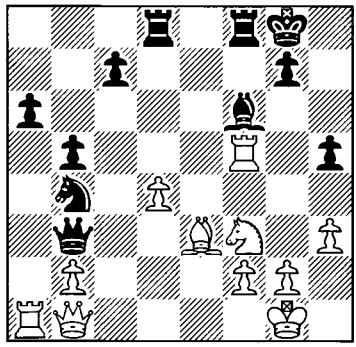
Instead the continuation 16 ♗f4 ♕d7 17 ♘xe4 dxe4 18 ♖xe4 ♖ad8 19 ♖xa6 ♘xd4 20 ♘xd4 ♗xd4 21 ♕c2, as in J.Murey-M.Sharif, Lyon 1993, gives White a persistent edge even after the tricky 21...♖xf4 22 ♖xf4 ♗e5 23 ♕e4!. This is however rather academic as Black should play 16...♗h4! (rather than 16...♕d7) 17 ♘xe4 ♖xf4, with no particular problems as in A.Martinez Gonzalez-J.Planas, Mallorca 1999.

16...dxe4 17 ♖xe4 ♕d5 18 ♖g4!

Provoking ...h5 before heading for the f4-square. This seems to be a better try than going there immediately, as then it seems that Black can claim enough play for the pawn:

18 ♖f4 ♖ad8 (18...♘e5 19 ♘xe5 ♗xe5, has been played but 20 ♕h5! looks strong) 19 ♗e3 ♘b4 20 ♖a3 c5 21 ♕b1 cxd4 22 ♘xd4 ♗g5 23 ♖xf8+ ♖xf8 24 ♗xg5 ♕xg5 25 ♘e6 ♕f5, and Black was able to hold in M.Adams-R.Polaczek, Haringey 1989.





18...h5

Well analysed, but equally unsatisfactory it seems is 18...♘e7 e.g. 19 ♗h6 ♘f5 20 ♗g5 and now:

a) 20...♗xg5 21 ♖xg5 h6 22 ♖g4 c5 23 dxc5 ♕xc5 24 b4, and White has reasonable chances of exploiting the extra pawn, J.Van der Wiel-A.Beliavsky, Amsterdam 1989.

Of course the question arises as to what happens if Black tries to hit the rook with a timely ...h5. The complications favour White on the basis of these two examples:

b) 20...h5 21 ♖f4 ♗xg5 22 ♘xg5 ♘xd4 23 ♖xf8+ ♖xf8 24 ♕xh5 ♕f5 25 ♕h4 ♘e2+ 26 ♔h1, A. de Souza-V. de Oliveira, corr 1996.

c) 20...♖ad8 21 ♖xa6 h5 22 ♖f4 ♗xd4 23 ♕c2 ♗e5 24 ♘xe5 ♕xe5 25 ♗xd8 ♕xf4 26 ♗xc7, P.Zarnicki-J.Rubinetti, Argentine Championship 1999.

19 ♖f4 ♖ad8

The rash 19...g5? is asking for trouble. Anand refutes it with 20 ♘xg5!, e.g. 20...♗xg5 21 ♕xh5!, or 20...♕xg5 21 ♖g4 hxg4 22 ♗xg5 ♗xg5 23 ♕xg4, winning in either case.

20 ♗e3 ♘b4

Although 20...g5 is still bad, this time it's because of 21 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 22 ♗xg5.

21 ♕b1!

Giving back the pawn to strive for an initiative.

21...♕xb3 22 ♖f5

We can see that with the h-pawn on h5 Black's kingside is shaky. The same idea would have distinctly less punch if it were on h7, see the note to White's 18th.

22...♕c2

Hoping to hold the inferior double-rook ending that follows.

Against all alternatives White has the advantage as analysed by Anand:

a) 22...♖d5 23 ♖a3! ♕c4 24 ♖c3.

b) 22...g6 23 ♖g5!.

c) 22...♕f7 23 ♘g5 ♕g6 (or if 23...♕b3, then 24 ♖xb5 ♗xg5 25 ♖xg5) 24 ♘e6.

d) The best of the bunch is perhaps 22...♘c2!?, which keep White's advantage to a minimum after 23 ♖xa6 ♘xe3 24 fxe3 ♕xe3+ 25 ♔h1.

23 ♕xc2 ♘xc2 24 ♖xa6 ♖fe8 25 ♗g5 ♗xg5 26 ♖xg5 ♘xd4 27 ♘xd4 ♖xd4 28 ♖c6!

A clear improvement over 28 ♖xh5? ♖b4 29 ♖c5 ♖e7 30 ♖c2 c5, when Black equalised and went on to draw in V.Anand-M.Sharif, Oviedo 1993. White could consider 28 ♖ag6 ♖e7 29 ♖xb5, which also looks promising.

28...♖e7 29 ♖xb5! h4

Doubling on the seventh is always worthy of considerations in such endings but here after 29...♖d1+ 30 ♔h2 ♖d2 31 f3!? ♖ee2, Black's counterplay is killed off by 32 ♖g5.

30 ♔h2! ♖d2 31 f3 ♖f7

If 31...♖e1, (hoping for doubling on the eighth and mate) then the cool 32 ♖c4 chops

off the h-pawn and the king will run via g3.

32 ♖c3 ♖f6 33 ♖g5 c6

After 33...♖xb2 34 ♖xc7 g6, White has 35 ♖g4!, which soon picks off a second pawn due to the plan ♖c7-c3 (defending the f3-square) followed by ♖xh4.

34 b4 ♖d4 35 ♖g4 ♖fd6 36 ♖xc6! 1-0

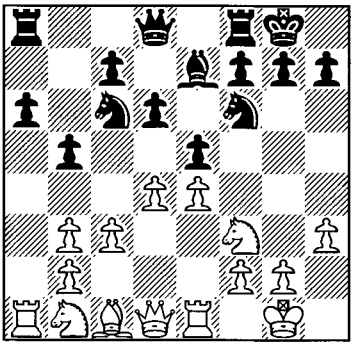
Neat. After 36 ♖xc6 ♖xg4, White has 37 ♖c8+ coming out a second pawn to the good.

Game 67

B.Gelfand-A.Mikhalchishin

Istanbul Olympiad 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗e6 10 d4 ♗xb3 11 axb3



11...exd4 12 cxd4 ♘b4

Seeking immediate action in the centre with 12...d5 was the subject of Game 66.

13 d5

White can also opt for quick development with 13 ♘c3 c5 14 ♗f4, against which Black has tried three moves:

a) Bringing both rooks to the centre with 14...♕b6 15 ♕d2 ♖ad8!? 16 ♖ad1 ♖fe8 17 d5 (calmly taking space and cutting off Black's queen from her king) 17...♘d7 18 ♘e2 ♗f6 19 ♘g3 g6 20 ♗g5, A.Kovalev-L.Kotan, Tatranska Lomnica 1999, leaves White with the advantage on the kingside. Closing the centre with d4-d5 and bringing the knight to g3 seems to be White's best plan here. However if Black had the rook on c8 (rather than d8) the black queen could return and defend with ...♕d8 if necessary.

b) 14...c4!? (gaining access to the d3-square, but White is able to play around the intrusive knight) 15 bxc4 bxc4 16 ♗g5 ♘d3 17 ♖e2 ♘h5 18 ♗e3 f5 19 exf5 ♖xf5 20 ♕a4, V.Ivanchuk-S.Agdestein, Tilburg 1989 and White was somewhat better.

c) 14...♖e8 15 ♖e2 (it's worth comparing this with 15 ♕d2 ♕b6 16 d5 ♘d7 17 ♖e2 ♗f6 18 ♖ae1 ♖ac8, A.Kolarov-B.Lengyel, Luhacovice 1969, which was a quick draw) 15...♕b6:

c1) 16 e5 dxe5 17 dxe5 ♖ed8 18 ♖d2 ♘e8 19 ♕e2 ♘c7 gave Black a grip onto d5 and e6 and he was thus happy enough, N.Short-Je.Piket, Amsterdam 1993.

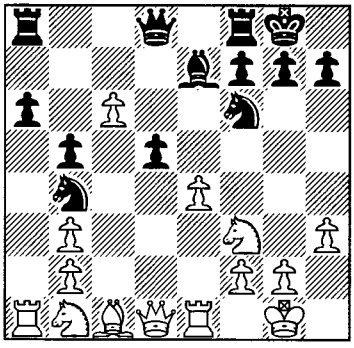
c2) Otherwise 16 ♖d2 ♖ad8 17 e5 dxe5 18 dxe5 ♖xd2! (after 18...♘h5?!, simply 19 ♗e3 should yield an edge) 19 ♕xd2 ♘h5! (but not 19...♖d8? 20 exf6! ♖xd2 21 fxe7, and White comes out with rook and two pieces for the queen) 20 ♗e3 ♖d8 and Black takes the initiative.

So tentatively, we can conclude that Black should choose 'c'.

13...c5

Without this move, Black can't easily cover his weaknesses: 13...♘d7 14 ♗d2!? ♘d3 (14...c5 is no improvement, e.g. 15 dxc6 ♘xc6 16 ♗f4 ♘f6 17 ♘c3 ♕c7 18 ♕d2 ♘b4 19 ♖ad1, D.Barria-G.Arburic Castro, Santiago de Chile 1997, with clearly the more comfortable game for White) 15 ♖e2 ♗f6 16 ♕c2 ♘3e5 (trying to shield the queenside with 16...♘3c5 isn't that convincing either: 17 ♗e3 ♖e8 18 ♘bd2 a5 19 ♗d4 a4 20 ♖ae1 ♗xd4 21 ♘xd4 ♕f6 22 ♘c6 ♘b6 23 b4 ♘a6, L.Yudasin-G.Kuzmin, USSR Championship 1990, and now 24 ♘b1!, in order to hit at b5 is unpleasant for Black) 17 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 18 ♘c3, with a space advantage for White who can play against Black's queenside weaknesses or go for more with f2-f4.

14 dxc6 d5!?



In Z.Lanka-G.Lane, Cappelle la Grande 1994, Black simply recaptured on c6 but was unable to equalise. White's ability to put pressure on f5 and d5 makes Black regret the lack of a light-squared bishop: 14...♘xc6 15 ♘c3 ♖e8 16 ♗f4 ♗f8 17 ♘d4 ♘b4 18 ♕f3 ♘d7 19 ♖ad1 ♕f6 20 ♘f5 ♘e5 21 ♕g3 ♕g6 22 ♖e3, and White kept an edge.

15 e5 ♘e4 16 ♘c3 ♘xc3 17 bxc3 ♘xc6 18 ♕d3 ♕d7

English GM Nigel Davies played a few games with 18...♖e8, but was forced to abandon this line after the following which convincingly refuted his idea: 19 e6! fxe6 20 ♖xe6 ♕d7 21 ♖e2 b4 22 ♗b2! bxc3 23 ♗xc3 a5 24 ♘e5 ♘xe5 25 ♖xe5, L.Shmuter-N.Davies, Rishon le Ziyyon 1995, and Black loses at least one of his weaklings.

19 ♖a2 ♕e6

Not 19...h6?!, as this allows the tactical shot 20 e6! fxe6 21 ♗xh6.

20 ♗g5 ♖fd8 21 ♗xe7 ♕xe7

If instead 21...♘xe7, then 22 ♘d4 ♕g6 23 ♕f3 keeps up the pressure. Black has chronic weaknesses on a6 and d5.

22 ♖ae2 h6?!

According to Gelfand, Black should defend with 22...♕e6 23 b4 h6 24 ♘d4 ♘xd4 25 cxd4 ♖dc8 26 f4 f5, when his weak points are well covered.

23 e6! ♖d6 24 exf7+ ♕xf7 25 ♘e5 ♘xe5 26 ♖xe5 ♖d7?

This proves to be too passive as it allows a white rook onto the third rank. This in turn enables White to ultimately win a pawn. Instead Black should first throw in 26...♖f8 27 ♕d4, and only then play 27...♖d7, when White will have a hard time to make anything of his advantage.

27 ♖1e3! ♖d6 28 ♖e7 ♕f6 29 ♖b7 ♖f8 30 ♖f3 ♕d8 31 ♕d4

Good, but 31 ♖g3 ♖d7 32 ♕xd5+! was even stronger.

31...♖g6 32 ♖xf8+ ♕xf8 33 ♕xd5+ ♔h7 34 ♕e4 ♕c5

White's pin is a nuisance but wouldn't have been quite so serious after 34...♕d6! stopping the rook coming to the d-file.

35 ♖d7 a5 36 ♖d5 ♕c6 37 h4 ♔g8 38 ♕d3 a4 39 ♕xb5 ♕xc3 40 bxa4?

With more time Gelfand surely would have played 40 ♕e8+ ♔h7 41 ♕e4, which would have been curtains, as h4-h5 is again threatened.

40...♕e1+ 41 ♔h2 ♕xf2 42 ♕e8+ ♔h7 43 ♕e4 ♕g3+ 44 ♔g1 ♕g4 45 ♖d4 ♕xe4 46 ♖xe4 ♖g3

So Black survives into an ending which may even be drawn.

47 ♔f2 ♖a3 48 g4 ♔g6 49 ♖f4 ♖h3 50 a5 ♖a3 51 ♖f5 ♔h7 52 ♖b5 ♖a4 53 ♔f3 ♔g8 54 h5 ♔f7

As pointed out by Gelfand 54...g5! (fixing the g4-pawn and gaining freedom for the king) would make the win problematic.

55 ♖b7+ ♔f6 56 ♖b6+ ♔e5 57 a6 ♖a3+ 58 ♔e2 ♔d4 59 ♖d6+ ♔e4 60 ♔d2 ♔e5 61 ♖g6 ♔d5 62 ♔c2 ♔c4 63 ♔b2 ♖a5 64 ♖xg7 ♖xa6 65 ♖g6 ♖a4 66 ♖xh6 ♔d5 67 ♖g6 1-0

Summary

Although 9...♕d7 may have some independent significance, it is closely allied with some of the early games in Chapter 5. A roundabout route perhaps, but nevertheless another road heading into Zaitsev territory.

The move 9...a5 has the merit of surprise value and may not be much worse than other ninth moves. Even so, the principled reaction 10 d4, as in Game 64, should yield a pull for White.

I can't recommend 9...♗e6, unless Black can find a way to cope with 11 axb3, as featured in Games 66 & 67.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 h3 ♗e6

9...♕d7 – *Game 61*

9...a5 *(D)*

10 d4 – *Game 64*

10 a4 – *Game 63*

10 d3 -*Game 62*

10 d4

10 ♗xe6 – *Game 65 notes*

10...♗xb3 11 axb3

11 ♕xb3 – *Game 65* 11...d5 12 exd5 ♘a5 13 ♕c2 exd4 14 cxd4 ♘xd5 15 ♘c3 c6 *(D)*

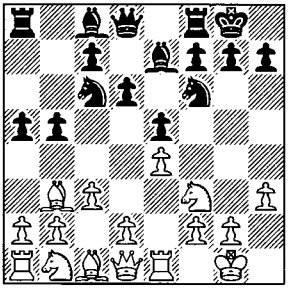
11...exd4

Others – *Game 67 notes*

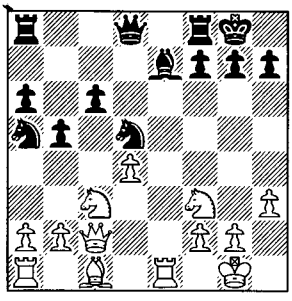
12 cxd4 d5

12...♘b4 – *Game 67*

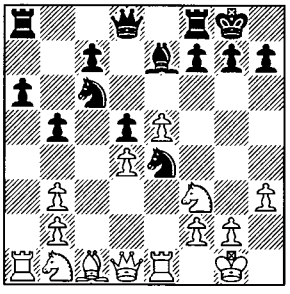
13 e5 ♘e4 *(D)* – *Game 66*



9...a5



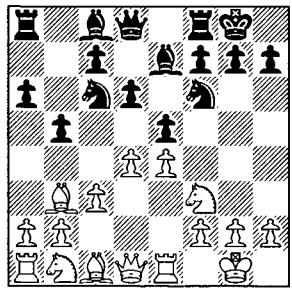
15...c6



13...♘e4

CHAPTER NINE

White Plays 9 d4



1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 d4

By taking immediate action in the centre White forces the pace and has a greater say about the type of middlegame that will arise. Some of the variations are quite tricky and Black needs to be prepared.

As various systems in the first eight chapters are particularly popular at the moment, it's not surprising that there is a tendency in some quarters to try and avoid an opponent's pet line. This chapter represents one of the better ways of doing so.

The direct 9 d4, without the preparatory h2-h3, is best met by 9...♗g4 pressurising the d4-point. White can then protect this with 10 ♗e3 (Games 68 & 69), or advance the d-pawn with a gain of time.

After the most common 10 d5 (Games 70-72), the further 10...♘a5 11 ♗c2 is typically followed with the traditional 11...c6, where Black hits back at the White centre. Nowadays 11...♕c8 is gaining in popularity so that 12 h3 can be met by 12...♗d7, but although ...c6 is temporarily delayed it's still the major counter in Black's armoury. After 11...c6 12 h3, Black generally opts for 12...♗c8, although 12...♗xf3 seems to be a reasonable option as illustrated in McShane-Nikolic, Game 71.

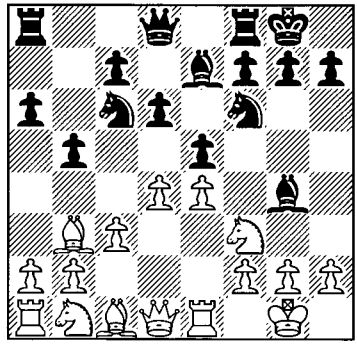
Older assessments are being tested by a new generation of players and 9 d4 shouldn't be underestimated.

Game 68

J.Van der Wiel-J.Timman

Tilburg 1983

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 d4 ♗g4



If White insists on playing d2-d4 without first avoiding this possibility with h2-h3, then Black should naturally 'punish' him by pinning, to create pressure on the d4-point.

Nevertheless Black could consider the

relatively unexplored alternative 9...exd4!? 10 cxd4, and only now 10...♗g4 e.g. 11 ♘c3 (11 ♗e3 will probably transpose to lines covered below or to Game 69) 11...♗xf3!? (I prefer this to 11...♘a5 12 ♗c2 c5 13 dxc5 dxc5 14 e5 ♕xd1 15 ♖xd1 ♘d7 16 h3 ♗e6 17 ♘d5 ♗xd5 18 ♖xd5 ♘b6 19 ♖d1 ♖ad8 20 ♗g5, Em.Lasker-E.Bogoljubov, Maehrisch Ostrau 1923, which left White with an edge) 12 gxf3 ♘a5 13 ♗c2 c5 14 d5 ♘d7 15 f4 ♗f6, B.Gruzmann-B.Arkhangelsky, Gladenbach 1999, with unclear play.

10 ♗e3 exd4

Immediately countering with 10...d5 has been played by some strong GMs over the years but is probably inadequate for full equality against precise play: 11 exd5 exd4 12 ♗xd4! (12 cxd4 ♘xd5 13 ♘c3 ♘xe3 14 fxe3 ♘a5 15 ♗c2 g6 16 h3 ♗xf3 17 ♕xf3 ♘c4 18 ♖e2 c5, was comfortable for Black in P.Liwak-B.Socko, Lubniewice 2003) 12...♘xd4 13 cxd4 ♗b4 14 ♘c3 ♗xc3 (also favouring White was 14...a5 15 ♕d3 a4 16 ♗c2 ♗xf3 17 ♕xf3 ♗xc3 18 bxc3 ♕xd5 19 ♖e5 ♕xf3 20 gxf3 c6 21 ♖c5 ♖ac8 22 ♗e4, G.Sax-J.Estrella Vidiella, Hungary 1987) 15 bxc3 ♘xd5 16 ♕d3 and here Black has tried various moves but has failed to equalise:

a) 16...♗e6 17 ♗c2 g6 18 ♖e5, and White has a comfortable edge, W.Unzicker-F.Jenni, Zurich 1998.

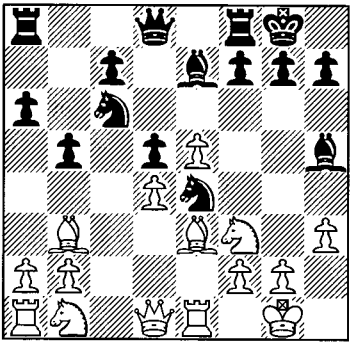
b) 16...g6 17 ♖e5 c6 18 ♖ae1 ♖a7 19 ♘g5 (with a strong initiative) 19...♗f5 20 ♕g3 ♕d6 21 ♕h4 f6 22 ♘e4 ♕d8 23 ♗xd5+ cxd5, and now White wins neatly with 24 ♖e8!, J.Van der Wiel-Pr.Nikolic, Novi Sad 1982.

c) 16...♕d6 17 ♖e5 ♘f4?! (17...♘f6 is a better try but White's game is still preferable after 18 ♖ae1) 18 ♕e4 ♗xf3 19 ♕xf3 ♘e6 20 ♖ae1, I.Herrera-C.Vittorino, Cali 2000.

11 cxd4 d5 12 e5 ♘e4 13 h3

Instead 13 ♘c3 should be compared to the next note (after the inclusion of h2-h3 by White and ♗g4-h5 by Black) 13...♘xc3 14 bxc3 ♕d7 (another idea is Hebden's speciality 14...f5!?, e.g. 15 a4 ♘a5 16 ♗c2 ♘c4 17 ♗c1 b4! 18 ♕d3 bxc3 19 ♕xc3 a5 20 ♕d3 ♗b4 21 ♖d1 ♖a6, and Black had active piece play in T.Hinks-Edwards-M.Hebden, Port Erin 2002) 15 ♗c2 (15 h3 ♗h5 transposes to the next note below) 15...♘d8 (a shade passive, instead 15...f5 is recommended in *ECO*) 16 ♕d3 g6 17 ♗h6, A.Fishbein-I.Ibragimov, Maringa 1991, and White obtains an edge.

13...♗h5



14 g4

Provoking complications as White tries to push up his kingside pawns and Black reacts as actively as possible. However this is risky and the alternative 14 ♘c3 ♘xc3 15 bxc3 is safer:

a) 15...♕d7 16 ♗c2 ♘a5 17 ♕b1 ♗g6 18 ♗xg6 fxg6!? 19 ♘d2 g5, Jo.Horvath-T.Karolyi, Debrecen 1987, with equality.

b) 15...♘a5 16 ♗c2 and now:

b1) 16...♗g6 17 e6 ♗xc2 18 exf7+ ♖xf7 19 ♕xc2 ♘c4 20 ♖e2 ♕d7 21 ♖ae1, is about equal as in B.Jacobs-M.Hebden, Guernsey 1988, as the tempting 21...♖xf3! should lead to a draw, e.g. 22 gxf3 ♕xh3 23 ♗f4 ♗d6 24 ♖e8+ ♖xe8 25 ♖xe8+ ♔f7 26 ♗xd6 ♔xe8 (the win-seeking 26...♘xd6?! was played in the game but proved to be inadequate) 27 ♕e2+ ♔f7 28 ♕e7+ ♔g6 29 ♕e8+ ♔g5.

b2) There has been a sudden explosion of interest in the position after 16...♘c4, (but I can't help feeling that Hebden's 16...♗g6 gives Black an easier life!) e.g. 17 g4 ♗g6 18

♗f5 ♗xf5!? (a less risky alternative was played more recently: 18...a5 19 ♕d3 b4 20 ♖e2 ♖a6, P.Svidler-A.Delchev, Plovdiv 2003, where one felt that Black was doing well) 19 gxf5 f6 20 e6 ♕e8 21 ♘h4 g5 22 fxg6 hxg6 23 ♔h1 ♔h7 24 ♖g1 ♘xe3 25 fxe3 ♖g8 26 ♕g4 f5 27 ♘xf5 gxf5 28 ♕xf5+ ♔h6 29 ♖xg8 ♕xg8 30 ♖g1 ♕h7 31 ♕f4+, A.Grischuk-I.Sokolov, Mainz rapid 2003. An exciting draw, but it's surprising that there doesn't seem to be a win.

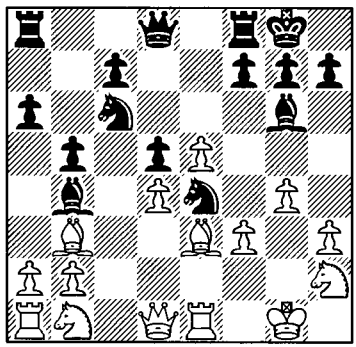
14...♗g6 15 ♘h2 ♗b4

Black has some other plausible alternatives:

a) 15...♘a5!? 16 f3 ♘g5 17 f4 ♗xb1 18 ♖xb1 ♘e4 19 ♗c2 ♘c4 20 ♗c1, J.Boudy-A.Rodriguez Cespedes, Palma Soriano 1983, and now Rodriguez gives 20...♗b4 21 ♖e2 ♕h4 as unclear.

b) 15...a5 16 f3 ♘g5 17 ♘c3 ♘b4 18 a3 ♘d3 19 ♘xd5 ♘xh3+ 20 ♔g2 ♗g5, and Black was better in T.Ochsner-L.Schandorff, Aarhus 1986.

16 f3



As the text move doesn't seem to favour White, readers may wish to investigate 16 ♖e2!? e.g. 16...f5 17 f3 ♘g3 18 ♖g2 f4 19 ♘c3 ♔h8 20 ♗f2 ♘a5 21 ♘xd5 (21 ♗xg3!? fxg3 22 ♖xg3 might be worth a closer look) 21...♘xb3 22 ♕xb3 ♘e2+ 23 ♔f1 ♘g3+ 24 ♔g1 (now however 24 ♗xg3 fxg3 25 ♘xb4 gxh2 26 ♖xh2 ♕xd4 looks risky for White) 24...♘e2+ 25 ♔f1 with a draw, L.Yudasin-V.Tseshkovsky, USSR Championship 1981.

16...♗xe1

In a previous encounter between the two leading Dutch players of the time, Black soon got into hot water with 16...♕h4? 17 ♖e2 ♘e7 18 ♕c1!, J.Van der Wiel-J.Timman, Amsterdam 1983.

Playable however is 16...♘g5, when 17 ♖f1 ♘e6 18 ♘c3 ♗xc3 19 bxc3 ♘a5 20 f4 ♗e4 21 ♘f3 g6 22 ♘d2 ♗d3 23 f5!?, as in E.Lobron-A.Greenfeld, Beersheva Zonal 1985, was double-edged.

17 ♕xe1 ♘g5 18 ♘c3 ♘e6

In A.Panchenko-E.Torre, Sochi 1980, 18...♘b4?! 19 ♕d2 turned out in White's favour.

19 ♗xd5

After 19 ♖d1, Timman considers 19...♘a5! to be unclear e.g. 20 ♗xd5 c6 21 ♗xe6 fxe6 22 b3 ♘b7, with chances for both sides. If instead 19...♘e7!?, then one must take into account 20 f4 f5 21 exf6 ♖xf6 22 f5, although 22...♗xf5 23 gxf5 ♖xf5 still looks fine for Black.

19...♘cxd4 20 ♖d1 c5 21 f4

Ambitious but incorrect. Instead 21 ♗xa8! leads to approximate equality after 21...♕xa8 22 f4 ♗e4 23 ♘xe4 ♕xe4 24 ♗xd4 ♕xe1+ 25 ♖xe1 ♘xd4 26 ♔f2.

21...b4 22 ♗xa8 bxc3!

Stronger than 22...♕xa8, when after 23 ♘e2 ♘f3+ 24 ♘xf3 ♕xf3 25 ♕f2! ♕xh3 26 ♕g3, White survives intact.

23 ♗g2 cxb2 24 f5 ♘xf5! 25 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 26 ♗g5

If 26 ♕b1, then Black wins with the elegant 26...♖d1+! 27 ♕xd1 ♘xe3.

26...♘xg5 27 ♕b1 ♖b8 0-1

Game 69

B.Gulko-M.Adams

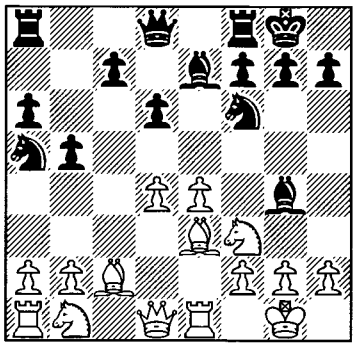
Groningen 1990

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 d4 d6 9 c3 ♗g4 10 ♗e3 exd4 11 cxd4

♘a5

The principal alternative 11...d5 was the subject of Game 68.

12 ♗c2



12...c5

Black can also consider 12...♘c4, when after 13 ♗c1 c5 14 b3, he has a choice of retreats.

a) After 14...♘a5, both sides have lost two tempi (...♘a5-c4-a5 as opposed to ♗c1-e3-c1). The knight would now like to come back to c6, hence White's next: 15 d5 (now Black switches attention to the long diagonal) 15...♘d7 (15...♘xe4?! 16 ♖xe4 ♗xf3 17 ♕xf3 ♗f6 18 ♘c3 b4 19 ♗b2 bxc3 20 ♗xc3 ♗xc3 21 ♕xc3 leaves Black with a poor knight) 16 ♘bd2 ♗f6 17 ♖b1 ♗c3 18 h3 ♗xf3! (better than 18...♗h5 19 g4 ♗g6 20 ♖e3 b4 21 ♘f1 c4 22 ♘g3 ♗f6 23 ♖e2 cxb3 24 axb3 h6 25 ♘d4, B.Gulko-W.Unzicker, Tallinn 1977, with an edge to White) 19 ♕xf3 b4 (I'm not sure that White had much in the ending after 19...♕f6 20 ♖e3 ♗d4 21 ♕xf6 ♘xf6 22 ♖e2 ♖fe8 23 ♔f1 ♖ac8, V.Tseshkovsky-E.Vasiukov, USSR Championship 1968) 20 ♖d1 ♖e8 21 ♘f1, and after 21...c4! Black obtains the c5-square for a knight, K.Klundt-S.Skembris, Bolzano 1997.

b) The knight is less likely to be left offside after 14...♘b6, but there is less incentive for White to advance the d-pawn to d5. Even so, play can be fairly similar after 15 ♘bd2 (15 dxc5 is rather limp as the open d-file is more likely to be useful for Black: 15...dxc5 16 ♘bd2 ♕c7 17 h3 ♗h5 18 ♗b2 ♖ad8 19 ♕b1 ♗g6 and Black had everything covered, A.Kovacevic-A.Shirov, Bosnian Team Championship 2003) 15...♖c8 16 h3 ♗h5 17 d5 ♘fd7 18 g4 ♗g6 19 ♘f1 ♗f6 (In the recent encounter A.Grischuk-I.Sokolov, Bled Olympiad 2002, Black continued with 19...♖e8 20 ♘g3 ♗f6 21 ♖b1 b4 22 ♖e2 h6 23 ♘e1 ♗h4 24 ♔h2 ♗xg3+ 25 ♔xg3 ♘f6 26 f3 c4, and obtained a position with chances for both sides. There's probably not that much significance in the move-order, only that Black waited to play ...c4 until White wasn't in a position to hop with a knight to d4.) 20 ♖b1 ♗c3 21 ♖e3 b4 22 ♔g2 ♖e8 23 ♘g3 c4 24 ♘d4, L.Yudasin-Y.Balashov, USSR Championship 1991, and White is favourite but it remains complicated.

13 dxc5

Now however 13 d5 is helpful for Black after 13...♘c4, heading for e5. Equally benign is the tame 13 ♘bd2, which is neutralised by 13...cxd4 14 ♗xd4 ♘c6 15 ♗e3 d5!, W.Unzicker-J.Smejkal, Bundesliga 2000.

The principal alternative is 13 h3, when Black has to make a choice between three reasonable alternatives. Grischuk has recently revived this and it's therefore become rather fashionable:

a) After the moves 13...♗h5 14 dxc5 dxc5 15 ♘c3 ♘c4, in N.Sedlak-A.Beliavsky, Terme Zrece 2003, White surprisingly sacrificed a pawn with 16 e5!? when after 16...♘xe5 17 g4 ♘xf3+ 18 ♕xf3 ♗g6 19 ♖ad1 ♕c8 20 ♗xg6 fxg6 21 g5 he had enough compensation due to his active pieces.

b) 13...cxd4 14 ♗xd4 ♗h5 15 ♘c3 (following 15 g4!? ♗g6 16 ♘c3 ♖c8 17 ♖c1 ♘c6 18 ♗e3 ♖e8 19 ♘d5 ♘xd5 20 exd5 ♘b8 21 ♗f4, it looks as if White should obtain some pressure in A.Timofeev-E.Bacrot, Istanbul 2003, but after the exchange of all the rooks, Black's queen was able to become very active: 21...♗f8 22 ♖xe8 ♕xe8 23 ♘d4

♗xc2 24 ♖xc2 ♖xc2 25 ♕xc2 ♕e1+ 26 ♔g2 ♘d7 27 ♘f5 ♕b4, and Bacrot even went on to win) 15...♘c6 16 g4 ♗g6 17 ♘h4 ♘xd4 18 ♕xd4 ♘d7 19 ♘f5 ♗f6 20 ♕xd6 ♘e5, and Black had adequate compensation for the pawn in Z.Hracek-D.de Vreugt, Istanbul 2003.

c) 13...♗xf3 14 ♕xf3 ♘c4 (or if 14...cxd4 15 ♗xd4 ♖c8 16 ♗b3 ♘c6 17 ♕d1 (White is less concerned about the bishop pair, he is aiming for structural superiority which becomes more apparent after exchanges) 17...a5 18 ♘c3 a4 19 ♗d5 ♘xd4 20 ♕xd4 ♕a5 21 a3 ♘d7 22 ♕b4, White had the better ending in A.Grischuk-V.Tkachiev, French Team Championship 2003, as b5 falls) 15 dxc5 dxc5 16 ♘c3 ♘d7 (otherwise following 16...♕b8 17 ♖ad1, S.Marjanovic-J.Smejkal, Sarajevo 1982, Marjanovic gives 17...♖e8 as unclear) 17 ♘d5 (although after 17 ♗f4 ♘de5 18 ♗xe5 ♘xe5 19 ♕g3 ♘c6 20 ♖ad1 ♘d4 21 e5 ♖a7, White went on to win in A.Grischuk-B.Socko, Istanbul 2003, Black could be fairly satisfied with the opening) 17...♗g5 18 ♗xg5 ♕xg5 19 b3 ♘a3 20 ♗d3 c4!, A.Grischuk-V.Golod, Dos Hermanas Internet 2003, and Black was fine.

13...dxc5 14 ♘bd2 ♘d7!?

The alternative 14...♘c6 makes sense, just coming back into play to have influence in the fluid centre (and in view of what happens in the main game, may well be best!), e.g. 15 h3 (15 ♕e2 ♕c7 16 ♖ad1 ♖fe8 17 h3 ♗h5 18 g4 ♗g6 19 ♘h4 ♗d6, and White's kingside push has been more self-weakening than threatening, I.Gurevich-Alexa.Ivanov, USA Championship 1992) 15...♗h5 16 ♖c1 ♘d7 17 ♗b1 ♖c8 18 b3 ♖e8, with no problems, P.Kotsur-A.Kuzmin, Calcutta 2002.

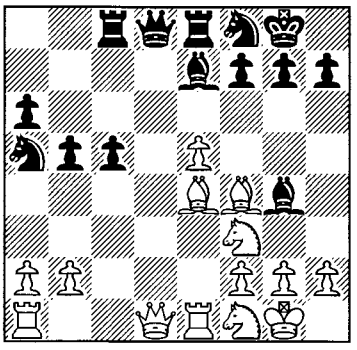
15 ♗f4!

Preparing the e4-e5 advance and thus activating the Spanish bishop.

15...♖e8 16 e5 ♘f8 17 ♗e4 ♖c8 18 ♘f1!

An interesting decision. White aims for ♘f1-e3 and then onwards to f5 or d5 and judges this to be more important than any inconvenience caused by ...♘f8-e6-d4.

This is more to the point than 18 h3 ♗e6 (the bishop is comfortable here) 19 ♕c2 ♘c6 20 a3 ♘g6 21 ♗g3 ♕b6 22 ♖ad1 ♖ed8 23 h4 ♘d4, when Black had a good game in A.Colovic-E.Dervishi, St.Vincent 2002.



18...♘e6 19 ♗g3 ♘d4 20 ♘e3 ♗h5

Simplifying with 20...♗xf3 21 ♗xf3 ♘xf3+ 22 ♕xf3 ♘c6 23 ♖ad1 ♘d4 24 ♕e4 also slightly favours White, who then has the plan of undermining the Black knight and pushing the f-pawn.

21 ♘f5 ♗xf3 22 gxf3 ♘ac6 23 ♖c1 ♕d7 24 ♘d6 ♗xd6 25 exd6

The advanced d-pawn supported by the bishop keeps Black tied down, whereas White's broken kingside pawns are not an important factor.

25...♘e6

If 25...c4, then after 26 b3 cxb3 27 axb3, Black's hold onto d4 will only be temporary.

26 ♕d5 g6 27 ♕d2 ♔g7 28 ♔g2

White gradually improves as Black cannot now go active with 28...♘cd4?, because of 29 b4! cxb4 30 ♗e5+.

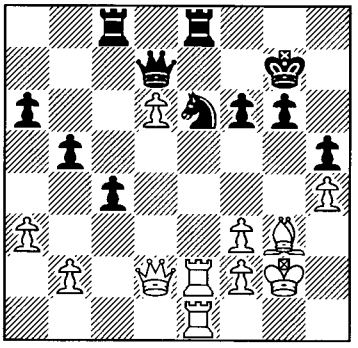
28...f6

Now that Black has weakened the e6-square, White deems it the right moment to simplify.

29 ♗xc6 ♖xc6 30 ♖e2 ♖cc8 31 ♖ce1 c4 32 h4 h5 33 a3!

A rare sight in a middlegame, Black is in

zugzwang!



33...♖cd8

Gulko points out that if 33...♖a8, then 34 ♕d5 ♔f7 35 ♖xe6 wins, and that 33...♔f7 loses nicely to 34 ♕h6 ♖h8 35 ♖xe6! ♖xh6 36 ♖e7+ ♕xe7 37 ♖xe7+ ♔f8 38 d7 ♖d8 39 ♗d6 ♔g8 40 ♗c7.

34 ♕a5 ♔f7

It seems obvious to play 34...♖a8, but Adams had obviously seen the study-like win with 35 ♖xe6! ♖xe6 36 ♖xe6 ♕xe6 37 ♕c7+ ♔h6 38 d7 ♕e7 39 ♕c8 ♕d8 40 ♕xa8 ♕xa8 41 ♗c7 and the d-pawn goes all the way.

35 ♕xa6 f5 36 ♔h2 g5

Here 36...f4 is met by 37 ♗xf4 ♘xf4 38 ♖e7+.

37 hxg5 ♔g6 38 ♕b6 f4 39 ♖xe6+ ♖xe6 40 ♖xe6+ ♕xe6 41 ♕xd8 fxg3+ 42 ♔xg3 ♕e5+ 43 ♔g2 1-0

Game 70

R.Ponomariov-P.Svidler

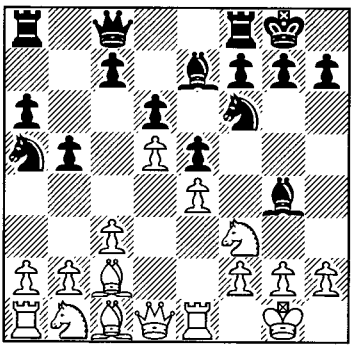
Panormo 2001

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 0-0 8 d4 d6 9 c3 ♗g4 10 d5

The most popular in recent years.

10...♘a5 11 ♗c2 ♕c8!?

Black intends ...c6 to challenge the forward d-pawn, and by playing the text first of all, the bishop is able to drop back to d7. The reason for this particular subtlety is that 11...c6 12 h3 ♗d7, allows 13 ♘xe5 dxe5 14 d6, when White obtains the advantage of the bishop pair (see Game 71, note to Black's 12th move for further details).



12 ♘bd2!?

This simple developing move is a more challenging option than pushing the bishop with 12 h3, as White aims to gain time against the bishop at a more opportune moment.

Experience suggests that 12 h3 doesn't worry Black, e.g. 12...♗d7:

a) Equality resulted from 13 ♗g5 c6 14 dxc6 (after 14 ♘bd2!? h6 15 ♗h4 ♖e8 16 dxc6 ♕xc6 17 a4 ♗e6 18 ♗d3 ♘c4 19 ♘xc4 bxc4 20 ♗c2, White had a problem with the b2-pawn as the bishop is far from home, P.Ricardi-M.Sorokin, Villa Gesell 1997) 14...♕xc6 15 ♘bd2 ♖fc8 16 ♘f1 ♘c4 17 ♖b1 ♗e6 18 a4 h6, B.Kurajica-S.Gligoric, Yugoslavia 1979.

b) 13 ♘bd2 c6 14 dxc6 (if White tries 14 b4, bullying the knight to a passive square, then after 14...♘b7 15 dxc6 ♕xc6 16 ♗b2, Black has 16...♘d8! 17 ♗d3 ♘e6, seeking a reasonable posting, as in L.McShane-M.Hebden, Hastings 1997/8, which continued 18 c4 ♕b7 19 a3 ♖ac8 20 ♖c1 ♘f4 21 ♗f1 ♖fe8, with a comfortable game) 14...♕xc6 15 ♘f1 ♘c4 (Black also achieved equality after 15...♖ac8 16 ♘g3 ♖fe8 17 a4 ♗d8 18 axb5 axb5 19 ♕e2 ♕b6 20 ♗d3

♕b8 21 ♗g5 ♘b3 22 ♖ad1 h6, S.Movsesian-M.Adams, Bundesliga 1998/9) 16 ♘g3 ♖fe8 17 a4 ♕c7 18 ♘h2 ♘b6 19 axb5 axb5 20 ♖b1 ♗e6 21 ♘g4 ♘xg4 22 hxg4 g6, L.McShane-R.Slobodjan, Arco 2000, and White has nothing.

12...c6 13 b4 ♘b7

Original is 13...cxd5!? 14 bxa5 ♕xc3 15 ♖b1 ♖ac8 16 ♗b3 dxe4 17 ♘xe4 ♘xe4 18 ♖xe4 ♗f5 19 ♖e3 ♕xa5, obtaining three pawns for the piece, although after 20 ♗d2 ♕b6 21 ♖c1 ♖xc1 22 ♕xc1 ♖c8 23 ♖c3, J.Ehlvest-E.Magerramov, Dubai 2001, Stohl prefers White slightly.

14 dxc6

Here 14 c4 can be met with 14...cxd5 15 cxd5 a5, and the knight obtains access to the c5-square.

14...♕xc6 15 ♗b2 ♘d8

With the d-pawn gone from d5, this knight heads for e6 and even f4.

16 ♘f1 ♘e6 17 ♘e3

In 2001 Stohl recommended instead 17 h3!, exploiting the fact that the bishop cannot retreat on the c8-h3 diagonal and that 17...♗xf3 18 ♕xf3 ♘d4? 19 cxd4 ♕xc2 20 ♖e2 is clearly favourable for White. This leaves 17...♗h5 18 ♘g3 ♗g6 19 ♘h4, when Stohl preferred White who has some pressure. This was tested in A.Volokitin-S.Smagin, Ekaterinburg 2002, 19...♖fd8 20 ♕f3 d5 21 exd5 ♘xd5 22 ♘xg6 hxg6 23 ♖xe5 ♗f6 24 ♖xd5!, when White retained his edge.

17...♗h5

The pawn grab 17...♗xf3?! 18 ♕xf3 ♘g5 19 ♕e2 ♘gxe4? loses to 20 ♘f5.

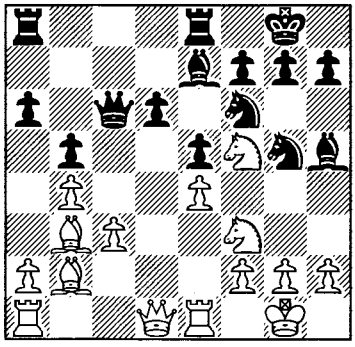
18 ♘f5

18 ♘d5 is not as annoying for Black as at first sight, e.g. 18...♕b7 19 ♗b3 ♖ac8 20 ♕d3 ♘xd5 21 ♗xd5 ♕d7 22 ♗c1 (Black was threatening ...♘f4) 22...♖c7 23 ♗d2 ♖fc8 24 ♖ac1 ♗f6, A.Volokitin-A.Beliavsky, Trgovina 2002, and Black obtained the better of it after 25 ♗b3 ♘f4 26 ♗xf4 exf4 27 ♘d4 f3!.

18...♖fe8 19 ♗b3

Threatening ♗d5.

19...♘g5!?



A sharp choice provoking a crisis. Instead the natural 19...♖ac8 keeps the pot simmering away.

20 ♘xg5! ♗xd1 21 ♖axd1

White has two pieces, plus an inevitable landing on f7, for the queen.

21...h6!

Virtually forcing White's hand and leading to an amusing draw.

22 ♘xf7 ♔h7 23 ♖d3 ♗f8 24 ♖h3 d5

The weakening 24...g6? is too optimistic as after 25 ♘7xh6! gxf5 26 ♘xf5+ ♔g6 27 ♖g3+ ♔h7 28 ♗f7, White obtains a winning attack despite the material deficit.

25 ♘g5+ ♔h8 26 ♘f7+ ♔h7 27 ♘g5+ ♔h8 28 ♘f7+

½-½

Game 71

L.McShane-Pr.Nikolic

Selfoss 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 d4 ♗g4 10 d5 ♘a5 11 ♗c2 c6 12 h3 ♗xf3

See Game 72 for the main line with 12...♗c8.

The other two alternatives are not catastrophically bad, but in both cases White has a

straightforward plan to obtain the better game:

a) Nowadays 12...♗d7 is rarely played as the tactical shot 13 ♘xe5! is generally recognised as yielding an edge to White, e.g. 13...dxe5 14 d6 ♗xd6 15 ♕xd6 ♘c4 16 ♕d3 ♗e6 17 ♕g3 ♘d7 18 b3 (White has the bishop pair and Black lacks central outposts for his knights) 18...♘cb6 19 ♘d2 a5 20 ♘f3 f6 21 ♘h4 a4 22 ♘f5! ♗xf5 23 exf5, A.Khalifman-A.Nenashev, USSR 1987, and the bishops enabled White to retain the advantage.

b) The problem with 12...♗h5 is that the bishop can easily be hit with ♘g3 rendering it misplaced: 13 dxc6 ♕c7 14 ♘bd2 ♘xc6 (or after 14...♖ad8 15 ♕e2 ♘xc6 16 ♘f1 ♗g6 17 ♗g5 ♘h5, A.Delchev-H.Hamdouchi, French Team Championship 2001, White should play 18 ♘e3! heading for d5) 15 ♘f1 ♖ad8 16 ♘g3 ♗g6 17 ♘h4 d5 18 ♘xg6 hxg6 19 exd5 ♘xd5 20 ♕f3, and now Black has an awkward decision to make:

b1) If Black just retreats (say to f6) then White has a safe edge with his bishops etc. and,

b2) 20...♘f4 leaves Black worse after 21 ♗e4 ♘a5 22 ♗xf4 exf4 23 ♘e2, E.Vasiukov-V.Bukhtin, USSR 1972.

b3) 20...f5?! is a recent ambitious try but it seems to be refuted by 21 ♗b3 e4 22 ♘xe4! fxe4 23 ♕xe4 ♖f5 24 g4 ♖xf2 (White regains the piece with plenty of interest after 24...♖e5 25 ♗f4 e.g. 25...♖xe4 26 ♗xc7 ♖xe1+ 27 ♖xe1 ♖d7 28 ♖e6! ♘a7 29 ♗b8 ♘c8 30 ♖c6) 25 ♗xd5+ ♔h7 26 ♔xf2 ♗h4+ 27 ♔e2, and White won in Z.Efimenko-V.Varavin, Alushta 2002.

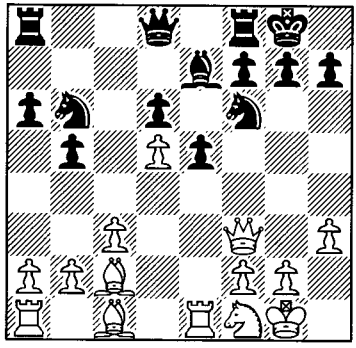
13 ♕xf3 cxd5 14 exd5 ♕c7

Rather than primarily seeking activity on the c-file, Black has an alternative plan involving ...♘a5-c4-b6 to pressurise the d-pawn: 14...♘c4 15 ♘d2 (15 a4 g6 16 ♗d3 ♕c7 17 ♕e2 ♕b7 [pressure on b5 is compensated by the weakness of the d5-pawn] 18 ♖d1 ♘b6 19 axb5 axb5 20 ♘a3 b4!, with chances for both sides, J.Benjamin-N.Short, London Match 1983) and now:

a) 15...♘xd2?! is erroneous as it eases White's development; he is thus no longer faced with the same problems with d5, 16 ♗xd2 ♕c7 17 a4 b4 18 a5 bxc3 19 ♗xc3 ♕c4 20 ♗d3, and the bishops are becoming an important asset, O.Romanishin-Pr.Nikolic, Yugoslavia 1991.

b) 15...♖c8 also allows the exchange of knights and after 16 ♘xc4! ♖xc4 17 b4! ♘e8 18 ♗d3 ♖c7 19 a4, White was on top in W.Kruszynski-K.Panczyk, Tarnow 1979.

c) 15...♘b6, seems to the point: 16 ♘f1



Can Black can get away with grabbing the pawn?:

c1) 16...♘bxd5! (this looks risky, but not taking the pawn may be even more dangerous) 17 ♘g3 ♘c7 18 ♘f5 ♘e6 19 a4 b4! 20 cxb4 g6 21 ♕g3 ♔h8 22 ♘xe7 ♕xe7, with a double edged game, V.Nevostrujev-I.Ibragimov, St.Petersburg 1994.

c2) Otherwise after 16...♕c7, White can play on either wing:

c21) 17 a4!? bxa4 18 ♘e3 g6 19 ♗xa4 ♘xa4 20 ♖xa4, F.Nijboer-Pr.Nikolic, Ter Apel 1996, and although White probably retains a small pull anyway, here 20...♖fb8 has been suggested with counterplay.

c22) The pure kingside attack with 17 ♘g3 g6 18 ♗h6 is delicate for the defender: 18...♖fc8 (18...♖fb8 19 ♖ad1 ♘bd7 20 h4 b4 was double-edged, S.Berndt-A.Shirov, Re-

thymnon 2003) 19 ♖ad1 (in D.King-Pr.Nikolic, Bundesliga 2000, White's attack proved too strong after 19 h4!? ♕d7 20 ♗f5! gxf5 21 ♘xf5) 19...♘fd7 20 ♘f5 ♗f8, J.Timman-R.Hübner, Wijk aan Zee 1979, and Black held his own with careful defence.

15 ♘d2 g6

The alternative 15...b4 was originally played by Rubinstein! In the game A.Beliavsky-Y.Razuvaev, Frunze 1979, White then obtained good attacking chances after 16 ♘e4 ♘d7 17 ♘g3 g6 18 ♘f5! ♗f6 19 ♗a4!.

16 ♘f1

In L.Vogt-P.Lukacs, Kecskemet 1977, White reacted very sharply with 16 b4!? ♘b7?! (16...♘c4! is more sensible, the knight is just too passive on b7) 17 ♘f1 ♘h5 18 g4 ♘g7 19 ♗h6 a5 20 ♖ac1?! (20 ♖ec1 is simpler with an edge) 20...♕d8 21 ♘g3 axb4 22 cxb4 ♖xa2 23 ♗d3, with compensation.

16...♖fc8 17 ♘e3 ♘e8 18 ♘f5!? ♗f6

It's an offer that Black should refuse: 18...gxf5?! 19 ♕xf5 ♘f6 20 ♗g5 ♕d8 21 ♖e3 looks too dangerous.

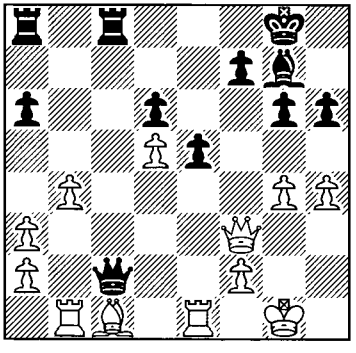
19 ♘h6+ ♔f8 20 g3 ♗g7 21 h4 ♘f6 22 ♗g5 ♘c4

Black's defences hold firm, as if White captures on f6, then Black takes back on h6.

23 ♖ab1 ♘g8 24 ♘xg8

Retaining pieces with 24 ♘g4 is natural, but then Black can even consider 24...f5.

24...♔xg8 25 g4 b4! 26 cxb4 h6 27 ♗c1 ♘a3! 28 bxa3 ♕xc2



The exchange of minor pieces has reduced White's attacking potential. He has an extra pawn but his structure is unhealthy looking with loose pawns and holes on all fronts.

29 ♖b2

A better try is probably 29 ♗b2!, when 29...♖c4 is met by the surprising yet strong 30 ♖bc1!. So Black's best response would be 29...♕c4, with adequate practical chances for the pawn.

29...♕xc1! 30 ♖xc1 ♖xc1+ 31 ♔g2 e4 32 ♕b3 ♗xb2 33 ♕xb2 ♖ac8

Neither side can really expect to win as both kings quickly become exposed.

34 ♕d2 ♖8c3!

Rather than 34...♔h7 35 ♕f4, or 34...♔g7 35 ♕d4+.

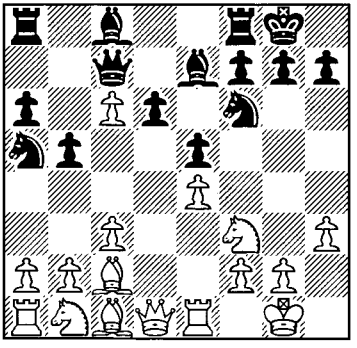
35 ♕xh6 ♖1c2 36 h5! ♖f3 37 hxg6 ♖cxf2+ 38 ♔g1 ♖f1+ ½-½

Game 72

E.Sutovsky-C.Gabriel

Bad Homburg 1997

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 d4 ♗g4 10 d5 ♘a5 11 ♗c2 c6 12 h3 ♗c8 13 dxc6 ♕c7



14 ♘bd2

White has the choice of playing a2-a4 early, late or never. In this game Sutovsky prefers to delay it until move 17.

Essentially a2-a4 gives White the option of

axb5 leaving Black with an isolated b-pawn. In return, the open a-file can be useful for Black in some cases and the White queenside couplet can come under attack (on b2 & c3, or particularly on b3 & c3). White would like to get things going on the other wing but at the same time retain significant control of events on the queenside.

14 a4 ♕xc6 (14...b4 has been found to be lacking e.g. 15 cxb4 ♘xc6 16 b5! [fighting for some key-squares] 16...♘b4 17 ♗b3 axb5 18 ♘c3 bxa4 19 ♖xa4 ♖xa4 20 ♗xa4 ♗a6 21 ♗b5, S.Maus-P.Lukacs, Gausdal 1989, with an edge for White as Black is stuck with his ugly bishop on e7 and pawn on d6) 15 ♘bd2:

a) 15...♗b7 16 ♗d3! (aiming at b5) 16...♘c4 (16...♖fc8 is suggested by W.Watson. Then with Black's kingside undermanned White should probably think about ♘d2-f1-g3 etc.) 17 ♕b3! ♖fc8 (17...♘xd2 18 ♗xd2 bxa4 19 ♖xa4 ♕c7 20 ♗g5 ♘d7 21 ♗e3, with only an edge to White was objectively better, C.Passoni-F.Bellia, Florence 1993) 18 ♘xc4 bxc4 19 ♗xc4 ♕xc4 20 ♕xb7, was clearly better for White in W.Watson-Alexa.Ivanov, Gausdal 1991.

b) 15...♗e6 16 ♘g5 ♗d7 17 ♘f1 h6 (following 17...♘b7 18 ♘g3 g6 19 ♗d2 ♘c5 20 a5 ♘e6 21 ♘f3 ♖ac8 22 b4 ♖fe8 23 ♖c1 ♗f8, Black is solid enough, but as he is not in a position to play for ...d5 (as the e5-pawn then falls) he will have to wait patiently for even longer, G.Timoshenko-M.Sorokin, Dubai 2000) 18 ♘f3 ♗e6 (alternatively 18...♖fe8 19 ♘h4 ♗f8 20 ♕f3 d5! was OK for Black in M.Kaminski-M.Grabarczyk, Gdansk 1994) 19 ♘g3 ♖fc8 20 ♘h4 ♔h8 21 ♘hf5 ♗f8 (White presses forward but Black leaves no targets) 22 ♕f3 ♘g8 23 ♘e3 ♘b3, with satisfactory chances for Black in V.Maki-A.Karpov, Helsinki (simul) 1989.

14...♕xc6 15 ♘f1

The most common move. A noteworthy try is 15 ♕e2, e.g. 15...♗e6 16 ♘g5 ♗d7 17 ♘f1 (White provokes ...h6, whereupon the typical ...g6 is more difficult to play) 17...h6 18 ♘f3 ♗e6 19 ♘g3 ♖fe8 20 ♘h4, but Black was fine after 20...d5! in S.Conquest-A.Grischuk, Batumi 1999.

15...♘c4

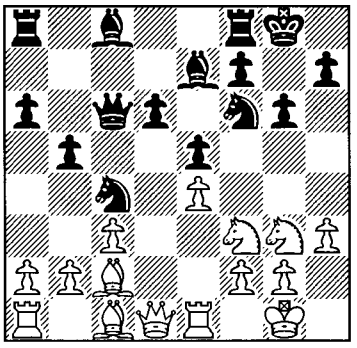
Not by any means the only move.

a) 15...♗e6 is the most natural square for the bishop but it will at some point require ...h6 in order to maintain it here. 16 ♘g3 (or 16 ♘g5 [just to be annoying!] 16...♗d7 17 ♘e3 h6 18 ♘d5!? ♘xd5 19 exd5 ♕c8 20 ♘f3 ♗f5, with a satisfactory game for Black in L.McShane-R.Slobodjan, Lippstadt 2000) 16...♖fe8 17 ♗d3 ♖ab8 18 ♕e2 h6 19 ♖d1 ♗f8 20 ♘h2 ♘c4 21 ♕f3 ♘h7 22 ♘g4 ♔h8, and Black was rock-solid in Xie Jun-Qin Kanying, New Delhi 2000.

b) The knight can drop back to b7 with ...♘c5 in mind, e.g. 15...♘b7 16 ♘g3 ♘c5 17 ♘h2 (17 ♘h4!? g6 18 ♗h6 ♖e8 19 ♕f3, S.Movsesian-D.de Vreugt, Netherlands Team Championship 2000, is active-looking for White) 17...♗e6 18 ♘f5 ♗xf5 19 exf5 e4 20 ♗e3 d5 21 ♗d4, and White kept the advantage in F.Nijboer-I.Sokolov, Wijk aan Zee 1993. However the idea may well be playable if Black were to play 19...♘cd7!? (rather than 19...e4) intending ...d5.

c) 15...♗b7 (the bishop is well placed in one sense, bearing down the long-diagonal, but it does neglect the kingside which may provoke White) e.g. 16 ♘g3 g6 17 ♗h6 (instead the more measured approach with 17 ♕e2! ♘c4 18 ♗d3 [White first covers b2 before seeking action on the kingside] 18...♘b6 19 ♗h6 ♖fe8 20 ♖ad1 ♖ac8 21 ♗b1 ♘bd7 22 ♕d2 ♘c5 23 ♘f5! gave White a strong attack in S.Kindermann-G.Barbero, Debrecen 1989) 17...♖fe8 18 ♘g5 ♘c4 19 ♕f3 ♘xb2 20 ♘f5 (one could call this the direct approach!) 20...♗d8 21 ♘e3 ♕c7 22 ♗b3 ♘c4 23 ♖ed1, with insufficient play for the pawn, F.Nijboer-J.Klovans, Groningen 1992.

16 ♘g3 g6



17 a4

White can also try doing without the a4-advance e.g. 17 b3 ♘b6 18 ♗h6 ♖e8 19 ♕d2 ♗e6 20 ♖ac1 ♔h8 21 ♗d3 ♖ed8 22 ♕e2 ♘g8 23 ♗e3 f6, J.Blokhuis-P.Petran, Budapest 2001, but then the further 24 ♗xb6!? ♕xb6 25 c4 b4 wasn't that clear.

17...♗b7 18 ♕e2

Pushing back the knight with 18 b3 is tempting but potentially self-weakening once a2-a4 has been played: 18...♘b6 19 a5 (or after 19 axb5 axb5 20 ♖xa8 ♘xa8 21 ♖e3 ♘c7 22 ♗a3 ♘d7, A.Kujawski-J.Jakubowski, Polish Team Championship 1994, the knight is comfortably recycled) 19...♘bd7 20 ♗d2 d5 21 b4 (White restricts the knight from c5, but it eventually gets to c4) 21...♖ad8 22 ♖c1 dxe4 23 ♘xe4 ♖fe8 24 ♕e2 ♘xe4 25 ♗xe4 ♕xe4 26 ♕xe4 ♗xe4 27 ♖xe4 f5 28 ♖e2 e4 29 ♘d4 ♘e5, J.Boey-J.Klovans, Bad Liebenzell 1996, with a big advantage to Black.

18...♖fc8

Black has ...b4 in mind and now 19 ♗d3 can be met by 19...bxa4.

19 axb5 axb5 20 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 21 ♗d3

A standard type of position. Black has to be careful with his b-pawn but in return he ties down White to e4 and has ideas of ultimately breaking out with ...d5.

21...♗c8

In V.Ciocaltea-S.Gligoric, Moscow 1977, a draw was agreed after 21...♖a2 22 ♗b1 ♖a1 23 ♗d3 ♖a2 24 ♗b1 ♖a1 25 ♗d3.

22 b3 ♘a5!

Virtually forcing White's hand. Alternatively, Sutovsky prefers White after 22...♘b6 23 ♗xb5! ♕xc3 24 ♕e3! ♕c7 25 ♗b2 with ♖c1 to follow.

23 b4 ♘c4 24 ♘d2 ♗e6 25 ♘xc4 bxc4 26 ♗b1 d5!? 27 ♗g5?!

Complicating the struggle but in a dubious way. After the more circumspect 27 exd5 ♘xd5, the game is far from clear.

27...d4! 28 cxd4 exd4 29 ♕f3 ♗d7?!

Instead, after the superior 29...♔g7 30 b5 (or 30 ♕f4 d3) 30...♕b7 31 ♕f4, White's attack is less credible than in the game.

30 b5! ♕e6 31 e5 ♖e8 32 ♕d1!

More dangerous than 32 ♘f5 gxf5 33 ♗xf5 ♕xf5 34 ♕xf5 ♗xf5 35 exf6 c3, when Black's passed pawns are too strong.

32...♗b4 33 ♕xd4!

Instead 33 ♗d2 ♗xd2 34 ♕xd2 ♗xb5 35 ♕xd4, and 33 ♗xf6 ♕xf6! 34 ♕xd4 ♕e6 35 ♖d1 ♗xb5 36 ♘e4 ♗e7, are about equal.

33...♗xe1 34 ♗xf6 ♗xb5 35 ♘f5!?

Good time scramble hacking!

35...♗b4

Covering c5; instead 35...c3? goes down to 36 ♘h6+ ♔f8 37 ♕c5+.

36 ♕b2

The initiative continues to be crucial here. So Sutovsky points out that 36 ♘h6+ ♔f8 37 ♕b2, is diffused by 37...♗e7! 38 ♕xb5 (if 38 ♗xe7+?! then simply 38...♖xe7 39 ♕xb5 ♕xe5) 38...♗xf6 39 exf6 ♕d6!, and Black takes control.

36...gxf5 37 ♕xb4 ♕d5 38 ♕c3

White rejected 38 ♕e1? because of 38...♗c6! 39 f3 ♕d4+ 40 ♔h1 ♕f4!, when Black prevents further access to his kingside.

38...f4 39 ♕e1! ♕d4?

After Lutz and Gabriel's suggestion of 39...♖e6!, things are still far from clear.

40 ♕e2 ♔f8 41 ♕g4 1-0

Black's best is 41...♖xe5, when White wins with 42 ♕g7+ ♔e8 43 ♕h8+ ♔d7 44 ♕d8+ ♔e6 45 ♕xd4 ♔xf6 46 ♕d6+ ♖e6 47 ♕xf4+.

Summary

Against 10 ♗e3, both the systems of defence outlined in games 68 & 69 seem adequate.

The more common 10 d5 should be met by 11...c6 12 h3 ♗c8, as in Game 72, as this is the most trustworthy of Black's responses.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 d4 ♗g4

9...cxd4 – *Game 68 notes*

10 d5

10 ♗e3

10...d5 – *Game 68 notes*

10...exd4 11 cxd4

11...d5 – *Game 68*

11...♘a5 12 ♗c2 c5 *(D)* – *Game 69*

10...♘a5 11 ♗c2 c6

11...♕c8 *(D)* – *Game 70*

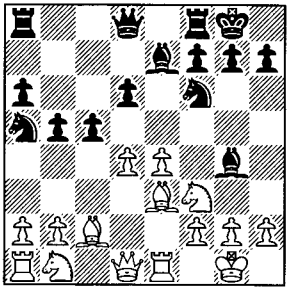
12 h3 ♗c8 – *Game 72*

12...♗xf3 – *Game 71*

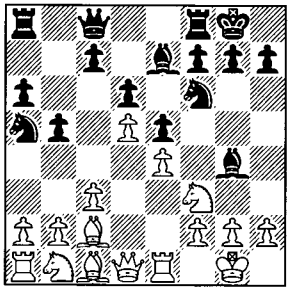
12...♗h5 – *Game 71 notes*

12...♗d7 – *Game 71 notes*

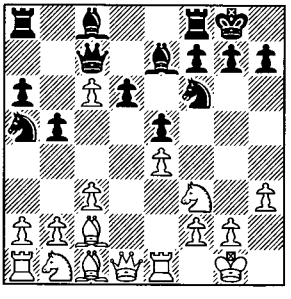
13 dxc6 ♕c7 *(D)*



12...c5

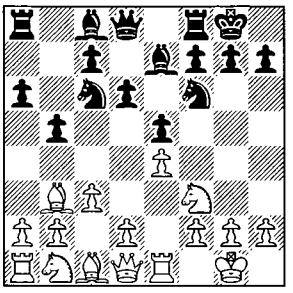


11...♕c8



13...♕c7

CHAPTER TEN



White's 9th Move Alternatives

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0

The various systems here have one theme in common – White delays d2-d4. The central tension has a tendency to build up more slowly with any crisis coming later. White prefers to avoid the main lines, aiming first of all to further his development, or perhaps jockey for position on the queenside.

Some of the ideas in this chapter have similarities to Anti-Marshall lines that are often employed against 7...0-0 and are to a large extent outside the scope of this book. Although they are less popular against our move-order, some players equally try to employ them against 7...d6, hence the inclusion of this chapter.

Although White needs to learn less theory, he is less likely to achieve an edge from the opening.

Transpositions and move-order subtleties abound, but in essence lines with the early bishop development to g4 (as in Game 74) or involving ...♗e6 are unique to 7...d6, whereas Games 75 to 77 could also occur from a traditional Anti-Marshall.

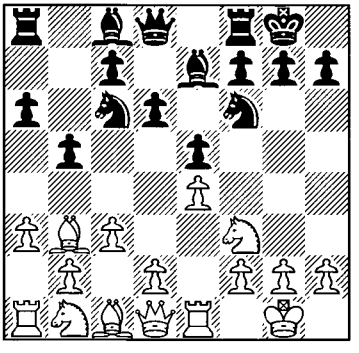
I've not aimed to be comprehensive in this chapter. I've instead emphasised ideas for Black to counter in a dynamic fashion White's essentially cautious approach. Game 75 outlines an alternative plan for lovers of sharp gambit-style play.

The final two games show Black playing in classical style.

Game 73
N.Short-Z.Almasi
Pamplona 1999

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 a3

A multi-purpose move. White can drop back with his bishop to a2 or c2, avoids counterplay based on ...b4, and can even expand himself with b2-b4.



9...♘a5

Another adequate plan involves 9...♗e6 10 d4 (compare 10 ♗xe6 fxe6 11 d4 with Game 65, notes to White's 10th move, i.e. after 9 h3 ♗e6 10 ♗xe6, Black hasn't any major problems) 10...♗xb3 (because of White's ninth move he doesn't have the option of capturing with the a-pawn, which is considered White's most promising approach in Chapter 8) 11 ♕xb3 ♖e8 (11...♕b8 was effective in the following game: 12 ♘bd2 ♕b6 13 d5 ♘a5 14 ♕d1 c5 [or even 14...c6!?] 15 b4 ♘b7 16 ♖b1 a5, A.Suetin-P.Keres, USSR Championship 1976 and Black already had the initiative) 12 ♕c2 ♕d7 13 ♘bd2 ♗f8 14 d5 ♘e7 15 ♘f1 h6 16 b3 c6 17 c4 ♖ac8 18 ♕d1 cxd5 19 cxd5 ♘h7 20 a4 f5!, with counterplay against the White centre, V.Topalov-V.Ivanchuk, Frankfurt 2000.

10 ♗c2

10 ♗a2!? has occasionally been played: 10...c5 11 d4 ♕c7 12 ♘bd2 ♘c6 (if 12...♗d7, then 13 b4 cxb4 14 cxb4 is annoying) 13 h3 cxd4 14 cxd4 ♘xd4 15 ♘xd4 exd4 16 ♘f3 ♗b7 17 ♕xd4 ♕c5 18 ♕d3 ♖ac8 19 ♗b3, O.Loskoutov-A.Gutov, Russian Team Championship 2000, and White retained some pressure. This pawn structure may be familiar as it arises in several earlier chapters.

10...c5 11 d4 exd4!?

An early try to create imbalance. More cautious is 11...♕c7:

a) 12 b4!? (fighting for space and control; any weaknesses created on the c-file are soon covered) 12...cxb4 13 cxb4 ♘c4 14 ♘bd2 ♘xd2 15 ♘xd2 ♗g4 16 f3 ♖ac8 17 ♖a2 ♗d7, A.Suetin-B.Lengyel, Sarajevo 1965 and although Black is objectively OK he was outplayed in the game and lost.

b) Following 12 ♘bd2, as in A.Suetin-E.Oldach, Bad Wildbad 1997, Black couldn't justify giving the bishop pair with 12...cxd4 13 cxd4 ♗g4 14 h3 ♗xf3 15 ♘xf3 ♖ac8 16 ♖e2 ♘d7 17 b3, and so ...♗d7 should have been preferred on either the 12th or 13th move.

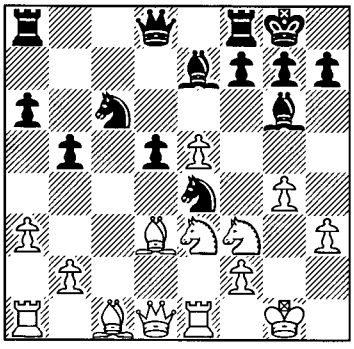
12 cxd4 ♗g4 13 ♘bd2 cxd4 14 h3 ♗h5 15 g4 d3!

A clever move that lures the bishop to a tactically exposed square.

16 ♗xd3 ♗g6 17 ♘f1

If 17 ♘d4, Black liberates with 17...d5.

17...d5 18 e5 ♘e4 19 ♘e3 ♘c6



20 ♘f5!?

Normal would be something like 20 ♗c2 ♗c5 21 ♗b3 ♘e7 22 ♘h4, with an unclear struggle. Short ambitiously prefers to create the right conditions for an interesting exchange sacrifice.

20...♗xf5 21 gxf5 ♕c8 22 ♖xe4!

A better choice than 22 ♕c2 ♕xf5 23 ♖xe4! (23 ♕xc6? is bad after 23...♕xf3) 23...dxe4 24 ♗xe4 ♕xh3 25 ♕xc6 ♖ac8, as then White's weakened kingside is the most significant factor.

22...dxe4 23 ♗xe4 ♖d8 24 ♕f1 ♘a5

Safety first. Holding onto the exchange could lead to problems after 24...♕d7 25 ♗e3 ♖ac8 26 ♕g2, as White's dominant bishops and kingside pressure would be dangerous.

25 ♗f4 ♕c4 26 ♕xc4 ♘xc4 27 ♗xa8 ♖xa8 28 b3

Defending both queenside pawns isn't possible unless White is willing to go too passive. Short naturally prefers active piece-play.

28...♘xa3 29 ♖c1 b4 30 ♘d4 ♗d8 31 ♘c6 a5 32 ♗e3 h6 33 ♗d4 ♗g5

Preparing to create a passed pawn by first improving the bishop's location.

34 ♖c5 a4 35 bxa4 ♖xa4 36 e6 fxe6 37 fxe6 b3 38 e7

Leading to some lively tactics and ultimately a drawn ending.

38...♗xe7! 39 ♘xe7+ ♔f7 40 ♘c6 ♖xd4 41 ♘xd4 b2 42 ♖c7+ ½-½

42...♔f6 43 ♖b7 b1♕+ 44 ♖xb1 ♘xb1 is dead drawn.

Game 74

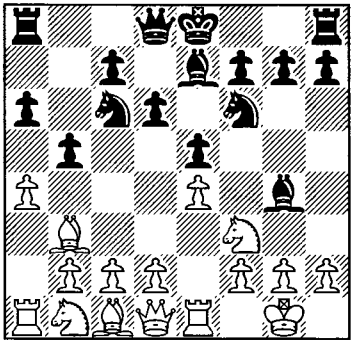
G.Kasparov-V.Ivanchuk

Prague 2002

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 a4

Otherwise 8 c3 0-0 9 a4 ♗g4 transposes back to the game.

8...♗g4

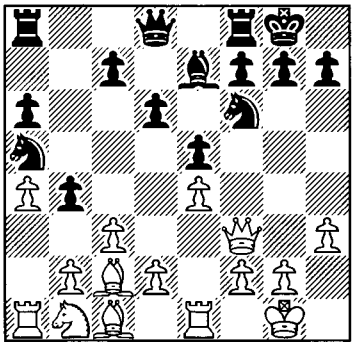


This rapid deployment gives this position its individual character. Instead 8...♗b7 9 d3 0-0 10 c3, or 10 ♘c3, would transpose to the Anti-Marshall.

9 c3 0-0 10 h3 ♗xf3

Trading off one's light-squared bishop for a knight shouldn't be done lightly. Ivanchuk follows up with an instructive strategic idea that fully justifies this exchange.

11 ♕xf3 ♘a5 12 ♗c2 b4!



Black gains space on the queenside as White cannot really consider 13 cxb4 ♘c6, as his structure is totally compromised. Also satisfactory is 12...c5 (with ideas of ...b4), e.g. 13 d3 ♘d7 14 ♕g4 b4 15 ♗h6 ♗f6 16 ♘d2 ♖b8 17 ♖ab1 ♕e7 18 ♘b3 ♘c6, with a balanced game, L.Bruzon-R.Hernandez, Cuban Championship 2000.

13 d4

Less ambitious is 13 d3, when Black is not seriously tested. Play could then continue as in the previous note, or alternatively 13...♘d7 14 ♘d2 (K.Guseinov-S.Azarov, Nakhchivan 2003, represents another example illustrating White playing a delayed d3-d4: 14 ♕g4 ♖b8 15 ♘d2 ♗g5 16 d4 c5 17 ♕e2 cxd4 18 cxd4 ♗xd2 19 ♗xd2 ♘c6, and access to d4 holds the balance for Black) 14...♖b8 15 ♘f1 bxc3 16 bxc3 ♗g5 17 ♗a3 ♕f6, A.Zapata-P.Van der Sterren, Wijk aan Zee 1995, with equality.

13...c5 14 dxe5 dxe5 15 ♘d2 ♘d7!

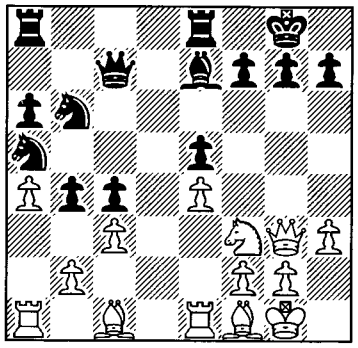
Black was able to obtain active play at the cost of a pawn in E.Sutovsky-Gyimesi, Medellin 1996, but the text is even better. That game saw 15...c4!? 16 ♘f1 bxc3 17 ♕xc3 ♘c6 18 ♕xc4 ♖c8 19 ♕d3 ♘b4 20 ♕xd8 ♖fxd8 21 ♗b1 and following 21...♘c2 compensation proved to be adequate.

16 ♗d3 ♘b6 17 ♗f1 c4

A more solid moment to venture this advance. Black's knights and queenside grip rather dominate White's bishops. Kasparov's attempt to get his pieces actively disposed

doesn't worry Black.

18 ♕g3 ♕c7 19 ♘f3 ♖fe8



20 ♗h6

Grabbing the e-pawn is risky:

a) 20 ♕xe5 ♕xe5 21 ♘xe5 bxc3 (if 21...♘b3 22 ♖b1 ♘xc1, then 23 a5!? creates interesting complications) 22 bxc3 ♗f6.

b) 20 ♘xe5 ♗d6 21 f4 ♗xe5 (here 21...♘b3!? 22 a5 ♗xe5 23 axb6 is murky) 22 fxe5 ♘b3 23 ♗h6 ♕xe5, and in both cases Black is at least equal.

20...♗f8 21 cxb4 ♘b3 22 ♖a3

Wedberg prefers 22 ♖a2 ♖e6 23 ♗e3 ♗xb4 24 ♖d1 ♗c5, but with the ugly rook on a2 White can't be that satisfied.

22...a5 23 bxa5 ♖xa5 24 ♖a2 ♖xa4 25 ♖xa4 ♘xa4 26 ♘h4?!

A forlorn attempt to attack. Instead with 26 ♘d2 ♘xd2 27 ♗xd2 ♘xb2 28 ♖b1 ♘a4 29 ♖c1, White rounds up the extra pawn and a draw would be inevitable.

26...g6 27 ♗xf8 ♖xf8 28 ♘f5 ♘xb2 29 ♖b1 ♘a4 30 ♗xc4 ♕xc4 31 ♖xb3 ♕xe4

In general, an extra pawn with all the pawns on one wing isn't an automatic win by any means, but even for the world number one the defence is difficult.

32 ♖f3?!

Allowing Black's knight to come back into play, so a better chance was 32 ♘e7+ ♔g7 33 ♖e3 ♕b1+ 34 ♔h2 f6 35 ♖b3.

32...♘c5 33 ♕g5 f6 34 ♘e7+ ♔g7 35 ♕c1 ♘e6 36 ♖a3?!

A final error but it's difficult to find a satisfactory alternative e.g. 36 ♕c6 ♕b1+ 37 ♔h2 ♘d4 etc.

36...♘f4 0-1

If 37 ♕f1, then 37...♕b7 Black picks off the knight.

Game 75

M.Ulibin-A.Goldin

Russian Ch'ship. Elista 1996

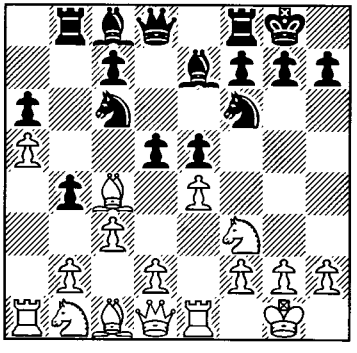
1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 a4 b4

Releasing the pressure on b5 but ceding the c4-square.

10 a5

After 10 d4 in L.Stein-M.Tal, Moscow 1967, Black equalised comfortably with the following simplifying continuation 10...bxc3 11 bxc3 exd4 (more ambitious is 11...♗g4!? 12 d5 ♘a5 13 ♗a2 ♘d7 14 ♗a3 ♗g5 15 h3 ♗xf3 16 ♕xf3 g6 17 ♕d1 ♘b7 18 ♘d2 ♘bc5, V.Savon-A.Beliavsky, Frunze 1979, with a complex game) 12 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 13 cxd4 d5 14 exd5 ♗b7 15 ♗g5 ♗xd5.

10...♖b8 11 ♗c4 d5!?



A lively Marshall-style gambit. Although Black had previously played ...d6 and only now ...d5, White has tarried with his development and therefore Black's idea is justified.

If Black decides to try and play slowly

there is a danger that White can get organised:

a) 11...♗b7 12 d3 h6 13 ♘bd2 ♘h7 14 d4!? bxc3 15 bxc3 ♗f6 16 d5 ♘e7 17 ♗f1 ♘g5 18 ♘c4, J.Mestel-J.Rubinetti, Lucerne 1985, and White had a fine game. The knight is well-placed on c4, the square weakened by 9...b4.

b) 11...bxc3 12 dxc3 (12 bxc3? allows the cheeky 12...♘xa5!) 12...♘a7 13 ♘bd2 ♘b5 (the knight covers the a6-weakness) 14 ♕c2 h6 15 b4, M.Ulibin-Z.Sturua, Moscow Olympiad 1994, and now Black is about equal after 15...♘h7 16 ♘f1 ♘g5 17 ♘xg5 ♗xg5 18 ♘e3 c6.

c) After 11...♗g4 12 h3 ♗h5 13 g4 ♗g6 14 d3, Black tried a belated 14...d5!?, M.Sion Castro-M.Gomez Estaban, Elgoibar 1995, but rather ruined his enterprise by offering a draw that was accepted!

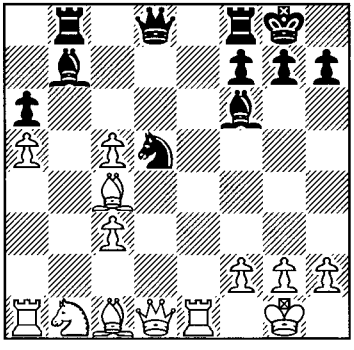
12 exd5 ♘xd5 13 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 14 ♖xe5 ♗b7

Another method is 14...c6, when 15 d4 ♗f6 16 ♖e1 bxc3 17 ♘xc3 ♘c7 18 ♗f4 ♖xb2 19 ♘a4 ♖b4, O.Loskutov-A.Bezgodov, St.Petersburg 2000, gave Black a fair game.

15 d4 ♗f6 16 ♖e1 c5 17 dxc5

The most solid is 17 ♗f1 bxc3 18 bxc3, as in A.Giacco-G.Soppe, Buenos Aires 1998, when 18...♖e8 would have been unclear.

17...bxc3 18 bxc3



18...♕c7!?

Black has achieved excellent development and active piece play, at the cost of a couple of loose pawns.

In an earlier game Black played 18...♘xc3, which after 19 ♕xd8 ♖fxd8 20 ♗b2 ♘e2+ 21 ♗xe2 ♗xb2 22 ♖a4 ♗c6 23 ♖c4 ♗b5 24 ♖e4 ♗c6 25 ♖c4 ♗b5, finished in a draw by repetition in Alexa.Ivanov-J.Klovans, Kostroma 1985.

19 ♗xd5 ♖bd8 20 ♗f4!?

Seeking an exchange of queens and thus an easier life.

Computers will probably recommend nicking a third pawn with 20 ♗xf7+?! ♖xf7 21 ♕h5, but after 21...♖e7 22 ♖xe7 ♕xe7 23 ♗d2 ♕e4, Black's pieces dominate.

20...♕xf4 21 ♕f3 ♖fe8 22 ♘a3 ♕d2

Or similarly 22...♕xf3 23 ♗xf3 ♗xf3 24 gxf3 ♗xc3 25 ♖xe8+ ♖xe8, when Black is in no danger of losing.

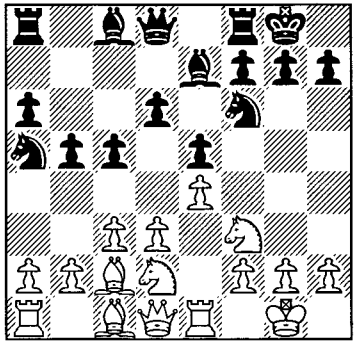
23 ♖ed1 ♗xd5 24 ♖xd2 ♗xf3 25 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 26 gxf3 ♗xc3 27 ♖b1 ♗xa5 28 ♘c4 ♗c7 29 ♖b7 ♖c8 30 ♔g2 ♗f4 31 ♘d6 ♖a8 32 ♘c4 ♖c8 33 ♘d6 ½-½

Game 76

J.Emms-P.Svidler

Esbjerg 2000

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3 0-0 9 d3 ♘a5 10 ♗c2 c5 11 ♘bd2

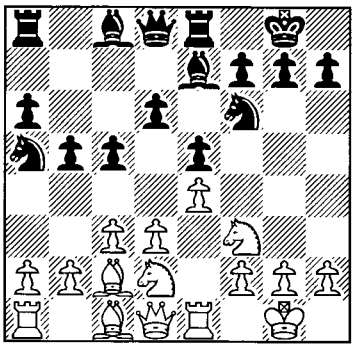


11...♖e8

Svidler intends combining prophylactic measures on the kingside, with active play elsewhere.

If Black is in a cautious mood he can concentrate primarily on general redeployment of his kingside. However he shouldn't get so carried away with his manoeuvring that he forgets that White can change the pace by switching to d3-d4: 11...♘c6 12 ♘f1 ♖e8 13 h3 h6 (or 13...♗f8 14 ♘e3 g6 15 ♘h2 ♗g7, I.Bilek-J.Kozma, Sochi 1963, when Black can look forward to the middlegame with confidence) 14 d4!? (or 14 ♘g3 ♗e6 15 d4 cxd4 16 cxd4 exd4 17 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 18 ♕xd4 ♖c8 19 ♗b3 d5! 20 e5 ♘d7 21 ♘h5 ♗c5 22 ♕f4 ♕g5 23 ♕xg5 hxg5 24 ♗xg5 ♗d4, with adequate play, I.Smirin-A.Grischuk, New Delhi 2000) 14...cxd4 15 cxd4 exd4 16 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 17 ♕xd4 ♗b7 18 ♘g3 d5! 19 e5 ♘e4, G.Kasparov-P.Svidler, Linares 1999, and Black was OK.

In these types of position if White doesn't show any intention to react with d3-d4 then Black can try for the initiative with ...d5, as Svidler does in the main game.

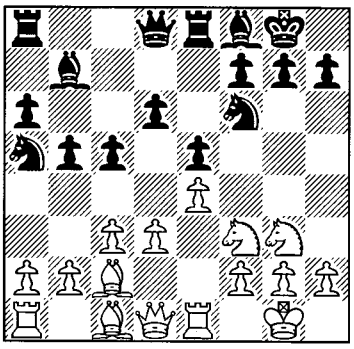


12 ♘f1 ♗b7

More precise than 12...♗f8, when the pin with 13 ♗g5 h6 14 ♗h4 (rather than 14 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 15 ♘e3 ♗e6, which yields nothing) is slightly annoying. Best is then the prudent 14...♗e7 15 ♘e3 ♗e6, but White keeps a pull after 16 h3, D.Ledger-L.Webb, British Team Championship 2000, as he is ready for d3-d4. This constitutes a clear improvement over 16 ♕d2 ♘g4! with equal chances, as in M.Adams-J.Timman, Dortmund 1994.

13 a3

White can delay or even ignore any attempt to counter on this wing. Bearing in mind what happens in the main game this may represent a more testing way of handling the white position. 13 ♘g3 ♗f8

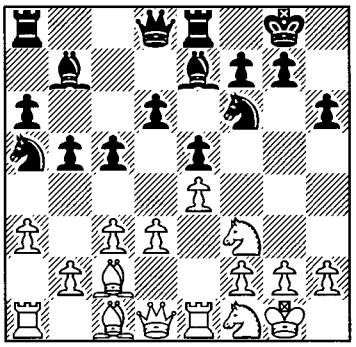


a) 14 h3?! is too slow e.g. 14...d5 15 exd5 ♕xd5 16 ♗g5 ♕c6 17 ♘f5 h6 18 ♗d2 e4, G.Kamsky-J.Timman, Tilburg 1990.

b) 14 d4 constitutes White's best try, going back into a position akin to the Chigorin covered in the first three chapters. Black has a number of ways of handling the position depending on taste but the most popular involves liquidating the centre: 14...cxd4 15 cxd4 exd4 (15...♖c8 16 d5 ♘c4 17 b3 is plausible, but Black may find counterplay hard to come by) 16 ♘xd4 g6 (both 16...♘c4, and 16...♖c8 come into consideration) 17 b3 ♗g7 18 ♗b2 d5!? 19 e5 ♘e4, and Black had no problems in the game E.Mortenson-J.Emms (playing Black this time!), Copenhagen 1995.

c) 14 ♗g5 h6 15 ♗d2 (unlike in the previous note the bishop has to release the pin allowing Black to counter in the centre) 15...♘c6 16 a3 d5 17 exd5, J.Hjartarson-Je.Piket, Debrecen 1992, when Hjartarson recommends 17...♕xd5! followed by ...♖ad8, when Black completes development and is ready to face anything.

13...h6



14 b4

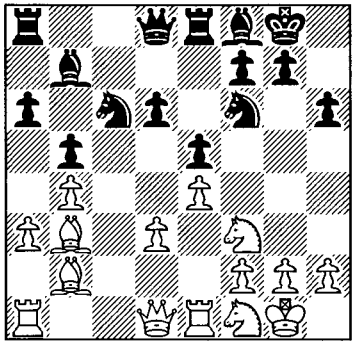
If 14 ♘e3, then Black plays 14...c4, exploiting the fact that 15 d4? would now drop the e-pawn.

So after 14 ♘e3 c4:

a) 15 ♘f5 cxd3 16 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 17 ♗xd3 ♗c6 looks about equal, Black toying with ideas of ...♘a5-b7-c5, (or in the case that ...♘b7 is met by b2-b4, then ...♘b7-d8-e6) or ...♕b7, ...♖ad8 and ...d5.

b) Instead J.Emms-Z.Almasi, Kopavogur 1994, continued 15 b4?! cxb3 16 ♗xb3 ♘xb3 17 ♕xb3 ♘d7 18 c4 ♘c5 19 ♕c3 bxc4 20 ♘xc4 f5, and Black had interesting play.

14...cxb4 15 cxb4 ♘c6 16 ♗b2 ♗f8 17 ♗b3



17...a5!?

Taking the initiative on the queenside with this move may be even better than bringing the rook to c8 first.

An earlier game involving Emms (J.Emms-P.Leko, Copenhagen 1995) continued with 17...♖c8 18 ♘e3 ♕d7 19 ♖c1 (19 ♘d5 ♘xd5 20 ♗xd5 ♘e7 21 ♗xb7 ♕xb7 22 ♕b3 ♘g6 is equal according to Leko) 19...a5 20 bxa5 ♘xa5 21 ♗a2 ♖xc1 22 ♕xc1 ♘c6 23 ♕d2 ♘d8 24 ♗c3 ♘e6 25 ♗b4 ♘f4, with a pleasant game for Black which turned clearly in his favour after the further 26 ♕d1?! d5!.

18 bxa5 ♘xa5 19 ♗a2

If 19 ♗c2 ♘c6 20 d4, then Wedberg points out 20...exd4 21 ♘xd4 ♘xd4 22 ♕xd4 ♗xe4! 23 ♗xe4 ♖a4.

19...♕d7 20 ♘g3 ♘c6 21 h3 d5! 22 ♗b3

After 22 exd5 ♘xd5 23 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 24 ♗xe5, the move 24...♖xa3 again illustrates the qualities of the rook on the a-file.

22...d4 23 a4 b4

Further cramping the first player.

24 ♘d2 ♘a5 25 ♘e2 ♘xb3 26 ♕xb3 ♕d8 27 f4 ♘d7 28 fxe5 ♘c5 29 ♕c2 ♗a6 30 ♘c1 ♖c8 31 ♕b1 ♘d7 32 ♘f3?!

Instead 32 ♗xd4! would be more resilient, although 32...♘xe5 33 ♗xe5 ♖xe5 34 ♘f3 ♖ec5 (Svidler) still guarantees Black a big advantage.

32...♘e5 33 ♘xe5 ♖xe5 34 ♘b3 ♖g5 35 ♗xd4 ♖g3 36 ♖e3 ♖xe3 37 ♗xe3 ♗xd3 38 ♕d1 ♗xe4 39 ♕xd8 ♖xd8 40 ♗c5 ♗c2 41 ♗xf8 ♔xf8 42 ♘a5 ♖a8 43 ♘c4 ♖xa4 0-1

Game 77

M.Adams-Z.Almasi

Dortmund 1998

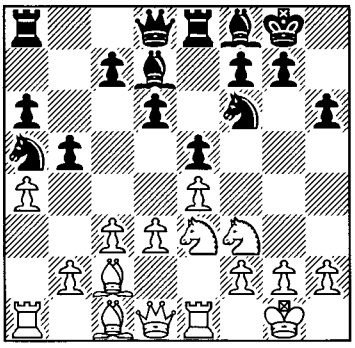
The following game is included with a word of warning. Avoid drifting into planless passivity!

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8

c3 0-0 9 d3 ♖e8 10 ♘bd2 ♗f8 11 ♘f1 h6 12 a4 ♗d7 13 ♘e3

13 axb5 releases the tension prematurely, as illustrated by the continuation 13...axb5 14 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 15 ♘g3 ♘a5 16 ♗c2 c5 17 d4 c4, J.Polgar-Je.Piket, Dos Hermanas 1995, when chances were already equal.

13...♘a5 14 ♗c2



14...b4

The standard plan would be to include c7-c5 here, or at some point. Although the text move is not bad in itself, Black is later made to regret omitting the c-pawn from his plans.

In the following example Black neutralises White's kingside play whilst maintaining a grip on the central zone: 14...c5 15 h3 g6 16 ♘h2 ♗e6 17 axb5 axb5 18 ♘hg4 h5 19 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 20 ♗d2 ♘c6 21 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 22 ♗b3 ♘e7, P.Jaracz-I.Ibragimov, Biel 1997, with a comfortable game.

15 ♗d2

In this, and analogous positions, capturing the b-pawn tends to compromise White's structure. However this isn't the end of the story, as for instance after 15 cxb4!? ♘c6, Wedberg suggests the double-edged 16 ♗d2!? ♕b8 17 b5 axb5 18 a5 b4. Instead inferior was 16 ♗b3 ♘xb4 17 a5 ♖b8 18 ♗c4 c6 19 ♘c2 d5, S.Dovliatov-D.Kaiumov, Abu Dhabi 1999, when Black had a fine active game.

15...bxc3?!

This move doesn't really work as White now is able to generate a comfortable initiative. More combative would be Wedberg's suggestion of 15...♕b8! 16 ♘d5 ♘xd5 17 exd5 c5 18 cxb4 cxb4 19 ♖e4 ♕b7 20 ♗xb4 ♕xd5, with chances for both sides.

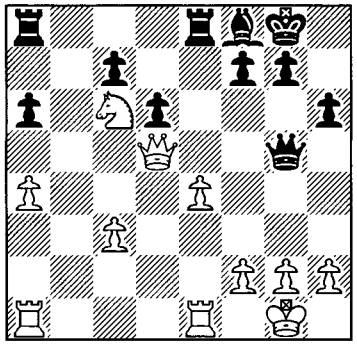
16 ♗xc3 ♘c6

It's true that 16...c5!? competes better for space, but Almasi must have been concerned about potential structural problems.

17 ♗b3 ♗e6 18 ♗xe6 ♖xe6 19 ♘d5 ♖e8 20 d4 exd4 21 ♘xd4 ♘xd5?!

The lesser evil was 21...♘xd4 22 ♕xd4 ♘xd5 23 exd5, as without knights on the board Black's position may be defensible.

22 ♘xc6 ♘xc3 23 bxc3 ♕g5 24 ♕d5



Exploiting Black's inaccuracy on move 21 White establishes an advanced outpost for the knight on c6. This one piece now dominates Black's whole army.

24...♕xd5 25 exd5 g6 26 ♖ab1 ♗g7 27 c4 ♗c3 28 ♖ec1 ♗f6 29 ♔f1 ♖e4 30 g3 ♗g5 31 ♖c2 ♖ae8

Attempting to activate, but having the undesirable effect of leaving the a-pawn to its fate. White's passed a-pawn is then the decisive factor.

32 ♘b8 a5 33 ♘c6 ♔g7 34 ♘xa5 ♖a8 35 ♖b5 ♗f6 36 ♖a2 ♗c3 37 ♘c6 ♖xc4 38 a5 ♖a6

If 38...♗f6, then 39 a6, followed by a7 and ♖b8 is trivial.

39 ♖c2 ♖cxc6 40 dxc6 ♖xa5 41 ♖b7 ♖a1+ 42 ♔g2 ♗a5 43 ♖a7 1-0

Summary

None of White's sidelines is particularly dangerous if Black has a consistent plan in mind.

Against 9 a3 in Game 73, then 9...♗e6 is solid, whereas Almasi's 9...♘a5 is more double-edged.

The plan with 8 (or 9) a4 was expertly dealt with by Ivanchuk in Game 74 with a strategy based around ...♗g4 and ...b4. In Game 75, 9...b4 followed by a ...d5 gambit gave enough compensation.

Game 76 is a model for the classical-style black defence.

1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 a6 4 ♗a4 ♘f6 5 0-0 ♗e7 6 ♖e1 b5 7 ♗b3 d6 8 c3

8 a4 ♗g4 – *Game 74*

8...0-0 9 d3 *(D)*

9 a4 b4 – *Game 75*

9 a3

9...♘a5 *(D)* – *Game 73*

9...♗e6 – *Game 73 notes*

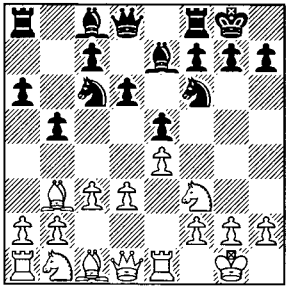
9...♘a5 – *Game 76*

9...♖e8 – *Game 77*

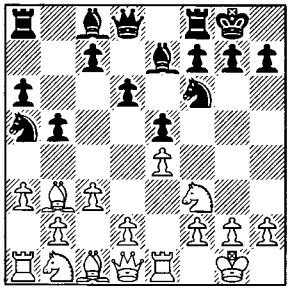
10 ♗c2 c5 11 ♘bd2 ♖e8

11...♘c6 – *Game 76 notes*

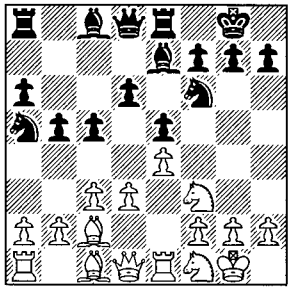
12 ♘f1 *(D)*



9 d3



9...♘a5



12 ♘f1

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